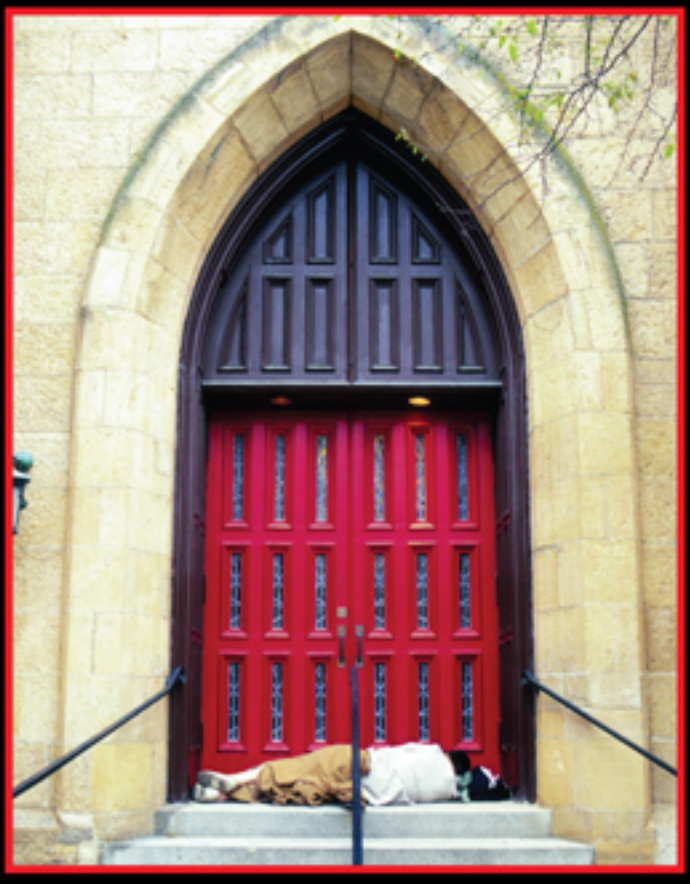
Edited by

Jane F. Maynard,
Leonard Hummel, and
Mary Clark Moschella



Pastoral Bearings

Lived Religion and Pastoral Theology

Pastoral Bearings

Pastoral Bearings

Lived Religion and Pastoral Theology

Edited by
Jane F. Maynard, Leonard Hummel,
and Mary Clark Moschella



LEXINGTON BOOKS
A division of
ROWMAN & LITTLEFIELD PUBLISHERS, INC.
Lanham • Boulder • New York • Toronto • Plymouth, UK

Published by Lexington Books
A division of Rowman & Littlefield Publishers, Inc.
A wholly owned subsidiary of The Rowman & Littlefield Publishing Group, Inc.
4501 Forbes Boulevard, Suite 200, Lanham, Maryland 20706
http://www.lexingtonbooks.com

Estover Road, Plymouth PL6 7PY, United Kingdom

Copyright © 2010 by Lexington Books

All rights reserved. No part of this book may be reproduced in any form or by any electronic or mechanical means, including information storage and retrieval systems, without written permission from the publisher, except by a reviewer who may quote passages in a review.

Lyrics to "We Need to Hear from You" in chapter 9 © 1982 Crouch Music (ASCAP) Bud John Songs (ASCAP) (adm. by EMI CMG Publishing). All rights reserved. Used by permission.

British Library Cataloguing in Publication Information Available

Library of Congress Cataloging-in-Publication Data

Pastoral bearings : lived religion and pastoral theology / edited by Jane F. Maynard, Leonard Hummel, and Mary Clark Moschella.
p. cm.
Includes bibliographical references and index.
ISBN 978-0-7391-2360-7 (cloth : alk. paper) -- ISBN 978-0-7391-4247-9 (electronic)
1. Pastoral theology. 2. Christian sociology. I. Maynard, Jane Frances. II. Hummel, Leonard M. III. Moschella, Mary Clark.
BV4017.P275 2010
206'.1--dc22 2009051179

The paper used in this publication meets the minimum requirements of American National Standard for Information Sciences—Permanence of Paper for Printed Library Materials, ANSI/NISO Z39.48-1992.
Printed in the United States of America

To our parents, whose vibrant lived religion has always been
a source of inspiration:

Paul and Rita Maynard
Leonard and Margaret Hummel
Sabino and Carmela Moschella

Contents

Figures ix

Acknowledgments xi

1 Pastoral Bearings: Lived Religion and Pastoral Theology 1
Jane F. Maynard, Mary Clark Moschella, and Leonard Hummel

Part I: Congregations, Bodies, and Theology

2 Theological Reflection and Theories of Practice: Rethinking Normative Memory as if Bodies Matter 23
Mary McClintock Fulkerson

3 Weaving a Communal Narrative: Agape United Methodist Church 43
Karen D. Scheib and Barbara Hedges-Goettl

4 Culture-Coded Care: Ecclesial Beliefs, Practices, and Artifacts in Response to Illness 75
Susan J. Dunlap

5 Homeless in Seattle: A Lived Religion of Hospitality 91
Sharon G. Thornton

Part II: Gender Positive Care: Re-writing Dis/ability, Denominational History, and Unchurched Religion

6 Resisting Stares and Stereotypes: Affirming Life 121
Janet E. Schaller

7 Baptist Clergywomen's Narratives: Reinterpreting the Southern Baptist Convention Schism 143
Eileen R. Campbell-Reed

8 "Spiritual But Not Religious": How Small Groups in America Redefine Religion 179
Jean Heriot

Part III: Intercultural Nuance

9 Lively Choruses: Relational Dance with God 211
Lonnie Yoder

10 Pastoral Care and Counseling in Independent Evangelical Charismatic Churches in Ghana: A Barthian Theological Perspective 235
Esther E. Acolatse

11 Religion in Thailand: Pastoral Theological Reflection from the Perspective of Thai Buddhist Monks 261
Siroj Sorajjakool

Select Bibliography 283

Index 289

About the Contributors 295

Figures

Figure 7.1 Tensions of Conviction in Baptist Life and Polity 147
Figure 7.2 Elements of Soul Competency 151

Acknowledgments

We, the editors, express our thanks to the many persons and institutions that have supported our vision and work on this volume. We express our appreciation to the ten authors who contributed essays to this volume for their imagination, rigor, and persistence in this project. We are grateful to the Society for Pastoral Theology, which has been a scholarly home to each of us for many years. In particular, we are grateful to the Study Group on Religious Practices and Pastoral Research (formerly Religious Practices and Commitment), where we shared this project and nurtured it along with the help of our contributors and other colleagues at annual meetings of the Society from 2004 through 2008. We acknowledge our appreciation also to the leaders and participants in the Ethnography and Theology Consultation at Emory University in March 2009 where Mary Moschella presented a paper on this topic.

We thank our respective churches and teaching institutions that have supported us through years of work on this project, including colleagues in the Episcopal Diocese of Olympia, the Lutheran Theological Seminary at Gettysburg, and Wesley Theological Seminary in Washington, D.C. The late Howertine Duncan, as research librarian at Wesley, assisted us kindly. We are grateful for the support of colleagues and friends who saw the value of bringing this collection together. These include, but are not limited to, Rod Hunter, Charles Scalise, Kathleen Greider, Michael Koppel, Bruce Birch, and Beverly Mitchell.

We acknowledge the help and support of our editors at Lexington Press, including Jessica Bradfield, Melissa Wilks, and Michael Wiles. We also thank M. Catherine Smith from Seattle University's School of Theology and

Ministry, who provided invaluable assistance in the preparation of the manuscript.

Finally, we are grateful to our loved ones for their enduring support and patience with us through this long term of work. Jane warmly thanks her husband, Jim Treyens, for his encouragement and her children, Daniel and Beckie, for their unfailing interest and love. Leonard expresses gratitude to his parents, Margaret and Leonard, for what they handed on to him, so that he might hand it on to others. Mary's love and gratitude go not only to her parents but also to Doug Clark, her devoted husband and proofreader, and to her amazing offspring, Ethan and Abbey.

1

Pastoral Bearings: Lived Religion and Pastoral Theology

Jane F. Maynard, Mary Clark Moschella, and Leonard Hummel

INTRODUCTION

Under the influence of postmodern theory, contemporary pastoral theologians and practitioners increasingly find themselves wrestling with issues of power, cultural diversity, and religious pluralism in their studies of the religious understandings and caring practices of individuals and communities. For example, some contemporary questions about religious practices and meaning facing pastoral theologians include the following:

- How can we understand the healing and transformative power of Catholic devotional practices for immigrants and their descendants? The ethnographic study of an Italian Catholic community in the Port of Los Angeles reveals a sacramental way of life involving prayer, art, artifacts, and food. In the mundane and material dimensions of religious practices seen up close at the local level, pastoral theologians can decipher meanings and trace evidence of God's grace.[1]
- How do some members of the Lutheran tradition who have experienced a wide variety of negative events cope with and seek consolation in the midst of those events? In their coping and seeking after consolation, how are these same Lutherans informed by their tradition and how do they also reform it through their unique beliefs and practices? A qualitative study of seven Lutherans reveals the importance of attending to tradition in the study of lived religion because the multiplicity and messiness of lived religion is startlingly revealed precisely via this lens. At the same time, it reveals that tradition, while not a cultural

consensus that binds all into one, is an organizing principle that influences some of the beliefs and practices of many.[2]

- How do the members of an Episcopal congregation in San Francisco who experienced massive AIDS loss recapture a sense of hope and goodness in the face of their grief? Interviews with survivors suggest that the presence of God revealed within the experience of loss transfigures it. When viewed through the lens of love, grief becomes a doorway to a profound emotional and spiritual awakening that softens the heart and enables a degree of intimacy that heals. The encounter with grief also provides a tangible reminder of the union in love the members share and of the responsibility that the members feel for one another. The fruits of this experience, and the congregation's theology of resurrection life arising from it, inform their advocacy for the marginalized and have birthed more hospitable liturgical practices.[3]

The brief vignettes just cited, besides illustrating the concerns facing postmodern pastoral theologians, provide a snapshot of the study of lived religion, an enterprise that elucidates how "ordinary" men and women in all times and places draw on religious behavior, media, and meanings to make sense of themselves and their world. Through the influence of liberation theology and postmodernism, pastoral theologians, like other scholars of religion, have begun more closely to examine the particularity of religious practice that is reflected through the rubric of "lived religion." Scholars of American religious history have adopted this term from French sociology of religion and extended it to include the ethnographic and cultural study of religion, particularly religious practice.[4] As Laurie F. Maffly-Kipp, Leigh E. Schmidt, and Mark Valeri remind us, there is an increasingly complex and multidisciplinary literature on practice as an aspect of "lived religion."[5] In their helpful review of this literature, they identify two distinct approaches to practice. First, they cite the work of social theorists such as Pierre Bourdieu, Michel de Certeau, Catherine Bell, and Talal Assad. These theorists emphasize "the hegemonic, regulatory and structuring character of practice" and view practice as a means through which social relationships are formed and maintained. In their view, a principle contribution of social theorists to the study of practice is their focus upon issues of power as an aspect of sociality, including attention to colonialism, political interactions, and economic and cultural domination.[6] Maffly-Kipp and colleagues also identify a second approach to the study of practice, that of "constructive theology and moral philosophy." They include within this strand the work of such scholars as Dorothy Bass, Craig Dykstra, and Stephanie Paulsell, who emphasize the contribution of Christian practice(s) to spiritual formation. They particularly investigate ways in which Christian practices, representative of the tradi-

tion, but also attuned to contemporary needs and situations, help to foster faithfulness and cultivate virtue.

The historians of American religion who contributed to the two volumes on lived religion edited by David Hall and Maffly-Kipp and colleagues believe that neither of these two approaches to religious practice is complete in and of itself. Thus, they attempt to foster an ongoing interdisciplinary conversation between social theorists, religious historians, constructive theologians, and practicing Christians. Their aim is neither to minimize the importance of social power nor the theological concerns related to the formative nature of practice. Rather, they seek to illustrate the particularity of practice, to provide fuller descriptive accounts of certain practices that have received relatively less attention such as dance and architecture, and to identify the ways in which these practices have contributed to community cohesiveness in the American religious context. As they put it, they aim to "take a mediating stance between social analysis and theological appropriation of practice," producing descriptions which hold in tension creative trust and the hermeneutics of suspicion. They also hope to illustrate how various practices viewed through the lens of history have helped to regulate religious culture *and* to expand its horizons through creativity, improvisation, and resistance.[7]

Meanwhile, a focus upon "everyday religion," defined as "all the ways in which non-experts experience religion,"[8] reflects a quiet revolution within the sociology of religion, a field which heretofore has been primarily concerned with "the internal condition and societal role of churches—or with survey data covering the beliefs and behaviors of large populations."[9] The impetus for this paradigm shift has arisen, in part, because sociologists have repeatedly observed that the complexities of individuals' religious lives have all too frequently challenged their standard scholarly assumptions about religion and spirituality.[10] Additionally, as Peter Berger suggests, their standard research procedures were simply too remote from much of what constitutes the everyday religious and spiritual life of many people to facilitate fuller understanding and interpretation. Increasingly, therefore, sociologists of religion have approached the study of everyday or lived religion, and their study has challenged some prevailing assumptions in their field at the same time as it has provided an increasingly nuanced understanding of others. In general, the research of Nancy Ammerman and her colleagues demonstrates that secularization and privatization, although present in both America and Europe, are much less pervasive than sociologists had previously assumed.[11] However, the mix of these trends varies. While Europe is more secularized and America is more religious, the importance of pluralism and personal choice have been widely observed on both sides of the Atlantic. The study of lived religion in both contexts has highlighted the dynamic nature of religious culture in which both official and unofficial religious ideas and prac-

tices exert a significant effect upon those of ordinary believers. Sociological research has also revealed the importance of negotiation as a metaphor in lived religion. Beliefs and practices cross not only institutional but also geographical boundaries, and social trends such as international migration and trans-nationalism combine with the dynamics of choice and improvisation to reveal and create a diversity of practices. Other findings suggest that while religion is present in a variety of practices not traditionally considered religious per se, such as gardening or Internet chatting, the individuals who engage in these practices are not "beyond the reach of the cultural patterns, the rituals and stories of the religious institutions in their societies."[12] After summarizing the many provocative questions and concerns that lived religion has given rise to within her field, Ammerman concludes that understanding religion will continue to require attention to both the "micro" world of everyday interactions and the "macro" world of larger social structures. Attending to other concerns such as the influence of habits on behavior, the importance of agency, and the intersection of the social domains of life and plural cultural patterns will also help to create a fuller picture of everyday religion and its effects. Ammerman notes that there are many modernities and many kinds of choices, each exerting its particular effects, and providing sociologists with much to ponder in their future research.[13]

As this brief introduction has illustrated, therefore, there is a burgeoning interest in lived religion, the everyday practices through which character is formed, communities are strengthened or subverted, and religious meaning is made. Let us now consider the implications of this growing body of literature for pastoral theologians and practitioners.

LIVED RELIGION AND PASTORAL THEOLOGY

The purpose of the present project is to describe and illustrate the value of the lived religion paradigm for understanding contemporary practices of care and expanding the development of pastoral theology. Like social theorists, church historians, systematic and constructive theologians, and sociologists of religion, pastoral theologians have also increasingly focused upon the notion of practice. A number of intellectual and theological influences have contributed to this development. They include:

- The shift within the fields of pastoral theology, care, and counseling from the clinical pastoral paradigm to newer paradigms, including the communal contextual and intercultural paradigms. These emerging paradigms are more sensitive to particularity and to the larger "web" of political and social structures affecting both the individuals and communities who seek and offer care.[14]

- The influence of liberation theologies that stress the inextricable links between theory and praxis and would judge the adequacy of care in terms of orthopraxy rather than orthodoxy.[15] A concern with these emancipatory movements and their stress upon relational justice has transformed the field of pastoral theology and is reflected in the work of many leading lights in the field, including, most notably, Pamela Couture, James Poling, Christie Cozad Neuger, Edward Wimberly, and Bonnie Miller-McLemore.
- A recovered emphasis on the caring activities of the laity as well as the clergy noted by pastoral theologians such as Peggy Way, who recognize care as a human activity first and foremost and view it as grounded theologically in baptism.[16]
- The influence of the congregational studies movement. Elaine Graham, Heather Walton, and Frances Ward see in this movement a renewed emphasis upon moral and spiritual formation within congregations understood with respect to locally dominant images and metaphors and sets of practices giving rise to a sense of corporate identity.[17] Don Browning's influential work, *A Fundamental Practical Theology,* illustrates this line of thought.[18]
- The developing understanding of local theologies which seek to embody the wholeness of the Gospel in a particular time and place.[19]
- The influence of postmodernism. Within the field of pastoral theology, perhaps the most sophisticated treatment of this topic may be found in the work of Elaine Graham. The central question with which she contends is "Do Christian truth claims make any coherent sense amid the multiple narratives of the public domain?"[20] In reconstructing the theological grounds for pastoral theology, Graham makes a "turn to practice," as a way of "understanding Christians as participating in and reshaping a living faith through their contemporary practices of worship, care and social concern." These practices both emerge out of reflection upon God and embody a concrete vision of the good and true. Thus, in engaging in them, in her view, the faithful may catch a glimpse of the Divine.[21]

We are arguing, therefore, that because of these crucial developments within the field of pastoral theology, pastoral theologians have much to offer to an interdisciplinary conversation about Christian practice. Like our colleagues in American religious history and the sociology of religion, we are committed to careful description of the practice of lived religion in all of its particularity. Similarly, we are committed to a hermeneutical approach to the study of practice. That is, we are open to the full meaning of caring practices in all of their complex and ironic richness. We are concerned, also, to illustrate the political import of caring practices, recogniz-

ing that like all religious practices they may be both liberatory and repressive. However, like our colleagues in constructive and systematic theology, we are also committed to understanding what the everyday practices of ordinary men and women and ordinary Christian communities may reveal to us about the way of life abundant in a given time and place.[22] Thus, we believe that careful attention to the caring practices of particular communities of faith and their effects has much to offer the fields of pastoral theology, care, and counseling.

"PASTORAL BEARINGS": A PRAGMATIC APPROACH

The title of this edited work, *Pastoral Bearings*, has its origin in the Pragmatic Maxim of the American philosopher, Charles Sanders Peirce (1839–1914). Like William James and other pragmatists of his time—and like pragmatic thinkers of our time—Peirce was concerned not so much with the usefulness of beliefs as with the ways whereby they informed life and vice-versa. In light of this concern, the point of the Pragmatic Maxim may be discerned: "Our idea of anything *is* our idea of its sensible effects. . . . Consider what effects, *which might conceivably have practical bearings*, we conceive the object of our conception to have. Then, our conception of these effects is the whole of our conception of the object."[23] The point that ideas and reality—and also that what we think and what we do—are connected was made even sharper by Peirce's explication of the maxim through the lens of religious tradition: "It [the maxim] is only an application of the sole principle of logic which was recommended by Jesus: 'Ye may know them by their fruits.'"[24]

It is not much of a stretch to apply pragmatic perspectives on the relationship between thought and life to the many varieties of lived religion because that is precisely what William James (1842–1910) did in his *Varieties of Religious Experience*. Doing so is also fitting because of James' abiding concern in his study of religious phenomena not so much with their origins but with their effects on human well-being, for example, "If the *fruits for life* of the state of conversion are good, we ought to idealize and venerate it, even if it be a piece of natural psychology."[25] By carefully laying out exemplary religious experiences and by noting the ideas at work in them, James strove to describe the ways in which religious truths affect life—sometimes for better, and sometimes not.

For our study of lived religion we have revised Peirce's Maxim to read this way: "Our idea of anything theological is our idea of its pastoral effects. . . . Consider how theology has pastoral bearings, and how the object of theology—God—is understood to be related to these pastoral effects. Then, our understanding of these pastoral bearings—that is, how an understand-

ing of God affects lived religion—is the whole of the object of theology—God." Accordingly our study of lived religion will attend to the pastoral effects of religious beliefs and practices relating to the divine. Some might argue that to inquire into the effects that beliefs in and practices related to God have on matters such as race, community, the body, sex, and sexism is to direct attention away from God as the ultimate concern to these more penultimate matters. To the contrary, we would argue that these very matters are the ultimate concern of God.

Not only does our concern for the pastoral bearings of religious beliefs bear an affinity with early pragmatic thought, but also with the pragmatically oriented Chicago School of Theology in the 1920s and 1930s[26] and with contemporary studies of empirical theology.[27] Our study of the pastoral bearings of lived religion also is connected to another movement that itself was a source for pragmatism's focus on thought and life—the broadly construed movement of European and American Pietism. While often adjudged, sometimes accurately, as fostering religious climates of excessive affectivity and individualism, the essence of Pietism may be that there is no essence of religion, no one form to religion, but that religion is a living thing—always changing, always formed by humans, always practiced by persons who are always in some community. In articulating his own pious desires, one of the earliest of the Pietists, Phillip Jacob Spener (1635–1705), asserted that "since theology is a practical discipline, everything must be directed to the practice ("praxis") of faith and life";[28] in doing so, Spener set the stage for the practical bearings of the similar desires of August Hermann Francke in his labors for the poor and with children. In later years, Pietism at times took on quasi-religious forms of thought and practice, even among some who, like G. W. F Hegel, railed against its emotional excesses. Later derided by not a few pragmatists for what they inaccurately perceived to be his otherworldly philosophy, Hegel's famous claim that what is true (*wahr)* is real (*wirklich*), and what is real is true, has links to Pietism and shows that movement's concern for religion as it is played out in the world: "[T]he fundamental question in Pietism has to do with making real or *wirklich* what is asserted as being formally and materially true—that is, *wahr*—in action or in life as lived."[29]

Somewhat recently, several theologians in Germany picked up on the theme of lived religion (*gelebte Religion)* in classical Pietism to find a direction for contemporary understandings of the relationship between fields of systematic and practical theology, and also between the constructs of religion and spirituality.[30] Even more recently, lived religion has become the subject of speculation among Swiss and German practical and systematic theologians as a topic that connects their inquiry. A number of theologians in both of those fields have also appropriated and applied lived religion to understand a variety of religious practices and struggles, for example, Regina

Sommers' ethnographic study of how Christian socialist women negotiate their triple identities.[31] Leonard Hummel's study of seven Lutherans in the United States who had experienced a variety of negative events was itself informed by these European studies and by the Pietist element in Hegel's thought. For example, Hummel asks, "To what degree is that which is said to be *true* in the Lutheran tradition *real* in the lived religion of seven Lutherans who sought consolation for their suffering?"[32] *Pastoral Bearings* extends the inquiry of these many theological studies in lived religion by focusing on the pastoral implications of all theological study.

CHAPTER OVERVIEW

Congregations, Bodies, and Theology

An increasing awareness of the importance of the sentient experiences of people at worship becomes apparent in many of these studies. In the first chapter, constructive theologian Mary McClintock Fulkerson helpfully lays out a case for "rethinking normative memory as if bodies matter." Examining her own reflexive experience of dis-ease as a white participant-observer in a worship service in a Protestant church that espoused the value of multiculturalism, Fulkerson lingers over her heightened awareness of skin-color differences as well as her awkwardness in greeting and settling in to worship near individuals with physical and intellectual disabilities. Using theorists of practice such as Paul Connerton and Pierre Bourdieu that view bodily proprieties as well as practices of inscription as constitutive of social memory, Fulkerson expands her theological understanding of traditioning or faithful memory. By taking seriously the memories lodged in the body as part of the Christian tradition that is routinely taught through segregated worship practices, Fulkerson gives us pause. If racism and able-ism are being learned as bodily proprieties through the very practice of Christian worship, in this church and likely in many others, then pastoral practice is undercutting pastoral theology. This work challenges the paradigm of belief-driven definitions of practice and theological reflection and illustrates how the gaps between professed theology and lived practices in congregations can become rich sites for theological reflection.[33] The full-length study, in which Fulkerson describes herself as "in search for a theology of the ordinary," is available in her book, *Places of Redemption: Theology for a Worldly Church*.[34]

The work of Karen Scheib and Barbara Hedges-Goettl also addresses questions of faithful social memory in a congregational context. Their ethnographic account of Agape United Methodist Church weaves together multiple strands of lived practices, professed theologies, denominational

records, and public and private stories of this "young and growing church." The authors explore the open secret of a previous pastor's atrocious crime, arrest, conviction, and incarceration. The crime and that period in the congregation's life seem to be remembered and at the same time forgotten when members of the congregation who are interviewed narrate the history, identity, mission, and ministries of their church. Viewing the congregation through the lens of narrative therapy, the authors suggest ways in which the church, which changed its name and relocated three years after this incident, has moved beyond a problem-centered mode of existence and with new leadership renewed its practice of the professed mission of sharing God's grace with the lost.

In another ethnographic chapter, "Culture-Coded Care: Ecclesial Beliefs, Practices, and Artifacts in Response to Illness," Susan J. Dunlap explores pastoral responses to persons whose bodies are disrupted by illness. She compares what she calls the "belief-practices" related to illness and care of the sick at three distinctly different congregations in Durham, North Carolina. One is a small, independent, African American congregation in the Apostolic Holiness tradition; another is a 650 member, primarily Euroamerican, downtown church in the Reformed tradition; the third is a Latino/Latina Catholic subset of a Catholic parish. In this essay, Dunlap focuses on the material cultural aspects of illness and care, including spiritual caregiving practices involving objects and artifacts such as anointing oil and visual representations of the holy. In particular, Dunlap highlights what she calls "tactile religion," which includes the use of items "meant to be touched, held, and embraced by the sick, as well as pieces of the material world that hold, anoint, and embrace believers in their illness." For Dunlap tactile religion also includes "the animate, the living human body." Dunlap foregrounds kinesthetic, felt, embodied encounters in the diverse experiences of care for the sick that she studies. She suggests that pastors, practitioners, and Christians of varying traditions can benefit from understanding each other's lived experiences of caregiving and care receiving, in order to expand pastoral imaginations.

Issues of class and bodies-at-risk also come to the fore in "Homeless in Seattle," Sharon Thornton's vivid description of the participation of St. Mark's Episcopal Cathedral in Seattle, Washington, in the Tent City 3 movement. Thornton describes Tent City 3 as "a roving encampment that has moved across the Seattle, King County area for more than a decade, journeying through vacant lots, churchyards, even a university tennis court." This movement houses roughly 100 homeless men, women, and children in colorful tents and temporary shelters designed to be a public and "visible statement about the abomination of the poverty that puts them there." Thornton offers thoughtful theological reflections upon this congregation's efforts to practice hospitality by working with homeless guests in a political

quest to end homelessness. Thornton makes use of personal interviews, public records, and the published remarks of various stakeholders in this endeavor, including the Dean of the cathedral, cathedral members, and Tent City dwellers. The author probes the process whereby a congregation embarks upon this unconventional ministry, experiences controversy, and moves forward in an on-going commitment to a ten-year plan to end homelessness in the city. She explores numerous theological concepts including the idea of "the stranger," and the "real presence" in the Eucharist as an ethic of giving and sharing bread. She is interested to understand how the liturgy forms the people and leads the church to its commitment to ending local poverty and homelessness. Thornton complexifies her analysis by probing the "dance of power"[35] between host and guest, and the importance of land, territory, and occupied space. Such work challenges Christians' complacency in light of homelessness even as it reveals the ambiguities involved in a church's efforts to provide space and forge relationships with homeless men, women, and children.

Gender Positive Care: Re-writing Dis/ability, Denominational History, and Unchurched Religion

Pastoral theologian Janet E. Schaller likewise keeps us focused on the lived experiences of embodied persons, and adds a focus on gender positive care through an analysis of the narratives of five women with visible physical dis/abilities. Using lengthy qualitative interviews, Schaller allows the women to tell their own stories of "resisting the stare," the oppressive cultural gaze that threatens to diminish and dehumanize women with dis/abilities. Schaller reflects theologically upon the spiritual challenge of affirming one's own life in the face of cultural assumptions that objectify and devalue. She suggests pastoral practices for congregations that can help "re-write dis/ability" by creating life-giving environments that support the full participation, agency, and leadership of persons with dis/abilities. By highlighting insights from these first-person accounts and bringing them together with the literature of disability studies, feminist pastoral theology, and theological reflection, Schaller exemplifies a life-affirming approach to pastoral theology and care that helps both disabled and nondisabled persons affirm the value of human life.

Eileen Campbell-Reed uses qualitative research methods to probe what she calls "Baptist Clergywomen's Narratives: Reinterpret Southern Baptist Convention Schism." According to Campbell-Reed, the well-documented schism in the Southern Baptist Convention in 1979 has been described extensively in recent years.[36] However, these studies, which rely most heavily on official publications and documents, treat women's ordination or

"the woman question" as "a chapter in a larger discussion of the splintering of the denomination, such that women functioned as one of several issues over which Baptists disagree." Taking her cues from the lived religion paradigm, which often directs attention toward laypersons and popular religious practices, Campbell-Reed conducts in-depth interviews with eight Baptist clergywomen with roots in the SBC, women whom she understands as occupying a boundary between popular and ecclesial religion. The author understands these clergywomen not only as a subject of the schism but also as subjects whose lives and stories can add a nuanced interpretation to the historical record of the split within America's largest Protestant denomination. Campbell-Reed's analysis focuses on the principle of "soul competency," one of five key "tensions of Baptist conviction" that theologian Bill Leonard has identified. Soul competency is the tension between Baptist understandings of individual liberty of conscience and biblical authority. Campbell-Reed's pastoral theological analysis opens up new insight into a lived denominational schism, revealing the painful persistence of theologically sanctioned gender discrimination, as well as the corruption and psychological splitting at work in negotiations over gender and women's leadership during the conflict.

Campbell-Reed did not set out to make an argument about Southern Baptists. In her words, she set out to understand these women's lives and thought the SBC conflict was important "background." It turned out that in gathering these stories, Campbell-Reed discovered that their narratives offer a way into a deeper understanding of the institutional rupture. The "good" in that pivotal moment of her research, as the author understands it, is that she pursued a close reading of lived religion in an understudied group and found that the women's lives had much more to offer than that for which they had previously been given credit.[37] Certainly this kind of research contributes to the work of relational justice that has emerged as a central concern of pastoral theology in the last forty years.[38]

The essay by Jean Heriot, a cultural anthropologist as well as an ordained minister in the Unitarian Universalist Association, also includes a focus on gender. Her essay, "American Spirituality," reflects on her ethnographic study of five small spirituality groups in upstate New York from 1992 to 1993. Heriot uses the themes that emerged from her study to plumb the meaning of the common phrase "spiritual but not religious" in contemporary American society. She finds that "the diversity, fluidity, and availability of multiple 'spiritual' markets ('unchurched' religion) have come to provide a viable alternative to congregationally based religious life ('churched' religion)." She elucidates some of the problems and limits of "unchurched religion." She goes on to suggest that that the term "spirituality" has taken on a certain functional meaning in the American context that expresses a felt need for healing and justice, a need that many individuals believe the

American institutional church has often failed to meet. Heriot's emphasis on spirituality and her reliance upon cross-cultural analysis provide a link to the next group of essays, which engage us with sites of lived religion outside of the continental United States.

Intercultural Nuance

Pastoral theologian Lonnie Yoder focuses our attention on the "sung religion" of Jamaican Mennonites. A Mennonite himself, Yoder worshipped on a regular basis with the twelve Mennonite Congregations on the island from 2001 to 2002. He was drawn to the singing of "lively choruses" as one important feature of Jamaican Mennonite worship services. He decided to write down the lyrics of forty-three of these choruses, check them for accuracy with a leading local musician, and then analyze these lyrics using grounded theory. Through this analysis, he finds that the lyrics suggest "an immediate, total, embodied and relational dance with God that recognizes God's saving actions in the past, transforms one's experience in the present moment, and sustains one's longing for personal faith experience and Christian community in the future." Yoder further finds a connection between these lyrics and the legacy of slavery and the challenges of contemporary social economic realties in Jamaica. By rigorously examining the lyrics that are regularly and enthusiastically proclaimed in worship, Yoder opens up a rich understanding of the faith of these Mennonite Christians. The practice of singing these lively choruses addresses the community's historical and contemporary experiences of subjugation and poverty, while at the same time proclaiming or "dancing" God into the midst of its life. The emphasis on communal pastoral practice and ritual exemplifies one of the recent shifts in pastoral theology.[39]

Esther Acolatse's study of pastoral diagnosis and care in African Independent Evangelical and Charismatic Churches (AIEC) in Ghana emphasizes the theological issues related to African traditional religions and the pervasive belief in the spirit world. She notes that this worldview plays a large role in the ways that persons perceive and present their problems and the ways that pastoral counselors process and interpret the information received. Based on her research conducted in four languages, English, Ewe, Ga and Twi, Acolatse finds that diagnosis in the AIEC churches seems to be based on a set of beliefs and practices that is inherited from African traditional religions and blended with certain cosmological ideas from the Old and New Testaments. In these, the power of Jesus is often invoked to ward off attacks from the spirit world. Acolatse describes some of the problems and liabilities related to this approach to healing. She goes on to suggest that Barthian theology offers resources for a practical theological framework that might be beneficial in AIEC churches with their deep adherence to

scriptural principles, and where belief in the spiritual world characterizes common life.

Expanding our sights further, Siroj Sorajjakool helps us to learn from the perspective of another faith as well as another culture in his essay, which is based on interviews with Thai Buddhist monks. Like Acolatse, Sorajjakool recognizes that pastoral theology as a discipline has formulated its own discourse and methodology within the context of Western cultural and religious practices. He challenges us to consider what pastoral-theological reflection would look like from within the context of the lived experience of the Thai monks. Among the Thai people, Sorajjakool finds a common belief in a spirit world, which is similar to but also quite distinct from the Ghanaian concepts of the spirit world. The monks report that they themselves do not believe in these spirits, but they work with these beliefs rather than challenge them when people come searching for release from pain and struggle. Sorajjakool finds that in these Buddhist monks' pastoral theology, spirituality rather than sociology is viewed as the main cause of suffering. Suffering is ultimately the result of attachment and helping people let go of attachment is the most important part of the monastic commitment.

"PASTORAL BEARINGS": IMPLICATIONS FOR PASTORAL THEOLOGY AND PRACTICE ARISING FROM THE STUDY OF LIVED RELIGION

Lived Religion and Research Methods in Pastoral Theology, Care, and Counseling

In her essay "Methods in Pastoral Theology, Care, and Counseling," Joretta Marshall considers four important methodological trajectories characterizing research in these fields.[40] We contend that the studies in the present volume, grounded in the paradigm of lived religion, both build upon and strengthen the existing methodological trends that Marshall names.

The first methodological commitment Marshall identifies is the need for continued attention to particularities and diversities of pastoral theology and practice within the United States. She also highlights the need for developing broader, more global understandings and pastoral theological methods that emphasizes experience and particularity, power dynamics, and deeper engagement with diverse theologies. The approach to lived religion exemplified within the present volume demonstrates the usefulness of this paradigm in highlighting the complexities in individual belief and practice arising in geographically diverse settings and arising from a challenging set of pastoral concerns. The lived religion paradigm also provides the basis for compelling and richly textured descriptions of theology and

practice in varied domestic settings, whether focused on individuals or communities. The paradigm also provides a useful tool for examining issues of power associated with sexism, homelessness, and illness. Further, the three studies that elucidate religious and pastoral practice in diverse cultural settings demonstrate how the study of lived religion may offer promise to the field in describing and analyzing liberatory practices in historically repressive settings, in offering theologically and spiritually grounded pastoral care within a religiously pluralistic context, and in enhancing religious and spiritual approaches to care through interfaith dialogue.

The second methodological trajectory Marshall identifies is engaging with interdisciplinary conversation partners and using sophisticated qualitative methods. The studies within the present volume draw on a wide variety of qualitative methods including participant observation, qualitative interviewing, grounded theory, and the ethnographic study of congregations and small groups. The use of the lived religion paradigm within pastoral theology creates exciting possibilities for cross disciplinary conversation with sociologists of religion, church historians, anthropologists, and those specializing in the cultural study of religion, including popular religion, as researchers within each of these fields use identical methods and cope with similar theoretical concerns.[41]

The third methodological trajectory, which Marshall describes as emerging within the fields of pastoral theology and practice, is the expression of a deeper commitment to public theology and the broader concerns of the world. Once again, the studies within the present volume touch on each of the areas Marshall identifies, including: religious pluralism; interreligious dialogue; racism, sexism and able-ism; public issues, such as homelessness; and the historical effects of oppression, such as slavery and gender discrimination. The lived religion paradigm seems particularly well suited to the exploration of such concerns through its reliance upon qualitative approaches that lend themselves to nuanced description and analysis and through its sensitivity to the concerns of ordinary people as they cope with the demands of pluralism, religious disestablishment, religious trans-nationalism, and hybridity.[42]

The final methodological horizon that Marshall identifies is the need for the fields of pastoral theology and practice to develop broader definitions of care that will definitively extend the scope of concern beyond mental health to include such concerns as the study of spirituality, the quality of theological reflection, congregational care and vitality, and social systemic analyses and critiques. The contributors to this volume provide robust examples of these diverse concerns. The congregational studies offered by Fulkerson, Scheib and Hedges-Goettl, Thornton, and Dunlap both elucidate the beliefs and practices of their members and invite us to consider the effects of power dynamics operating within these social systems and

the social and cultural contexts in which they are embedded. Heriot's study of small spirituality groups also sensitizes us to the pluralistic context within which traditional congregations are situated and emphasizes the hybridity that more and more characterizes spiritual practice in the postmodern American context. Yoder's fascinating study of lively choruses describes ways in which church music may enliven and strengthen those challenged by both a legacy of slavery and economic disadvantage, providing a medium through which believers may encounter God and experience transformation and hope. In conclusion, therefore, these studies and others in this volume provide exciting examples of the new horizons in research to which Marshall points and demonstrate how the lived religion paradigm offers great promise for extending the scope of research in pastoral theology and practice.

Contributions of the Lived Religion Paradigm to Education in Pastoral Theology, Care, and Counseling

Some fruits of studying lived religion have shown themselves in a course that one of us, Leonard Hummel, has taught at the Lutheran Theological Seminary at Gettysburg. In a class composed of those who have completed a unit of Clinical Pastoral Education (CPE), lived religion is the hermeneutic tool by which students first unpack and then repackage that learning experience. Concerns, if not complaints, are legion that what seminarians learn through CPE is split off from the rest of their theological education. Often tightly packaged into an intense summer program, CPE is experienced by not a few students as a "summer fling" upon which they look back—some with wistful fondness, others with painful regret—but without a discernable link to their ongoing theological formation. In this "Integrative Seminar" at Gettysburg Seminary, students are asked to demonstrate a capacity to use the concept of "lived religion" in understanding the nature of their ministry and religious practices of others. Accordingly, through readings and reflections on their CPE training, students reflect on their own lived religion and that of the persons to whom they ministered in order to further their pastoral theological formation.

Two ways in which these students appropriate lived religion for its pastoral bearings are worth highlighting. One involves their focusing on the ways in which they and all persons reform traditional religious beliefs to meet present challenges. They employ the concept of "organic power" from the nineteenth-century German philosopher Johann Gottfried Herder to do so: "These are the powers that human beings possess to receive and convert into their own natures what has been transmitted to them by tradition. These powers apply tradition to the needs of the present situation. Without such powers, history would be an endless imitation of what has already

been."[43] Lived religion is never a carbon copy of what has come before—and its evolving character demonstrates that the present, while informed by the past, also has power to redefine the past. The second way in which the pastoral significance of lived religion shows itself to students comes in the final sessions of the course and involves their review of and commentary on several of the essays contained in this volume. Without fail, they have found doing so helpful in thinking through and beyond their CPE experiences.

This volume can also be used in teaching ethnography as a pastoral practice.[44] The goal of this kind of pastoral research is to increase understanding of a particular community's values and longing for God; this includes the "deliberative theology" that members of the community discuss directly, and the "embedded theology" that is revealed through story or through practice.[45] Pastoral ethnography can deepen relationships between and among researchers and research participants, and enhance the quality of theological conversation among members of the community. The essays in this volume can be used as examples of pastoral research in teaching ethnography. Most of these essays provide summaries of longer and more complicated research projects; the collection as a whole demonstrates for students a range of subjects, research questions, and methods of interpretation.

Contributions of the Study of Lived Religion to the Practice of Pastoral Care and Counseling

Why should practitioners take up the task of identifying the nature of lived religion in individuals and communities? In her chapter, Dunlap suggests three important benefits. First, a knowledge of lived religion may expand the practitioner's empathic entry into the world of care receivers through broadening an understanding of the rules, roles, and cultural artifacts that communicate meaning, comfort, belonging, and connection to the transcendent. Second, having identified these aspects of the care receiver's world, practitioners may then work with them to disclose the novel, redemptive, and sacred dimensions of it, thus enabling transformation and greater wholeness. Third, the study of lived religion may also empower congregational leaders and others ministering to faith communities to call upon their historical cache of sacred images, objects, and practices in order to improvise new ones to address the demands of a particular situation of pain or rupture.[46]

Additional benefits for practitioners may arise with the recognition, articulated by McGuire, that many individuals in this age of religious pluralism do not practice a single religion exclusive of other options. Instead, McGuire indicates that the religion of particular individuals may not be "fixed, unitary, or even coherent."[47] The term "lived religion" describes the importance of what Orsi has called "embodied practices,"[48] rather than religious ideas or beliefs, and McGuire argues that the everyday practices of

both individuals and communities are not usually confined to those of a single formal religious denomination, institution, or organization. A focus upon lived religion thus provides practitioners with a more nuanced understanding of the religiosity of individual believers and honors the full range of consciously chosen beliefs and practices which can and do shape both caregivers' and care receivers' relationships with the transcendent. As the noted sociologist of religion Peter Berger puts it "[Today] there is a lot of religion that cannot be studied by looking under 'churches' in the Yellow Pages of the phone book."[49] The diversity and dynamism of the everyday religious practices of both care receivers and practitioners begs for a new approach to the promotion of healing and wholeness. In our view, the paradigm of lived religion, as exemplified in the research of our contributors, honors the embodied practices of believers, lends itself to a nuanced analysis of power dynamics, easily accommodates the faith concerns of individuals as well as communities, and helpfully expands sensitive inquiry in interfaith and intercultural settings. We are pleased to present this body of research on lived religion and we look forward to witnessing the new horizons of research it will undoubtedly open for pastoral theologians, educators, and practitioners.

NOTES

1. Mary Clark Moschella, *Living Devotions: Reflections on Immigration, Identity, and Religious Imagination* (Eugene, Ore.: Pickwick Publications, 2008).

2. Leonard M. Hummel, *Clothed in Nothingness: Consolation for Suffering* (Minneapolis, Minn.: Fortress Press, 2003).

3. Jane F. Maynard, *Transfiguring Loss: Julian of Norwich as a Guide for Survivors of Traumatic Grief* (Cleveland, Ohio: Pilgrim Press, 2006).

4. See David D. Hall, "Introduction" in David D. Hall ed., *Lived Religion in America: Toward a History of Practice*, (Princeton, N.J.: Princeton University Press, 1997), vii.

5. See Laurie F. Maffly-Kipp, Leigh E Schmidt, and Mark Valeri, "Introduction" in Laurie E. Maffly-Kipp, Leigh E. Schmidt, and Mark Valeri, eds., *Practicing Protestants: Histories of Christian Life in America 1630–1965* (Baltimore, Md.: Johns Hopkins University Press, 2006), 1–2.

6. Maffly-Kipp, Shmidt, and Valeri, *Practicing Protestants*, 2–3.

7. Maffly-Kipp, Shmidt, and Valeri, *Practicing Protestants*, 6–7.

8. Nancy T. Ammerman, "Introduction: Observing Modern Religious Lives," in Nancy T. Ammerman, ed., *Everyday Religion: Observing Modern Religious Lives* (New York: Oxford University Press, 2007), 5.

9. Peter L. Berger, "Foreword," in Ammerman, *Everyday Religion*, v.

10. See especially Meredith B. McGuire, "Everyday Religion as Lived," in Meredith B. McGuire, *Lived Religion: Faith and Practice in Everyday Life* (New York: Oxford University Press, 2008), 3–17.

11. Berger, "Foreword," in *Ammerman, Everyday Religion*, vi.

12. Ammerman, "Studying Everyday Religion," in Ammerman, *Everyday Religion*, 221.

13. Maffly-Kipp, Shmidt, and Valeri, *Everyday Religion*, 234.

14. Nancy J. Ramsay, "Contemporary Pastoral Theology: A Wider Vision for the Practice of Love" in Nancy J. Ramsay, ed., *Pastoral Care and Counseling: Redefining the Paradigms* (Nashville, Tenn.: Abingdon Press, 2004), 159.

15. Elaine Graham, Heather Walton, and Frances Ward, *Theological Reflection: Methods* (London: SCM Press, 2005), 170.

16. Peggy Way, *Created by God: Pastoral Care for All God's People* (St. Louis, Mo.: Chalice Press, 2005), 3.

17. Graham, Walton, and Ward, *Theological Reflection*, 135.

18. Don S. Browning, *A Fundamental Practical Theology: Descriptive and Strategic Proposals* (Minneapolis, Minn.: Fortress Press, 1996).

19. Browning, *Fundamental Practical Theology*, 227.

20. Elaine Graham, *Transforming Practice: Practical Theology in an Age of Uncertainty* (Eugene, Ore.: Wipf and Stock, 2002), 2.

21. Graham, Walton, and Ward, *Theological Reflection*, 193–95.

22. Craig Dykstra and Dorothy C. Bass, "A Theological Understanding of Christian Practices," in Miroslav Volf and Dorothy C. Bass, eds., *Practicing Theology: Beliefs and Practices in Christian Life* (Grand Rapids, Mich.: W. B. Eerdmans, 2002), 15.

23. Charles Sanders Peirce, "How to Make our Ideas Clear." In James Hoopes, ed., *Peirce on Signs: Writings on the Semiotic* (Chapel Hill: University of North Carolina Press, 1991), 169.

24. Charles Sanders Peirce, *Collected Papers*, vol. 5. eds. Charles Hartshorne and Paul Weiss (Cambridge, Mass.: Harvard University Press, 1958), 258.

25. William James, *The Varieties of Religious Experience* (New York: Viking/Penguin Press, 1982), 237.

26. Victor Anderson, *Pragmatic Theology: Negotiating the Intersection of an American Philosophy of Religion and Public Theology* (Albany: SUNY Press, 1999).

27. Johannes van der Ven, *Practical Theology: An Empirical Approach* (Leuven, Belgium: Peeters, 1993).

28. Philip Jacob Spener. *Pia Desideria*, ed. and trans. Theodore G. Tappert (Minneapolis, Minn.: Fortress Press, 1964), 105.

29. Alan Olson, *Hegel and the Spirit: Philosophy as Pneumatology* (Princeton, N.J.: Princeton University Press, 1992), 45.

30. Dietrich Rössler, "Fromm sein als Protestant: Gelebte Religion als Frage an die wissenschaftliche Theologie," *Evangelische Kommentare* 11 (1978).

31. Regina Sommers, *Lebensgeschichte und gelebte Religion von Frauen* (Stuttgart: Kohlhammer, 1998).

32. Leonard Hummel, *Clothed in Nothingness: Consolation for Suffering* (Minneapolis, Minn.: Fortress Press, 2003)

33. See Amy Plantinga Pauw, "Attending to the Gaps Between Beliefs and Practices," in Volf and Bass, eds., *Practicing Theology*, 33–48.

34. Mary McClintock Fulkerson, *Places of Redemption: Theology for a Worldly Church* (New York: Oxford University Press, 2007).

35. Julia Kristeva, *Strangers to Ourselves* (New York: Columbia University Press, 1991), 96–97.

36. Goodwin, 1997; Hankins, 2002; James and Leazor, 1994; Stricklin, 1999; Ammerman, 1993; and Kell and Kamp, 1999.

37. Eileen R. Campbell-Reed, *Anatomy of a Schism: How Clergywomen's Narratives Interpret the Fracturing of the Southern Baptist Convention* (PhD dissertation, Vanderbilt University, 2008). A newer analysis of this study is forthcoming from Baylor University Press.

38. Kathleen J. Greider, Gloria A. Johnson, and Kristen J. Leslie, "Three Decades of Writing for Our Lives," in Bonnie J. Miller-McLemore and Brita L. Gill-Austern, eds., *Feminist and Womanist Pastoral Theology* (Nashville, Tenn.: Abingdon, 1999), 21–50.

39. Nancy J. Ramsay, "A Time of Ferment and Redefinition," in Nancy J. Ramsay, ed. *Pastoral Care and Counseling: Redefining the Paradigms* (Nashville, Tenn.: Abingdon, 2004), 1–14.

40. Joretta L. Marshall, "Methods in Pastoral Theology. Care, and Counseling," in Ramsay, *Pastoral Care and Counseling*, 133–154.

41. See, for example, the discussions of embodiments, healing and wholeness, and gendered spiritualities in the work of religious sociologist Meredith McGuire, in *Lived Religion*. These concerns echo those identified in the present volume.

42. See, for example, Nancy Ammerman, "Introduction: Observing Religious Modern Lives," in Ammerman, *Everyday Religion*.

43. Marcia J. Bunge, "Herder and the Origins of a Historical View of Religion," in Mary Potter Engel and Walter E. Wyman Jr., eds., *Revisioning the Past: Prospects in Historical Theology* (Philadelphia: Fortress Press, 1992), 178.

44. Mary Clark Moschella, *Ethnography as a Pastoral Practice: An Introduction* (Cleveland, Ohio: Pilgrim Press, 2008).

45. Carrie Doehring, *The Practice of Pastoral Care: A Postmodern Approach* (Louisville, Ky.: Westminster John Knox, 2006), 112–18. Doehring borrows the terms "deliberative" and "embedded" from Howard Stone and James Duke, *How to Think Theologically* (Minneapolis, Minn.: Fortress, 1996).

46. See chapter 4 of this volume.

47. McGuire, *Lived Religion*, 12.

48. Robert Anthony Orsi, *Between Heaven and Earth: The Religious Worlds People Make and the Scholars Who Study Them* (Princeton, N.J.: Princeton University Press, 2005), cited in McGuire, *Lived Religion*, 12.

49. Berger, "Foreword," in Ammerman, *Everyday Religion*, vi.

I

CONGREGATIONS, BODIES, AND THEOLOGY

2

Theological Reflection and Theories of Practice: Rethinking Normative Memory as if Bodies Matter

Mary McClintock Fulkerson

A long-standing insight of liberation theologies that theological reflection emerges from situations is both an obvious and trivial truth. To observe that responses of faith, both reflective and active, come from situations is like saying that everything that happens happens somewhere, sometime.[1] Sometimes, however, this observation is profoundly transformative for the nature of faithful Christian reflection. To factor in the liberationist sense is to say not only that God is doing a new thing, but also that the markers, constraints, and interests of that somewhere/sometime will impact the form theological responses take. The recent work on "lived religion" is another example of attention to the situational character of religious faith and the equal significance of "ordinary" believers' creative agency to that of official inherited doctrine.[2] Juan Segundo's liberation hermeneutical circle remains, however, a classic elaboration of this insight, especially when he reminds us that theological ideas, like any other human ideas, are at least unconsciously complicit with existing social situations and, therefore, in need of critical rethinking in relation to newly emergent dilemmas. It is the contemporary situation and its "rich," "basic," and compelling questions that generate theological *phronesis*, a wisdom that is a way of living.[3] I want to pursue the argument that perceptions of conflict or contradictions in a situation can generate new questions and demand reformulations of what the Christian community has taken as normative and authoritative. Furthermore, I wish to take a rather bold approach to this issue. Setting aside for now the need to have standards for such claims, since not every perceived situational dilemma will generate new theological insights, I will simply put forth a situation

and its implications, allowing my readers to decide what might count as qualifications for such situational claims.

As liberation theologies and the study of "lived religion" have shown, "popular religion" is a rich place to ask how minority populations creatively employ the resources of faith. Trained as a systematic theologian, I have found my interest is increasingly drawn to the faith practices of such groups.[4] Most recently I was a participant observer at Good Samaritan, an interracial church with regular attendees from group homes.[5] This United Methodist community proved quite innovative in its appropriation and practice of traditional Christian faith. What I wish to explore in the essay, however, is not so much the creative practices of the community, as some jarring contradictions that caused me to rethink how I defined the traditioning or normative memory of the community. I will argue that a disconnect between claims about racial inclusivity and actual practices has implications for the process of maintaining the community's Christian identity.

THE CONTRADICTION

The church was a small white congregation in a lower socio-economic section of a mid-sized southern town. Because of its steadily falling numbers the Methodist conference decided to shift its mission toward a growing area a bit farther out and sent a new young minister to rebuild the community. Rev. Dan Weaver departed a bit from the plan, however.[6] With the support of the handful of remaining white members he started a ministry of outreach to get new members. The focus, as Rev. Weaver put it, was to "those not like us," a phrase soon picked up by members. His vision was contagious, and gradually the church became significantly interracial with African-Americans and new members from the African countries of Kenya, Uganda, and Liberia. It also succeeded at bringing residents from two local group homes to regular Sunday worship. What generated a dilemma for me was a welcoming language that did not correspond with significant perceptions of some members. To illustrate, let me relate a small incident in the first year of Good Samaritan's new life. While the numbers of African and African-American participants were not equal to the number of whites, an occasional Sunday had black bodies outnumbering white. Once, when the white minister was out of town, he invited a Liberian minister friend to preach, and the number of black bodies multiplied when other Liberians came to the worship service. A small number of the white members complained to Dan about his choice of a substitute preacher. The complaint was quite blunt: the church was "getting too black."

Such a blatant display of ruffled white power was, as I said, not literally correct. Africans and African Americans did not outnumber members that

society labels "white." However, these members had not simply misspoken; the comment has quite a bit of meaning. Indeed, what strikes me is its resonance with my own experience as an amateur theologian-ethnographer at the church. When I first visited the church one Sunday to begin my participant observation I found myself in a gathering of mostly black bodies. My heightened awareness of the whiteness of my skin caught me by surprise, and I was embarrassed by the disconnect between my liberal, justice-oriented "intentional world" and my on the ground visceral response of discomfort. My sense of dis-ease indicates that I am unaccustomed to being a racial minority, and this dis-ease was reproduced in a slightly different way when, on my first visit, I attempted to respond in a welcoming manner to some of the group home members in attendance. When I approached a man sitting in a wheelchair next to another gentleman who appeared to have Down's syndrome, I found myself stumbling with awkwardness. Not knowing where to put myself, or how to communicate, my normal sense of comfort in "social space" was disrupted by his twisted body and (to me) unintelligible noises.

To grant any revelatory status to my reactions would seem an overindulgence at best.[7] Certainly we all have reactions to new situations, and those reactions do not normally generate new theological concepts. However, in retrospect, the gap between my beliefs and visceral reaction to those who were "other" seems significant. First, as I suggested, it has some affinity with the dynamics of Good Samaritan, where claims "not to see color," as one of the leaders put it, did not always match behavior. Second, in the larger society, the disconnection between beliefs and behavior is quite common around issues of difference.[8] More than ever before white Americans are saying that they believe in racial equality; however, what has really changed is what they say in public, not where they live or go to church.[9] Reports indicate that schools are becoming more segregated.[10] An observation that resonates depressingly with the response of the congregation members to the African preacher suggests that many whites have low tolerance for any but a token presence of persons perceived to be black. While African Americans display great willingness to live in integrated neighborhoods, the "tipping point" for whites is an increase of non-white presence in a neighborhood of 8 percent.[11] The group homes for people with disabilities are similarly unpopular with the majority population and are typically located outside of neighborhoods with economic clout.[12]

It would be nice if Christians could make sense of these realities with the demurral that the church is different; radical love for Jesus brings people together regardless of race, class or ability. However, only about 8 percent of Christian congregations in the United States are significantly interracial, having no more than 80 percent of one so-called racial group.[13] Sociologist Michael Emerson estimates that while 20 percent of white Catholics go to

mixed-race churches, only 6 percent of Protestants do.[14] The contradiction between Christian belief and actual practice is a wider and more significant issue than my own experience or that of the few outspoken Good Samaritans suggests. I believe it is a contradiction of a sort that requires further theological reflection.

The function of a contradiction in a liberation hermeneutical trajectory is to call into question a settled way of theological thinking. Of course, the distance between what we say we believe and what we really do in a situation is as familiar in ordinary experience as it is in theological anthropology. Categories of sin can easily account for the distance between welcoming language and exclusive behavior. Definitions of racism and able-ism as sin are plentiful, particularly with regard to the social character of oppression for these populations that have been marginalized in such a variety of ways.[15] However, the behaviors at Good Samaritan were exemplified by white folks who had decided to welcome persons who were "not like us," as Rev. Weaver said, not people indulging in malicious, hateful acts or callous indifference. Racism and able-ism, or prejudice against those judged to have "abnormal" human fragilities, certainly occur in the form of vicious and cruel beliefs by members of dominant populations. What is at stake in this community, however, is the more subtle way social systems reproduce these "isms" and the individual behaviors of supposedly well-meaning people like myself or Good Samaritans. To attend to that subtlety, we need a framework for recognizing the linkage between belief and action and a way to connect the unintentional with the conscious and purposeful. This conflict, I will argue, implicitly challenges the way tradition has long been defined by the Christian faith. Recent interest in expanding such accounts in theories of practice, however, signals promise for a more adequate alternative.

TRADITION AS CHARACTER-SHAPING PRACTICES

Traditioning refers to the way in which any social entity comes to have and maintain an identity that allows it to endure over time.[16] Normative traditioning for the faith community refers to the appropriation by believers of Christianity's authoritative texts, Scripture and classic creeds, in addition to the particular traditions of a denomination. A standard definition has it that tradition is both "the body of beliefs shared with past generations and handed on to succeeding ones and . . . the process by which those beliefs are transmitted."[17] To say this is to recognize that biblical and doctrinal content are crucial for creating faithful communities. They do not become mere possessions of the intellect, however. The "body of beliefs" that makes Christian communities has to be appropriated through *processes* in a community, processes that range beyond the simple memorization of dogma or Bible verses.

Catechesis, the process of formative education, refers to the distinctive way that such learning happens in the community. It must be age-appropriate; it must take different learning styles seriously; it is a complex process that takes time. To take this process seriously suggests that the very separation of content and processes in the standard definition of tradition may not be a fully adequate way to think about traditioning in an actual community. The experiential knowledge of faith is not adequately captured as beliefs, which is typically viewed as the primary product of tradition.

Take the idea that traditioning involves certain content. What I was able to observe of Good Samaritans over a three-year span suggests that a focus only on content in the community's traditioning would never suffice as a litmus for their faithful embodiment of Christianity. First, while there were overlaps in the convictions of the church members, my study turned up no fixed set of clearly shared beliefs. This is not to deny that all would agree on some key things; they believed in Jesus Christ, that in him was salvation, that they were called to love their neighbor, and a host of other very briefly stated convictions. As studies of lived religion show, religious meanings are "volatile"; they do not simply conform to orthodoxy.[18] However, each of these convictions is connected to a variety of trajectories of understanding. For example, much of Rev. Weaver's preaching expressed themes that resonated quite strongly with a good number of congregants, but not with everyone. All agreed on the theme of welcome for all people, but the resonances of "welcome" varied for different racial and class groups. The liberation themes of a second pastor appealed more to the liberal university students; their attraction to the church was its diverse make-up. Many in this group found Dan's folksy sermons with altar calls not to their liking. But the "just folks" warmth of Rev. Weaver and his emphasis on God's acceptance of "ordinary folks like us" was exactly what attracted a number of the more theologically conservative white and African-American members. So discourse of "welcome" connected more immediately to the non-moralistic, non-judgmental character of the community than to its interracial and ability-diversity.

A search for some specific biblical or doctrinal content to account for Good Samaritans' behavior would also come up short. The variety of denominations represented in the congregation alone would ensure that there was no doctrinal consensus. (Members came from Baptist, United Methodist, African Methodist Episcopal, and Pentecostal Holiness denominations, to name a few.) As it was, the Methodists' awarenesss of the teachings of the faith was rather slim; while there was use of the Trinitarian formula in the service, and by many of the members interviewed, accounts of this belief did not correlate with accurate historical understandings of the ancient formulas. There were different takes on Scripture as well; while all the members that I interviewed would agree that the Bible is God's Word, there were

very different understandings of what this meant. One group found the highly creative reading practices of a womanist biblical scholar quite appealing. While in agreement that God spoke through Scripture to redeem and transform their lives, these African and African-American women were also clear that Scripture was written by men, expressed male prejudices, and could be used to oppress. Another group of more theologically conservative white members were fond of citing texts as God's revealed will to authorize or condemn behaviors.

Regardless of how helpful more catechesis in historical traditions might be for this community, I contend that the faithfulness of Good Samaritan's traditioning will never be identified with a specific doctrinal or Biblical test. A preferable model would emphasize the connected character of belief and process, respecting crucial features of lived faith. Indeed, the content/belief model has become less and less viable for theologians as well as social scientists.[19] Widespread interest in more complex notions of the "practical" is helpful here. Adding to liberation theologies' attention to the praxis-origins of theological knowledge, a recent flurry of work on Christian practices tries to heal the long-standing separation of "belief" and "practice" in new ways.[20] Such explorations are crucial to fostering adequate accounts of lived faith. Not only do they suggest an alternative to the inadequate split of theory-practice, important for Good Samaritan's situation. Theories of practice also refuse to separate the various dimensions of human "knowing" that make up lived faith. They remind us that the end of Christian faith is transformed life, not ever-more sophisticated gnosis.

Most prominent in such efforts are theories of *phronesis*. Drawing from Aristotle, Hans-Georg Gadamer, and Alasdair MacIntyre, such theories portray the practical character of knowledge.[21] The MacIntyrean definition of practice,[22] in particular, has caught the attention of theologians, for it provides three insights that seem vital to a theological account of faithful life.[23] First, it refers to behaviors that enhance one's capacity to achieve an end or good, and by achieving such a "good," MacIntyre understands that practices are "means" that are correlated to or congruent with those ends. They entail virtues that, when enacted, make the agent increasingly able to achieve the good end. Second, the "ends" that evaluatively shape practices come from communal traditions, thus, for Christian communities, biblical and other normative content has significance insofar as it is life-altering. Third, an account that so well integrates knowing with doing fosters respect for the lives of ordinary believers.

These features of practice are helpful for thinking about Good Samaritan. Some of the members who were best at welcoming the stranger, or "those not like us," were not the most skilled at articulating the specifics of Christian tradition. An older white couple, including a husband retired from his job as a mail deliverer and the wife from her work in a children's clothing

store, were two of the best practitioners of hospitality at Good Samaritan. Both were regular workers at the church; Richard was always fixing anything that broke at the church; Olive was always cooking food to sell and to make money for the community, which was usually in financial trouble. Their regular attendance at the monthly worship services for people with "special needs" was strong evidence of an increasing capacity to welcome, that is, to achieve the community's end. Helping with this service required learning how to relate to persons with disabilities. Another member exemplary at such practices was Betty, the first African-American woman to join Good Samaritan. Looking back, she testified to her deep distrust of white people, based on growing up in a racist society which told her again and again that she was less than fully human. However, Betty insists that her participation in the community created a new sense of possibilities for relations across the race divide. She came to see white people in new and humanizing ways.

To count as practices on MacIntyre's terms, behaviors must shape members' lives by increasing the capacity to advance a good.[24] On such terms, believing and doing are inseparable. Implicit in this definition of practices is a temporal moral trace of sorts; change in a life is marked by connecting its various moments with regard to particular ends. As a part makes sense only in a larger whole, says MacIntyre, individual actions can only be made intelligible in terms of larger contexts. And narrative is the primary genre for naming and shaping such change.[25] Betty's act makes sense in the larger story of her life as an African-American woman; and that life-story is embedded in the narratives of the communities that grant her identity. The "making sense" of her actions at Good Samaritan and those of Olive and Richard has to do, then, not only with their personal histories and the narratives that shape them, but with a notion of *goods* or *ends* which come from the stock of stories in the Christian communities that form them.[26]

The specific ends for evaluating Good Samaritan's practices come from Rev. Weaver's definition of the mission of the church to seek out and welcome people who are "not like us." In the words of Richard, the sought-after good is to be a state where "we don't see color, just Christians." Although not doctrinally fluent, members had a variety of ways to express the meaning of what they did, all of which are connected in one way or another to the stock of stories from Christian tradition. Frequently members appealed to Jesus's life and stories of his hospitality to the outsider. Such comments as "this is what the church is supposed to look like" and appeals to God's love for all kinds of people were ways Olive and Richard would account for their behavior. Betty's willingness to step out and take the risk of helping to create an interracial community came initially from Rev. Weaver's invitation, but its foundation was her sense of God's call for her life. She spoke not only about welcoming those who were different, but also about the need to be challenged by those "not like me." She admitted her

stereotypes of Africans came in for real challenge as she came to know the women of Good Samaritan from Uganda and Liberia. Further, her prejudices about people with disabilities were altered, as well as her sense of redemptive possibilities with whites.

Sometimes members' stories were clearly blended with other cultural images and narratives. The appeal to color-blindness, for example, invokes a liberal democratic discourse to describe the inclusiveness of Christian community. Whatever the rationale, however, narratives were inevitably crafted from the stories of authoritative traditions, usually biblical. "Practitioners" employed images in a "making sense" that could be evaluated over time, that is, could be assessed in relation to their progress in welcoming those "not like us." What matters here is that MacIntyrean practice offers an understanding of the intersection of tradition with lived faith that potentially bypasses the problematic separation of content and process. It suggests that "knowing a tradition is more fundamentally a knowing *how* to live in and live out a tradition," as Terrence Tilley puts it in his work on tradition.[27] While this does not rule out the need for doxastic practices—those that "form beliefs for practitioners"—it does take seriously the crucial sense that "understanding" a tradition requires a kind of participation *in* it. Further, it suggests that rather than using the logic of systematic theology to evaluate a community, communities might better be assessed with the logic of a narrative, that is, a teleological discourse tracing a move from one state to another.

What I have argued thus far is not particularly original. MacIntyre's account of practice has shaped virtue ethics for quite some time. More recently it has caught the attention of a number of systematic theologians who have used it to call the theological field away from its long-standing reputation as detached from reality. According to Craig Dykstra and Dorothy Bass, a Christian definition of practices refers to "things Christian people do together over time in response to and in the light of God's active presence for the life of the world." They invoke standards of excellence that come from the historical community and its shaping by biblical and other Christian traditions.[28] Enthusiastically commending this move to MacIntyrean-shaped Christian practices as a way to address "practical atheism," theologian John Burgess praises its resonance with the ancient notion of *lex orandi, lex credendi*.[29]

TRADITION AS COMMUNICATIVE PRACTICE

There is another sense, however, in which these definitions of practice and its accompanying view of normative tradition, even in its expanded Christian form, are not adequate to the situation at Good Samaritan United

Methodist Church. They are not adequate, that is, if we take seriously the earlier mentioned contradiction. That contradiction can be described as a disconnect between convictions of generosity and welcome and pre-reflective reactions to bodies that are perceived as "Other." Even as a well-intentioned theologian/ethnographer, I responded like the white Good Samaritans to the "blackness" of the community. I also responded with discomfort to the twisted body of Tim, a group home member. These reactions are what William Connolly calls visceral, and they speak of a sense of discomfort which verges on anxiety and fear.[30] The claim of the church members that the church was getting "too black" was a complaint about feeling outnumbered; it was lodged out of a sense of losing control.

Rather than writing off such reactions too quickly as individual problems which are the result of uncaring and sinful secular cultures, I want to insist that they, too, are the effects of communal tradition. To claim this is to move to a broader question about communal identity and memory. For if traditioning is characterized by "a set of enduring practices," as Tilley says in his expansion of MacIntyre's account, it not only includes a vision, its ends, and patterns of action, but also the particular practices that extend that vision. Tilley argues that tradition also consists of attitudes, the dispositions or affective character of lived experience that fill out the communicative processes constitutive of communal life.[31] This affective, dispositional experience is not necessarily congruent with the highly cognitive and reflective. A fully adequate corrective of the belief-practice split not only reweaves knowing and doing, but also recognizes the full continuum of human experience and the complex ways that experience is produced and communicated.

Two points are crucial to correcting the belief-practice split. First, to make sense of the contradictions of Good Samaritan requires recognition of the communicative functions operative with practices, functions that require attention to bodies. As Robert Orsi points out, lived religion must attend to "knowledges of the body."[32] Communication is not simply a matter of storytelling, sermons, Bible lessons and other forms of linguistic discourse. Bodies "send messages" as well. Non-white bodies, for example, "send messages" in North American culture, as illustrated by white reactions to those designated as having "race" (or reactions of non-white persons to "whites"). Nor are bodily forms of communication limited to these pre-conscious affects. Persons with disabilities often communicate through facial expressions and other bodily movements, without spoken or written language. Second, formative practices, or those practices that fundamentally shape us into faith, are not simply displays or enactments of beliefs; they make subjects. Bodily communications are at the same time part of *formation*. Thus we must take seriously the kind of Christians being "made" in current homogeneous communities of the church.

To take these rather different issues seriously and come to see what they have in common, the notion of practice as *habitus* is helpful. *Habitus* refers to a distinctively bodily skill, since a *habitus* is an enacted form of knowledge, not simply a technique or mindless repetition. Knowledge of fencing, of how to play the piano, indeed, even the art of conversation, are examples of such bodily practices. Further, it is not just courage or patience that can be expanded by good practices, as we saw with MacIntyre; bodily knowledges are extended and improved through practice as well. Such skills, then, refer to a wisdom of sorts, and they have identity or continuity, as Pierre Bourdieu would say, not merely through following rules, but through the wisdom of improvisation. A good practitioner is able to perform a skill by improvising for a new situation. If we are to understand how bodies are part of communication, *habitus* requires a very distinct way of thinking about the body "as an assemblage of embodied aptitudes, not as a medium of symbolic meanings" as Talal Asad puts it.[33]

By focusing on the notion of embodied aptitudes, Asad directs us to a kind of knowledge that is not identical with or collapsible into the symbols and beliefs that characterize Good Samaritan.[34] If they were, then the significance of bodily practice would be missed, and we would be forever tempted to think of bodies as simply *expressing* the meanings conveyed by language, or practices of inscription. A good example of the non-translatability of such aptitudes is the development of capacities to communicate with and read the "bodily languages" of people with disabilities. Most members of Good Samaritan, myself included, did not have the skill to communicate with Tim, or with Debby. Neither had spoken language skills, but they did make noises and communicate through facial expressions and bodily gestures. Rachel could be easily upset by noise and certain kinds of movements. It was their relatives and attendants, with their years of caring cohabitation, who had developed the skills to "read" them, and to adjust and negotiate their own bodily responses so as to reciprocate in kind, for example, by gentle rubbing of arms or legs, or eye contact, or singing in response to varied, seemingly disruptive behaviors. The awkwardness of my own first reaction to Tim illustrates how important it is to perform a gesture and "affect language" that can communicate.

Bodied aptitudes, or what constitutes a *habitus,* are significant for understanding visceral reactions to racial and ability difference as well. While skills at communication with Tim and Debby come from conscious efforts at training, some bodied aptitudes are knowledges of oppression and survival. Such body knowledges come from being shaped by the cultural processes that mark groups as "other." A familiar such marker is the attribution of "race" to African Americans and other people "of color." Recognizing this attribution as a social construction rather than a biological trait illustrates that to be "black" is to be defined and marginalized by a history of social

processes in the United States. Throughout that history, black women's bodies have been marked as sexualized and dehumanized; Western culture "has created out of the black male body a walking palimpsest of the fears and fascinations possessing our cultural imagination," as Maurice Wallace puts it.[35] Such cultural identifying produces subjects; it *habituates.* As such it is a striking indicator of the power dynamics of marking. For it suggests not only that to be black is to be diminished, but that also to be "white" is not to have race. Importantly, whiteness is not simply an attribute, however largely unacknowledged. To be habituated as white is to be formed as the "normal" human. To put it more dramatically, it is like being "catechized" into a subjecthood, but without explicit recognition of such.

To think of these cultural markings as resulting in "knowledge," then, is to recognize that being habituated can be a process of gaining skills that can be negative as well as positive. This is not simply a reference to the passive symbolic meaning that is represented by white or black bodies. Not only is a *habitus* a kind of cultural bodily skill that might be admired as we admire a communally shaped virtuous character, it is also a form of knowledge that is constitutive of social identity and memory. As such, it can be as much an unacknowledged residual, which places a serious *limit* on change, as it is the creative possibility for change. To understand this kind of bodily knowledge, I turn to Paul Connerton's claim that bodily knowledges are constitutive of social memory, indeed, of the identity of communities.

TRADITION AS COGNITIVE MEMORY AND HABIT-MEMORY

While the most obvious notion of social identity has to do with the kinds of meanings associated with stories about events, from a community's public and celebrated founding events to its unsavory hidden narratives, such practices of *inscription* are not sufficient for describing social identity.[36] For just as a social entity has shared stories and self-understandings, it is also comprised of shared bodily habits. And those bodily habits, like the storable memories called practices of inscription, are part of social memory. To make sense of this phenomenon, Connerton reviews three senses of memory. There is *personal memory*, life stories that are always constructed out of the social stock of meaning; *cognitive memory*, memory for names, theories, basic mathematical computation, and so on; and "*habit-memory*," the knowledges suggested by the bodily *habitus.*[37] The first two types are typically explored by historians and those of other disciplines; both suggest what I have identified in Good Samaritans' beliefs.

It is this cognitive and storable memory that is typically identified as normative Christian traditioning. Along with the background knowledges of different historical periods, such as the cosmologies and conceptions of

healing, the Christian tradition is defined by the social version of personal memory, that is, the stories of Christian community. It is founding events in Jesus's life, death, resurrection, the birth of the church, the stories of its crises, the background narratives of the faith of Israel, and the canonization of accounts of such events that create a normative tradition.[38] What is less understood and rarely recognized as part of social memory, both for Christian and non-Christian communities alike, is "habit-memory." Communal habit-memory refers to implicit "knowledges" constitutive of a group's identity that are bodily and may or may not be dependent upon conscious reflection.[39] Here we think of social conventions about what is proper, who can wear what, who bears status and authority, and the wide variety of other conventions that display what is considered allowable and appropriate in a given society. As Connerton points out, "habit-memory" is not typically the subject of conventional history precisely because it *is convention*.[40] It is taken for granted, representing "a world taken to be the world that it is" because the rules that define it are tacit. Intersubjectively agreed upon, these habit memories are rarely rendered explicit.[41] While the table manners of the upper classes are a trivial example, the appropriate bodily postures of slaves and servants suggest the serious and complex character of "habit-memory" for social identity. There will be much naturalized habit-memory in any particular historical period.

Habit-memories vary in types. Some incorporative or bodily practices can be categorized as *bodily techniques*. An example would be modes of communication, such as the Southern Italian techniques of "talking with your hands."[42] Other habit-memories are more explicitly connected to issues of power. It is vital to identify such practices explicitly. These practices help shape and maintain a communal identity by continuing its oppressive power dynamics, power dynamics that are "taken for granted" by virtue of their multiple pay-offs for some and the inability of others to challenge them. If whites are used to being the dominant population, not only numerically, but also in relation to the power to own the social landscape, then it is in part due to their habituations into a kind of "ownership of space" that enables them to access and occupy social landscapes with unlimited freedom. Such habituations are further complicated because they are also gendered and shaped by class and are all tacit bodily knowledges. As bodily displays of what is "proper," they qualify as social *bodily proprieties* in Connerton's terms.[43] Similarly, segregations of so-called normal people from those with disabilities contribute to the creation of a bodily *habitus* that does not assume interactive communication skills with persons without language.[44] Other marginalized populations are likewise habituated into bodily proprieties that reflect their very different historical inheritances; "proper behavior" will more likely take the form of practices of submission and vigilance, requiring tacit attentiveness to the location of those in power.

While such habit-memory is not explicitly a part of Christian tradition, I propose that it is a crucial subject for further investigation.[45] What the apparently different "knowledges" displayed in Good Samaritan have in common is their status as habit-memory. The power-related knowledges of racial and normate bodily proprieties,[46] on the one hand, and the non-symbolic communications of people with special needs, on the other hand, are "wisdoms" that come from formation and get passed down in "communities."[47] The very idea that Christian communities are shaped only by normative biblical and post-biblical stories of redemption and not shaped by habituations into socially located bodily proprieties is docetic at best. At worst it continues to reproduce the false notion that what really matters is what we *believe*, not the various inheritances that shape our bodily wisdom, our social relations, and our bodily knowledge about who merits our full attention. If, as theorists and theologians of practice insist, that Christian life is about doing and not simply correct knowing, then a full understanding of the "doing" of Christian communities through the ages must include attention to those heretofore invisible conventions that are represented in bodily practices.

What "traditioned" me and many other white members of Good Samaritan UMC were racial bodily practices that gave us a sense that church space, like much of our social space, was racially homogenous. In such a traditioning, black bodies do not disrupt that habituation—leaving it natural and, therefore, invisible—if they are token in number or dressed in janitorial, housekeeping, or other uniforms signifying subordination. They disrupt and expose that white bodily propriety if they are in the majority and dressed as equals. The parallel but very different traditioning of the African-American members of Good Samaritan is suggested by much writing by African-American authors. For example, bell hooks writes of the bodily proprieties of careful vigilance that were necessary when she left the black part of her hometown growing up. Teresa Frye Brown tells of how she was taught proprieties of restraint and took care to not display her spirit and intelligence in front of white people.[48] African members of the church would have had even more complex habituations. Those of us whom society defines as "normal" have also been traditioned into bodily proprieties. Insofar as we live and worship segregated from people with disabilities, our proprieties for appropriate social space are exposed when they are disrupted by our contact with someone like Tim or Rachel or Debby, as mine were. Such disruptions take the form of what Erving Goffman calls rituals of degradation, as they reveal our inability to communicate with and "read" such persons as Tim.[49]

Given such habituations, the contradictions at Good Samaritan that are signaled by interaction with persons who are "other" trespass on "what we are used to." They represent disrupted social identities as well. As suggested

by the good intentions of the community (and me), the "knowledges" these encounters disrupt do not necessarily correlate with symbolic and narrative versions of those identities, that is, what we say we believe. Good Samaritans wished to welcome those who were different, to recognize all people as God's children. However, in doing so, they uncovered knowledges representing habituations that are, for many people, as unconscious and natural as they are deeply embedded. These knowledges are the result of social traditioning; they are as "deep in the bones" as skills like fencing and piano playing and constitute identity. If we are to call for Christian catechesis, the formation of faithful believers, then these habituations as the bodily knowledges that inevitably accompany practices of inscription must be factored into the formation process.

To factor in bodily habituations is to rethink normative tradition as lived practices that pass on the vision of the gospel. We cannot remain satisfied with defining the tradition as content; nor is it sufficient to say that tradition is content and process, at least without attention to a broad spectrum of human experience. As Tilley rightly insists, while tradition involves a vision, and patterns that display that vision, it also includes the attitudes and dispositions, or what he terms the affective character of lived experience. This affective communicative process of passing on the gospel is every bit as much defined by incorporative practices as it is by practices of inscription. Habit-memory is as constitutive of communal life as is the memory provided by story.

The implications of this broader account of tradition are, at this initial stage of thinking, threefold. First, and perhaps most difficult, theological reflection must recognize that such traditioning is not a phenomenon that can be blamed on the secular culture, the liberal state or the racist society. Habituation into the faithful remembering of Jesus, catechesis for both youngsters and adults, worship itself—all the Christian practices that enhance and extend the goods of the gospel—are practices performed by bodies. Bodies get knowledges—skills—that cannot be reduced to linguistic discourse, as the people with disabilities illustrate. Further, since bodies are already constituted by race and gender, they are already marked as subjects by power-inflected processes. These habituations are forms of affective disposition toward the world. Thus, habit-memory is as key to traditioning as Scripture and creedal formation.

Second, just as we must orient the function of written tradition to shape redemptive formation, we must orient the other communicative functions of Christian community toward redemptive formation. To pass on the gospel is to be formed by stories that shape one's character toward agape. To pass on the gospel is *also* to discern how bodily proprieties are inflected with power or powerlessness; it is to learn the appropriate habit-memory that might redeem the deeply embedded conventions of social segregation.

For as Hacker reminds us, the change in our society's long history of such segregations requires change in public discourse about bringing the races (or differently abled) together, every bit as much as it requires change in where we put our bodies.[50] Finally, the bodily proprieties of a largely race and ability segregated Christian community make Burgess's invocation of the ancient wisdom, *lex orandi, lex credendi* ("the way we worship shapes the way we believe"), rather poignant.[51] Without attention, after all, to racial and other bodily habituations, the current segregated character of that "*lex orandi*" in reality teaches us a "*lex credendi*" that contradicts the Christian call for justice and inclusivity.

NOTES

1. This is a "trivial" observation that can, however, be overlooked. Much of the work in my field, systematic theology, will acknowledge its historical context, but quickly moves on to suggest that church teachings, the creeds, the work of famous theologians, transcend their originating situation and continue to be true in ever-changing situations. Determining what it means to acknowledge situatedness as one allows for claims that continue to make (new) meaning is another complicated task.

2. David D. Hall, ed., *Lived Religion in America: Toward a History of Practice* (Princeton, N.J.: Princeton University Press, 1997).

3. Juan Luis Segundo, S.J., *The Liberation of Theology*, trans. John Drury (Maryknoll, N.Y.: Orbis, 1976).

4. My previous work is a study of the discursive practices of Christian women in different social locations. See Mary McClintock Fulkerson, *Changing the Subject: Feminist Theology and Women's Discourses* (Minneapolis: Fortress Press, 1994).

5. I did participant observation at Good Samaritan (not its real name) from 1996 to 1999. The resulting account is my book, *Places of Redemption: Theology for a Worldly Church* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 1997).

6. The names of the pastor and church members are pseudonyms given to protect anonymity. These comments come from interviews I did in the period from 1996 to 1999, and I received permission from the members to quote them.

7. Considering the impact of the ethnographer's subjectivity on the results of participant observation is clearly a quite relevant issue here, but one I cannot fully address, given space limitations. I am certainly exposing myself as the "vulnerable observer," to use Ruth Behar's notable expression. See Ruth Behar, *The Vulnerable Observer: Anthropology that Breaks Your Heart* (Boston: Beacon Press, 1996).

8. For a sociological analysis of the way claims to color-blindness qualify as serious racism in society, see Eduardo Bonilla-Silva, *Racism Without Racists: Color-Blind Racism and the Persistence of Racial Inequality in the United States*, 2nd ed. (Lanham, Md.: Rowman & Littlefield, 2006).

9. Andrew Hacker, *Two Nations: Black and White, Separate, Hostile, Unequal* (New York: Scribner, 2003), 52.

10. Erika Frankenberg and Chungmei Lee, "Race in American Public Schools: Rapidly Resegregating School Districts," Press Release, August 8, 2002, from the

Report of Harvard University's Civil Rights Project, *Race in American Public Schools: Rapidly Resegregating School Districts*.

11. Even newly arrived immigrants are preferred over blacks in white neighborhoods. Hacker cites the significant white intolerance for being in the minority. Hacker, *Two Nations*, 36.

12. For accounts of the church's relation to people with disability, see Nancy L. Eiesland and Don E. Saliers, eds., *Human Disability and the Service of God: Reassessing Religious Practice* (Nashville, Tenn.: Abingdon Press, 1998).

13. Michael Emerson and Christian Smith, *Divided by Faith: Evangelical Religion and the Problem of Race in America* (New York: Oxford University Press, 2000), 10.

14. Michael Emerson, "Beyond Ethnic Composition: Are Multiracial Congregations Unique?" (Paper presented at the annual meeting of the Society for the Scientific Study of Religion, 2000).

15. Out of a large and rich literature, a few selections include Delores S. Williams, "A Womanist Perspective on Sin," in *A Troubling in My Soul: Womanist Perspectives on Evil and Suffering*, ed. Emilie M. Townes (Maryknoll, N.Y.: Orbis, 1993), 130–49. Dwight N. Hopkins, *Being Human: Race, Culture, and Religion* (Minneapolis: Fortress Press, 2005).

16. Paul Connerton, *How Societies Remember* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1989); Eric Hobsbawm and Terence Ranger, eds., *The Invention of Tradition* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1983).

17. E. Glenn Hinson, "Tradition," in *A New Handbook of Christian Theology*, ed. Donald W. Musser and Joseph L. Price (Nashville, Tenn.: Abingdon Press, 1992), 489–90. Yves Congar has been the most important Roman Catholic thinker on the crucial nature of process in an account of tradition. See Yves Congar, O.P., *Tradition and Traditions: An Historical and a Theological Essay*, trans. Michael Naseby and Thomas Rainborough (New York: MacMillan, 1967).

18. Robert Orsi, "Everyday Miracles: The Study of Lived Religion," in *Lived Religion*, ed. David D. Hall (Princeton, N.J.: Princeton University Press, 1997), 13.

19. Congregational studies focus on much more than beliefs. See Nancy T. Ammerman, Jackson W. Carroll, Carl S. Dudley, and William McKinney, eds., *Studying Congregations: A New Handbook* (Nashville, Tenn.: Abingdon Press, 1989).

20. Examples of such work include the aforementioned *Lived Religion* volume by David Hall. Also see Dorothy C. Bass, ed., *Practicing Our Faith: A Way of Life for a Searching People* (San Francisco: Jossey-Bass, 1997); Miroslav Volf and Dorothy C. Bass, eds., *Practicing Theology: Beliefs and Practices in Christian Life* (Grand Rapids, Mich.: Eerdmans, 2002); Dorothy C. Bass and Craig Dykstra, eds., *For Life Abundant: Practical Theology, Theological Education, and Christian Ministry* (Grand Rapids, Mich.: Eerdmans, 2008).

21. Don Browning uses Gadamer, Habermas, and Thomas H. Groome's Marxist-related notion of praxis. See Don Browning, *A Fundamental Practical Theology: Descriptive and Strategic Proposals* (Minneapolis: Fortress Press, 1996).

22. A "practice" is "any coherent and complex form of socially established cooperative human activity through which goods internal to that form of activity are realized in the course of trying to achieve those standards of excellence which are appropriate to, and partially definitive of, that form of activity, with the result that human powers to achieve excellence, and human conceptions of the ends and

goods involved, are systematically extended." Alasdair MacIntyre, *After Virtue: A Study in Moral Theory*, 2nd ed. (Notre Dame, Ind.: Notre Dame University Press, 1984), 187.

23. I speak here of thinkers typically identified as "systematic theologians" as opposed to "practical theologians." While the distinctions bear more inspection, the latter (such as Bonnie Miller-McLemore and Pam Couture) are more likely to cite Don Browning, who has developed a notion of practical reasoning drawing on Gadamer. I am drawing here on the systematic theologians who have been attracted to MacIntyre.

24. The behaviors are more explicitly distinguished and defined as homemaking practices; storytelling was also key. See this discussion in my *Places of Redemption: Theology for a Worldly Church* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2007).

25. For a classic essay on this see Stephen Crites, "The Narrative Quality of Experience," *Journal of the American Academy of Religion* 39, no. 3 (September, 1971), 291–311.

26. MacIntyre's account of practices correlates temporality and change with evaluation such that the unity of a self is a unity of character defined by story, and the concept of the end puts a sort of moral trace on behavior. MacIntyre, *After Virtue*, 204–25.

27. Terrence W. Tilley, *Inventing Catholic Tradition* (Maryknoll, N.Y.: Orbis, 2000), 45.

28. Craig Dykstra and Dorothy C. Bass, "Times of Yearning, Practices of Faith," in *Practicing Our Faith*, 5–7.

29. John P. Burgess, "Acting Out," *Christian Century* 119, no. 11 (May 2002): 40–42.

30. William Connolly, *Why I am Not a Secularist* (Minneapolis: University of Minnesota Press, 1999), 19–29.

31. Tilley, *Inventing Catholic Tradition*, 45–46, 51. Tilley has rightly moved beyond MacIntyre's minimalist nod to the range of human experience and communication, signaled by his notion that tradition is a history of arguments. I say minimalist nod, because in his later work MacIntyre recognizes that creatures without language can have beliefs and acknowledges persons with disabilities. He does not, however, develop his notion of tradition in light of such. Alasdair MacIntyre, *Dependent Rational Animals: Why Human Beings Need the Virtues* (Chicago: Open Court, 2003), 29–41, 135–42.

32. Orsi, "Everyday Miracles," 7.

33. Talal Asad, *Genealogies of Religion: Discipline and Reasons of Power in Christianity and Islam* (Baltimore: Johns Hopkins University Press, 1993), 75. Here Asad is describing the work of Marcel Mauss on techniques of the body, noting that Pierre Bourdieu later popularized the notion of *habitus*. Marcel Mauss, "Body Techniques," in *Sociology and Psychology: Essays*, ed. and trans. B. Brewster (London: Routledge & Kegan Paul, 1979).

34. See Asad's account of how ritual as a discipline that produces subjects gets altered by a modern definition of religion that would have liturgy as enacted symbolism. Asad, *Genealogies*, 27–79.

35. Maurice O. Wallace, *Constructing the Black Masculine: Identity and Ideality in African American Men's Literature and Culture, 1775–1995* (Durham, N.C.: Duke University Press, 2002), 2.

36. Connerton distinguishes practices of inscription from incorporative practices. The former are practices that can preserve the past by way of print, sound tape, computer, and photographs. The last are bodily practices that send messages "only during the time that bodies are present to sustain that particular activity." Paul Connerton, *How Societies Remember* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1989, 2003), 72–73.

37. Connerton, *How Societies Remember*, 21–40.

38. This, of course, is captured in a Christian appropriation of MacIntyre's definition.

39. While MacIntyre's notion of character-shaping practice suggests traditioning is about more than cognitive formation, it does not attend to these other communicative forms.

40. Speaking of the invisibility of such habit-memory for historians, Connerton notes that "one of the limitations of documentary evidence is that few people bother to write down what they take for granted. And yet much political experience will have been built up about 'what goes without saying.'" Connerton, *How Societies Remember*, 18.

41. Connerton, *How Societies Remember*, 28.

42. Connerton, *How Societies Remember*, 81–82.

43. Connerton, *How Societies Remember*, 82–87. The third kind of bodily practice is ceremonial.

44. While this is a somewhat negative definition, their existence is suggested by what disrupts "normate" ownership of space. See note 46.

45. The most likely exception to my claim that habit-memory is not treated adequately by accounts of Christian tradition is the recognition of ritual as a bodily *habitus*. Connerton discusses commemorative practices in this vein. Connerton, *How Societies Remember*, 84–87, 41–71.

46. "Normate" was coined by Rosemarie Garland Thomson to refer to the subject position of "normality" that is produced by "social processes that sort and rank physical differences into normal and abnormal." Since all humans are fallible and, inevitably, disabled, there is no natural, universal mark between these two designations. What counts as "normal" is, thus, in complex ways the result of power and value judgments. See Rosemarie Garland Thomson, *Extraordinary Bodies: Figuring Physical Disability in American Culture and Literature* (New York: Columbia University Press, 1997), 8–9.

47. The knowledge represented by the habit memory of a normate person to communicate nonsymbolically is more intentionally learned than that of the white bodily propriety of ownership of space. To learn how to read and respond helpfully to the nonsymbolic communication of a person without language takes much focus and concentration. The bodily propriety of whiteness is learned almost unconsciously. However, both are examples of bodily knowledge or incorporative practices.

48. Teresa L. Fry Brown, *God Don't Like Ugly: African American Women Handing on Spiritual Values* (Nashville, Tenn.: Abingdon Press, 2000), 53.

49. This comes from the work of a social scientist of disability. Erving Goffman's theory of stigma is cited in Nancy L. Eiesland, *The Disabled God: Toward a Liberatory Theology of Disability* (Nashville, Tenn.: Abingdon Press, 1994), 92–93. In reality, all human beings are on a continuum of disability.

50. Hacker, *Two Nations*, 52.
51. Burgess, "Acting Out," 41.

3

Weaving a Communal Narrative: Agape United Methodist Church

*Karen D. Scheib and Barbara Hedges-Goettl**

Agape United Methodist Church[1] sits cradled between gently rolling hills on nine and a half acres of what was once farmland. The original farmhouse, which served as the first sanctuary for this congregation, currently houses the church offices. The road fronting the property now serves as a major thoroughfare. Behind the old farmhouse and further up a small hill is a modern looking multi-level brick and stucco building in which the new sanctuary is located. With its moveable chairs and open spaces, this building was designed to accommodate the changing needs of a growing congregation and community. When the congregation changed its name and moved to this location in 1989, twenty years after its founding, the surrounding community was transitioning from a rural to a suburban area.

As a "young and growing church" Agape UMC seemed a good candidate for a congregational study on the practices of care in the local church.[2] The original intent of our study was to identify the visible and invisible practices of care in this congregation. We were also interested in discovering the ways in which the church's articulated theology of care was carried out in actual practice. As we began to hear various stories about the church and its history, we learned of a potentially traumatic series of events in this congregation's past. In 1989 the pastor, Rev. Watkins, was removed from the pulpit when arrested for murder.[3] Three years later the congregation moved and changed its name. Accounts of these events were shared in personal conver-

* Barbara Hedges-Goettl conducted the historical and field research for this chapter. Karen Scheib provided the theoretical frame building on previous work published in *Challenging Invisibility: Practices of Care with Older Women* (St. Louis: Chalice Press, 2004).

sations, but did not appear in the published history of the congregation. Our discovery of these seemingly conflicting accounts of the church's history shifted our attention to how this congregation told its stories. We also wondered about the way in which what appeared to be conflicting stories shaped the identity of the congregation.

In this chapter we explore the multiple story strands that comprise the *communal narrative* of Agape UMC. Our development of the concept of *communal narrative,* as the means through which the formation and communication of corporate identity occurs, is informed by insights from narrative personality theory and narrative therapy theory.[4] Both of these theories share the assumption that the human mind is a narrating mind and that stories are the primary means through which identify is formed and communicated.[5] Before turning to the particular stories of Agape UMC, we examine the role of narrative in identity formation. We discuss the way in which multiple stories and senses of self, including those arising from both public and private domains, are held together in a coherent whole through personal myths and communal narratives.

The majority of the chapter provides a detailed description of a number of the multiple story strands that comprise the communal narrative of this congregation. At the end of the discussion of each story strand, we offer our reflections on how that strand contributes to the congregation's communal narrative. In the last section of the chapter, we provide our interpretation of this congregation's ecclesiological identity expressed through its communal narrative.

The information presented here was collected through qualitative research methods and informed by an ethnographic research paradigm. Data collection methods included participant observation over a six-month period, semi-structured interviews with the pastor and two lay leaders, informal conversations with members and leaders, and an analysis of written materials.[6] In addition thirty-one congregants completed a standardized questionnaire.[7] The theories and research paradigm employed here carry post-modern assumptions, including the conviction that human reality is socially constructed and all practice is theory laden. We are aware that when we present data collected through our research we are not reporting objective facts. Some level of interpretation has already occurred in the process of gathering and reporting information.[8]

NARRATIVE AND IDENTITY

How is a sense of identity formed and communicated to others? From the perspective of narrative personality theory, as developed by Dan P. McAdams, identity is both formed and expressed through life stories.[9] McAdams

describes the developmental narrative processes through which an individual constructs a personal myth which delineates identity and illumines the values of an individual life.[10] Personal myths are formed over the course of our lives from infancy to old age, often unconsciously, and are continually revised.[11] One's personal myth is not a fictional tale but rather communicates "personal truth."[12]

Like other postmodern theories of the self, narrative personality theory holds that the singular sense of self that we experience is an imaginary construct that holds together multiple senses of self.[13] For McAdams, personal myths serve the function of bringing together different parts of one's self and life into a purposeful and coherent whole.[14] McAdams suggests that these different senses of self arise, in part, because modern life requires us to act in a "multitude of different and sometimes, contradictory ways."[15] We often find ourselves inhabiting multiple, and sometimes conflicting roles that give rise to a multiple sense of self.[16]

In addition to the multiple roles we inhabit, particular contexts and relationships in which we find ourselves can also give rise to different senses of self. The "self" we reveal in the private world of family and friends may be both similar to and different than the "self" we reveal in the public world. McAdams suggests that the lives of many modern middle-class Americans continue to be influenced by the split between the public world of work and the private world of family that began during the nineteenth century.[17] While this public/private split is not the only factor determining the existence of multiple selves, it can be understood as one factor that may occasion the expression of different aspects of the self. The public world of work and the private world of family require different ways of being and lead to different senses of the self.[18]

FORMING A COMMUNAL NARRATIVE AND IDENTITY

Building on previous work by one of the authors, we develop the concept of *communal narrative* as the means through which a group, such as a congregation, communicates its identity and purpose.[19] We propose that communal narratives serve the same function for communities as "personal myths" do for individuals. Communal narratives are not simply a compilation of individual narratives or the sum of stories of interpersonal interactions, though these are certainly intertwined with the narrative of a community. Communal narratives communicate a congregation's sense of identity. Communal narratives bring the multiple story strands of the congregation into a coherent and purposeful whole. By holding seemingly contradictory stories together, communal narratives provide a coherent sense of communal identity.

Public and Private Stories

Early in our study we discovered that among the multiple story strands contributing to the *communal narrative* of Agape UMC were what we designated as public and private stories. The public/private split of contemporary American life that influences the formation of multiple sense of self for individuals also leads to multiple story strands within a communal narrative of a congregation. We have defined *public stories* as those that are primarily about the work of the congregation, particularly its sense of mission and purpose in the larger world. We have defined *private stories* as those stores about the internal relational life of the congregation.

Through its public stories, the congregation communicates its corporate self-image to the external world. These public stores are intended to encourage others to become a part of the congregation. Public stories usually cast the congregation in a positive light and accent its strengths. The public stories of Agape include a written history in which Agape UMC is identified as a "young and growing" church. Public stories, usually communicated in print, are enacted through programs in public settings, such as worship.

The private stories of the congregation are about events that occur within the internal relational or "emotional system" of the congregation. This emotional system includes the congregation as a family, the families of the congregation, and the families of the pastors and other key leaders.[20] Agape's private story includes stores about intimate relationships, sexuality, passions, and conflicts that occur in the realm of these intimate relationships within the families of the congregation and within the congregation as a family.

While the public and private stories that comprise a part of an individual's personal myth or a congregation's communal narrative may arise out of different realms of activity or a different set of relationships, these worlds are not always neatly divided. Conflicts in the private realm of the individual, such as marital infidelity, can affect one's performance or relationships in the public world of work. Likewise, events in the private lives of congregational leaders can impact the work of a congregation. A set of events that occurred in what we have defined as the private realm of personal relationships within Agape UMC have had a significant impact on the public life and work of the congregation. What was private became quite public.

In May 1986, the church's pastor, Rev. Randolph Watkins, was removed from the pulpit when arrested for murder.[21] He was subsequently convicted of this crime and sentenced to prison. The pastor's removal occurred in 1986, three years before the church relocated and changed its name. As we learned about this traumatic experience in the life of this congregation, we became interested in how the multiple stories, including those we named private as well as public, were woven into a communal narrative that shapes the ecclesial identity and practices of this congregation.[22]

THE MULTIPLE STORY STRANDS OF AGAPE UMC

We turn now to examine some of the various stories comprising the communal narrative of Agape UMC, both those designated as referring primarily to the public realm and those referring primarily to the private realm. The story strands included here are (1) the physical setting of the congregation and the demographics of the surrounding community[23]; (2) the church's written history; (3) accounts of the trial of the pastor accused of murder as recorded in area newspapers; (4) denominational records of membership and pastoral leadership; (5) the church's understanding of its mission and purpose; and (6) stories told by members of their experiences of being a part of this congregation.

Story Strand 1: Context and Setting

Although we might not think of the physical setting as one of the strands in Agape's narrative, it does play an important role. The church's physical location and setting as well as the demographics of the surrounding community provide the context in which the narrative of Agape unfolds. Since the congregation made the choice to move to its current location following a critical incident in its history, its location is significant.

Physical Setting and Facilities

One's first impression of the church is likely to come from seeing its signboard.[24] It provides information about the activities of the church, advertising upcoming events and announcing the sermon title. In addition, a Bible verse exhorting conversion or political statements (such as one supporting the posting of the Ten Commandments in public) are also posted on the signboard.[25] In addition, one might see banners proclaiming "Visitors Welcome," or announcing the dates of Vacation Bible School, the Pumpkin Patch, the Fall Festival, or a revival.

The new multi-purpose building was completed in 1997. The upper level of this building is used as the worship sanctuary, with movable chairs and a built-in raised choir and pulpit area. For large dinners, tables are set in this room and the commercial-sized second floor kitchen is used. The sanctuary is filled with about 200 upholstered, movable chairs that are arranged in two banks of angled rows facing a raised chancel. A communion or altar rail borders this area at the front and a low wall marks the back of the area. The communion table sits in the middle of this space with the pulpit and baptismal font on one side and the lectern and piano on the other.

Chairs for those leading worship are all in front of the low wall at the back of this space that serves as the boundary for the choir loft located several steps above the pulpit area. The lower level has a smaller fellowship

room with some kitchen facilities and multiple classrooms that are used both for Sunday school and for the church's large preschool.

Demographics of the Surrounding Community

Agape UMC had a membership of 125 at the time of our study. Within the last fifteen years the surrounding town has mushroomed, growing at more than twice the rate of the surrounding county and almost three times that of the state, which is itself growing at just over twice the national average.[26] This is also a highly mobile community. According to 2000 census data, area residents are less likely to have lived in the same house between 1990 and 2000 than residents living in the surrounding county, state, or in the country as a whole.

The demographics of the surrounding area show a population that is largely white (81.5 percent) and approaching middle age (the median age is 35.2 with 50 percent of the population between the ages of twenty and sixty-four). The median household income in this area is higher than in the surrounding county, state, or in the United States as a whole. Residents are generally well educated, with a large percentage holding bachelor's degrees. In sum, residents in the surrounding community are more likely to be white, have higher household incomes, be better educated, and own more expensive homes than those in the surrounding county and state.[27]

Reflections

The architecture of the congregation's newest building resonates with the church's self-image as a young and growing congregation. This is a relatively young congregation (thirty-five years old) with many young members, in a recently developed and growing community. The architecture of the church's main building is large and open in order to accommodate expansion. The church sits on a large plot of land, mirroring the generally large lots of the surrounding suburban homes. While the church's sanctuary is not visible from the heavily traveled road in front of the church, the signboard is. The signboard draws attention to the physical presence of the church and provides information about the church to the larger community. Beyond providing information, the signboard also communicates something of Agape UMC's identity and mission to those who pass by. The church's physical location and appearance communicate something about the identity of the congregation to the larger world and are thus a part of Agape's public story.

Story Strand 2: The Public Story in Printed Documents

Agape's communal identity as a congregation is also communicated through the various printed documents produced for public viewing. The

worship bulletin is probably the most widely distributed document, serves multiple functions in this congregation, and is updated weekly. Other forms of written communication that we examined include brochures for visitors and articles posted on the website. We did not examine written records such as committee minutes or financial reports. The written documents discussed here play an important role in reinforcing Agape's self-understanding for its members and communicating this identity to visitors.

The Worship Bulletin

The bulletin printed for the Sunday worship service is the primary means of communication for this congregation, particularly since a separate newsletter is not produced. The same design appears on the front cover each week and includes the United Methodist logo of a cross and flame. Agape's current mission statement appears on the cover of the bulletin every Sunday and states: "Our mission is to win the lost to Jesus Christ, make disciples for Jesus Christ, and provide an atmosphere of Love, Caring, and Kindness for Worship and Fellowship."[28]

In addition to the church's own mission statement, the slogan "Open Hearts, Open Minds, Open Doors" from a denominational campaign also appears on the outside of the bulletin. The inclusion of this phrase reflects the congregation's adoption of a denominational program emphasis.[29] The back cover of the bulletin contains basic information about the church, including the times of worship and Sunday School, the church's e-mail address, a URL for the website, the pastor's name, church phone numbers, and office hours. Descriptions of some of the church's programs are also found, such as "Stephen Ministry" program. Of course, the primary purpose of the worship bulletin is to provide a guide for each Sunday's worship service. The prayers recited by the congregation, the hymns, the sermon title, and the anthem to be sung that day are found on the interior pages of the bulletin.

Also found on the interior pages are the announcements for the week, a report of the amount of offering collected the previous week, and a brief note from the pastor. The pastor's notes printed in the worship bulletin serve as a primary means of printed communication between the pastor and the congregation. Each pastor's letter begins with the same opening lines:

> Welcome to Agape United Methodist Church! We are excited that you have allowed us the opportunity to share in worship with you this Sunday. If there is anything that we can do to make you feel more comfortable, please let us know. We hope that you enjoy the service and leave here with a renewed heart having been touched by God.

Beginning in September 2005, this portion of the pastor's letter was in bold print, and eventually appeared before the heading addressed to "Dear Agape Church Family."

Brochures for Visitors

Other printed documents produced by the church include brochures given during worship to first-time visitors to the worship service. Visitors are welcomed at a time of greeting and invited to remain seated while an usher brings them a coffee mug with the church's logo. Tucked inside the coffee cup are two brochures about the church.[30] Printed on the front of one brochure are the words "prayers, presence, gifts and service," which are included in the membership vows one recites when joining a United Methodist church.[31] This brochure also contains some general information about the church, including its address, phone number, and web address. However, the purpose of this brochure seems to be to encourage visitors to become members. Inside are short sections providing information on "Becoming a Member," "The Role of a Member," and "A Brief History of Agape UMC." The section "The Role of a Member" identifies key obligations of those who join stating, "When you join . . . you agree to support this church with your tithes, talents, gifts and service." This last phrase is also taken from the vows persons make when joining a United Methodist Church.

A second brochure describes "This Church's Commitment to You."

> To provide sacred and inspiring worship; To have Sunday school for all ages; To provide an activities program for every member of the family; To be here when you need us for counsel, or for help; To provide you with opportunities to serve.

The back cover contains the membership vows for those who have not previously been United Methodists, including a promise to "be loyal to the United Methodist Church," and the vows for those transferring their membership from another United Methodist congregation.[32] The shorter brochure lists "Categories by Which You Join" and describes the various ways in which members can join the congregation any Sunday. These include a letter of transfer, reaffirmation of faith, baptism, and profession of faith

Printed History

An article titled "A Brief History of Our Congregation" is included in a printed brochure and appears on the church's website. The article reports that the congregation was first chartered in 1969 one town west of its current location, but reconstituted itself under the same church charter in a new location with a new name in 1988. Prior to the church's

move, its "membership . . . fell to about 40 families."[33] In the summer of 1988 the congregation persuaded a local farmer to sell his 9.5-acre property even though the property had not been on the market. This property was well situated in a growing community to the east and in the direction of the booming growth. Within a few months of purchasing the property, the church also changed its name as it prepared to move to its new location.

According to "A Brief History," "the first service at the current location was held in the living room of the farmhouse on August 20, 1989. . . . We grew steadily to the point where we had to knock down walls in the farmhouse to accommodate our parishioners." Between 1990 and 1992 the church's membership hovered between 115 and 120. At this same time, average attendance grew from fifty-five in 1990 to seventy in 1991 to ninety-five in 1992. By January 1993 the church had grown to an average attendance of 147, with a regular membership of about sixty families. Having outgrown the farmhouse, the congregation moved to a triple-wide trailer for its worship services.[34]

A "Brief History" continues: "In 1994 we experienced rapid growth for the next few years. With about 200 members and visitors attending worship every Sunday, plans were made and executed to build a multi-use facility to house our growing congregation." The groundbreaking ceremony was held on January 12, 1997, and the old sanctuary was deconsecrated on October 19, 1997. The trailers were removed to make way for the construction and were sold to another church. Between October and December 1997, the congregation "worshipped in a big tent which was often referred to as 'the tabernacle in the wilderness.'"[35] The congregation formally moved into its new sanctuary, albeit without carpet, on December 21, 1998.[36] "On December 21, 1998, we held our first service in our new sanctuary. In June of 2000, Rev. Vernon Able was assigned to Agape UMC as Pastor. We have experienced tremendous growth since that time. God has nurtured and upheld us in the past, and our future is in His hands."[37]

Website

The church's website is another location where one can find public, printed information about the church. The main page contains the church's name and the phrase "Making Disciples for Jesus Christ: Come Join Us!" The main web page contains a photograph of the multi-purpose building that houses the sanctuary and classrooms. Immediately under this photo is the denominational phrase "Open Minds, Open Hearts, Open Doors," followed by the church's own mission statement and a link to their vision statement. While the mission statement is broadly focused on making disciples and creating a loving atmosphere for worship and fellowship, the

vision statement articulates concrete objectives through which the mission statement might be realized.[38] The Sunday schedule, the pastor's name, and contact information, including a link for directions, are also found on the main page. To the left of the main page is a menu containing links to the following: announcements, calendar, Christian education for adults, children, and youth, the church's preschool, history of the church (with a link to history of the United Methodist Church), staff, mission, outreach, Pastor's corner, music ministry, scouting, Stephen Ministry, worship service, and youth ministry.

Reflections

The primary written documents through which this church reinforces its identity and communicates this to others are the worship bulletin, the brochures for visitors, and the website. These are the documents seen by the largest numbers of people. While the website may be used more often by those unfamiliar with the church seeking information, the bulletin is seen by both members and visitors alike. The bulletin is the primary written means through which the pastor communicates to the congregation.

The story told in the written documents of the church includes its sense of mission, its denominational identity, and its self-image as a growing congregation. This self-image is clearly evident in the written account of the church's relatively short history, which presents a story of steady growth and expansion. Also prominent in these documents is the proclamation of the church's understanding of its mission. The mission statement is printed on the bulletin every Sunday and is included in brochures given to new visitors. A strong sense of denominational identity is also communicated through the frequent use of official United Methodist logos and slogans. The denomination's mission to make disciples is echoed in the congregation's own mission statement. Since the church's mission can be considered its work, these documents are a part of Agape's public stories.

Story Strand 3: Murder and Misconduct at Agape UMC

The official account of the congregation's history found on its website does not fully reveal the challenges the church has experienced regarding pastoral leadership. As the current pastor diplomatically puts it: "The congregation has a history that is very, very interesting."[39] The stories of the failures in pastoral leadership and of internal struggles and conflict appear to be private stories of the congregation. One of the lay leaders, Edward Fields, indicated that these stories "are not secrets."[40] However, most of the details did not come from our interviews, but from newspapers and other public records about the events surrounding the arrest and trial of Watkins.

Accounts from the Congregation

The accounts of Rev. Watkins's arrest and removal that we gathered from conversations with the pastor and lay leaders provided a general outline of the events surrounding the arrest and conviction of their former pastor, but few details. Most of the information about these events surfaced in informal conversations and was not discussed in the formal interviews. Perhaps the members we interviewed assumed that since we resided in the area we knew more of this church's story than we did. It was big news in the community at the time it occurred. Most of the details that we know about the arrest and conviction of Rev. Watkins come from newspaper articles written about the bond hearing and trial.

Edward Fields, who served as the administrative council chair at the time of our study, provided the fullest account of these events shared by a lay leader.[41] He noted that the change of location and name not only addressed demographic factors affecting the church's growth, but also provided a chance for the ten dedicated families who made the move to leave behind the painful legacy of a pastor currently serving a life sentence in prison for the murder of his alleged homosexual partner.[42] Fields reported that even though long-time church members who experienced this part of the church's congregation history don't talk about it much, "It isn't a secret." Folks will discuss these events, as Mr. Fields did, if asked. However, it is important to note that Mr. Fields told this story in an informal conversation prior to the formal interview, which occurred at a later date. He did not expand on these events in the formal interview, which was tape-recorded, even though prompted to by the interviewer. He lamented that the denomination was not much help during this critical time in the church's history.

In Mr. Field's opinion, denominational leaders regarded the church's move as a simple relocation of an existing congregation, while the congregation experienced this as a more significant change, since it came relatively soon after the traumatic event of Rev. Watkins' removal. Mr. Fields felt that had denominational leaders treated their move like the founding of a new congregation, rather than relocation of an older established congregation, they might have received the support they needed. Having been established only twenty years earlier, the congregation was relatively young at the time of the move. In addition, the decision to move was made only two years following Rev. Watkins's arrest and subsequent removal. In Mr. Fields's mind, the congregation's move was a time of starting over and they needed the support of the denomination in this process.[43]

In recounting the more recent history of pastoral appointments, Mr. Fields stated that the "the last pastor before the current one (Bob Meadows)

was accused of a lot of things which were not true."[44] Mr. Fields indicated that this pastor was not removed, but that he left voluntarily (in 1999) when charges of misconduct were brought to the administrative body of the church. This former pastor now works as representative for a church directory photography service and serves as a freelance evangelist. In recounting these events as well Mr. Fields indicated unhappiness with how these events had been handled by the denomination.

Accounts from Newspaper Articles: Rev. Watkins

According to these newspaper reports, Rev. Randolph Watkins, who had been serving the church since 1982, was charged with the brutal murder of Lyle Baker in 1986. It was alleged that Rev. Watkins was engaged in a homosexual relationship with the victim. The local newspaper reported that during the 1986 bond hearing, approximately "ten witnesses, including fellow United Methodist ministers and members of his congregation, appeared to testify on Rev. Watkins' behalf" to request leniency.[45] However, the medical examiner offered evidence regarding the cruelty and violence of the murder, stating that the number and severity of [the knife] wounds suggested "'torture or punishment,' and the intensity of the attack seemed to indicate an emotional bond between the victim and his killer."[46]

Witnesses at the 1986 bond hearing also presented testimony regarding two prior arrests of Watkins. The first was a 1978 arrest for fondling a teenager in her home during a counseling session. The sheriff was ordered to drop charges after being approached by influential community members who belonged to the church, despite records which stated that Watkins had drawn a .22-caliber revolver on the sheriff who attempted to arrest him. In a diversion agreement, Watkins had agreed to seek counseling. There is no official report indicating whether this counseling had taken place.[47] The second arrest occurred when Watkins and another man were discovered by the security manager of a local discount store engaging in sexual relations in the men's room. Store officials decided not to prosecute, but issued a warning to the men to stay out of its stores or risk prosecution. At the bond hearing Watkins's defense attorney tried to dismiss this second arrest by noting "that the incident had been investigated by a commission from the United Methodist Church, including the use of polygraph tests, and no action was taken against Watkins."[48] However, given the violent nature of the 1986 crime and the record of past arrests, the court denied Watkins's bond request on May 23, 1986.

At the trial itself, the defense attorney stated that the case was based "exclusively on circumstantial evidence." The defense quoted Watkins's statement to police that "he had been attacked by an unidentified assailant," that he found Baker wounded but alive inside the house, and that he left

after Baker urged him not to "get involved."[49] This defense was apparently unconvincing. The jury found Watkins guilty of murder and sentenced him to life in prison. Watkins was placed on leave of absence from the church in 1986 and had his conference membership and clergy credentials revoked in 1987.[50]

Reflections

These critical events of misconduct and murder were shared in bits and pieces in informal conversations by the pastor and lay leaders. However, these events were not repeated in recorded interviews, even when the interviewer who had heard the story previously from the interviewee posed direct questions. Written accounts of these events from the archives of local newspapers provided details that were not recounted by church members. Reading articles written at the time these events occurred gave us a very different picture than the one painted by the more vague recollections of church members. Church members may have assumed that this story was known in the larger community since it was big news at the time. These would clearly be unusual events in the life of most congregations and it's understandable that they might wish to put these events behind them.

One sentiment that was repeated by the lay leaders and the current pastor was a feeling that the denomination had not handled these matters well and had not provided the congregation with the kind of leadership it needed to recover from the trauma surrounding Rev. Watkins's arrest. In the interview, the pastor stated that the congregation felt "that they've been mistreated by the conference by and large."[51] It is not clear what kind of support, if any, was provided to the congregation to deal with the removal of their pastor under these unusual and violent circumstances.

The events that led to Rev. Watkins's arrest initially occurred in what we would consider the private realm of personal relationships. However, given the violent end to the relationship between Rev. Watkins and the victim and the violation of public laws, these events soon became public record. The public life of the congregation was significantly affected by these events that erupted out of the private sphere into the public. The public story of the congregation's name change recorded in this history makes no link between these events and the congregation's move and name change. However, the proximity of these events to the congregation's decision to move and change its name is quite striking. We can easily speculate that there is some link between Rev. Watkins's arrest and the church's decision to move. Mr. Fields does suggest that the move and name change did allow the church to put painful events from their past behind them. Perhaps the congregation's name change was an attempt,

likely unconscious, to restore the delineation between private and public spheres in the life of the church.

Story Strand 4: The Public Story in Denominational Records

Denominational records, which comprise part of the "official" written history of the church, are based on information that is supplied by the congregation to denominational offices. We have focused our attention on the attendance records from 1982 to 2004. The official attendance records show alternating periods of growth and decline. Some of the declines in membership seem to be correlated with changes in pastoral leadership and with the critical events of pastoral misconduct that occurred in the life of this congregation.

Attendance and Membership Records

According to the church's membership records submitted to the denomination, attendance fell from 171 to 91 during the first year of Rev. Watkins's ministry (1982–1983), and then remained relatively constant through 1987. Net changes in membership show slight increases during his tenure from 1982 to 1983. However, ninety-three transfers occurred between 1983 and 1984, for a net loss of seventy-one, a significant drop in membership. This loss appears to correspond in time to Watkins's second arrest. Membership then leveled off with net losses of two in 1985 and eleven in 1986; in 1987, a net gain of two was recorded.[52]

In the first few years following the move, the church experienced a precipitous drop in attendance and membership, which had been relatively stable from 1984 to 1988. Membership growth began to resume in 1993 and generally continued through 1999. Over this period, membership increased from 117 members to 378 between 1999 and 2000. While membership appeared to grow, attendance showed the opposite trend. Official statistics note a significant decrease in attendance beginning in 1998. Attendance dropped from 212 in 1999 to 133 in 2000. The reasons for this drop are unclear. Perhaps they are related to the removal of the previous pastor. This might have been due to the congregation's objection to the appointment of a woman pastor. She served only two years and was followed in 2001 by Bob Meadows, the pastor at the time of the study. Attendance continued to drop during the first year of his appointment, but began to increase by his second year of service and continues currently. Bob Meadows's appointment might have initially stirred controversy as well, since this was a cross-racial appointment. Bob, who is African American, was appointed to a church that was primarily, if not exclusively white in 2001. Attendance figures for 1982 to 2004 are listed in table 3.1.[53]

Table 3.1

Year	Total Full Members At Close of Yr	Average Worship Attendance
1982	307	171
1983	313	162
1984	242	185
1985	240	86
1986	229	87
1987	231	84
1988	219	87
Name change took place between 1988 and 1989		
1989	124	68
1990	115	55
1991	120	70
1992	117	95
1993	147	125
1994	163	115
1995	190	134
1996	215	146
1997	245	185
1998	286	199
1999	357	212
2000	378	133
2001	352	139
2002	317	120
2003	319	150
2004	272	170[1]

1. A good number of those leaving membership (for example 60 in 2004) are "removed by charge conference action or withdrawn." Withdrawn means a member voluntarily removed his/her name from the membership list. Removal by charge conference action is an administrative removal of names of persons who have not been attending or been active members for a designated period of time. Usually, some attempt has been made to contact these members to see if they desire to remain on the membership role before this action is taken.

Pastoral Appointments[54]

Denominational records also include the names of all the pastors who have served this church and their dates of service. One striking pattern that emerges when reviewing these records is the succession of short-term pastorates following Rev. Watkins removal. This pattern of short-term pastoral assignments, some lasting as little as one year (the minimum time for an appointment) continued until 2001. Articles from area newspapers also confirm the quick succession of ministers. The pastor who served immediately after Rev. Watkins remained only one year and was followed by a second pastor who also stayed one year. The first pastor to follow Watkins requested a voluntary leave of absence in 1989, though he later returned to

active ministry in other United Methodist churches in that area.[55] Denominational records list a second pastor as having been on voluntary leave beginning July 1999, and ending in 2000 with his retirement from active ministry.[56] The congregation's first woman pastor, who served two years from 1999 to 2001, followed this pastor. Rev. Bob Meadows, the pastor at the time of our study, was appointed in 2001.

Reflections

The story told by denominational records about levels of attendance and membership did not always correspond to the story contained in the congregation's own printed accounts of its history. In contrast to the picture of continued growth depicted in "A Brief History of Our Congregation," denominational records showed cycles of growth and decline in both attendance and membership. This discrepancy seems noteworthy since it is the congregation's responsibility to report attendance and membership figures to denominational officials. The net growth over time may allow the congregation to see itself as on a trajectory of growth. Periods of decline may be understood simply as brief interruptions in a pattern of growth.

A second interesting mismatch occurred between accounts of the history of pastoral leadership communicated in conversation and interviews and in denominational records. In our search of these records, we discovered information that had not been shared with us by any of the persons interviewed. For example, we discovered the service record of a woman pastor who served the church for a year. Neither the church members interviewed nor the current pastor mentioned this person or commented on her service. We also discovered a discrepancy regarding the starting date of the current pastor between the denominational records and the church's history on its website.

Memories, whether individual or corporate, are not simply remembered facts, but are a construction or interpretation of past events and serve to inform one's identity in the present. The church's self-image as a "young and growing church" as it describes itself on its website is reinforced by a particular recollection of attendance patterns over the last twenty or so years. It is hard to discern the role of the absence of any account of the tenure of the woman pastor in the church's story. Unless the denominational records are inaccurate, this omission would seem to have some meaning.

Story Strand 5: Moving On Under New Leadership

If some members of the congregation initially perceived Rev. Bob Meadows's cross-racial appointment as yet another example of the denomination following its own agenda rather than taking account of their needs, this may explain the drop in membership shortly after his appointment. Yet,

based on conversations and interviews with church members, many in the church seemed to consider the appointment a sign of the denomination's recognition of the church's need for healing and stability after many years of crises and frequent pastoral changes. Rev. Meadows, who served as a United Methodist pastor for five years prior to serving Agape UMC, came to his current vocation following a twenty-year career as a corporate executive for a large multi-national company. Denominational leaders and members of the congregation may have perceived Rev. Meadows as having the leadership skills necessary to support the church's ongoing recovery and provide a modicum of stability. The church appears to have experienced this pastor's leadership very positively. The website claims that during his tenure the church has "experienced tremendous growth." When the announcement was made in worship of Pastor Bob's reappointment for the coming year, the relief was visible. Apparently, many members were afraid that they might lose him to another church in the area undergoing turmoil significant enough to be reported in the local paper.

Despite the positive perception of Rev. Meadow's leadership, he notes that his tenure has not been conflict free. He believes that ideological conflicts are more likely to arise when immediate survival is no longer the primary concern. External threats often cause a community to draw together despite differences.[57] An internal conflict, which Rev. Meadows described as "ideological" emerged not long after he arrived. In his opinion, this internal conflict arose in part because the church was less focused on past events of pastoral misconduct or financial difficulties in the church and attendance was steadily increasing. Such conflicts may have been ignored in the past when members felt a need to band together for survival.

Meadows describes his perception of how this ideological conflict arose and the nature of the conflict:

> Organizations that are weak struggle for survival, so consequently their perception is that anything that shows up will help them survive. In this case it was a financial statement . . . So what you have is that you have groups of people who show up, and irrespective of what their ideologies are, they tolerate each other along the line because the real emphasis, and the real focus, is on how are we going to meet this month's bills, how are we going meet this month's need to do the things that need to be done. And what happens is that as soon as you get to a point where that is not the main focus again, the differing ideologies emerge and you have conflict and that drives the organization back into survival mode. In our church [we] had a group of people who were what I would consider to be flaming liberals, from all standpoints, politically, theologically, you know, the whole nine yards, and that was a point of conflict in the church, although in a lot of cases they were not yelling at each other, but it was something that was very, very apparent to people who were outsiders.[58]

The crux of the conflict appears to have been differing theological perspectives between some of the members and the pastor. The pastor perceived this conflict as a challenge to his freedom of the pulpit.

> That group of people had a problem with some of the sermons. They came and confronted me with that, and I basically told them that I wasn't going to have anyone to tell me what I can and cannot preach. They said well, we have to leave and I said "bye." It wasn't quite that abrupt, but that's what it amounted to. We had a person who was a staff member here who was a part of that. Ultimately, because of some other circumstance, that person was asked to resign. The whole tone of the church changed. And suffice it to say; I'm not saying that they are bad people, what I'm saying is that where they are and where the vast majority of people in this church are is just different.[59]

Meadows noted that this conflict now appears to have been resolved. This resolution involved both membership losses and gains.

> I had a conversation recently with a family that is getting ready to be a member of this church, they had visited here more than a year ago and had made a decision that this church was not the place for them and in talking with them a year later what they said was that um, ah, that after they had visited around that some of the people who knew them and that had invited them to some activities and their observation was that the conflict that they had observed a year earlier had gone away.[60]

Three years after arriving, Rev. Meadows led the congregation in a strategic planning exercise. He states that he felt they were not ready to engage in this exercise until that time. The church's current mission statement, found on the website and the Sunday worship bulletin, emerged from this process. The vision statement, also found on the website, is more recent and represents an attempt to translate the mission statement into action statements. Rev. Meadows feels that the congregation is now prepared to move into the future.

Reflections

The lay leaders we interviewed, as well as the pastor, gave a sense that the church has weathered both externally and internally generated crises and is now experiencing a period of relative stability. Meadows's leadership seems to have been well received. He had served five years at the time of our study, which was a longer tenure than several of his immediate predecessors. Meadows helped the congregation shape its current mission statement, which emphasizes evangelism and connection. He may also be responsible for the strong United Methodist identity reflected in the printed materials. Clearly there is some feeling of having been treated poorly by the

denomination, yet official symbols and logos appear on the bulletin, the primary written document produced by this congregation.

Rev. Meadows also seems to have a clearly defined theological perspective, which might be characterized as conservative. His report of the "ideological conflict" indicates that he believes his theological position is in keeping with the majority of the congregation. It is interesting to note that the conflict was resolved when those who had a difference of opinion chose to leave. The lack of external threat did not seem to lessen this congregation's need for a sense of cohesion and theological agreement.

Story Strand 6: Enacted Mission

A significant dimension of this congregation's current communal narrative is its sense of mission, which is communicated not only through various form of oral and written communications (e.g., sermons, brochures) but is enacted through its worship services and programs. The church's mission statement reads as follows: "Our mission is to win the lost to Jesus Christ, make disciples for Jesus Christ, and provide an atmosphere of Love, Caring, and Kindness for Worship and Fellowship."[61]

"Winning the Lost" and "Making Disciples"

The first part of the church's mission statement, "to win the lost to Jesus Christ, make disciples for Jesus Christ," echoes language found in the denomination's statement about the mission of the church.[62] The mission of the United Methodist Church as articulated in *The United Methodist Book of Disciplines* states: "The mission of the Church is to make disciples of Jesus Christ."[63] It appears that Agape UMC has truly embraced this mission and claimed it as its own. In addition to appearing on the cover of the church bulletin weekly, various versions of this mission statement appear in several locations on the website. The web page describing the church's outreach ministries contains the following: "The AUMC Outreach committee works on important projects to reach out and show Christ's love to those in need."[64] On the youth page we find this statement: "The Youth Ministry exists to reach non-believing students, connect them with other believers, help us all grow in our faith, and honor God with our lives." A similar statement is found on the page providing information about the preschool:

> The goal of our ministry with children is to lead each one to an acceptance of Jesus Christ as their personal Savior and to develop God-like habits in their relationships with others, loving God and loving their neighbors as themselves.[65]

This mission to "seek the lost" and make disciples is also enacted through various programs of the church. One example of this is the church's "pump-

kin ministry." The sale of pumpkins, which occurs throughout the month of October, was consistently referred to as the "pumpkin ministry" in announcements made during worship. This ministry was referenced not only during announcement time, but also during prayer time. One Sunday in October someone in the choir shared the following as a prayer concern during the worship service:

> There are too many folks who come to the pumpkin patch who don't have a church and don't have a family in a congregation. When you guys work the (pumpkin) patch ask, "Do you have a church?" If they have a church, fine; but take the time to ask because there are lots of folks that need us." The pastor commented, "The harvest is plenty and the workers are few. Is that how it goes?" The original speaker responded, "Yes, that's how it goes." The following week, the associate pastor included in her prayers: "Gracious heavenly Father . . . You know our hearts. We want to not just be sharing [Christmas] boxes or letters [for children in other countries through the Christmas Child box program] or pumpkins; we want to be sharing you.

In addition to these public statements, more casual comments confirm this missional understanding of the pumpkin ministry. One of the researchers overheard a conversation in worship on October 30 in which a pumpkin patch worker reported to another member that he told one family of potential buyers that they could just have the pumpkin(s) if they would come to worship on Sunday. The church sells Christmas trees during the Christmas season with a similar understanding of this sale as ministry and not simply fundraising.

A commitment to this mission of "making disciples" is expressed through other church-sponsored events, including Fourth of July activities, a revival in August, and a Fall Festival in mid-October. On the Fourth of July, the church makes the churchyard and parking lot available for viewing the town fireworks for a small fee and provides refreshments and hosts games for the children while families wait to view the fireworks. During this event, the associate pastor talked with visitors about the church and invited them to worship.[66]

The August revival, which is a series of worship services held outside the regular Sunday hour, is also seen as an opportunity not only for reviving one's faith, but for finding the lost and making disciples. Prior to this event the pastor's weekly letter in the bulletin contained the following

> Once again I need to remind each of you to BRING SOMEONE TO REVIVAL . . . please note that I encourage you to bring someone, that means that I expect you to be there. We have an all-star lineup to lead each of the worship services. It is my expectation that we will have great music and great preaching; however it is the spirit of worship that each of you brings that will make this a "Hallelujah" good time. Let's come together and make this a great time of worship.[67]

At another community event, the Fall Festival held, October 15, a southern gospel-singing group provided the primary witness. Many church members attended and assisted with this event. The pumpkin patch was open and there were several vendors, including the "Nimble Fingers" group, which does knitting and crochet work for sale and for charities, providing baby blankets for premature babies who survive and burial shrouds for those who don't. Community participation was encouraged through a free concert and supper was served for a nominal fee.

In addition to these special events, ongoing programs also embody the church's commitment to "make disciples."[68] During the six months of our study, three Bible studies were offered and we learned that a prayer group is offered year-round. Various approaches to prayer are emphasized in the "Pastor's Corner" articles on the website. Sunday morning adult Sunday school offers four class choices, while the children's Sunday school serves all ages. Vacation Bible School served more than seventy children the previous summer.

The emphasis on making disciples is also evident in worship. The pastor's sermon frequently challenges members to live up to their call to be Christian, and on most occasions some come forward for prayer during the hymn of invitation. Numerous prayer requests are publicly voiced during the worship service. The Sunday the pastor preached on "We Have Met the Pharisees . . . [and They are Us]," calling people to account for the ways in which believers do not listen to Jesus, nineteen congregants came to the front for prayer. During this time, most pray not only individually, but also with the pastors and worship leaders who are available.[69]

An Atmosphere of "Love, Caring, and Kindness"

The second sentence in the church's mission statement expresses the church's commitment "to provide an atmosphere of love, caring, and kindness for worship and fellowship."[70] This statement is enacted through programs such as the Stephen Ministry and in regular pastoral appeals to hug others in the congregation when departing worship. Agape UMC sees itself as a community that cares for its own and seeks to create a loving environment in which members can worship and live out their commitment to the Christian life.

One of the church's stated goals is to "become a medium sized church, *retaining the warmth and intimacy of a small congregation* (emphasis added)." This desire for warmth and intimacy is summed up by the pastor's words at the end of every service: "Don't forget to hug two or three people on your way out." These words are so familiar that congregation members often repeat them along with the pastor.

Rev. Bob Meadows described what he calls the "the parking lot test" through which he gauges "how people kind of feel about each other in a congregation."

> When worship is over, how long does it take before the people leave? And it takes a long time because people want to get around and be with each other. So they stand around after worship and talk with each other, visit with each other, and a lot of them go out to have lunch with each other.[71]

The intention to create a caring community is not only expressed in the church's mission statement but is also embodied in its programs. Some of the programs examined in the earlier section, such as the Fall Festival or August Revival, not only serve the evangelistic commitments of the mission statement, they also provide opportunities to create the loving fellowship among members to which the church aspires. The Stephen Ministry program, a lay pastoral care program, is the program that most directly addresses the church's mission to create a particular kind of community. Sheila Price, who serves as the coordinator for the Stephen Ministry Program, reflected on the church's caring ministry:

> It's what this congregation does . . . and that's something kind of unique. I think in this congregation . . . they naturally offer caregiving even to people you would consider relative strangers. A prayer request might be lifted up in church and someone would receive a card or letter from a member of the congregation that did not really know them very well, but had just heard that request and wanted to offer a note of encouragement; I find that to be a unique characteristic that people just up and do that without being assigned a role. They are not members of the official congregational care committee; it's just what people naturally do in this congregation.[72]

The desire to be a warm and caring community is experienced as present reality, at least by some members. The responses from the thirty-one participants in the congregational survey indicated that these persons experienced the congregation as warm and caring. The statement "Our congregation feels like a close-knit family" garnered responses averaging a little better than "quite well" (toward "very well").[73] Statements about the caring atmosphere of the church are prominent in worship experiences and the pastor's bulletin letters. In personal conversations with congregants about the church, themes related to the concepts found in the second portion of the mission statement include belonging, inclusion, gratitude, and exhortation.[74]

Sheila Price expressed her sense of the congregation not only as a place of love and care between members, but also as a community in which one experiences the love of God. It is this experience of God's love that makes the fellowship the church desires possible. She describes the congregation as a place of "a deep abiding caring for one another." She continues:

> And that caring extends not only to people that you know very well, but to total strangers who just walk in off the street; that's exhibited time and time again. A deep love of Christ and the knowledge of a sure and active presence

> of God in the life of this congregation, not only in the life of this church per se, but in the life of individuals, and a willingness and a passion to share those experiences with others. While certainly everybody perceives God in different ways and has different experiences with a living God, people are more than willing to recognize that my experience can be different from yours and each is valid in its own right.

The themes of God's grace and the warmth of the community were cited by Sheila as reasons she stayed in the church during a period of conflict. She joined the church on the heels of the resignation of the pastor in 1999. This pastor resigned under accusations of pastoral misconduct thirteen years after the removal of Rev. Watkins. She talks about her decision to stay through a difficult period:

> I think it was mostly prior to me (the difficulties in the church) so it's hard for me to give a handle on this. I came here on the tail end of one of the problems (1999) . . . and I can just answer on why I chose to stay in the midst of it. . . . I was totally devastated at what I saw being played out in the parking lot and in the sanctuary and among individuals; and the one thing that kept me here was the very real presence of God that I continued to feel, a supernatural presence of God that I continued to feel even in the midst of the trouble.
>
> Q: What did you see as indicating that presence of God?
>
> I could still see that love in individuals even in individuals that were battling with each other; I could still see individuals' aspects of that in each individual; and I was not willing to walk away from that love that I had received there. I wanted to be a part of whatever might happen to even find out as opposed to just wash my hands in the situation and then walk away, so I did not have the ties to the congregation nor did I have the ties to the years [of] history that some of the individuals had; that wasn't what kept me there it wasn't all the years of struggle it wasn't that because I was a newcomer. It was the very real presence of God and the possibility that I still continued to see in this congregation and I wanted to be a part of that most of the time.

Sheila points to "the presence of God" and the love among persons, even those who "were battling with each other" as reasons she stayed. Here she echoes the central themes of the congregation as contained in its very public mission statement.

Reflection

The commitment expressed in the mission statement, "to win the lost to Jesus Christ, make disciples for Jesus Christ," is clearly central to the church's communal narrative and proclaims something of its purpose and identity. We might summarize the church's self-identity in the following way: "We are

people who seek to conform our lives to Christ, and to help others do the same." Those who visit Agape UMC receive this message in several ways on their first visit: through the worship bulletin, printed material, the pastor's welcome statement in the bulletin, and through invitations to church membership or altar calls. Those who choose to join know something of this church's communal narrative and presumably identify with it.

This identity, as a church that reaches beyond itself to "save the lost" and extend the gospel into the world, demonstrates that it understands itself as participating in the shared mission of the Christian church. Given the particular history of this congregation, is it possible that this mission takes on added significance by focusing the church beyond itself and its own troubled history? It could be noted that this congregation had personal experience through its pastoral leadership with someone who appears to have lost his way. Claiming this mission of "saving the lost" declares that, in spite of its problems, this congregation has "good news" to share that comes from beyond itself.

WEAVING A NARRATIVE

We have examined some, though not all, of the stories of Agape UMC, some of which were designated as primarily public while others were categorized as primarily private stories, though as we have seen the designations are not always clear cut. These multiple strands contribute to the construction of this congregation's communal narrative. We turn now to our interpretation of how these particular story strands are woven together. Should we see contradiction in these multiple strands? Do the public and private stories cohere in some way or represent two disparate narratives and identities present in this congregation?

As noted earlier, from the perspective of narrative personality theory the existence of multiple story strands is not seen as contradictory, but rather as a normal part of human experience. Narrative therapy theory not only recognizes the existence of multiple story lines within a narrative as normative, but also seeks to highlight the existence of hidden or unrecognized story lines as part of the therapeutic process. One of the initial tasks in narrative therapy is to name the "problem" story that has come to dominate a person's life.[75] The "problem story" focuses only on the dimensions of the person's life related to the problem. A central goal of a narrative therapist is to assist a person to construct a narrative that includes stories reflecting other dimensions of one's life beside the problem.[76] These counter stories include stories that illustrate the person's ability to break free of the influence of the problem.

We might speculate that this congregation did experience being caught in a problem-saturated narrative in the years between 1986 and 1989 and

perhaps longer. Church members may have begun to feel that the identity of the congregation was narrowed to "that church where the pastor was accused of murder." The congregation's decision to change its name when it relocated could be read as support for this interpretation. The former name of the congregation reflected the county in which it was located and since the move occurred within the same county, the change was not required. Edward Fields, who experienced these events, felt that the move and name change did indeed provide a break with a painful past. What is interesting to note is that the church's written account of its history, which is readily available on the website, gives no indication that the move was motivated by anything other than a desire for church growth. Fields complained that the denomination did not understand all the factors behind the church's relocation, yet the denomination may have held that same view as reflected in the church's public statements.

Moving beyond a "problem story" requires the recognition of additional story strands and allows for a more complex sense of identity. In addition to the change in name, over time the congregation also claimed story strands about winning the lost, making disciples, and creating a warm and caring environment for its members. These elements of the church's identity emphasize God's grace and provide a way for the congregation to focus on something beyond themselves. Perhaps it also reflects a sense of gratitude for having survived. Having received God's grace, the members feel called to share this with others. Having also experienced the warmth of a caring congregation in the midst of personal or communal challenges, they want to bring others into this community.

Beyond understanding the psychological dynamics shaping this congregation's narrative, how might we understand its narrative processes theologically? If narrative does indeed communicate one's sense of identity, then how does the narrative comprised of multiple strands communicate the church's communal identity as a Christian congregation? To put this differently we might ask how this church constructs its ecclesial identity.

FORMING AN ECCLESIAL IDENTITY

As we have seen, a significant element of this congregation's ecclesial identity is its designation as a United Methodist congregation. This identity is embraced in several ways, including the use of United Methodist symbols on printed documents and adoption of a mission statement very similar to that of the denomination. We believe that the congregation's embrace of its United Methodist heritage as a significant part of its ecclesial identity provided this church with important resources for resilience as it dealt with some of the traumatic events in its past.

The church's mission statement links its identity to that of the Christian church as a whole and affirms its identity as a United Methodist congregation. The congregation's adoption of "making disciples," a key phrase from the denominational mission statement, as well as its use of denominational symbols, supports the conclusion that this church has a strong denominational identity that shapes its self-understanding. A significant part of this church's communal narrative appears to be the way in which it perceives its mission to be a part of the larger mission of the United Methodist church.

Agape's two-part mission statement indicates that it is not only concerned with extending God's love to those beyond its walls, but also embodying this love in its communal life. The congregation's desire to create "an atmosphere of love, caring, and kindness" is not unique to Christian congregations. However, it is possible that the inclusion of this desire in the mission statement and the intentional ways this atmosphere is fostered, including the pastor's weekly reminders to hug someone, have particular significance for this congregation given the conflict and divisions that appeared to have occurred in its history. Sheila's comments indicate that this atmosphere is about more than just positive feelings among community members, but rather is a sign of God's presence in their midst.

The connectional polity of the United Methodist Church may have helped this congregation feel that it was not entirely on its own, but a part of something larger than itself, thus providing a another story strand to its narrative. At other times this denominational identity may have allowed the congregation to place blame for some of its troubles outside of itself. Because of the way in which pastors are deployed in the United Methodist Church, appointed by the Bishop rather than called and hired by the congregation, denominational identity is critical to understanding how the church might have been able to weather the failures of pastoral leadership. Since the congregation did not choose its pastors, it need not feel responsible for their failures. If this congregation had been in a denomination with a call system, the congregation may have felt a greater sense of accountability for these pastoral failings since the church would have been responsible for hiring its pastors.

In addition to understanding Agape's narrative in terms of denominational affiliation, we might also understand the congregation's ecclesial identity through Avery Dulles's ecclesiological typology, in which he identifies five models of the church.[77] The two models most evident in Agape's narrative are the church as "herald" and the church as "mystical communion."[78] Dulles identifies the church as "herald" as a common model in the Protestant tradition. In this model the church is primarily gathered and formed by the Word, while the sacraments often play a sec-

ondary role.[79] The church, having received the word, has a particular responsibility to pass it on. Thus, mission takes on a central role in this model.[80] In the "mystical communion model," the focus is on intimate fellowship in the Spirit and a strong sense of community is emphasized, often with an internal focus.[81]

Evidence of the church as "herald" model is easily found in the first part of Agape's stated mission to "seek the lost" and "make disciples," as well as in its practices with new visitors. New visitors are given information about how to join the church and become a disciple. Preaching also plays a central role in the life of this congregation, not only on Sunday morning, but also during the August revival. The primary purpose of a revival is proclamation and conversion. One of the recent church conflicts was about the evangelical content of the preaching. The congregation also understands its various programs and activities, including the selling of pumpkins, to be opportunities for evangelism and proclamation of the good news. Even the church signboard is used as an opportunity to proclaim a word to passersby so that the church might fulfill its mission of evangelism. As noted earlier, this outward focus may have been very helpful to the church when events within its internal life were quite painful.

The focus on intimate fellowship that is characteristic of the church as "mystical communion" is reflected in Agape's commitment to be a warm, loving, and caring community, which is expressed in the second part of the church's mission statement. We earlier examined how Sheila expressed her experience of the warmth of this community. It is one of the main reasons she chose to stay even through a difficult period in the life of the church. The many church fellowship events are not only opportunities to proclaim the good news to others, but also provide a means to strengthen the bonds of fellowship between members. Worship is not only a place where the Word is proclaimed, but also a time in which members are encouraged to foster the feeling of warmth by hugging someone on the way out. This sense of internal cohesion may have also been important to those who stayed after many others left the church. The church's desire to retain a sense of warmth while growing may point to some of the tensions created in simultaneously embracing these two models.

At the same time that coexistence of these two ecclesial models might produce some tension, they may also provide some balance and stability in the life of this congregation. It is hard to determine how long these models have been present and if they were a means to Agape's survival of the traumatic events in the past or were formed as consequence of these events. The presence of both of these models, one that focuses more externally and one more internally, may also provide us additional clues of how the public and private stories of Agape cohere into a communal narrative and identity.

CONCLUSION

Through an exploration of the multiple story strands of this congregation we have observed the way in which narrative practices provide meaning in the midst of difficulties in forming a communal identity. We have also seen the way in which public and private elements of a communal narrative might both diverge and intertwine. Not only is this congregation guided by narratives themes of God's grace that one is called to share by seeking the lost, and that is a warm and caring community, it enacts these themes through these relational practices. Only through a study of the lived experience and practices of this congregation were we able to gather any clues as to how it coped with difficulty and constructed a communal ecclesial identity.

NOTES

1. At the request of the church, and as a condition for their participation in this study, the name of the church has been changed. Pseudonyms are used for the church and for all persons interviewed, and noted in the church's history. This congregation is a part of the United Methodist Church.

2. This information is found on the church's Website in "A Brief History of Our Congregation." The church was thirty-five years old at the time of the study.

3. Rev. Watkins is a pseudonym as are all names used in this document.

4. The concept of communal narrative has been expanded beyond what was first developed in Karen Scheib, *Challenging Invisibility: Practices of Care with Older Women* (St. Louis, Mo.: Chalice Press, 2004) 52, 61.

5. See Dan P. McAdams, *The Stories We Live By: Personal Myth and the Making of the Self* (New York: Guilford Press, 1993), for a description of his narrative personality theory. For narrative therapy theory see Michael White and David Epston, *Narrative Means to Therapeutic Ends* (New York: W. W. Norton Co., 1990); also Martin Payne, *Narrative Therapy: An Introduction for Counsellors* (London: Sage Publications, 2000), 20–24; also Jill Freedman and Gene Combs, *Narrative Therapy: The Social Construction of Preferred Realities* (New York: W. W. Norton, 1996), 19–41.

6. One of the leaders interviewed served as the chair of the administrative council and the other serves as the coordinator of the Stephen Ministry program. The administrative council coordinates the various ministries and programs of the congregation. The pastor recommended the persons interviewed.

7. The survey used was "This Is Our Church: A Congregational Study," United Methodist Congregational Study by the United Methodist Office of Research (since closed).

8. For a discussion of the postmodern assumptions of narrative therapy see Payne, *Narrative Therapy*, 20–24; also Freedman and Combs, *Narrative Therapy*, 19–41.

9. McAdams, *The Stories We Live By*.

10. McAdams, *The Stories We Live By*. This brief summary is a synopsis of McAdams's theory of identity formation.

11. McAdams, *The Stories We Live By*, 11.

12. McAdams, *The Stories We Live By*, 13.

13. See, for example, Romm Harre, *Personal Being: A Theory for Individual Psychology* (Cambridge, Mass.: Harvard University Press, 1984); or Kenneth Gergen, *The Saturated Self: Dilemmas of Identity in Contemporary Life* (New York: Basic Books, 2000).

14. McAdams, *The Stories We Live By,* 12.

15. McAdams, *The Stories We Live By*, 118.

16. Ibid.

17. McAdams, *The Stories We Live By*, 119.

18. Ibid.

19. See Scheib, *Challenging Invisibility*, 52, 70–71, for a further discussion of forms of narrative.

20. I am borrowing this designation about the congregation as a family, the families of the congregation and the family of the pastor from Edwin Freidman's discussion of the components of the emotional system of a congregation in *Generation to Generation: Family Process in Church and Synagogue* (New York: Guilford Press, 1985).

21. Randolph Watkins is a pseudonym.

22. See Scheib, *Challenging Invisibility*, 52–54, and 58–63.

23. This includes demographic information from the U.S Census Bureau.

24. After the township bought some frontage property from the church, this road now has four through lanes plus turning lanes. The large store that had been denied zoning board permission has since been approved and built.

25. These observations are based on the real contents of this signboard.

26. Census Bureau data for this community shows a 62.5 percent change in population between 1990 and 2000; although census data estimates a 2.4 percent drop in population between April 1, 2000 and July 1, 2003. The city government's website estimates a 7 percent increase between the 2000 Census and June 30, 2005. quickfacts.census.gov/qfd/states/13/1367284.html, 12/2/2005 and www.ci.roswell.ga.us/Departments.asp?Page=346, 12/2/2005. Anecdotal evidence from living in the community suggests older homes are being replaced by larger, more expensive homes or by retail facilities. *City Quick Facts from the U.S. Census Bureau*, quickfacts.census.gov/qfd/states/13/1367284.html, 12/1/2005; *County Quick Facts from the U.S. Census Bureau*, quickfacts.census.gov/qfd/states/13/13067.html, 12/1/2005; *County Quick Facts from the U.S. Census Bureau*, quickfacts.census.gov/qfd/states/13/13121.html; *State Quick Facts from the U.S. Census Bureau*, quickfacts.census.gov/qfd/states/13000.html, 12/1/2005.

27. *Quick Facts from the U.S. Census Bureau*, quickfacts.census.gov/qfd/states/1300.hmtl, 12/1/2005.

28. Agape UMC worship bulletin.

29. There is no specific indication on the bulletin that this is a United Methodist phrase rather than one unique to this congregation.

30. Barbara had visited (and remained seated as per instruction) three or four times before receiving this mug and materials.

31. These words in this order are spoken upon reception into membership in the United Methodist Church. *The United Methodist Hymnal: Book of United Methodist Worship* (Nashville, Tenn.: United Methodist Publishing House, 1989), 48.

32. *The United Methodist Hymnal*.
33. "A Brief History of our Congregation," November 8, 2005, Church website.
34. All data is from the *General Minutes of the Annual Conferences of the United Methodist Church*, Evanston, Ill.: UMC General Council on Finance and Administration.
35. Historical information is from "A Brief History of Our Congregation" found on the church's Website.
36. Historical information is from "A Brief History of Our Congregation."
37. Church website "A Brief History of Our Congregation."
38. These concrete objectives focus on community, worship, and education.
39. Interview with the senior pastor, October 18, 2005.
40. Interview with Edward Fields.
41. A pseudonym.
42. The *Atlanta Journal* and the *Atlanta Constitution*.
43. Interview with Edward Fields.
44. According to conference reports, there were actually two female intervening pastors. For 1999, only one woman's name is listed. In 2000 there are two women listed, one of whom was appointed, the other of whom was a Deacon, rather than an elder, who was hired by the church rather than appointed by the Bishop.
45. Gayle White, "Witnesses say pastor cited in sex crimes. Judge rejects bond for minister charged in 'brutal' stabbing death," *Atlanta Constitution*.
46. *The Atlanta Constitution*
47. Ibid.
48. Ibid.
49. Ibid.
50. Annual Conference records.
51. Interview with senior pastor, October 18, 2005. The conference is the body responsible for oversight of congregations. The Bishop, who presided over the conference, is responsible for appointing the pastor to a congregation.
52. Watkins had his "conference membership terminated under complaint/charges" in 1987.
53. All data is from the *General Minutes of the Annual Conferences of the United Methodist Church*, Evanston, Ill.
54. Pastors in the United Methodist church are "appointed" by the Bishop. In contrast to a "call" system in which the congregation essentially hires the pastor, in an appointment system, the Bishop assigns the pastor to a church. While there is a consultative process between the congregation and the Bishop, the Bishop has final authority over the assignment of pastors to congregations.
55. Notes from *The Journal of the Conference of the United Methodist Church*. Identifying information has been removed to protect the anonymity of the church.
56. *2000 Annual Conference Report*.
57. In family systems terminology, anxiety increases the tendency for systems to move toward fusion. See Ronald Richardson, *Creating a Healthier Church: Family Systems Theory, Leadership, and Congregational Life* (Minneapolis: Augsburg Fortress, 1996).
58. Interview with the senior pastor, October 18, 2005.
59. Interview with the senior pastor, October 18, 2005.

60. Interview with the senior pastor, October 18, 2005.
61. Agape UMC worship bulletin.
62. Church mission statement.
63. From *The Book of Discipline of The United Methodist Church 2004* (Nashville, Tenn.: United Methodist Publishing House, 2004), section 1, paragraph 120, xxx.
64. All quotes taken from the church website (the name has been changed as previously noted).
65. Church mission statement.
66. Administrative Council Meeting, April 10, 2005.
67. Church bulletin, pastor's letter, August 7, 2005.
68. In all the data collected from worship services, Sunday school, and interviews, the terms "opportunity" and "opportunities" occur fourteen times, placing these terms solidly in the middle group of terms mentioned most consistently. The general brochure for the church uses opportunities as its theme, listing "Worship Opportunities," which includes Sunday worship with a nursery provided and children's church and monthly communion; "Opportunities for Learning" Sunday school for all ages; Bible study; guided study of the Psalms and annual confirmation class; "Fellowship Opportunities" of monthly Young at Heart luncheon, UM Men and UM Women; "Musical Opportunities" listing choir rehearsal; "Youth Opportunities"; and Sunday evening fellowship and Tuesday and "Opportunities to be of Service."
69. When communion is served, a greater portion of the congregation kneels at the prayer rail after receiving the elements. On these occasions, more people pray by themselves, rather than with the ministers.
70. Church mission statement.
71. Interview with senior pastor.
72. Interview with lay member "Sheila Price" who serve as the Stephen Ministry coordinator.
73. N = 31; Likert of 3.3 on scale of 4 = very well; 3 = quite well; 2 = somewhat; 1 = slightly.
74. Belonging includes love; community, care* (* indicates all forms of the word were counted), together, welcome, share, congregation, join, friend*, the use of "family" to refer to the church, inclusion refers to uses of every, each, and all when referring to communal activities and participation. Gratitude encompasses grateful* and thank*. Exhortation includes calls to such things as experience*, opportunities, and excitement*.
75. Freedman and Combs, *Narrative Therapy*, 15, 66.
76. Freedman and Combs, *Narrative Therapy*, 47–50.
77. Avery Dulles, *Models of the Church*, exp. ed. (New York: Image Books, Double Day Press, 2002).
78. Dulles, *Models of the Church*, 39–54, 68–80
79. Dulles, *Models of the Church*, 68.
80. Dulles, *Models of the Church*, 69.
81. Dulles, *Models of the Church*, 39–54.

4

Culture-Coded Care: Ecclesial Beliefs, Practices, and Artifacts in Response to Illness

Susan J. Dunlap

INTRODUCTION

For several decades, pastoral theology has been reclaiming its theological roots at the level of deep formative assumptions as well as at the level of practice, such as the emphasis on the uses of scripture in pastoral counseling. This development highlights theology as a crucial and fundamental aspect of our field.[1]

More recently, the field of pastoral theology has also recognized the importance of identifying the cultural and ecclesial contexts of care, giving particular attention to the matrices of power distributed according to race, gender, ethnicity, sexuality, and age.[2] Awareness of the deforming impact of oppressive social structures has been claimed as part of excellence in pastoral care and counseling. This development highlights literatures of feminist and womanist theory, analyses of race, and post-structuralist philosophers.[3] Even more recently has been an effort in both pastoral theology and practical theology that builds on these earlier developments. Like the reclamation of theological categories, this effort focuses on the religious and theological worlds of its subjects. These studies, like the contextual analyses that precede them, uncover the circulation of power at the local level, at the level of the very particular.[4]

The study of lived religion by pastoral theologians is a natural outgrowth of these recent developments in our field. It includes the observation of the role of particular theological truth claims, for good or ill, in the practices of actual communities. Such an enterprise uncovers the impact of our theologies in the lives of believers and opens the possibility of seeing how seemingly

problematic categories (submission, for example) can be deployed for liberatory ends.[5] The study of lived religion reveals socio-cultural power dynamics at the very local level. For example, rather than describing large social forces of patriarchy or white supremacy, the study of lived religion focuses on highly particular practices, such as sending sympathy cards, and discerns in them unique hybrids of multiple historical and cultural strands, possibly including the operations of deforming power relations. Such studies identify the individual, local places where power circulates in specific everyday activities.

The study of lived religion encourages pastoral theologians to see individuals and communities as *creators of culture in a theological idiom.* If scripture and theology have been established as essential and primary sources for pastoral theology, and if the theories of power which reveal the destructive operations of white supremacy, patriarchy, and other power formations have also been established as intrinsic to excellence in pastoral theological scholarship, then the study of lived religion further highlights the generative, constructive dynamics of local communities. Robert Orsi describes this emphasis.

> Rethinking religion as a form of cultural work, the study of lived religion directs attention to institutions and persons, texts and rituals, practice and theology, things and ideas—all as media of *making and unmaking worlds*. The key questions concern what people do with religious idioms, how they use them, what they make of themselves and their worlds with them, and how, in turn, men, women, and children are fundamentally shaped by the worlds they are making as they make these worlds [emphasis mine].[6]

"The making and unmaking of worlds" is what we are about as pastoral theologians. Our scholarship deals with the practices of care and counseling, the sites of nothing less than world transformations at individual, familial, and community levels. The study of lived religion allows us to see individuals and communities not only as passive *objects* of larger cultural forces, but also as creative *subjects*, as agents in the construction of culture, particularly during times of pain and stress. According to Orsi,

> The religious person is the one acting on his or her world in the inherited, improvised, found, constructed idioms of his or her religious culture. The study of lived religion focuses most intensely on *places where people are wounded or broken*, amid disruptions in relationships, because it is in these broken places that religious media become most exigent [emphasis mine].[7]

This chapter is devoted to looking at three congregations as sites of the construction of culture, in particular material culture, in response to the "disruptions" of illness. While illness is not as momentous a disruption as war or natural disaster, it is certainly a disruption of an individual life, a family, and at times a whole church community. Congregations create hab-

its of response to these disruptions, "where people are wounded or broken," out of "the inherited, improvised, found, constructed idioms of [their] religious culture." These habits of belief, practice, and the artifacts that are embedded in them, that are constructed in response to illness are the topic of this chapter.

CONGREGATIONS AS SITES OF BELIEFS AND PRACTICES

Beliefs, which are connected to a past preserved in texts, rituals, oral traditions, and symbols, are also connected to present day *practices,* such as caring, teaching, preaching, serving, worshiping, discerning, and praying. Because beliefs and practices are linked inextricably as each gives the other its particular force or meaning, I refer to particular "belief-practices."

What Serene Jones says about doctrine, can also be said of belief-practice matrices. Jones writes that doctrine can be understood with two images: "lived imaginative landscape" and "drama."[8] As *landscape*, doctrines (or, for our purposes, belief-practices) create "imaginative spaces that we occupy—we inhabit them and learn to negotiate the complexities of our living through them," including our illnesses. They "demarcate the interpretive fields through which we view the world and ourselves and are not merely 'truth claims' whose objective factuality demands our assent."[9] As *drama*, doctrines (and belief-practices) also function as "ruled patterns of performance" which "craft the character not only of individuals but of entire communities as well." Doctrines (and belief-practices) are the "script" for "ruled patterns of thought and behavior," including the script and ruled patterns for illness.[10] Congregations and their belief-practices will offer varying landscapes and dramas, and it is the purpose of this essay to spell out the predominant belief-practices relating to illness in three churches.[11]

A congregation's beliefs and practices regarding illness constitute, in the final analysis, a congregation's treatment of finitude. The central theological issue raised by illness is the human response to being creatures rather than the Creator. I do not speak of finitude as simply mortality, the inevitability of death. Rather, illness is a face-to-face confrontation daily with the fact that we are alive and that we are limited, fragile, and vulnerable in many ways. Illness confronts us with the reality of finite bodies—our own and others—and our limited control over their well-being. The question brought to the fore by illness is the question of how we respond to our finitude: do we anxiously search for salvation in a piece of the finite, created order, such as a treatment regimen or correct prayer; or do we turn to the one who is the source of all life, the infinite Creator?

Churches are not composed of generic human beings, and one is never simply a sick generic person. Rather one is a sick woman, a sick African

American, a sick old person, a sick white person, a sick man, a sick Latina, a sick lesbian. Karla Holloway writes of "black death" and how African Americans "die a color-coded death."[12] In a similar way, the sick endure color-coded illness, or a gendered illness, or a Hispanic, gay, female, old, straight, young, or white illness. Therefore, a congregation's beliefs, practices, and artifacts will always exist in relation to larger power matrices, and this chapter will consider how these belief-practices subvert, reinforce, or leave untouched social power structures.

MATERIAL CULTURE, BELIEFS, AND PRACTICES

Embedded in belief-practices are myriad material objects, ranging from the communion chalice to images of Jesus to the church building. There has been great interest in exploring the material cultures of various religious communities. An early definition of the scholarly field of material culture understood a culture's objects to be the means of accessing core beliefs. In an article titled, "Mind in Matter: An Introduction to Material Culture Theory and Method," Jules Prown wrote, "Material culture is the study through artifacts of the beliefs—values, ideas, attitudes, and assumptions—of a particular community or society at a given time."[13] The scholar uses cultural artifacts to access the mind of a community, Prown claimed.

Later scholars recognized that artifacts are not only a crystallization of a culture's beliefs, but, as they are used, they help to reproduce such beliefs. Colleen McDannell, when considering Christian material culture, claimed that:

> The symbol systems of a particular religious language are not merely handed down, they must be learned through doing, seeing, and touching. Christian material culture does *not simply reflect* an existing reality. Experiencing the physical dimension of religion *helps bring about* religious values, norms, behaviors, and attitudes. Practicing religion sets into play ways of thinking. It is the continual interaction with objects and images that makes one religious in a particular manner [emphasis mine].[14]

Objects are not the final product, a dead end, a final representation, in the operations of a culture. Rather they are intrinsic to a culture's life, as they are caught up in the beliefs and practices of particular people.

David Morgan implicates material objects even more strongly as integral aspects of the belief and practice matrices of a particular culture.

> If culture is the full range of thoughts, feelings, objects, words, and practices that human beings use to construct and maintain the life-worlds in which they exist, material culture is any aspect of that world-making activity that happens

> in material form. That means things, but also includes the feelings, values, fears, and obsessions that inform one's understanding and use of things. But that is not all. As I understand it, the study of material culture gives special attention to the scrutiny of practices, that is, *what people do with things*. As a field of inquiry, material culture assumes that meaning does not inhere in things, *but is activated by them*. Meaning is *a complex process of interaction in which people, objects, environments, histories, words, and ideas take part* [emphasis mine].[15]

This very brief essay is an attempt by a life-long Presbyterian to render a faithful, respectful, and appreciative account of some of the uses of material objects on occasions of illness in three congregational settings. The objects are presented in their original world of belief and practice. I explore these congregations' responses to the body when its fragility comes to the fore in times of illness. Each congregation develops ways of thinking about the body, habits of responding to it, and understandings of God's response to the body's pain or peril.

COMMON PRACTICES, COMMON CONTEXT

This is a study of three particular congregations, which I have called Healing Waters Church, First Downtown Church, and Our Lady of Durham Church. All of the churches engage in time-honored ecclesial practices: visiting the sick at home and in the hospital, praying for the sick in worship, providing meals, transportation, house cleaning, child care, and companionship. They all believe that God's desire is that people should be healthy and whole. Sunday morning worship is the center of church life, and scripture, along with preaching based on a careful study of scripture, is at the core of worship in all three churches. They all have ministries to the sick in the community outside the church walls. Finally, they are all located in the same city, Durham, North Carolina, population roughly 190,000. Originally the City of Tobacco, Durham has become a center of medical and biotechnological research centered in Duke University Medical Center and the Research Triangle Park. It is now called the City of Medicine. I have written about the beliefs and practices of these congregations in a book-length work, *Caring Cultures: How Congregations Respond to the Sick*.[16] In the course of studying these congregations, I discovered material cultural evidence that included rich iconography, adorned worship spaces, architecture marked by theological conviction, pamphlets, framed founding documents, and varieties of forms of dress for divine worship. I realized that these material objects and buildings are core bearers of a congregation's belief-practices. They are not incidental to what a congregation believes and does, but they are indispensable carriers of the care that a congregation provides to the sick. Part of the "construc-

tion of culture" in response to the "disruptions" of illness involves material culture in its many and congregationally-specific forms.

Material culture raises eyebrows for Protestant theologians. When I was in seminary, a professor told us of another professor of bygone days who wanted to emphasize the fact that we in the Reformed tradition do not worship the Bible, but the God of the Bible. To make this point, he picked up a Bible during his lecture and flung it across the classroom. It was the transcendent Word that we worship, he emphasized, and the material Bible can be treated as so much trash. This was a rather dramatic illustration, and it created an impression on me. Given this background, you may understand my emotional response upon entering the material world of Apostolic Holiness with its prayer cloths, anointing oil, water, salt, and herbs. I found the world of Latino Catholic popular religion even more dazzling with its images, statues, candles, and home altars. Finally, I was most intrigued to discover that my own most iconoclastic and logocentric of traditions, Calvinism, has produced a congregation that, in the face of an impoverished historical corpus, has improvised a material religion.

LIVED TACTILE RELIGION

This essay addresses a particular aspect of material religion: what I am calling "tactile religion." It addresses specifically uses of that which is meant to be touched, held, and embraced by the sick, as well as pieces of the material world that hold, anoint, and embrace believers in their illness. Originally I had conceived of "tactile religion" as a subset of "material religion" which also included objects that were not accessible through touch, but through sight, smell, or hearing. Yet the subject of this essay exceeds the realm of "material religion" in that it also includes the animate, the living human body, as part of tactile religion. Thus, as I am using the term, tactile religion reaches beyond the inanimate objects normally considered by scholars of material religion to include the living human body.

My interest in uses of the material arises out of a concern for practices of care for the sick in my own Reformed tradition. When it comes to illness many Presbyterian congregations display elements of the Weberian notion of "disenchantment," a modernist, mechanistic, rationalist material world devoid of mystery, "robbed of gods."[17] For the most part, the sick body has been relinquished to the world of biomedicine, access to which we should be grateful. However, this leaves the sick and their caregivers impoverished categories and practices for understanding God in relation to their illness. Not only is the power of God segregated from the sick body, but it is also segregated from material objects which might open the believer to the transcendent. I am defining spirituality here not only in terms of particular

disciplines of prayer, fasting, and ways of reading scripture, but as a receptivity to the divine, the transcendent, and mystery in the material world, including the sick body.

During times of illness, the body comes to the fore. When one is healthy, there is a unity of mind and body. We want to cross the room to pick up a book, and our body-selves do it with ease. When one is sick, the body and the will can be unhinged: it may become impossible to carry out the desire to cross the room to pick up a book. The body moves to the foreground of awareness as its pains and incapacities dislodge it from the mind with its wants and needs. Is it possible during illness, when the body is foregrounded, that material religious objects mediate the holy in unique ways? Is it possible that the touch, feel, temperature, texture, and weight of materiality can provide a particular sort of access to the sacred dimensions of life, and even to illness itself?

THREE CONGREGATIONS

Healing Waters Church

In the African American Apostolic Holiness congregation I'm calling Healing Waters Church, the primary response to illness is healing. Like many other churches in this tradition, this congregation teaches that illness is caused by the devil. Therefore, one of the primary roles of material objects is to protect the body from the devil or to cast out the devil. Anointing oil, holy water, and prayer cloths were particularly important in this regard. One woman described rubbing oil all over the afflicted part of her body, "saturating it," she said. Another described rubbing oil all over the body of her young son during a sickle cell anemia attack saying, "In the name of Jesus, I plead the blood of Jesus, I bind every evil attack, I curse every attack of the enemy, and I believe God for your healing in the name of Jesus." The child also wore a tiny red prayer cloth pinned to his underclothes for the first two years of his life. The pastor explained to me that these objects are "points of contact" between God and the sick person.

However, in these churches, "tactile religion" often includes not only objects but also the human body as a sacred icon. For example, at Healing Waters Church, the bodies of worshippers are often engaged in shouting or holy dance, and become what Daniel Albrecht calls "kinesthetic icons."[18] It is the *movement* of the human body that draws worshippers into the presence of God. In Albrecht's words, "According to Pentecostal ritual logic, God is expected to move, but so are God's worshippers . . . They move even as God moves."[19] These bodily icons function visually as they are viewed by fellow worshipers, but these icons also reach out to others, they touch, embrace, and anoint, and they shepherd others immersed in ecstasy.

Bodies also function as icons in another sense, as the church's welcome for its founding pastor demonstrates. On the first Sunday I visited the church, the service had been going for twenty or so minutes, and the pastor still had not arrived. Then the worship leaders began an enthusiastic lead up to his entrance. It was clear that their respect and affection ran deep, that he was a person worthy of honor, and that his arrival was a significant event. I expected a big man, a towering figure, to sweep down the aisle in black robes, full of power and authority. When the moment came for him to enter, I turned around to face the door, and down the aisle came an old man in a black clerical robe, pushed in a wheelchair. I quickly realized he was a quadruple amputee. They rolled him to the front, and, at the time for his sermon, he was picked up and put on a high stool behind the pulpit. He spoke with great authority and vigor, and he waved his shortened arms to emphasize his points. The people I interviewed spoke with great admiration for the founding pastor's strong faith even as he grew sicker and sicker. They interpreted his illness as serving a purpose: "So that God might be manifest." Several people reported being buoyed in their faith as they witnessed the strength of his faith throughout his illness. His sick yet powerful body clearly served as an icon.

First Downtown Church

In contrast to Healing Waters Church is First Downtown Church. Located only a mile or so from the former church, it is a starkly different world. Because of the strong Protestant, iconoclastic Reformed tradition, members have a spare historical corpus of material objects to call upon in times of illness. For them, the causes and cures of illness are explained in biomedical terms, though sometimes psychological categories, like stress, were invoked. This congregation displays the Weberian "disenchantment of the world" to the greatest extent of any of the congregations I studied.

However, I discovered that the members have improvised a tactile religion in relation to illness. Greeting cards play an important role. Several people brought out bundles of cards in a box, or tied with a ribbon, that they kept long after they were well. The congregation has also contributed such "sacred objects" as prayer shawls. One man with cancer was offered a laying-on of hands, but instead of accepting this offer, he sent out an e-mail asking the congregation to "give him a hand." He explained he wanted cutouts of people's hands. People sent well over a hundred paper, felt, stitched, glued, and painted hands to him. For others who were sick, people made quilts, signed blankets, gathered one flower from many members' gardens, and designed customized t-shirts. In this most "disenchanted" of the three worlds I explored, the members nevertheless honored an impulse toward seeing the divine in the mundane by creating their own material and tactile links to the divine.

However, these objects were not a direct link to the divine. At the Apostolic Holiness Church, people reported God directly speaking, sending, preventing, healing, and demonstrating a variety of things. In contrast, at First Downtown Church, there were few references to God's direct action. When I probed further, asking where God was in their illness, almost without exception, people responded, "in the community." In their eyes, material objects do not provide a direct link to the divine; they are not "a point of contact" with God as at Healing Waters. They primarily constitute a connection to "the community" which *does* mediate God. For example, the woman with breast cancer who pulled the pink blanket around her, found in it a link to the women who signed it, and they were her link to the divine. The hand cutouts were a connection to the people who cared, and these people mediated the divine. All this is to say that in this Presbyterian congregation, material objects held a sacred character, but they were a bit removed from the divine: the sequence was object-community-God.

Our Lady of Durham Church

I am calling the third church I studied Our Lady of Durham. It is home to a large Latino sub-congregation that remains rather distinct from the larger congregation. According to Roberto Goizueta, Latino Catholics are inheritors of medieval Christianity's "profoundly sacramental view of the cosmos. Creation everywhere revealed the abiding presence of its creator, a living presence that infused all creation with meaning."[20] Echoing this sentiment, the priest of the Latino sub-congregation referred to the rich "sacramental imagination" of his parishioners.

For historical reasons, many Latinos have had limited access to the sacrament of the Eucharist. Rural areas and small towns had access to the sacraments only on occasion because the New World was so large and the number of priests so few.[21] This history of limited access to the sacraments has led to a greater emphasis on the sacramentals in Latino piety.

The term "sacramentals" has a slightly different meaning than the more commonly used term, "sacraments." The sacraments, of course, are material objects that mediate the saving grace of God. The efficacy of the sacraments depends on the correct application of form to the material elements. Sacramentals, on the other hand, are material objects whose efficacy is dependent on the strength of piety of the one who is using them. In this Latino community candles, rosary beads, wallet-sized pictures of Our Lady of Guadalupe as well as gigantic pictures of her, small statues of Jesus, Mary, and the saints serve as sacramentals. In addition, the priest splashed holy water on homes, cars, trucks, medals, children, sinners, and sick bodies. In the home of a paraplegic man, there were several dolls dressed as various saints on the mantle, and one of them was a doll of a small child representing

Jesus dressed as a doctor in all white. On his chest was written, "*niño Doctor Jesus*" (literally, "boy Doctor Jesus"). The man's wife pointed to this Jesus and said, "*Here* is the doctor of the house." When enormous pictures of Our Lady of Guadalupe and Juan Diego came through Durham on a pilgrimage from Mexico City to New York, this man was one of many who lined up to touch them, seeking healing for their bodies. Sacramentals permit access to the holy to those who are sick.

An important visit to my home also helped me to learn more about an additional function of material objects in Latino spirituality. I had told one older woman that, as a Protestant, I was not familiar with Mary, the mother of Jesus, and that I would like to understand her better. I soon realized she was very concerned about this. She asked if I would like her to bring a picture of Mary to my house and leave it there for a week. I agreed, thinking it might be a way to bring a general blessing to my home. At the appointed time, the woman arrived at my house with twelve other women, men, and children. As they stepped out at the curb of our cul-de-sac, they began to sing and handed me a large picture of Our Lady of Guadalupe adorned with an arch of silk flowers over the top. We went into my house, knelt on the floor, sang, and eventually said the rosary. The ceremony lasted over an hour.

Rather than bringing a general sort of blessing to our home, this guest was bringing a *person* to our house so that I could meet her. She was introducing me and my family to a living, beloved person, and bringing her to live with us for a week. The material object was merged with an actual beloved person who would mediate through her son his healing power to the sick.

"FINITUDE" AS PRIMARY THEOLOGICAL LENS

The belief-practices discussed above can be understood as the products of each congregation's generative, culture-creating negotiation of human finitude.

Each congregation has developed belief-practices to deal with the *trials of bodily finitude*. Toward that end, they all provide such practical help as meals and transportation. They also all provide presence in visits to the sick at home and in the hospital. They all pray for people who are sick. Yet each specializes in what they believe is the primary form of God's presence to the sick and how they, as a church, mediate it. At Healing Waters Church, healing is the primary way they mediate God's presence to people facing the trials of human finitude. Through the prayers of the faithful, the strength of belief, and the channel of particular healers, "God is going to move," God will heal the sick. Offering another emphasis, First Downtown Church seeks to mediate God's presence through the support of "the community." The interpersonal bonds of sustaining presence, care, and on-going commitment constitute what is described as the primary way God is present

during the trials of bodily finitude. At Our Lady of Durham, being a prayerful presence during illness was the primary response to illness. The weekly visits to the hospital, which included prayer and the reading of scripture, were a core part of the church's ministry. Again, both practical help and words of prayer and scripture are also part of both Healing Waters Church and First Downtown Church's belief-practices.

Each congregation's belief-practices also deal with the question of *God's relationship to the finite*, God's relationship to the created order. In the case of illness, it is a matter of God's relation to the sick body and to material objects which mediate God's presence to the sick body. At Healing Waters Church the sick body is the site of God's healing power. God intervenes directly and heals the sick body. God invokes praise in the people who respond with fully embodied prayer as they engage in a holy dance. The moving, active bodies in worship serve as icons of the God who moves and who acts in healing, transforming ways. Material objects are channels for God's power, such as healing oil, prayer handkerchiefs, salt, and herbs, as well as the body of the healer. By contrast, at First Downtown Church the body is only indirectly the site of God's healing power. God's healing power is manifest primarily through modern medicine, though the emphasis on the mystery and unknowability of God leaves claims about the mode of God's healing action somewhat open ended. Because of the strong Protestant, iconoclastic Reformed tradition, members have a spare historical corpus of material objects to call upon in times of illness. However, they have improvised with cards and letters, and created such "sacred objects" as prayer shawls, paper hands, quilts, flowers, and customized t-shirts to communicate divine sustaining presence. At Our Lady of Durham, it is firmly believed that God heals the sick body and that through suffering of the sick body one draws closer to the suffering Jesus. The holy is accessed through multiple material objects, such as statues and images of Our Lady of Guadalupe, candles, and holy water dispensed by the priest.

Each congregation's belief-practices reflect a negotiation of *relative access to finite goods* accessible through social power—such goods as health care, housing, jobs, and status. At Healing Waters, where relative access to finite goods, particularly medical care, has historically been limited, there is greater confidence in extra-biomedical forms of healing. Furthermore, in African-American communities there is greater suspicion of the reliability of biomedicine in the wake of such injustices as the Tuskegee Syphilis study.[22] On the other hand, at First Downtown Church, where there is greater relative access to material goods, such as the offerings of biomedicine, there is greater confidence in the effectiveness and trustworthiness of medical care. In contrast to Healing Waters, there is little talk of invoking God's power to heal the sick there. However, greater access to the finite goods of society renders them vulnerable to the isolating effects of wealth.

For example, financial resources make it possible to buy services for the young, the old, and the ill instead of calling upon friends, family, neighbors, and church communities. At First Downtown Church, the isolating effects of financial independence are ameliorated by the congregation's emphasis on interpersonal support during illness. The great American "pursuit of loneliness" is disrupted by the presence of supportive community during illness.[23] At Our Lady of Durham, where 80 percent of the congregants are undocumented residents, and where most members are single men, there is a painful separation from family. Crossing the border, for either the U.S. resident or the family member abroad, is extremely difficult and hazardous. Therefore, during times of illness, many members of Our Lady of Durham are cut off from important sources of nurture and guidance. The church's ministry to the sick is in many ways a substitute for the family's presence.

BELIEF-PRACTICES AS SOURCES OF ILLNESS MEANINGS

Why is it important for caregivers to understand belief-practices and artifacts? Belief-practices and artifacts are sources of *illness meanings*, and in order to care adequately, caregivers must attend to these meanings. Arthur Kleinman reminds us that all illnesses have meanings. He says baldly, "Acting like a sponge, illness soaks up personal and social significance from the world of the sick person."[24] These belief-practices are the raw material out of which the sick cull interpretations for their illness.

Empathy is the first move in pastoral care, but attending to meanings is often essential as well. The *Dictionary of Pastoral Care* defines empathy as "the ability to identify with and experience another person's experience . . . by (as much as possible) suspending one's own frame of reference in order to enter the perceptual and emotional world of the other."[25] As a first move in pastoral care, it is vitally important to "enter the perceptual and emotional world of another." But what if the person's perceptual world is distorted? What happens when the way their world is constructed is based on falsehoods? What about the lies that some families tell? "You are no good and will never amount to anything." "Love has to be earned." "Real men don't cry." The ambient culture tells lies based on racism, heterosexism, ablism, ageism, and sexism. If compassionate caregiving starts with empathy, it also often requires moving beyond empathy to attend to the distorted readings of God, self, other, and the world. Caregiving will also attend to the *meanings* of things, addressing the distorted *interpretations* of God, self, other, and the world. Skillful care for the sick will include attending to illness meanings. In order to respond to a care receiver's illness meanings, it is helpful to understand the belief-practices from which they were constructed.

Earlier I discussed the usefulness of the study of lived religion to *scholars* in the field of pastoral theology. This leaves unanswered the question of what *practitioners* can learn from the study of lived religion, again an area normally discussed by historians or anthropologists of religion. Why should the practitioner—the one who directly comforts the bereaved, guides the perplexed, and binds up the wounds of the brokenhearted—take up the task of identifying the lived religion in religious communities? Briefly, there are several reasons. First, a knowledge of lived religion expands our empathic entry into the world of the care receivers. If our care givers' eyes are opened not only to feelings, family dynamics, and ways of emotionally and cognitively constructing a world, but also to the roles, rules, and cultural artifacts that relay meaning, comfort, belonging, and a connection to the transcendent, then our empathic capacities are enlarged. Knowledge and fluency in a care receiver's lived religion expand our empathy.

Second, knowledge of lived religion provides "handles" for pastoral interventions, for broadening or stretching the world of a person in pain. As care givers, we are accustomed to working in the realm of imagery, discerning a care receiver's operative image of God, for example, and possibly suggesting new ones. In a similar way, care givers can discern the rules, roles, and meaning-laden artifacts in a care receiver's lived religion and work with them to disclose the novel, the redemptive, and the sacred. Third, the study of lived religion empowers congregational leaders to call upon their historical cache of sacred images, objects, and practices in order to improvise new ones to address the demands of particular situations of pain or rupture.

CONCLUSION

My experiences as a pastor have resulted in a lasting love for congregations in all their particularity and grittiness. It is the inseparability of the gritty and human from the sublime and heavenly that inspires this love. In congregations we see the fusing of the creaturely and flawed with eternal and perfect love—the indivisibility of the pita bread and grape juice from the body and blood of Jesus Christ. That we should ever meet the redeeming power of God in the humble stuff of congregations is witness to the extraordinary nature of both. Yet this is what we claim. We make this claim partly based on reason, but mostly because, time and again, so many of us have been bathed in redemption through God's reach in and through congregations.

It is my hope that this chapter devoted to the study of three very different congregations will serve as a reminder that Christians of varying traditions need each other because we all have partial truths. The congregations I describe all have something to teach and something to learn from the others. Mostly, I have a profound hope that this work will contribute in some way

to revitalizing the often floundering mainline denominations. By looking at forms of vitality in other traditions, by articulating God-mediating practices in other churches, and by lifting up what we do well in the mainline congregations, my hope is that this stream of Christian witness will be replenished. If Robert Orsi is right, that religion is "a form of cultural work," and if Christian community is constantly making and remaking itself, especially during times of stress and strain, then the turn to the ecclesial neighbor in openness and humility bears the possibility that we might be recreated in ways that serve our longevity as denominations and our faithfulness as disciples. There is no doubt that mainline denominations are always changing. The question is, where will we turn for "the novel?" What will our resources be for the truly "new?" We can be enhanced through our interaction with Christians of other traditions who are faithfully following Christ even as we are trying to do so ourselves.

NOTES

1. See Donald Capps, *Biblical Approaches to Pastoral Counseling* (Philadelphia: Westminster Press, 1981); Don Browning, *Religious Thought and the Modern Psychologies: A Critical Conversation in the Theology of Culture* (Philadelphia: Fortress Press, 1987); Charles Gerkin, *Prophetic Pastoral Practice: A Christian Vision of Life Together* (Nashville, Tenn.: Abingdon, 1991); Edward Wimberly, *Using Scripture In Pastoral Counseling* (Nashville, Tenn.: Abingdon, 1994).

2. Nancy Ramsay, *Pastoral Care and Counseling: Redefining the Paradigms* (Nashville, Tenn.: Abingdon, 2004).

3. See Susan Dunlap, *Counseling Depressed Women* (Louisville: Westminster John Knox Press, 1997); Carol Watkins Ali, *Survival and Liberation: Pastoral Theology in African American Context* (St. Louis, Mo.: Chalice Press, 1999); Christie Neuger, *Counseling Women: A Narrative, Pastoral Approach* (Minneapolis: Fortress, 2001); Homer Ashby, *Our Home Is Over Jordan: A Black Pastoral Theology* (St. Louis, Mo.: Chalice Press, 2003); Carrie Doehring, *The Practice of Pastoral Care: A Postmodern Approach* (Louisville, Ky.: Westminster John Knox Press, 2006).

4. See Mary Moschella, *Living Devotions: Reflections on Immigration, Identity, and Religious Imagination* (Eugene, Ore.: Pickwick Publications, 2008) and Moschella's *Ethnography as a Pastoral Practice: An Introduction* (Cleveland, Ohio: Pilgrim Press, 2008). See also Susan Dunlap, *Caring Cultures: How Congregations Respond to the Sick* (Waco, Texas: Baylor University Press, 2009).

5. See Mary McClintock Fulkerson's discussion of Pentecostal women in the Appalachian South in *Changing the Subject: Women's Discourses and Feminist Theology* (Minneapolis, Minn.: Fortress, 1994), chapter 5.

6. Robert A. Orsi, "Is the Study of Lived Religion Irrelevant to the World We Live In? Special Presidential Plenary Address, Society for the Scientific Study of Religion, Salt Lake City, November 2, 2002," *Journal for the Scientific Study of Religion* 29, no. 2 (June 1, 2003): 169.

7. Orsi, "Is the Study of Lived Religion Irrelevant to the World We Live In?" 172.

8. Serene Jones, "Graced Practices: Excellence and Freedom in the Christian Life," in *Practicing Theology: Beliefs and Practices in Christian Life*, eds. Dorothy Bass and Miroslav Volf (Grand Rapids, Mich.: Eerdmans, 2002), 74.

9. Jones, "Graced Practices," 74.

10. Jones, "Graced Practices," 75.

11. See Dunlap, *Caring Cultures*, 10.

12. Karla Holloway, *Passed On: African American Mourning Stories* (Durham, N.C.: Duke University Press, 2002), 3.

13. Jules David Prown, "Mind in Matter: An Introduction to Material Culture Theory and Method," *Winterthur Portfolio* 17, no. 1 (Spring 1982): 1.

14. Colleen McDannell, *Material Christianity: Religion and Popular Culture in America* (New Haven, Conn.: Yale University Press, 1995), 2.

15. David Morgan, "The Materiality of Cultural Construction," *Material Religion* 4, no. 2 (July 2008): 228.

16. See note 4 for publication information..

17. Max Weber, *From Max Weber: Essays in Sociology*, ed. H. H. Gerth and C. Wright Mills (London: Oxford University Press, 1981), 281.

18. Daniel E. Albrecht. "Pentecostal Spirituality: Looking Through the Lens of Ritual," *Pneuma* 14 (1992): 113.

19. Albrecht, "Pentecostal Spirituality," 113.

20. Roberto Goizueta, "The Symbolic Realism of U.S. Latino/a Popular Catholicism," *Theological Studies* 65 (June 2004): 262, quoting Louis Dupré in *Passage to Modernity: An Essay in the Hermeneutics of Nature and Culture* (New Haven, Conn.: Yale University Press, 1993), 94.

21. Gary Riebe-Estrella, "Latino Religiosity or Latino Catholicism?" *Theology Today* 54, no. 4 (January 1998): 513.

22. For a discussion of the effects of this experiment where African American men died of untreated syphilis, see Emilie Townes's chapter, "'The Doctor Ain't Takin' No Sticks': The Tuskegee Syphilis Study," in *Breaking the Fine Rain of Death: African American Health Issues and a Womanist Ethic of Care* (New York: Continuum, 1998).

23. Philip Slater, *The Pursuit of Loneliness* (Boston: Beacon, 1970).

24. Arthur Kleinman, *The Illness Narratives: Suffering, Healing, and the Human Condition* (New York: Basic, 1988), 31.

25. David E. Massey, "Empathy," in *Dictionary of Pastoral Care and Counseling*, eds. Rodney Hunter et al. (Nashville, Tenn.: Abingdon Press, 1990), 354.

5

Homeless in Seattle: A Lived Religion of Hospitality

Sharon G. Thornton

The purpose of this study is to look at the "lived religion" of hospitality as it is being practiced by Saint Mark's Episcopal Cathedral in relationship to poverty and homeless people in Seattle, Washington. Acting executive director of the National Coalition for the Homeless Michael Stoops said in an interview for KOMO television services: "Homelessness is a pressing religious issue that won't go away unless we focus our energy and resources on it."[1] This study speaks to this "pressing religious issue" of homelessness and how Saint Mark's is directing time, energy and resources to it through its support and hosting of Tent City 3, a roaming encampment of homeless people in the Seattle area.[2]

Saint Mark's Cathedral has opened its facilities to accommodate the individuals and families that make up Tent City 3 for nearly a decade. Through their gestures of hospitality temporary shelter is being provided for these homeless people so they can get back on their feet and find employment and permanent housing. One can ask, what is it that motivates Saint Mark's to live its faith by offering hospitality to poor strangers in their midst? And further, how is their lived religious practice of hospitality understood and negotiated when it is extended to the public square? These questions guide the following exploration of Saint Mark's lived religious practice of hospitality in relationship to Tent City 3 and others of Seattle's homeless population. But first, some background information to set the context.

BACKGROUND: "FOXES HAVE HOLES, AND BIRDS HAVE NESTS: HOMELESS HAVE TENTS"

One of the world's richest men lives in the Seattle area, and many of his neighbors are the several thousand homeless people who wander through the streets, often "invisible" and rarely greeted by name. They roam the alleys and become unofficial greeters outside theaters and grocery stores. They constantly seek shelter from the wind and rain on any given day. Seattle is promoted in the media and through national polls as one of the nation's most livable cities, but this is not true for everyone. Nearly 12 percent of its citizens live below the poverty level.

Facts involving King County where Seattle is located:

- The Seattle/King County Coalition for the Homeless conducted its annual "One Night Street Count" in October (2007) and counted 2,159 homeless men, women and youth on the streets. This is approximately a 12 percent increase from 2003's total of 1,734. The count included downtown Seattle, the University District, Ballard, Kent, North and East King County and White Center. "One Night," which began twenty years ago, is an unduplicated tally of those living on the streets. *Information: www.homelessinfo.org*.[3]
- The King County Citizens' Advisory Commission on Homeless Encampments (CACHE) estimates there are enough shelter beds for roughly 4,600 homeless on any given night, well short of the estimated 8,000 in need. *Information: www.metrokc.gov/dchs/cache/*.

Too many sons and daughters have nowhere to lay their heads. But some of them are taking matters into their own hands by constructing temporary and very distinctive housing villages that have become known as "Tent Cities." Today there are two, Tent City 3 and Tent City 4. Tent City 3, the focus of this study, is the older of the two and resides on various sites in the Seattle area. Tent City 4 is a more recent development that is trying to establish itself in communities east of Seattle in such areas as Woodinville, Kirkland and Bellevue.

Tent City 3 is a roving encampment that has moved across the Seattle, King County area for more than a decade, journeying through vacant lots, churchyards, even a university tennis court. Seattle saw its first Tent City, Tent City 1, materialize in 1990 during the World Games when people pitched some tents and put together makeshift shelters on some vacant land just south of the downtown business district near the Kingdome, Seattle's first professional sports stadium. This first encampment sprang up quickly, and as it grew in size, community and civic leaders hurriedly began searching for places where they could move the people away from public

view. They found some spaces in church basements and others in transient hotels. They even housed some of the homeless people in an old bus barn! It was out of this first experience of trying to create some kind of communal living that a few of the original camp members began to mobilize on behalf of the rest of those who had been involved in this initial attempt at contemporary "homesteading."

A second try at organizing a community for homeless people by homeless people, Tent City 2, was attempted in 1998 just southeast of the city center in an area of Seattle called Beacon Hill. However, this encampment lasted only a few weeks before city officials had it bulldozed, saying it violated the city's ban on public camping. In response to this action a non-profit, homeless-advocacy group formed in 2000 called SHARE/WHEEL.[4] The first legal action by this group was to take the city to court in order to secure some kind of protection and legal support for those seeking to shelter themselves. An agreement was eventually reached by the King County Superior Court in 2002 that opened the way for homeless people to create their own temporary outdoor living sites as long as they did not do so in a city park. In addition, a ruling was also made at this time stating that the city could not prevent private property owners from hosting the encampment as long as guidelines involving public safety and health were followed.

The first two Tent Cities, while primarily attempts at creating viable living space for folks with nowhere to go, were also political statements about poverty and homelessness in an affluent city. While Tent City 1 and Tent City 2 were eventually dismantled and scattered, they did succeed in paving the way for a more durable Tent City 3. In 2000 Tent City 3 was organized as a loosely organized campsite that is still in operation today as it migrates across various vacant fields in and near Seattle. It still provides living accommodations for people from the streets, and it is still making a visible statement about the abomination of the poverty that puts them there.

Because of legal restrictions, Tent City 3 is limited to three months in any one place, after which the residents are required to "pull up stakes" and move on to a different location. This has led to a pattern where they stay at any one location anywhere from thirty days to up to three months on average. Almost from its beginning, Tent City 3 has been hosted by various religious communities that have become aware of the plight of its residents. Today it has evolved to a point where roughly 100 people live in the mobile encampment that costs about $45,000 a year to run, or about $4,000 a month. The name "Tent City" has stuck, mainly because of the members' ability to maintain a simple but effective democratic organization.

To get an idea of what Tent City 3 is like, imagine an area about the size of half a football field dotted with blue tarp–covered tents. The blue tarps are an identifying symbol of Tent City. They cover the dwellings that are closely packed together into the mobile village. Some of these are designed

for single occupants, others for couples. On the front of these tents are paper-plate "addresses" to distinguish one tent from another. Some even place flowers or a stuffed animal on their tent flap in order to give it a more personal and home-like touch. In the center of the camp is a larger communal tent much like the one used in the old television series M*A*S*H. Food and other supplies are kept here. Next to this tent is another 10'x10' tent that is a community center complete with a large screen television, donated by a concerned citizen, and a library of videotapes. To one side of the campground you will see a row of portable toilets. On another side, you will see the power cables that provide electricity for microwaves and coffee makers. At the entrance to the camp, there is a large table and chair where camp members take turns sitting, around the clock, to give information and help provide security. Picture a clean, well-organized living situation where residents keep track of donations and help each other find the support services they might need. See a place where people share food, conversation and respect for each other and you have a fairly accurate view of what Tent City 3 looks like. The encampment actually looks remarkably similar year after year. One passer-by commented, "This looks like a refugee camp!"[5] Maybe so, but the encampment is clean and well organized.

Tent City 3 provides a safe alternative to sleeping on park benches or under freeways and bridges for a portion of the roughly 8,000 homeless people of the Seattle region, with fewer than 5,000 shelter beds. It is estimated that about a quarter of the Tent City 3 residents are employed. Many work at day labor jobs in the area, others at minimum wage or temporary jobs. One member, Larry, works during the day in front of the Seattle Art Museum selling newspapers while he clasps a sign that reads "The War in Iraq Hurts the Homeless." He tells anyone who will listen about how the war is harming the poor people in this country. He also tells people to spread the word about this![6]

No one suggests that Tent City 3 is a desirable or long-term solution to homelessness. For the time being, it does provide emergency shelter and a material witness to the vulnerability and plight of the homeless. The presence of Tent City 3 is a provocative reminder of the poor in our midst as it presents visual evidence of the connections between poverty, mental illness, and the ravages of alcohol and drug abuse. Over the past decade, Tent City 3 has proven successful in helping the poor while raising the region's awareness about its shortage of shelter space and affordable housing. It has played no small role in helping to move legislation forward that has led to new regional policies for addressing poverty.[7] More will be said about this later.

In its present form, Tent City 3 represents an alternative to shelters as a way to provide for homeless people. They are provided a kind of "housing," tents, instead of the mat on the floor of a traditional shelter. Residents are offered a level of dignity and agency that is too often missing from their

experience with many of the traditional human-service agencies. For example, Tent City 3 operates on a basis where residents share responsibilities for the day-to-day operations of the camp. Each resident takes a turn in overseeing the security of the camp. All members monitor the management of litter in the camp, even picking up trash regularly in the host neighborhoods. There is a strict code of conduct that prohibits the use of drugs, alcohol, abusive language or violence of any kind. There is an executive committee made up of five elected members that meets twice a month to oversee the running of the camp. Members vote on everything. They elect their own representatives to negotiate with the city regarding any policy that might affect their lives, or any disputes that may arise between the encampments and surrounding communities.[8]

Tent City 3 has moved more than fifty times since it began. During this time it has been hosted by churches, community groups, and even a major university, all of whom share the coordinating agency SHARE/WHEEL's philosophy that if you give homeless people consistent shelter they are more likely to be able to move into their own long-term housing. Camp members report that almost half of the people who spend time in the encampment find a permanent housing situation within a year.[9]

Saint Mark's Episcopal Cathedral has had a long history with Tent City 3, having provided the encampment living space on their property eight different times. As a representative host, this community can give us some hints about how some practicing Christians understand the way they live their religious convictions beyond the Sunday morning worship service. The Cathedral's ministry with Tent City 3 offers a close view of the day-to-day workings of this lived religion of hospitality as it engages poverty and homelessness.

SAINT MARK'S CATHEDRAL: "WHERE GOD PITCHED A TENT"

Saint Mark's Cathedral sits atop Capitol Hill in Seattle overlooking Lake Union, a body of water separating Lake Washington from Puget Sound. It is the Episcopal Cathedral for the Diocese of Olympia in Washington State and is known for its progressive views and community involvements. The members of Saint Mark's Cathedral have pioneered relationships between Tent City 3 and various communities of faith and advocacy groups in Seattle and have been outspoken on issues of poverty and homelessness. A look back at the beginnings of Saint Mark's may offer some clues as to why the Cathedral community has played such a vital role in these community connections.

Construction began on the first Cathedral in the 1920s shortly after World War I. In the aftermath of the war people were looking for healing and a way to move forward in a world that seemed forever changed. Recon-

ciliation became a key organizing factor for the emerging community of faith at Saint Mark's. Given their central location in the city, they wanted their cathedral to be "a beacon on a hill shedding light on the pain and suffering in the world."[10] The Dean of the Cathedral from 1999 to early 2008, Robert Taylor, observed how "experiences shape a people and so does landscape" in reference to this early beginning. [11]

The original building was never completed. By the mid-1920s funds began to run out, and by the mid-1930s, caught in the midst of the Great Depression, the situation became grave. When the congregation was unable to meet the mortgage payments, the bank foreclosed and the members of Saint Mark's lost their building. In effect the congregation became "homeless." Some members left and joined other churches. Those who remained relocated to a house in the neighboring community. This experience left an indelible mark on the memory of this community to the point where it has really become part of the DNA of this congregation, sensitizing its members to the plight of others facing adversity.[12] The Cathedral's long history of social justice can be traced back to its founding mission, its location, and this firsthand experience of disruption and hardship.

Interestingly, Saint Mark's is still unfinished. Today raw concrete defines the current structure of Saint Mark's, or the "Holy Box" as it is affectionately called.[13] The Cathedral still stands on its original hilltop location, still determined to be a beacon shedding light on the pain of the world. Today it stands as a prominent symbol of reconciliation in an affluent section of the city that is only a short drive to some of the most destitute neighborhoods of Seattle. It is located at a pivotal intersection of the city, just a few blocks from Broadway, a colorful neighborhood of funky coffee shops and secondhand stores in addition to high-end restaurants and fashion boutiques. Broadway is also known as Seattle's "Castro," a place where the gay, lesbian, bi- and trans-gendered community gathers. It also houses Seattle Central Community College, an educational institution with a diverse racial and ethnic student body. The Cathedral draws a cross section of these neighbors to its doors as it bridges very diverse communities.

In 1999 the Very Reverend Robert V. Taylor came from White Plains, New York, to serve as the Cathedral's new Dean. Originally from South Africa, Taylor arrived in the United States after a long history of anti-apartheid activism. Throughout his ministry in New York he continued his justice work and became deeply involved in issues of poverty and homelessness in that region. When he came to Saint Mark's he immediately connected with members at the Cathedral and with others in the surrounding area that shared similar commitments to social justice. Soon after his arrival, the Cathedral's public witness began to be expressed through cooperative programs and strategies to address issues of poverty, homelessness and economic justice, particularly in the Seattle, King County, area.

In 1998 one of the first community conferences on homelessness was held in Seattle. This provided a fresh opening for conversations between concerned citizens, county and city officials, and religious leaders. Dean Taylor joined this conversation a year later upon his arrival to Seattle. There was a strong consensus among these early participants to move the countywide dialogue on poverty beyond what some feared might become an "industry of homelessness." To safeguard this concern, an agreement was reached at the outset that the voices of homeless people were critical and needed to be included from the beginning as decision makers in any plan of action affecting their lives. When the question arose about who should act as convener of this process, all of the participants said the moral voice of Saint Mark's Cathedral was needed. What grew out of these conversations was the establishment of a commission to address and end homelessness.[14]

During the time these dialogues were taking place, Saint Mark's was approached to offer space for Tent City 3 in 2000. To coincide with this, a large media event was planned to feature the Cathedral hosting Tent City 3 as an act of Christian hospitality. It was hoped that the publicity would offer a compelling way to focus attention on the issues of poverty and homelessness and to raise community awareness. Saint Mark's was chosen because of its high visibility and its history of commitment to issues of poverty through its meal programs and shelter programs. In addition, Cathedral members were known to be active and involved with Habitat for Humanity. It was only three months after Taylor arrived that Saint Mark's began to host Tent City 3. As of this writing, the encampment has lodged at Saint Mark's eight more times, the latest in the spring of 2007.

Consistently during the years that the camp has been hosted at the Cathedral, members have been urged to continue their reflection on "why" it is important to attend to the poverty and homeless in their midst. Newsletters, sermons and educational forums have been venues for this ongoing education of the congregation. A sampling of sermons and items from the church newsletter, *The Rubric*, give a sense of how the Saint Mark's community has prepared itself for its many engagements with Tent City 3. The following come from the year 2005 when the Cathedral hosted the encampment during the months of Lent.

Early in February 2005, the Cathedral newsletter, *The Rubric*, carried a notice for a Book Talk. Readers of the newsletter were invited to a book forum featuring, *To Pause at the Threshold: Reflections on Living on the Border* by Esther De Waal.[15] Participants in the discussion of this book were asked to reflect the religious meaning of "threshold" by considering the Benedictine monk who greets visitors at the gate of the monastery

> with one foot inside the gate of the monastery and the other outside as he greets each visitor with "*Deo gratis* . . . Thank God you have come."[16]

De Waal uses "threshold" as a spiritual metaphor signifying the place where out of respect for the other side "we pause at the border."[17] Here, at the "threshold," people shed prejudgments about one another and take on the risk of offering hospitality.

While the newsletter did not mention the upcoming encampment explicitly, people who read the newsletter and participated in the book discussion were offered subtle connections between the timely theme of this book, *To Pause at the Threshold*, and the spiritual posture required in order to provide hospitality to the guests soon to arrive at their church parking lot. The article reads: "In that pause we prepare to offer an open mind and heart to the new adventure."[18] For those anticipating the arrival of Tent City 3 this most likely helped evoke the new adventure that Saint Mark's was about to undertake at the "threshold" now identified as their parking lot.

Later in the month after the book discussion, during the Second Sunday in Lent, Dean Taylor preached the sermon, "God Has Pitched a Tent." Drawing on the stories of Nicodemus and Abraham, he used the morning homily to challenge worshipers on the meaning of the "risky encounter with Jesus," who says, "I come not to condemn, but to save." Throughout the sermon he stressed that both Abraham and Nicodemus became pilgrims in their search for God, pointing to the tent in the biblical story as a marker of the pilgrim's journey. Quoting Gregory of Nyssa: "To seek God is to find God, to find God is to seek God," Taylor challenged the congregation to enter upon a pilgrimage that would invite them to be open to where they pitch their tents with one another. He then made an elegant transition from the tent of the text to the tents soon to be pitched on the Saint Mark's parking lot:

> Markers and gifts for many of us at St. Marks have been discovered in the literal pitching of tents on this Cathedral campus. In eight days' time we will welcome approximately one hundred residents of Tent City to our life in this place. Their tents will be pitched in our parking lot. We do it because of the ancient Christian spiritual practices of hospitality of discovering and welcoming God in strangers and visitors. We do it because we know that the deepest values of the scripture and of Christianity are about how we respond to injustice and to the homeless and hungry. And it is we who receive the gift. Tent City offers us a holy moment . . . [it is] the expression of God's tent pitched in our midst. . . . God has already pitched a tent; you or I may not yet know what encounters it invites, what truth and new birth it leads to, but the tent is pitched.[19]

This sermon, following the earlier February newsletter, offered a seamless introduction of Tent City 3 to the Cathedral campus. Then, just before the residents were to set up camp, the reason for the Tent City commitment was again confirmed in a follow-up article published in the March 2005 *Rubric:*

> As our congregation knows, we are engaged in partnership with Tent City 3 as a profound and public witness to our faith in the belovedness of all of God's children. We are following our baptismal vows of seeking and serving Christ in all persons, and striving for justice and peace among all people while respecting the dignity of every human being.[20]

Also listed in this newsletter were ways that parishioners could participate in welcoming Tent City—by donating such things as batteries, cots, hygiene supplies, first-aid supplies, food, and towels and washcloths, among other items. In the same issue they were invited to volunteer to help prepare meals and snacks. They were also asked to consider hiring residents of the village to do odd jobs and yard work. Ongoing community events and forums about issues of homelessness were also listed.[21] Cathedral members were being given specific ways that they could "cross the threshold" with their new neighbors who were "pitching tents" in their parking lot.

The letter from the Dean to the community in the same March issue further illustrates the mission of the church in relationship to Tent City 3. Arriving as they did, at the beginning of Lent, Dean Taylor writes to the congregation:

> Their presence among us for March and April is a poignant reminder of what we heard at the beginning of Lent from the prophet Isaiah, that true religion is expressed in how we are engaged in working for God's justice for all, including those who are homeless (Isaiah 58:1–12). Tent City is a vivid reminder of the homeless in our midst and how we as individuals and as a community of faith express the journey to resurrection and new life through our actions.

The reference to the "journey to resurrection" offers additional depth to the meaning of "threshold" introduced to this community of faith. Resurrection here suggest a nuanced reading of "threshold" as that boundary one not only crosses in order to get from where one has been to a new place, but as the place of life-giving meeting and surprising adventure. This reading of resurrection connects becoming pilgrims in search of God with being engaged with others, particularly strangers, in a particular place. In this way resurrection becomes identified with the "threshold" where "God has pitched a tent"—the place of meeting and surprising adventure. It is on this "threshold," for Saint Mark's now identified with their parking lot, that surprising new life will come from sharing hospitality with Tent City 3.

As the involvement with Tent City moves into a rhythm, the lead article in the April edition of *The Rubric* takes the commitment to Tent City 3 a step farther. In his letter to the readers, Dean Taylor asks Cathedral members to think of themselves as a community of reconciliation, as a "Commons": "A community of the Cathedral that expresses an uncommon commitment to justice, because we are grounded in practicing an uncommon commitment

to love and hospitality."[22] This expanded vision of the Cathedral as a "Commons" marks an intentional shift in this community's involvement in issues of homelessness. From this point on, Saint Mark's became more deeply committed to ending homelessness in the Seattle, King County, area.

In an interview reported in Seattle's homeless newspaper, *Real Change*, Dean Taylor was asked about how the experience of hosting Tent City 3 had changed Saint Mark's. Taylor shared how the experience of the encampment on the Cathedral grounds was a "remarkable and wonderful experience," affecting the members in profound ways. One story he offered that reflected this involved a church volunteer:

> The first time Tent Village was here, a much-loved member of the congregation walked between the tents and had someone tap him on his shoulder. It was his nephew, whom he had not seen in 20 years. And they have been reunited with family members and it has been a powerful story. That encounter was spoken about a lot in the life of the Cathedral.[23]

This story has become foundational for the Saint Mark's community, helping to put a human face on homelessness.[24]

Another equally powerful example impacting the congregation again involved a volunteer, this time one whose family had been part of Saint Mark's for generations:

> She's a very quiet, thankful, wonderful human being [the Cathedral member]. She started baking bread for Tent Village every morning. And after Tent Village left after their first visit, I learned that she was still baking bread every day and following them around from place to place. I said to her, "Cokie, this is amazing, you know. You are just wonderful." And she said, "It's nothing, don't thank me." And I said, "No, you don't understand. We talk about the Eucharist, and the bread is the symbol of life and eternity, and you are carrying that out in a very practical way."[25]

Taylor remarked, "There are endless stories about the way in which St. Mark's has been transformed by this wonderful experience. It's been a gift to us."[26] Members who participated with Tent City 3 tend to agree. One person said: "We have gained so much by their presence here." Another commented, "When we eat together we get to listen to their stories." Another reflected, "It changed my idea about what homelessness is like and who the people are that live in these camps." Still another said, "Volunteering at the camp and getting to know the residents has deepened my faith, and helped me to grow as a person."[27] A consistent theme that runs through these commentaries is one of gratitude. Volunteers continually say things like: "I receive so much from them." "We are so honored they are here." "I am so grateful for this experience." "I am a different person than I was before I became involved with Tent City. I am glad, and thankful."[28] It seems that those who become

involved are in some way transformed for the good, as individuals and as a community. Taylor observes that there have been some very joyful surprises as members increase their engagement in the ministries of the Cathedral and the community becomes strengthened by these commitments. More than 140 members of Saint Mark's are consistently involved.[29]

The experiences of hosting Tent City have motivated members and confirmed Dean Taylor's faith in Seattle's commitment to end homelessness. In the interview with Taylor conducted by *Real Change* reporters, he said:

> We're not going to live with the idea that we can manage homelessness—we're going to actually say that we're going to end it. There are strategies being developed so that by 2015, people will look back at 2005 and say, "Wow, can you believe what they lived with?"[30]

When Tent City 3 was first invited to St. Mark's in 2000, religious and community leaders along with homeless men and women began to meet together to address how homelessness might be approached differently from the past. The Interfaith Task Force on Homelessness was convened in 2001 as an affiliate organization of Saint Mark's. In 2003 the action arm of the Interfaith Task force, the Committee to End Homelessness, was created and by 2005 it issued a Ten Year Plan to End Homelessness. The resulting document "A Roof Over Every Bed in King County, Our Community's Ten-Year Plan to End Homelessness"[31] was adopted and released that same year. This document was the culmination of the five years of work of leaders from King County, Saint Mark's, other religious communities, and members of Tent City.

INTERPRETATION: A LIVED RELIGION OF HOSPITALITY FORMED BY EUCHARIST

How did the people of Saint Mark's who were involved in hosting Tent City 3 understand what they were doing from a faith perspective? For certainly their behavior cannot be understood apart from meaning, as David Hall argues in his edited volume *Lived Religion in America*.[32] How Saint Mark's members lived their religion can only be understood by a more careful rendering of their religious understanding of hospitality. This is no simple task since hospitality is a multi-layered, meaningful practice that communities of faith have engaged in together over time in various houses of worship. Hospitality can be viewed as extending the believer's baptismal vows. Indeed, Dean Taylor evoked just this connection in his March *Rubric* message: "We are following our baptismal vows of seeking and serving Christ in all persons."[33] Members may have been mindful of this as they prepared for their guests. Yet, the

focus that Saint Mark's gave to providing meals for Tent City, inviting camp members into the Cathedral for shared meals, including Tent City 3 residents in worship, and sharing the sacrament with them suggests that Eucharist provided an equally, if not more central religious nexus for interpreting hospitality in this community of faith.

Indeed, if you look at the patterns of behavior that Saint Mark's exhibited as they hosted Tent City 3, they seem to reflect the postures of Eucharistic participation. Preparing the table can be seen as creating a hospitable space, a campground for Tent City. Bringing the elements can be seen as preparing the meal and bringing it to the Tent City community. Sharing the elements can be seen as church members and Tent City members partake and share the meal together. Thanksgiving is evident in the heartfelt testimonies of gratitude offered by both Tent City residents and Saint Mark's participants. Sending forth into the world "changed" through the preparing inviting, partaking in the meal/ministry of hospitality, all with thanksgiving, becomes evident when the members of Saint Mark's go to other congregations to support them in hosting Tent City. It also becomes clear when Saint Mark's works with Tent City 3 residents to engage policy and structural issues of homelessness and poverty in the city. Here living out the Eucharistic hospitality of invitation, partaking of the elements and giving thanks leads to becoming "bread for the city."

As Saint Mark's clergy and lay church leaders enact hospitality with Tent City 3 they begin to connect with their practice of table fellowship or Eucharist. This was evident in many of the preparatory remarks and public statements made by the Dean. Lay members, too, made this connection as reported in publications and interviews. In one interview the respondent answered an emphatic "Yes. Absolutely," when asked if she saw any connection between the Cathedral's hosting of Tent City 3 and celebration of the Eucharist.[34] As a way to explore this recognized connection between Eucharist and hospitality to Tent City, it will be helpful to bring this understanding into conversation with some of the recent writings on religious interpretations of hospitality. In this way, perhaps some of this initial reading of Saint Mark's explicit "lived religion" of hospitality can be deepened and nuanced to reveal some of the horizons of an implicit "lived religion" of Eucharist embedded in Saint Mark's hospitality to Tent City.

HOSPITALITY TO STRANGERS

> When a [stranger] resides with you in your land, you shall not oppress the [stranger]. The [stranger] who resides with you shall be to you as the citizen among you, and you shall love the [stranger] as yourself, for you were [strangers] in the land of Egypt: I am the Lord your God. (Leviticus 19:33–34)[35]

Who is the stranger? Christine Pohl, in her work on hospitality, defines strangers as those who are "disconnected from basic relationships that give persons a secure place in the world."[36] To offer hospitality, then, is to welcome a "stranger" into a space where they can become re-connected, safe and comfortable; a place where they will be respected and accepted. The hospitable space will offer a place for mutual sharing of lives, mutual listening and hearing. In such an environment, strangers become visible to one another and begin a process of re-connecting with others. Such hospitality means that the stranger will experience, even if temporarily, a sense of inclusion in a life-affirming network of relations.[37] When this happens, the give and take between strangers becomes a means of grace and not simply charity. Or, as one of the volunteers at Saint Mark's put it, "Hospitality means learning to be with people and not just 'give' something, not only to be charitable."[38]

But today, fear of strangers for many has become the norm. Overtures of hospitality have diminished on the national and local scene since 9/11. We have come to look upon the stranger as a threat to our very existence. The Latin root of the word hospitality is *hostis*, suggests that the guest may indeed double as the enemy. (And, so might the host!) So, we are faced with a grave contradiction: dangers in our world are real *and* a central message of our faith is to welcome the stranger. In fact, stories about strangers are central to the biblical message. The challenge becomes, who do we allow to cross our borders, our "thresholds"? The members of Saint Mark's resist today's trend where fear toward the unfamiliar grows walls of hostility to keep the stranger out. Instead, by their actions they are dismantling hostility "brick by brick" or "tent by tent."

In contrast to the Latin root, the word for hospitality in Greek is *philoxenia*, which means love for strangers. However, this love is not only for the one who is close to us. It is a love that is lavished upon the stranger who is unfamiliar or even unknown to us. Biblical hospitality is neither a sentimental gesture nor is it an event for show, or "Martha Stewart entertaining." As Christine Pohl points out, hospitality in the biblical understanding has deep moral and theological implications. In fact, her study on hospitality, *Making Room*, makes the point that hospitality is really the organizing worldview for authentic Christian discipleship.[39] Hospitality is the taproot of the Christian faith, not something that is complementary or added on to enhance its meaning. Hospitality is the very foundation for the Realm of God, the "kingdom prepared . . . from the foundation of the world" (Matthew 25:34):

> for I was hungry and you gave me food, I was thirsty and you gave me something to drink, I was a stranger and you welcomed me, I was naked and you gave me clothing, I was sick and you took care of me, I was in prison and you visited me (Matthew 25.35–36).[40]

Hospitality is a prism that reflects the heart of the gospel. It involves many different facets, including the offering of food, shelter and critical life amenities. But even more fundamental to these practical expressions of welcome are the attitudes of respect, generosity, humility and open recognition of the deep humanity of one another. Participants of Tent City 3 speak of the joy of being welcomed warmly. Referring to another setting, one resident said, "They were so welcoming . . . there was a mob of people from the neighborhood that met [us] at the church."[41] Shifting the conversation back to Saint Mark's, another camp member added, "I always like it when we come here. They make us feel at home."[42] Through such expressions of welcome camp residents experience their dignity and worth as human beings restored.

From a "lived religion" point of view, the practice of hospitality by a community of faith enacts the way of the God who comes in the form of a stranger, a stranger Christians have come to believe is Christ. Furthermore, this God becomes homeless, dislocated and a wanderer precisely in order to establish a new home, a new residency in our midst. As Taylor proclaimed, "God has pitched a tent."[43] In doing so, God's hospitality awaits our hospitality—"Truly I tell you, just as you did it to one of the least of these who are members of my family, you did it to me" (Matthew 25:40). The surprising twist in this encounter is that at the same time the host is also the guest who experiences welcome. When this happens we become willing participants where *philoxenia* crosses our given "thresholds" and in the process disrupts our established borders and boundaries, rules and rituals. Such hospitality is the love of strangers grounded in absolute respect. This love greets the stranger and welcomes them unconditionally as someone we do not desire to manage or control.

> The One who comes as a visitor and a guest in fact becomes the host and offers a hospitality in which human beings and, potentially, the entire world, can become truly at home, can know salvation in the depths of their hearts.[44]

Yet, some caution is in order. Even this extension of hospitality is not a simple gesture of welcome. It is a complex exchange between host and guest that entails definitions of who is the "stranger" and who has authority in the moment of exchange. It always takes place on the uneven terrain of power that helps determine who are insiders and who are seen as outsiders. French feminist Julia Kristeva observes that there is a kind of "dance of power" that is engaged for this defining process of the stranger as someone who will be determined to be either gift or harmful threat to the host group. This dance includes a complicated set of steps or "checks and balances" that become activated by the host group as they encounter the new stranger in their midst. Recognizing that there is always a power differential in this

dynamic, it is clear that it is the host group that decides whether or not the stranger is to be welcomed or rejected.[45] Indeed, Saint Mark's is clearly in this position of authority whether or not this is named.

Complicating this dynamic further, Kristeva suggests that the stranger we encounter can also represent the stranger we deny or reject within us. This recognition can set in motion an intricate negotiation that will ultimately determine whether or not the stranger is someone who will be accepted or rejected, or in other words, whether *hostis* or *philoxenia* will prevail.

Yet, while the possibility of rejection is real, so is the chance for acceptance when a certain self-understanding emerges that says, "The foreigner [stranger] is within me, hence we are all foreigners [strangers]. If I am a foreigner [stranger], there are no foreigners [strangers]."[46] This seems to have happened for some at Saint Mark's as they hosted Tent City. Perhaps it offers a clue as to why the story of the volunteer who discovered his nephew in the camp became such a powerful narrative, not only for the uncle but also for the whole congregation. Expecting only a stranger in the Tent City resident, they instead discovered a relative, one to whom they were related. In such a meeting, part of one's very self is found. Or as another volunteer remarked, "Involvement with Tent City has given me a greater understanding not only of the homeless but also of myself."[47] Novelist and theologian Fredrick Buechner also captures this theme when he writes:

> Deep in you there is a self that longs above all to be known and accepted, but there is also such a self in me, in everyone else the world over. So when we meet as strangers, when even our friends and loved ones look like strangers, it is good to remember that we need each other greatly you and I, more than much of the time we dare to imagine, more than most of the time we dare to admit.[48]

You can hear this theme of recovered "identity" repeated in the words of another volunteer at the campsite who remarked, "Coming here has given me a new understanding of myself. When I listen to their stories and experiences it gives me a new sense of purpose and meaning."[49]

From a faith perspective, hospitality is never one way. The dynamic between host and guest is fluid and ongoing. At the same time, from the perspective of the stranger, especially the stranger who is "homeless" in today's society, hospitality is no simple matter to be taken for granted, even in relationship to churches and church-related organizations. One camp member said, "We don't want to stay in one host spot for more than three months . . . we don't want to burden the host."[50]

Too many times homeless people have experienced the fear of others, the stereotyping of them as lazy, stupid, and shiftless. Unfortunately there is enough evidence to suggest that when the Tent City 3 residents arrive at their temporary destinations they may experience some form of discrimi-

nation or censure even in subtle ways. For example, even under the best of circumstances camp members come to an unfamiliar ground that is well-known territory for the hosts. They can feel a sense of uncertainty, even if they have previously camped there. Each time they prepare to secure their tents, there is a complicated ritual of learning to know the "rules" of the host community again in order to make the stay workable. While Tent City members establish the rules within the camp, the guidelines for occupying the space, for setting up the tents and other living quarters, as well as what happens while they are there, are very much in the hands of the hosts. It is the hosts who delineate the space, say when the campers can reside there, decide what services will be offered, and choose when and how to enter the camp in order to interact, or not, with the residents. This negotiation of space signifies the reality of power discrepancies between the host and the guest, eliminating any romantic notion of what hospitality means. This is a reality for even a most well-intentioned and accommodating host like Saint Mark's.

In unintended and unavoidable ways the act of welcoming Tent City helps establish whose territory is whose and what criteria must be met in order to temporarily reside there. Yet, this hegemony can be disturbed to a certain extent when hosts can identify as stranger with stranger. When this occurs, a disjuncture begins to form in the usual understanding about the meaning of the occupied space. Space starts to become seen and defined differently. It starts to become a less differentiated space as public and private boundaries become blurred, or at least permeable. A transformed "tent site" begins to emerge that challenges and subverts the forces that create artificial boundaries and structures of ownership. When authentic meeting can be allowed and encouraged between stranger and stranger, the forces that work to keep people separate and hostile begin to collide. This collision can produce a kind of rupture of the threshold, opening the space for new life, or what some might call resurrection. Upon this re-conceived "threshold" the possibility for new meaning and ways of connected living start to play out among the members of the encampment and volunteers.

If hospitality involves us in a deep commitment to the well-being of another, it will make room for ambiguity and a certain "spirituality of flexibility" that allows for the unknown to become familiar. At the same time, this does not mean that the stranger becomes so familiar that he or she is robbed of their unique image of God, an image that can never be fully known. A spirituality of flexibility makes room, provides space, for the guest. It involves fostering the movement from *hostis* to *philoxenia*, from hostility toward the stranger to hospitality of the stranger or welcoming the stranger as a valued guest rather than as a fearful intruder. This kind of spiritual posture is critical for practicing the kind of hospitality Henri Nouwen describes as creating a free and friendly space for the stranger.

Real hospitality wants to offer friendship without binding the guest and freedom without leaving the guest alone. Hospitality, then, wants to create a kind of empty and friendly space, where strangers can enter and discover themselves as created free; free to sing their own songs, speak their own languages, dance their own dances; free also to leave and follow their own vocations. Above all, hospitality is not a subtle invitation to adopt the lifestyle of the host, but the gift of a chance for the guest to find his or her own.[51]

In spite of the structural realities and hurdles that make achieving true hospitality difficult, communities like Saint Mark's have been able to enter this ambiguous territory and persevere in offering "friendship without binding the guest" by providing a home where there is no home for Tent City 3 members.

The kind of spiritual flexibility that allows us to see how the homeless stranger "out there" truly reflects the homeless stranger "in here," also reveals an additional truth: in a very real sense not one of us is "at home" in our current world of violence, injustice and alienation. Furthermore, it is the recognition of not being "at home" that perhaps ties Saint Mark's volunteers and the rest of us more closely to the reality of the residents of Tent City 3 than we at first realize. Although not spoken of by the volunteers of Saint Mark's, this connection seems valid enough to offer as one more strand of interpretation to be woven into this community of faith's lived religion of hospitality. It is a tie that binds each and every one of us in a living religion that recognizes that we are all equal members of the household of God: "So then you are no longer strangers and aliens but you are also members of the household of God . . . built together spiritually into a dwelling place for God" (Ephesians 2: 11–22).[52]

When we understand ourselves as inextricably bound with others, creating space for the stranger becomes vital to our own well-being. Recognizing that our well-being is dependent on the well-being of others is the worthy challenge that begins the magnificent transformation of fearful hostility in our world toward hospitable openings where strangers can meet and become friends instead of enemies. Pohl reminds us that this is holy work: "Acts of hospitality participate in and reflect God's greater hospitality and therefore hold some connection to the divine, to holy ground."[53] This radical hospitality that crosses borders of inclusion/exclusion conventions can be seen as Saint Mark's hospitality rooted in their practice of Eucharistic Presence in the world. As one church member stated: "Hospitality means to extend our boundaries; extend table fellowship after Eucharist."[54]

EUCHARIST AS "REAL PRESENCE" IN HOSPITALITY

Saint Mark's is a sacrament-oriented, Eucharist-centered community of faith. Sacrament is understood as the "outward and visible sign of an inward and

spiritual grace." According to the catechism in the *Book of Common Prayer*, the inward and spiritual grace that the believer receives through Holy Communion is the "forgiveness of our sins, the strengthening of our union with Christ and one another, and a foretaste of the heavenly banquet which is our nourishment in eternal life."[55] What this requires is that "we should examine our lives, repent of our sins, and be in love and charity with all people."[56]

Eucharist is central to Saint Mark's self-understanding, and hospitality is closely associated with their practice of Eucharist. Saint Mark's commitment to hosting Tent City can be seen as their "lived religion" of this faith orientation. In preparation for hosting Tent City at Saint Mark's, Dean Taylor made this connection between hospitality and the Eucharist explicit during his morning sermon:

> The bread of communion says, "I want to be in communion with you God and that whatever humility I have makes me want to be transformed by communion with other people. A communion in which I share that same bread by doing justice and by loving kindness and mercy."[57]

If sacrament is indeed the "outward and visible sign of an inward and spiritual grace," the homeless people who participate in Saint Mark's hospitality are made visible (outward and visible signs) and they are recognized for who they are as children of God (recipients of inward and spiritual grace). If, as we stated earlier, hospitality is reciprocal, sacramental recognition involves a mutual gaze. Through the ministry of hospitality rooted in Eucharist, *we see* and *we become seen* and recognized as equal inheritors of God's holy image. Through this mutual gaze we not only see Christ in the ones before us, we also pray that we might be worthy to be seen as Christ by them as well. Through this sacramental exchange gifts of "insight, wisdom, and perhaps also forgiveness" are both given and received. Within the context of hospitality fed by Eucharist, we are unavoidably led to examine our lives, repent of our sins, and seek to be in love and just relations with all people. This is "a foretaste of the heavenly banquet which is our nourishment"[58] and hope for eternal life.

The banquet table is not for the likeminded, those of similar social status, identical backgrounds and comparable talents and abilities. Rather, it is prepared for a gathering of strangers who are invited to pause at a "threshold" and to enter into a new relationship where *hostis* is transformed into *philoxenia*, hostility to hospitality, and new bonds of friendship are formed. At the table, one is called to dine attentively without pretense, to entertain the unpredictable and trust what one cannot know in advance. This is no "tame" notion of hospitality. When this kind of eating and sharing occurs between Tent City residents and Saint Mark's hosts, they participate in a practice of sacramental sharing that reveals a deep and implicit understanding of hospitality as noted by Daniel Migliore, who claims that:

> To be hospitable to the poor, the weak, and the outcast, and paradoxically, this often involves our willingness to be their guests, to listen to them, to receive from them gifts of insight, wisdom, and perhaps also forgiveness.[59]

Table fellowship with Tent City 3 is an extension of hospitality that demonstrates a "lived-Eucharist-inclusion" across boundaries of class, race and life circumstances. Making and living this connection between hospitality and Eucharist means the "real presence" in the sacrament becomes recognized in practice. The "real presence" of this Eucharist is not merely a memorial of another time and place; it becomes the very material substance of a "lived religion" of hospitality in the present moment. It means that "Christ as hospitality" with the community of the poor and "Christ as the community of the poor" *together* constitute the "real presence" of the new human being in the world ("Do this in remembrance of me." 1 Corinthians 11:24). For Christians, Christ is the "real presence" in hospitality with the poor as well as the "real presence" in the poor being served. The mystery of the "real presence" of the Eucharist is made flesh in the actual sharing of food, a food that nourishes the body as it "feeds" just discernment, reparation and forgiveness.

In hospitality with the poor we encounter Christ (Matthew 25:31–46), which makes our encounter with the poor more radical and authentic; in the words of theologian Joerg Rieger, "more Christ-like."[60] Through hospitality to strangers, poor strangers, the practice of Eucharist in the Saint Mark's sanctuary ceases to be any form of "let's pretend" as it takes part in a continuum of hospitality of giving and receiving outdoors in the parking lot during the week.

Breaking Eucharist bread connected to sharing meals becomes one and the same pivotal action that interrupts "life as usual," especially any feelings of entitlement to the so-called good life. Through hospitality to strangers, hosts become strangers themselves, which gives a new identity to those being served and calls to account the hosts who previously have not questioned their identity. This is especially significant for those whose "privileged personhood" has, as Rieger notes, "deprived others of their personhood."[61] This new knowledge can inspire new thoughts about the political implications of sharing power and authority in a community. It breaks open what is normally taken for granted and exposes new possibilities. Frederick Herzog coined the phrase *innovatio Christi* in contrast to the *imitation of Christ* to express the implications of this being "gripped by a new reality."[62] The radical meaning of this is that those in positions of privilege give up the myth of control. Just as the "real presence" of Christ cannot be controlled, the homeless are not objects to be engineered, contained or managed. They are to be seen and empowered through respect and given the opportunities to envision their own lives.

When Eucharist is a lived religion of hospitality, we are talking about hope. In the "Blessed Are You" sermon mentioned earlier, Dean Taylor said:

> Hope is active participation in the vision of God for a new heaven and a new earth.[63]

Continuing, Taylor emphasized this point by quoting Wendell Berry:

> There is a grace in the world that Wendell Berry talks about resting in. It is a grace that we find in each other as if we, each one of us, are each pieces of the bread of communion. To live in the active hope of God is to trust and draw strength and life from the grace that is all around us.[64]

Through their lived religion hospitality formed by Eucharist, Saint Mark's can be seen as participating in a "real presence" that enacts the Great Thanksgiving, that invites Tent City members and the congregation to enter into the world of grace. Entering into this hope, participants can see a new way of being with each other where love is not cynical and trust is not eclipsed by fear; a way where deep commitments are made. As one volunteer reflected on Saint Mark's deepening commitments she said, "We now ask, how can we help? How can we get other churches involved? How can we find regular places for them to stay?"[65] This is about real bread and real friendship not just for a few, but also for everyone for all time, an intimation of the Realm of God through the "real presence" of Eucharistic hospitality. The realm of God does not materialize without this dynamic between Eucharist and hospitality, the offering of thanks that involves staking our lives with the lives of others.

Saint Mark's living religion of hospitality grounded in Eucharist can be seen as participating in the great transformation of all aspects of human life from *hostis* toward *philoxenia.* This means there will be an ever and increasing demand for transparency between their private and public living as they discover and explore new forms of giving and taking, new ways of sharing power and authority, and disciplined ways of seeing and recognizing all people as children of God. It is the connection between hospitality and Eucharist that helps restore the lost moral dimension to the practice of hospitality.

Canadian theologian Mary Jo Leddy talks about living during the week in ways that make it a little easier to celebrate Eucharist.[66] In this way Eucharist becomes what she calls "valid."[67] One can perceive Saint Mark's hospitality with Tent City 3 as being one way they seek to make their practice of Eucharist valid. Perhaps it is this authentic dimension of Saint Mark's life that helped them to be recognized as capable of trustworthy leadership for the wider community.

When Eucharist becomes valid, the blessed life is near. Dean Taylor captures this sense of validity in his reflections upon the conclusion of Tent City's stay at Saint Mark's:

> On Friday night the residents of Tent City cooked a farewell meal of thanks for the people of St. Mark's Cathedral. . . . I will always think of the Tent City corner of our parking lot as hallowed ground. A space for blessing to be discovered. A space that allowed so many members of the St. Mark's community to experience a blessing in casting our lot with ending the outrageous indignity of homelessness. A blessing received and given over countless meals served and shared and cleared. A bare, pruned space, making way for meeting one another. And in meeting one another, a blessing to ask of God the blessing of courage and love to be about justice.[68]

Yet, the blessing is never separated from the harsh reality imposed anew on the consciousness of hosts and volunteers of Saint Mark's. The blessing calls for new responsibilities because of a new understanding:

> Yesterday our guests from Tent City left the Cathedral community. I hope that you and we were a blessing to them. I know that they were a blessing to many of us. After looking out at their tent encampment for these last two months the image imprinted on my soul and heart is one of a refugee camp. Refugees who have no housing. Refugees who make so many feel uncomfortable. So uncomfortable that all sorts of means are used to make sure that the truth of homelessness is not seen, so that we are not disturbed by the sight of refugees among us.[69]

As camp members pulled up stakes and moved they were no longer invisible—no longer "out of sight or mind." As hospitality formed by Eucharist has become a lived religion by the people of Saint Mark's, it is also becoming a pro-active public faith. It is becoming a lived political religion of "do this in remembrance of me" as it is interpreted through the shared interactions between parishioners and camp members who shared meals and holy ground. Members of Saint Mark's joined with Tent City 3 residents to help organize and address issues of poverty and homelessness in the Seattle, King County, area by engaging in political advocacy toward the formation of public policy. In the understanding of David Hall, lived religion reveals "the potentially explosive political import of religious practice . . . of religious play, of its liberatory possibilities."[70] There are compelling reasons to conclude that there is a direct relationship between Saint Mark's hosting of Tent City and their involvement in addressing homelessness and poverty as they participate in the unfolding drama among Tent City 3, other religious communities, and city and county officials.

SUMMARY: LIVED RELIGION AND POLITICAL ACTION

There is no place in the United States, including Seattle, where anyone earning minimum wage can afford a market-rate apartment. Furthermore, the number of low-income housing units in existence is far below the number

of people who need them and it has been dropping ever since 1979. This means there is a growing "housing gap" swelling the number of homeless without shelter.

Low-income housing is housing that is affordable by people earning 20 percent or less of the median income, in other words 20 percent of the population.[71] However, it is important to view these statistics as approximate, because there are many homeless people who do not want it known that they are homeless. This is understandable considering there is tremendous fear on the part of homeless families that their children will be taken away from them. This cruel situation finally galvanized the attention of religious communities in the Seattle, King County, area to begin ways of addressing this mounting crisis, and involvement with Tent City residents has played no small role.

The annual hosting Tent City 3 by Saint Mark's provided them an initial push to address Seattle's housing crisis. It helped wake this religious community up to the reality of poverty, the lack of affordable housing, and the role one plays in perpetuating that wrong. You might say that offering hospitality to Tent City 3 led Saint Mark's to a radical conversion as participants began to experience the direct effects of homelessness on the lives of the people they met.

A conversion that generates genuine repentance involves the whole person, the whole (communal) body, resulting in a new posture of commitment that eventually gathers up and involves the entire community. This is a conversion that transforms the mind, will, emotions and actions of a community leading its representatives to critique government policies that diminish shared life and human dignity. This is a conversion that unavoidably issues in public action. The experience of grace for those who live out this radical conversion becomes the tangible results generated through projects of justice and public renewal. Such projects are extensions of a lived religion of hospitality, for Saint Mark's, a lived religion of hospitality formed by Eucharist.

The fruits of eight years of living hospitality with Tent City 3 have led Saint Mark's to become a leading proponent of a plan for addressing homelessness in the Seattle, King County, region. In 2005 Saint Mark's hosted Tent City to coincide with the release of a document "A Roof Over Every Bed in King County, Our Community's Ten Year Plan to End Homelessness."[72] This document is the culmination of the process that began in 2000 when Saint Mark's invited community leaders and public officials throughout King County, including the homeless themselves, to begin a comprehensive dialogue on how to approach the issue of homelessness in some fresh ways. The dialogue continues to this day with a central aim of networking with local people, community organizations, and elected officials to change structures and systems that perpetuate poverty and home-

lessness in order to make a long-term difference. This extended conversation has resulted is the creation of the Committee to End Homelessness in King County.[73]

Tent City 3 has always been seen as a temporary solution to homelessness while new and long-term ways of responding are explored. The Committee to End Homelessness was created to do just that. They began by cultivating interest and commitment from the business community and foundations that could bring new money to the issue. They looked for partners among religious organizations and non-profit agencies. Saint Mark's is to be commended as a pivotal and visionary force among the thirty-eight (or so) communities of faith, including churches, synagogues and mosques; eighteen non-profit organizations; eleven local governmental representatives; thirty-two inter-agency representatives; along with twenty members of the homeless community who are official supporters of the Plan.[74]

In the years since Seattle adopted the "Ten Year Plan" in 2005, progress in its implementation has surpassed all expectations. 563 new housing units have been constructed and funding for 391 more units is already committed. Funding for converting 387 units of existing housing stock is also committed.[75] The plan and its initial success indicate that homeless people have been heard and their plight is being taken seriously. Stories abound telling of the impact this plan is having on individual lives. One young mother who lived in transitional housing was able to move into a house with her three children. She has enrolled in a community college and her children attend school regularly. She said, "The children and I are happier, and I'm not under so much stress."[76] Another recipient of services, a man afflicted with chronic alcoholism, was helped into a housing situation with supportive services. He is no longer disoriented and is now on the road to sobriety.[77] Caring providers in King County helped create support for young teenagers about to fall through the cracks of the welfare system. She is now actively involved in a local church, attending school, and has actually become a member of the pastor's family.[78] Finally, one former homeless man who is now a member of several sub-committees of the Committee to End Homelessness said: "Restoring my relationship with my son and daughter has been one of the biggest highlights of my recovery, and to see my grandchildren is a new joy."[79] These are but a few of the success stories. There are countless more waiting to be told.

If, as Christine Pohl said, strangers are those who are disconnected from basic relationships that give persons a secure place in the world,[80] the people represented in these comments were strangers indeed as they experienced homelessness. Yet, hopefully they are no longer strangers as their words testify to the fruits of hospitality. They are being welcomed into new spaces where they are inter-connected, safe and respected.

A lived religion of hospitality is bearing fruit by seeking to transform public structures and meaning. This has meant challenging governmental policies and reminding public officials, and the citizens they represent, of their moral and ethical responsibilities. Saint Mark's hospitality with Tent City 3 as an expression of Eucharistic thanksgiving, has propelled members into a conversion process that has led the Cathedral to become involved in finding new ways to address the needs of camp members by working to create safe and affordable housing.

At the same time, Saint Mark's own life and character have started to shift as their lived religion of hospitality begins to impact their self-understanding. They are starting to ask new questions about what it means to be a community and what it means to be human.[81] This budding new identity is beginning to resist conventional expressions of faith as it charts new territory and meaning. Through just undertakings new meaning is given to their familiar practices of worship, mission, even fundamental understanding of what it means to be a community of faith. For instance, on a seemingly simple level, the liturgical year becomes viewed differently as hosting Tent City becomes an on-going relationship. The rhythm of the year now includes opening space for the rotation of campers, with all the attending preparation involved in the hosting. As Saint Mark's reconsiders its identity and its relationship to the wider community, it is beginning to see itself as a "commons," a shared public space and not a private haven. This new vision, however, also reaches back and retrieves their founding vision of their Cathedral as one of reconciliation, "a beacon on a hill shedding light on the pain and suffering in the world."[82] Experiences and landscape do shape people; so does the lived religion a community chooses to practice.

Perhaps the words of a five-year-old girl sum up what a lived religion of hospitality rooted in Eucharist means. When asked during a Sunday morning worship service, "What do you think it means when we come up here together around this Communion Table?," the little girl raised her hand and responded, "It means when we share our food other people won't be hungry."[83] When we are transformed by sharing our food we will change the conditions that make hunger and homeless the blight that it is. This is the meaning of a lived religion of hospitality today exemplified by Saint Mark's Episcopal Cathedral in Seattle, Washington.

POST SCRIPT

This study is only an introduction to what is going on in Seattle and surrounding areas by communities of faith that are becoming more directly involved in addressing homelessness and poverty. Since other Seattle communities have hosted Tent City 3, and now Tent City 4 located east of Se-

attle, it would be valuable to examine additional "lived theologies" of hospitality that might be rooted in various other faith perspectives. For example, some may view their practice as living into their baptismal vows, others might view their hospitality as grounded in mitzvah, and others might think of their practice as evangelism. There is more to be discovered that would yield an even richer tapestry of the practices of hospitality offered by these faith communities.

The full meaning of this particular lived religion of hospitality cannot even be completely captured for Saint Mark's. If more volunteers were to be interviewed it might be discovered that other aspects of their faith were evoked than what has been reported here. Yet, it appears that the relationship between hospitality and table fellowship, or Eucharist, is salient enough to warrant taking this identification seriously. There is evidence that the significance of this connection has had far-reaching implications for the meaning participants of Saint Mark's give to their behavior when their so-called private religion goes public. For many, they are finding that hospitality informed by Eucharist disrupts their taken-for-granted understanding of the relationship between strangers and hosts. They are learning that when hospitality is extended through Eucharist practice, both become united in subverting "the way things appear." In other words, as they experience hospitality informed by Eucharist, they are discovering that poverty and homelessness are unnatural and unnecessary arrangements; they are doing something about this. Whether or not they would say this about themselves, through their lived religion they are going public with their religious practice and they are becoming subversive agents, participating in holy and subversive activities that challenge the status quo.

NOTES

1. The National Coalition for the Homeless cites statistics from the Urban Institute and the National Survey of Homeless Assistance Providers, which estimates that about 3.5 million people are homeless nationwide, and nearly one-third are children. (Urban Institute study, www.urban.org).

2. Saint Mark's is featured because of its historic and leading role in addressing the needs of Seattle's homeless, particularly those who inhabit what has become known as Tent City 3. Saint Mark's has also supported other faith communities that have become involved with hosting Tent City 3.

3. The twenty-eighth annual One Night Count of people who are homeless in King County took place overnight on January 24–25, 2008. At least 8,439 men, women, and children were homeless during this one night. Hundreds of volunteers counted 2,631 people without shelter in parts of thirteen cities and unincorporated areas. The same night, staff at nearly 200 emergency shelters and transitional housing programs completed surveys about the 5,808 people staying in

their programs. The 2008 One Night Count documented an increase in how many people are on the streets and without shelter. Volunteers observed a 15 percent increase in people surviving outside in the same areas counted in 2007. www.homelessinfo.org/onc.html

4. The Seattle Housing and Resource Effort and the Women's Housing, Equality and Enhancement League.

5. Comment made by neighbor walking past the encampment. Noted by Todd Cole while interviewing Tent City residents August 18, 2006.

6. Personal conversation between Sharon Thornton and Larry (not real name) in front of the Seattle Art Museum, January 10, 2007.

7. The Real Change news organization representing the homeless noted in their April 13, 2006, online edition: Tent City has caused neighborhoods to first confront the poor and by doing so has done "more to build the political will to end homelessness than all the Task Force meetings of the past three years combined. They have kept homelessness in the press and in the people's faces." www.realchangenews.org.

8. Interview by Sharon Thornton with camp member at the security desk at the entrance of the encampment, March 30, 2007.

9. Ibid.

10. Interview by Sharon Thornton with Dean Robert Taylor, April 18, 2007.

11. Ibid.

12. Ibid.

13. Saint Mark's website.

14. Interview by Sharon Thornton with Dean Robert Taylor, April 18, 2007.

15. Esther De Waal, *To Pause at the Threshold: Reflections on Living on the Border* (New York: Morehouse Publishing, 2004).

16. *The Rubric*, February 2005, Vol. 63, No. 2.

17. Ibid.

18. Ibid.

19. "God Has Pitched a Tent," a sermon by Dean Robert Taylor at Saint Mark's Cathedral, February 20, 2005

20. *The Rubric*, March 2005, Vol. 63, No. 3.

21. Ibid.

22. *The Rubric*, April 2005, Vol. 63, No. 4.

23. Timothy Harris and Liz Smith, "Faith Matters: Dean Robert Taylor on Homelessness, Community, and the Politics of Caring," *Real Change*, April 5, 2001.

24. Interview by Sharon Thornton with Dean Taylor, April 18, 2007.

25. Harris and Smith, "Faith Matters." .

26. Harris and Smith, "Faith Matters."

27. Comments made by church members at a farewell meal with the Tent City residents April 1, 2007.

28. Reflections by a staff member offered to Sharon Thornton March 29, 2007, and an interview by Sharon Thornton with one volunteer October 17, 2007.

29. Interview by Sharon Thornton with Taylor April 18, 2007.

30. Wesley Rahn, "Got Any Spare Change," *Seattle Weekly Media*, April 13, 2005.

31. "A Roof Over Every Bed in King County: Our Community's Ten-Year Plan to End Homelessness." This document was approved by the Committee to End Homeless in King County on March 7, 2005. Bill Block, Project Director, Gretchen Bruce,

Program Manager. The Committee to End Homelessness in King County: 401 5th Avenue, Suite 500 Seattle, WA 98104, cehkc@kingcounty.gov.

32. David D. Hall, *Lived Religion in America* (Princeton, N.J.: Princeton University Press, 1997), ix.

33. *The Rubric*, March 2005, Vol. 63, No. 3.

34. In an interview by Sharon Thornton with JA, October 17, 2007, JA reflected: "Yes, absolutely—although at first I may not have thought of it in those terms."

35. New Revised Standard Version: The bracketed "stranger" is my interpretation of "alien."

36. Christine D. Pohl, *Making Room: Recovering Hospitality as a Christian Tradition* (Grand Rapids, Mich.: Wm. B. Eerdmans Publishing Company, 1999), 13.

37. Pohl, *Making Room.*

38. Interview by Sharon Thornton with JA, October. 17, 2007.

39. Pohl, *Making Room*.

40. New Revised Standard Version.

41. Interview by Douglas Todd Cole, August, 18, 2006.

42. Interview by Sharon Thornton with Tent City resident, March 30, 2007.

43. "God Has Pitched a Tent."

44. Brendan Byrne, *The Hospitality of God: A Reading of Luke's Gospel* (Collegeville, Minn.: Liturgical Press, 2000), 4.

45. Julia Kristeva, *Strangers to Ourselves* (New York: Columbia University Press, 1991), 96–97.

46. Kristeva, *Strangers to Ourselves*, 192

47. Interview by Sharon Thornton with JA, October 17, 2007.

48. Frederic Buechner, *The Hungering Dark* (New York: Harper & Row, 1985), 47.

49. Conversation between a volunteer and Sharon Thornton, March 30, 2007. The important place of stories was later confirmed in an interview with another volunteer who reported that after Saint Mark's volunteers had participated in the Tent City community for a time, they created a task force to coordinate and record stories. Interview with JA, October 17, 2007.

50. Interview by Douglas Todd Cole with Tent City 3 resident August 18, 2006.

51. Henri Nouwen, *Reaching Out* (New York: Doubleday and Company, 1975), 51.

52. New Revised Standard Version.

53. Pohl, *Making Room*, 13.

54. Interview by Sharon Thornton with JA, October 17, 2007.

55. *Book of Common Prayer*. New York: The Church Hymnal Corporation, 1979.

56. *Book of Common Prayer*.

57. "Blessed Are You," a sermon by Dean Robert Taylor at Saint Mark's Cathedral, January 30, 2005.

58. Book of Common Prayer, 860.

59. Daniel Migliore, "Christology in Context: The Doctrinal and Contextual Tasks of Christology Today," *Interpretation*, July 1995, 252.

60. Joerg Rieger, *Remember the Poor: The Challenge to Theology in the Twenty-First Century* (Harrisburg, Pa.: Trinity Press International, 1998), 208.

61. JRieger, *Remember the Poor*, 208.

62. Ibid..

63. "Blessed Are You."

64. "Blessed Are You."
65. Interview by Sharon Thornton with JA, October 17, 2007.
66. Mary Jo Leddy, *Radical Gratitude* (Maryknoll, N.Y.: Orbis Books, 2002), 65.
67. Leddy, *Radical Gratitude*, 64.
68. "Blessings Given and Received," a sermon by Dean Robert Taylor at Saint Mark's Cathedral, May 1, 2005.
69. "Blessings Given and Received."
70. Hall, *Lived Religion in America*, 13.
71. National Low Income Housing Coalition.
72. www.cehkc.org.
73. The Committee to End Homelessness (CEH) is a broad coalition of government, faith communities, nonprofits, the business community, and homeless and formerly homeless people working together to implement the Ten-Year Plan to End Homelessness in King County, www.cehkc.org/default.aspx.
74. Committee to End Homelessness, "The Ten-Year Plan to End Homelessness in King County: The First Bold Steps," Spring 2006, 15.
75. "The Ten-Year Plan," 7.
76. "The Ten-Year Plan," 3.
77. "The Ten-Year Plan," 5.
78. "The Ten-Year Plan."
79. "The Ten-Year Plan."
80. Pohl, *Making Room* 13.
81. Interview by Sharon Thornton with Taylor April 18, 2007.
82. Ibid.
83. When I served as the pastor of Christ Church of Chicago, UCC, this was the response of a child who was involved with her family in supporting and providing services to the local shelter program in the church's neighborhood.

II

GENDER POSITIVE CARE: RE-WRITING DIS/ABILITY, DENOMINATIONAL HISTORY, AND UNCHURCHED RELIGION

6

Resisting Stares and Stereotypes: Affirming Life

Janet E. Schaller

> When I'm putting my chair together, when I'm rolling into the store, or actually getting stuff off the shelves, people are staring at me for each of those activities.
>
> —Rebecca

> All of a sudden here I am in the public eye . . . and self-conscious. . . . But, at the same time, I've always just done things anyway. Even in the face of adversity . . . I just went ahead and did my thing and struggled through whatever people said or did. I still do that.
>
> —Camille

> Sometimes I feel like the suffering I go through, God puts me through to be able to identify with another person's suffering. Some people say it's not so, but [I'm] just trying to make some sense out of the whole thing.
>
> —Joanne

Women with visible dis/abilities report being stared at as a common part of life. For Rebecca, the stare is ubiquitous—"a normal part of my existence." Sometimes Rebecca interprets stares as benign curiosity. At other times, when the words that accompany the gesture call for a less generous interpretation, being the object of stares may be painful. Camille at times feels self-conscious about public attention to the particularities of her body. She is "really uncomfortable" when others make a public matter out of what she considers private, when her "personal behavior" is brought "up for discussion." She may be momentarily distracted and distressed

when these things happen, but she keeps going and deals with others' "insensitivity" the best she can. As with nondisabled people, women with dis/abilities have diverse experiences, multiple reactions and responses, and different ways of making sense of their lives. Joanne's belief that God is the source of dis/ability and suffering helps her make meaning of the world and her experience. If the suffering she faces, because of her dis/ability and the stigma attached to dis/ability, resides in the activity of God, then she is able to claim the good that grows out of her painful experiences, the good that comes from her ability to be with others in their suffering. Joanne's religious faith rests on a conviction that God has good reasons for all that happens and that God can use all things, even her pain and suffering, for good.

Rebecca, Camille, and Joanne, along with Liz and Edie, are women with visible dis/abilities whose stories about resisting stares and stereotypes and affirming the value of their own (and others') lives form the core of this chapter. Each of the women, at some time or other, resisted implicit or explicit negative meanings carried by stares and clearly said "no" to dominant cultural assumptions and stereotypes about dis/ability. For each of them, that "no" accompanied a "yes" to a life of value, purpose, and meaning. The practice of resisting stares, therefore, is associated with affirming one's life as is. "As is" does not mean life is worthwhile in spite of dis/ability, nor does it mean life is worthwhile in the ways that dis/ability does not interfere with living. "As is" means life is worthwhile in the circumstances in which one finds oneself, including dis/ability. Resistance to the stare is ultimately not a defiant, defensive posture, nor a demand for civil rights, though such a posture or a demand may be important at times. Rather, resistance to the stare and its implications is ultimately a movement toward flourishing.

Like the women I interviewed I, too, have felt eyes evaluating me, with my slow, uneven manner of walking. I cannot pinpoint the time when I first became aware of stares directed toward me. My earliest memories are from grade school, usually on the playground, when older, unfamiliar children would step in front of me or in some way stop me and ask, "What's wrong with you?" To their eyes I manifested some sort of wrong-being, a view that was discordant with my inner sense of self and, thus, startling and confusing. Part of me began to internalize this common view of dis/ability as "wrong" and that part wished I were invisible when children—or adults—pointed out any of my physical variations from the fairly narrow range of what is considered "normal." Another part of me rejected their conclusions altogether. What spurred me to investigate the experiences of women with dis/abilities was what I noticed happening in church gatherings related to dis/ability. I began to see more clearly the ways in which the church unthinkingly denied full participation to people with dis/abilities, often in

very subtle ways, and mirrored, not surprisingly, the assumptions of the commercial, legal, economic, and medical cultures surrounding it. I was troubled by the steps in the chancel area that kept people with mobility dis/abilities out. I was dismayed at rituals, old and new, that sidelined people with dis/abilities. It seemed important to hear the voices and stories of women with dis/abilities in order both to name the problem of marginalization and to seek practices of care that go beyond encouraging people with dis/abilities to adjust or adapt to an environment created for nondisabled people. I learned more than I expected to find. Most prominent in my findings is the uniqueness of each person. Though most people with visible dis/abilities confront attitudinal barriers in some ways, those barriers are not necessarily the same for each person. Nor did the women interviewed respond in the same ways. There are some similarities and many differences. I will present some of each.

This chapter, as a venture in lived religion and pastoral theology from the vantage point of living with dis/abilities, endeavors to show the diverse ways women with visible physical dis/abilities face narrow and largely negative social attitudes about dis/ability and yet choose to write narratives with their lives that are different from the scripts society expects, and even (re)creates, for them. Whereas medical, religious, economic, and consumer cultures tend to make people with dis/abilities objects of another's actions, these women prefer to be subjects of their own actions. Their personal agency takes place in hospitals, communities of faith, boardrooms, workplaces, and homes. As a work in lived religion, this essay describes how these five women make meaning from their life experiences, especially confrontations with negative social attitudes, and shows the intertwining of their deeply held beliefs and the life practices that emerge from such beliefs. Through the practices of resisting stares and stereotypes and writing their own narratives by the living of their lives, Rebecca, Camille, Joanne, Liz, and Edie reveal the fundamental conviction that their lives have value, purpose, and meaning.

Lived religion is religion broadly construed, not necessarily tied to organized religion or to specific doctrines. It is with this broad understanding of religion or faith that I consider the practices and meanings of resistance to stares and stereotypes. As someone with deep roots in Christianity, I see the affirmation of life in resistance to marginalization and stigmatization as a profoundly faithful practice. As C. S. Song emphasizes, in both the Hebrew Scriptures and the Christian New Testament, God is found in the choosing of life, not death.[1] An affirmation of life involves the choosing of life and life in its fullness. In the Gospels Jesus seeks out and companions with persons who are marginalized—to the disapproval of the religious authorities. Choosing life and resisting diminishment are ways of being in the world that enact divine intentions and

can guide pastoral caregivers who have the opportunity to serve in the company of people with dis/abilities.

This chapter has two main sections. The first section describes dominant cultural beliefs about dis/ability as those are revealed in terminology, stares and stereotypes, and cultural assumptions. The second part focuses on the ways these five women encounter and disrupt stereotypes by living meaningful lives. Implications for pastoral practice thread their way throughout the chapter. Before surveying cultural beliefs, let me briefly describe the women.

THE WOMEN

Joanne, Camille, Liz, Rebecca, and Edie are women with visible dis/abilities. Each woman is distinctive; each has her own history, worldview, and particular way of making meaning out of her experiences and context. The women also experience commonalities as they face similar environments.

- Joanne, a poet, is extremely active in her local church and mainline Christian denomination. She states that she "was born with cerebral palsy."
- Camille is an artist. She has close ties with her local congregation, which would be comfortable drawing on faith traditions beyond Christianity. She describes herself as having dystonia, which is characterized by neck spasms that cause involuntary head movements. This began in early adulthood.
- Liz, a dis/ability advocate, runs an organization that promotes the gifts of people with dis/abilities. A tumor was discovered on her spinal column in early childhood. She views the Christian church of her childhood as a somewhat restrictive place to persons with dis/abilities and currently nurtures her spirituality individually.
- Rebecca is a graduate student whose spirituality reveals itself in a reverence toward nature. Several years ago she experienced a traumatic injury that necessitated the amputation of both her legs.
- Edie, a graduate student, finds her spiritual home in Buddhism. She had a spinal cord injury seven years ago due to a car accident.

Joanne is African American; the other women are European American. Four of the women use a wheelchair; Camille does not. Rebecca and Edie are in their late twenties; Camille is in her forties; and Joanne and Liz are in their early fifties. Some rely on social service agencies to get needs met; others are rather well off. All five live in the United States and are native English-speakers.

CULTURAL VIEWS ON DIS/ABILITY

Terminology

The word "disability" has more than one meaning and, as the study of lived religion makes clear, meanings and actions are connected. For some, "disability" refers to a physical feature attached to an individual that signifies an inability. Because this way of thinking about dis/ability focuses on what is "wrong" with the individual, the solution focuses on the individual as well. The individual requires change—correcting a "defect" (Liz characterized herself as "rebuilt from shoulders down to feet and back up again") or accommodating to the social environment (Joanne tried to keep people from noticing the "shaking" of her hand by sitting on it) or learning to work around the particularities of physicality (Edie sometimes asks another shopper to reach an item on a top shelf in the grocery store).

Though a definition of dis/ability as a physical feature involving a "lack" is popular, particularly in our medical-oriented culture, this meaning is problematic. First, the term emphasizes what a person appears to lack in comparison with some typical or even ideal body and ignores the abilities a person possesses. My use of a "/" to separate the "dis" from the "abilities" when referring to persons with dis/abilities is an effort to remind readers that physical limitations and physical (or other) abilities are not mutually exclusive.

Second, "disability" as "lack" is inadequate because it focuses only on individual characteristics and ignores the culture within which the individual functions. A fuller understanding of the term would take into account that people with dis/abilities live in an environment created for nondisabled persons. Literary critic and dis/ability scholar Rosemarie Garland Thomson addresses this problem when she defines "disability" as "the attribution of corporeal deviance—not so much a property of bodies as a product of cultural rules about what bodies should be or do."[2] Identifying a body as having deviance ascribed to it acknowledges physical particularities but does so by also admitting the social judgment that places that body outside of a predetermined cultural norm. The body with a dis/ability, by "disobeying" the "rules about what bodies should be or do," is relegated to a different category—a category that carries stigma and marginalization. This definition places the "problem" of dis/ability in narrow cultural assumptions rather than in specific features of particular bodies. Thus, addressing the "problem" of dis/ability involves social change more than any physical alterations.

Stares and Stereotypes

As the word "disability" has multiple meanings, so the stare can be both gesture and symbol; the gesture is a concrete action while the symbol is

more complex and potentially damaging. Within dis/ability studies literature, the stare as gesture-symbol often carries a specific negative meaning[3] and reflects the differences in value society attributes to people with dis/abilities in comparison with nondisabled persons.

Camille tells of being at a party when she notices a man staring at her. After a while he approaches her with a scarf in hand, inviting her to cover up her "problem." The stare tends to go in one direction. This unidirectional nature of the stare reveals power differentials. Nondisabled people feel quite comfortable staring at people with dis/abilities and approaching them with personal questions or suggestions. Differences in power are also revealed when nondisabled people assume the power to make decisions for the disabled person. Joanne attended an out-of-town conference and was unable to take her electric wheelchair with her. The non-motorized chair she used required someone else to push her. The person who volunteered to take her around took her where he wanted to go rather than asking her where she wanted to go and with whom she wished to speak. He was quite at ease in taking the lead and not consulting with her.

The stare usually focuses on a specific feature of an individual's body or behavior to the exclusion of everything else. According to Thomson, the body with a dis/ability, in violating society's rules about what a body should be and do, becomes a "visual assault" to the nondisabled person.[4] One man casually remarked to Rebecca that it was "horrible" to look at her. The stare, Thomson notes, "sculpts the disabled subject into a grotesque spectacle."[5] On the other hand, some people find the accoutrements of dis/ability fascinating. Liz encounters people, children, and adults, who are particularly attracted to her van. Edie was on a date once with a man who directed his attention and desire toward her chair, which he lovingly admired. Whether a woman is viewed as a grotesque or fascinating spectacle, the interest is in something other than the person herself. The focus is on an attribute or possession of the individual rather than the whole self. Such staring parses the person.

According to Stewart D. Govig, a minister, professor of religion, and a person with a dis/ability, stares communicate social or attitudinal barriers. He compares stares to stairs, the latter functioning as architectural barriers. Attitudinal barriers are "more elusive enemies" and include "hidden fears and habits of 'keeping one's distance.'"[6] The stare has a twin—"Don't stare!"—which is another form of distancing that fails to acknowledge the other. Camille, whose work as an artist involves both creating and selling her products, describes the "Don't stare!" barrier with customers as an "awkwardness" and notes that some people refuse to "even look at you at all. They'll talk away from you."

The stare also functions as a symbol for negative interactions in general. When I asked Joanne about her experiences of the stare, she told stories of

times when she felt devalued. Not all of these stories involved her being the object of visual attention alone. Some stories focused on negative remarks about her speech patterns while others told of exclusion or mistreatment. For Joanne, the stare symbolizes being on the receiving end of unkindness, cruelty, and ignorance.

In a single gesture, a stare may communicate a myriad of messages. For these women, all stares are not equally distressing. Sometimes another's staring is chalked up to curiosity, which is not unduly troubling to several women. Stares experienced as harmful convey cultural power dynamics, focus on a single bodily or behavioral characteristic, indicate an attitudinal barrier, and often are accompanied by demeaning words or actions.

The ways in which the messages communicated by a stare conform to social beliefs about dis/ability contribute to the (re)formation of a stereotype. The person who sees another and regards her body as outside conventional expectations of bodies—and, therefore, disabled—has placed that person into the disabled "box" or category with little more than a single glance. Rebecca described an incident in which she was rolling down the street in her chair heading for town when she noticed a man standing on the corner staring at her. As she came closer to this man, he initiated a conversation with her and asked, "Are you able to do anything?" The stranger failed to see Rebecca and, inaccurately, saw a disabled person who in *his* eyes very likely could do nothing, who was marked by inability—a common stereotype of people with dis/abilities.[7]

The stare is about seeing and being seen, and it is also about not seeing and not being seen. Knowledge based on visual observation is partial. We know less than we think we know. To be truly known requires more than visual apprehension. Our vision is restrictive, and thus, our knowledge based on the visual is limited, even false. The stare is a way of seeing that sees selectively, sees what the starer has been taught to see, and creates anew what has already been created. It confirms what the one who stares already thought she or he knew. Because one sees only what one is looking for, one takes for granted that what is noticed is all there is and fails to look further. The multiple possibilities of taking in the other are cut short.

The stare is an oppressive gaze that becomes a vehicle for objectification, for seeing what one already thinks one knows and, thus, projecting onto the other a stereotype previously formed. An object to be observed is not a person with whom one could be in a mutual relationship. In churches, and no doubt in other communities as well, there is the false notion that caregiving, when it involves persons with dis/abilities, goes from the nondisabled to those with dis/abilities. It is often called charity. But having a dis/ability does not negate the capacity to offer and provide care to others. Living fully includes caring that goes both ways.

Transformation is possible when those who have been objects of the stare become subjects in defining themselves. Refusing to buy into the dominant stereotypes, women with dis/abilities challenge the paradigm for dis/ability as crafted by nondisabled seers as they create their own lives and stories. Ministries of care can support this urge to resist, both in people with dis/abilities and in communities of faith. Such ministries help to create communal stories where the value of an individual is not judged by corporeality, where no one is stigmatized as deviant due to physicality, and where every-body belongs.

Cultural Assumptions about Dis/ability

Embracing the value, purpose, and meaning of life with dis/ability involves persons with dis/abilities resisting stares and negative messages about their value. Along with stereotypes about what a person with dis/ability is like, dominant cultural assumptions about dis/ability include the notions that people with dis/abilities are better off dead, not quite human, and undesirable.

Better off Dead

Unfortunately, one of the consequences of living with a body that does not follow "cultural rules about what a body should be or do" is that some people think you should not exist. It is not uncommon to hear (or repeat) such pronouncements as "Some things are worse than death" when a relative, friend, or acquaintance has had a paralyzing stroke or has been in an accident that severed limbs. According to Paul K. Longmore, a historian and dis/ability scholar, a dominant view of dis/ability in the United States is that "disability makes membership in the community and meaningful life itself impossible, and death is preferable. Better dead than disabled."[8] Dis/ability and living fully are mutually exclusive in this line of thought.

The biomedical issues in genetic testing, choices in medical treatment about artificially prolonging life or death, and the misery of some illnesses involve many complexities to which family members and physicians respond the best they can. Nonetheless, selective abortion, withholding of medical treatment, assisted suicide, and "mercy" killing are or have been methods utilized to eliminate or attempt to eliminate people with dis/abilities at every stage of life. Compassion and caring are reasons given for these actions. Susan Wendell challenges this notion and suggests that

> the desire for perfection and control of the body, or for the elimination of differences that are feared, poorly understood, and widely considered to be marks of inferiority, easily masquerades as the compassionate desire to prevent or

> stop suffering. It is not only a matter of being deceived by others, but all too often a matter of deceiving ourselves. It is easy to make the leaps from imagining that I would not want to live in certain circumstances to believing that no one would want to live in those circumstances, to deciding to prevent people from being born into those circumstances, to supporting proposals "mercifully" to kill people living in those circumstances—*all without ever consulting anyone who knows life in those circumstances from experience*.[9]

In fact, most people with dis/abilities are reasonably satisfied with their lives.[10] Many people with dis/abilities believe that social attitudes, such as those revealed in stares and stereotypes, are greater obstacles to their full participation in a community than any physical trait.

Not Quite Human

A second cultural assumption questions the full humanity and value of people with dis/abilities and, thus, compromises their basic physical, emotional, relational, and spiritual needs. In his ground-breaking work on stigma, Goffman states that stigmatized persons, a category including those with dis/abilities, are viewed as "not quite human."[11] A person who is considered less than fully human can be treated less than humanely.

Disrespectful behavior is an aspect of dehumanization. Joanne recalls times when people behind her in line at the grocery store would criticize her because of the long time it took her to write a check. The YMCA refused to provide her housing. A religious organization decided she was unfit to join them. Furthermore, her own siblings fail to invite her to gatherings in which non-family members will be present—she suspects they are embarrassed by her dis/ability.

Poet and essayist Eli Clare, a woman who has cerebral palsy, remembers the childhood wounds caused by name-calling.[12] She also reports being a target for sexual abuse as a child.[13] Dis/ability and violence expert Dick Sobsey "estimates that people with disabilities are abused sexually 50 percent more often than people without disabilities."[14] Two of the women I interviewed mentioned histories of abuse, one as a child, the other as an adult.

Medical treatment may not seem as if it belongs in the same category as dehumanization and abuse. Indeed, many medical treatments provide persons with dis/abilities with the potential for living fuller lives, able to engage in more activities than otherwise possible. However, medical treatments with the goal of correcting "defects" sometimes fail to appreciate the integrity of a particular body.[15] Medical treatment may also focus on "normalizing" bodies to the extent that it fails to take into account the wholeness of the person whose body is identified as needing treatment.

When I interviewed Edie, she had recently returned from a month's stay in the hospital due to a decubitus ulcer that had gone unnoticed and, therefore,

untreated far too long. Edie was ambivalent about her treatment. On the one hand, she believed that the medical personnel did everything in their power to bring about the necessary healing. On the other hand, she experienced the restrictions they placed on her and the suggestions they offered for further care as conflicting with her way of being in the world. She saw herself and expected others to see her as strong and competent. The restrictive recommendations of the physicians and nurses, Edie felt, underestimated her strength and her abilities. "I learned all over again, in many ways more deeply, how insidious and how disabling that experience itself is—being told 'You can't do it.'" She resisted living out the life that others determined would be sustaining for her. She wanted to follow her own sense of her life's path and ways of living that met her emotional and spiritual needs.

Undesirable

Stares and stereotypes show that bodies are often valued according to their proximity to the ideals of consumer as well as medical cultures. A consumer culture's definition of physical beauty excludes dis/ability. Edie experienced this when the collision of "woman" and "dis/ability" played out in her social life. She reported a dramatic change in the way others, particularly men, perceived her prior to her becoming a woman with a dis/ability and afterward. Before her accident, men regularly sought her out, and she was "dating like crazy." Afterwards few men took a romantic interest in her. Rather, she was considered "just friends" by male acquaintances.

Accepting the goodness and beauty of bodies with dis/abilities when cultural messages deny such a possibility is a challenge. Women especially (as compared with men) are noticed and appreciated for physical attractiveness. Those who do not or cannot reach or attempt to reach culture's ideal of female attractiveness may experience "cultural humiliation."[16] Sociologist Gilkes, in discussing the oppression faced by African-American women when their bodies differ from the standard of beauty in North America, suggests loving one's body as an act of resistance. Women with dis/abilities of any ethnic group or skin color can love themselves despite narrow cultural values. Persons in ministries of care can join that resistance and learn to value variations in human bodily form and convey that appreciation to others.

Those engaged in pastoral practice can promote well-being for people with dis/abilities by nurturing the urge to resist these forms of dehumanization. On a communal level this calls for both people with dis/abilities and nondisabled people to belong to and participate fully in communities of faith. Not only is the well-being of people with dis/abilities diminished by exclusion from fully belonging, but nondisabled persons also are the lesser for restricting their companionship to other nondisabled persons, limiting their view of possibilities in life.

AFFIRMING LIFE

All the women in this study faced stares and encountered the ill effects of stereotypes, yet each woman also affirmed the value of her own life. The challenges differed for each, and the ways the individual women moved into affirming the value of their lives varied. As noted earlier, resistance to cultural views that tend to diminish the value of people with dis/abilities is not only a rejection of false assumptions, but a move toward flourishing.

JOANNE: "I'M JUST TRYING TO MAKE SOME SENSE OF THE WHOLE THING"

Joanne is the most traditional of the five women in understanding the meaning of her life in religious terms. The reasons for mistreatment, the affirmation of herself and her life as valuable, and the pastoral practices leading to her living life more fully are all grounded in her Christian faith.

Joanne has been identified by hurtful labels, beaten up at school, neglected by family members, ostracized by neighbors, denied housing, and ridiculed in public places. In her understanding, stares and stereotypes are symbols for demeaning experiences. A steady stream of devaluing experiences could lead a person to believe that she is worthless. And Joanne's bouts of depression likely indicate that sometimes she struggles with this. But overriding these experiences and feelings is a powerful and life-affirming sense that God is with her, cares about her well-being, and calls her to participate in the divine intention for others. She believes her corporeality is part of God's plan for her life and gives purpose to her life. She thinks her experiences, even the painful ones, lead her to be more sensitive to others. And she is able to "be there for another person, to listen to someone . . . to show the face of Christ" because she, too, has suffered. So she concludes, as her remarks at the beginning of the chapter reveal, that her suffering is God-given to form her into one who has the sensitivities to understand the suffering of others and be a credible source of comfort to them. She recognizes that not everyone agrees with the way she makes sense of her life experiences, but it gives life meaning and purpose for her. Her meaning-making is a wrestling with ultimate meaning, an attempt to make sense of God's activity in the world in light of unkindness and injustice and in acknowledgement of the fruits of her abilities to relate and respond to others when they are enduring troubles. Her ability to reach out to others and have an impact on their lives gives her a sense of God's purpose for her life as she sees herself as a vehicle of Christ. In one of her poems she writes, "I am God's servant." She asserts that those who fail to take the time to listen to her are missing something since "I am worthy to be heard." She claims the

value of her being, her words, and her life and the importance of her relationship with God.

Joanne also states that God doesn't see her as disabled. As she uses the term in this way she separates her physicality from the social construction or stereotype of dis/ability. This is her way of saying that God does not see her as lesser than others. She resists the devaluation and dehumanization that she sometimes has experienced, and still encounters, with social agencies, neighbors, educational institutions, and even the church. Though the church has largely been very good to her, Joanne's story of her interactions with communities of faith is rich in ambiguity: she is marginalized at times and takes leadership roles at other times. She has stopped attending fellowship time after worship in her local church because people avoid talking to her. Her local congregation derails any of her offers to speak in corporate worship, whether to read scripture or to make announcements. On the other hand, leaders at the denominational level select her to participate in special worship services or as part of the leadership team at retreats.

Pastoral practices affect Joanne's life in various ways and multiple levels. She is both the provider and recipient of care. She offers care as she extends herself to others who are experiencing painful times. Others offer care to her—often in practical individual ways, such as taking her to a doctor's appointment when she is too ill to drive. Pastoral practice is extended to her *and* the community when she is invited to read her poems at the installation of a denominational official. It is practices such as these that demonstrate a rejection of cultural stereotypes and false assumptions and an affirmation of her ability to contribute to the community.

LIZ: "NOBODY ELSE NEEDS TO GO THROUGH THIS STUFF AGAIN"

Except for growing up with a dis/ability, Liz's story and circumstances are very different from Joanne's. Liz grew up in an affluent family. Her parents focused much loving attention on her. She had access to the best medical care. Liz describes confusing and off-putting interactions with the church and religious people. Furthermore, whereas Joanne is very careful about her practices of resistance, usually concerned not to upset others, Liz cultivates political clout in order to advocate for the civil rights of people with dis/abilities.

Liz finds stares so common that she says she is "accustomed" to them and usually unconcerned about them, though they were not always as easy to shake off as they are now. The ones she described in some detail occurred when she was a young adult. She recounted a time when she was traveling with a group of disabled people, and noticed a man staring at each of them as they boarded the bus. She stared back and, laughingly, pointed toward

him until *he* became embarrassed and walked away. "He was looking at us like we were freaks. We are not freaks. We are out here doing what we want to do, all of us having a good time on this trip . . . how dare he!" Now, in her advocacy work, Liz uses any attention she gets to good advantage. Liz's affluence and boldness give her the resources necessary to make a difference in many peoples' lives. She participates in a number of civic and political organizations, always on the lookout for the implications their actions have for people with dis/abilities.

She describes her current work as making sure that others do not have to endure the difficulties she faced. "Nobody else needs to go through this stuff again. Nobody else needs to go through people throwing money at you on the streets because you have a dis/ability. Nobody needs to ever have to wonder whether they can go to the bathroom some place again. Nobody ever needs to wonder whether a program is going to be accessible, or a college, or a movie theater, or whether there's going to be a sign-interpreted performance, or an audio description available, or any of those aspects—transportation, housing . . . churches, by God!" The charge to dismantle the architectural and social barriers that she has faced throughout her life seems to give Liz meaning and purpose in life. However, I hasten to add that her work is not the only thing that gives her life value. It is one of the many activities she enjoys, but not her sole interest.

Liz grew up connected to a church, but her early memories of encounters with religious folk as well as lack of accessibility in the church building resulted in a very different relationship with organized religion than Joanne had. As a young child Liz remembers strangers coming up to her and her mother to give them money, often accompanied by religious comments. She found such gifts and sentiments humiliating and puzzling. She also recalls notes from her mother's friends encouraging her to have "faith like a mustard seed" so that she would be able to walk without assistance. She knew the medical facts and prognosis of her physical condition—it was permanent. Faith was important to her but it was not understood as a remedy to the tumor on her spinal column. Her impression of people of faith, especially those in the church, was not very positive. As a child she saw steps as she surveyed the chancel area and thought, "Jesus knows I can't get up those steps; I don't think Jesus is here." Her faith led her to question the actions and environment of the church.

Pastoral practices of care need to fit the person and her belief systems. Giving money to Liz when she was a child was not the care she needed. It would have served her better to have access to all parts of the church building. We also see in her story several ways in which care that resists obstacles and promotes fullness of life can be offered. She exemplifies ways of offering care that support and encourage others with dis/abilities without trying to change their physical appearance. Liz's foundation work

offers disabled people the ability to transcend cultural barriers and take their place in the wider community. Her work also has implications for the opportunities the church offers people with dis/abilities. Liz runs a major foundation, participates in think-tank organizations, and serves on several boards. Care for the community of faith recognizes that persons with dis/abilities have leadership abilities and are not simply marked for the role of recipient of care.

CAMILLE: "I THINK I'M REALLY GOOD AT WHAT I DO"

Unlike Joanne and Liz, dis/ability entered Camille's life when she was a young adult. Neck spasms cause involuntary and random movements of her head and arms. Because medical treatments have diminished these uncontrollable movements at times and an injury worsened them, Camille is aware of variations in the extent and degree to which these movements are noticeable. Therefore, she has an unusual perspective and is able to compare differences in the way she experiences herself and the ways others seem to perceive her when her muscle spasms are more and less obvious. As she reflected on her experience of public scrutiny, she concluded, "People are put off by the visual things they don't understand." Camille senses awkwardness on the part of others. Some people, in an apparent effort to avoid staring, avoid any face-to-face interaction with her at all. She recalls one woman in particular who looked and talked away from Camille the entire time the woman was purchasing artwork from Camille.

Camille expresses some sympathy for people who stare because they do not understand. Even so, she resents strangers calling attention to her body. She recounted some recent episodes that disturbed her. One woman thought Camille was having a seizure and was eager to get medical help for her. Another person seemed to believe that Camille was purposely moving her body in a peculiar way and laughed long and heartily at her, asking, "How do you do that?" A man mocked her and mimicked her physical movements. Attitudes and actions such as those get in the way of her life and work—but do not stop her. As the chapter's opening quotation conveys, no matter what hurtful situations confront her, she goes on with her life and work.

Camille chooses not to yield to social forces that would undermine her well-being. Through her art, she has an undeniable sense of purpose in life that guides her activities and choices. Her particular designs grow out of her gifts and abilities and her life experiences. In addition, her work is valued, she pursues her art in multiple ways, and she has confidence that she is good at it. Dis/ability complicates her work and her life but does not change her path. Because of complications, she has had to alter the

way she carries out some work, but she has managed to adapt in creative ways.

Though she does not let people who are uncomfortable with her or people who would misinterpret or make a joke out of her bodily movements change her direction in life, Camille most appreciates people who, rather than focusing on particularities of her body, look "beyond" her dis/ability and see the whole of who she is. She believes that, despite some difficulties and complications with her dis/ability, it is "no big deal." People who look "beyond" confirm that her dis/ability is "no big deal."

Camille offers pastoral caregivers a wise perspective to take—dis/ability does not define a person. There is much more to a person with a dis/ability than his or her corporeality. This is true for all persons; people with dis/abilities are not unique in this regard. Sometimes a statement such as "It's no big deal" is interpreted to mean that physicality does not matter. But our bodies do matter. Bodies, with or without dis/abilities, set limits on what we can do. When bodies are believed not to matter, we fail to take them into account when planning rituals, or arranging meeting places, or setting up activities. If a person with a physical dis/ability cannot engage in certain rituals, or finds certain meeting places to be off-limits, or cannot participate in an activity intended for an entire congregation, then failing to pay attention to corporeality means exclusion. So, echoing Camille, dis/ability is "no big deal." It does not stop a person from living fully, though limited opportunities can be restrictive and the reality of exclusion betrays Christ's call of welcome to all. Communities of faith have the opportunity and responsibility to model a way of being in the world that includes rather than excludes and that demonstrates a belief that both nondisabled bodies and nonconventional[17] bodies are normative.

In living out her life, Camille tries to discover the meaning(s) behind what happens. She wrestles with things of ultimate concern, part of which involves her understanding of the role dis/ability plays in her life. She believes that things happen in life because one has something to learn. Thus, she understands her dis/ability to mean this experience has something to teach her. The corollary to this is that when she learns the appropriate lesson, the neck spasms will go away. When the spasms diminished for a time, she thought she was on her way to understanding, and when they worsened, she concluded that she had not learned the lesson. This is in some ways a double-edged sword. On the one hand, she can be open to experiencing the fullness of life with a dis/ability, eager for learning what the universe or God has planned. On the other hand, she can become disheartened when the physical effects of the spasms increase and, then, blame herself and her lack of understanding. Pastoral listening could assist her as she wrestles with the meanings of dis/ability and its place in her life.

EDIE: "MORE IMPORTANT THAN JUST YOUR INTENTIONS [IS] THE EFFECT, THE CONSEQUENCES OF YOUR ACTIONS"

Edie suspects that stares and stereotypes are about another's encounter with the unexpected. People express surprise at her physical abilities—she doesn't fit their expectations. Strangers do not seem to expect her to be able to maneuver her chair in and out of the car. They stare at her as she gets her chair out of her car. Often they want to help her. She tells them "I have seven years of experience," and they continue to stare as she puts it together, surprised, she thinks, that she can manage this task. In college she found that other students were surprised that she was smart, that she could engage the professor in an intelligent exchange of ideas. She likes showing people what she can do; she likes challenging their views of her. Some people are surprised she can fill out forms, or that she can get her change from the rolling change machine at the grocery store. Often people ask her if they can help her with these tasks, some reach to "help" without even asking. Friends are amazed when she rearranges her furniture by herself. She affirms her value and her ability by letting her actions speak for themselves. She hopes people catch on by watching her do things that they did not expect she could do.

She experiences people expecting less of her or having no expectations of her at all. These reactions are different from the ones she got when she was a nondisabled person. "When you're able-bodied, people expect you to do things, and you expect yourself to do them." It was a shock for her to realize, about a year after her accident, that her parents were doing things for her, for example, changing channels on the television, that she could do herself. She decided to push herself to see what her limits were and not to let others do for her what she could do for herself. It is important for her to resist this lack of expectation—or expectation of lack. She experiences this as insidious and damaging to her personal well-being. As noted earlier regarding her medical treatment, the medical plan for her assumed significant dependence while she saw herself as independent and completely able to care for herself. She is insistent about claiming and demonstrating her abilities, intending this to undermine the assumption that she is marked by incapacity.

Edie also resists the hurtful notion that she is undesirable as a mate. Her basic posture toward people is trying to understand things from their perspective. She acknowledges the difficulty of dealing with wheelchairs and recognizes that the mere negotiation of her chair in and out of vehicles may be a deterrent to a man asking her out. She also believes that most nondisabled people are ignorant about sexuality and dis/ability. There is a gap, she suggests, between nondisabled people's assumptions about the sexual interest and capacity of people with physical dis/abilities and the sexual feelings and experience of disabled persons. Edie contends that bridging that gap is not so difficult. At the time of our interview Edie indicated that she was not

interested in her own personal bridge-building, though she expressed sympathy for other women with dis/abilities who were pained by being excluded as a potential partner. Even though she is not interested in an intimate relationship at this time, she chooses to challenge the idea that she is undesirable by occasional flirting. Sometimes Edie does this at times when the other will not know that she is a wheelchair user, such as by responding to the flirting initiated by a guy in the vehicle next to hers while stopped at a traffic light. But at other times she flirts with men she finds attractive in situations when she and her chair are together. She notes that they are usually surprised. Some flirt back after they get over their surprise. In her challenging assumptions and resisting stereotypes, Edie writes a new story about women with dis/abilities as sexual beings.

Despite her frequent rejection of offers of help for things she can do herself, Edie's underlying philosophy of life is that offering help to someone who needs it should be encouraged. "I don't think it's ever a good thing to thwart someone's efforts to help." Nonetheless, she hopes her polite refusals of help, accompanied by the demonstration of her ability, will lead to increased awareness. The message she hopes people learn is: "Don't be insulting; don't assume." The Buddhist understanding of "skillful means" informs her position. There are right ways of assisting others. "The idea behind [skillful means] is your intentions may be good . . . [but] more important than just your intentions [is] the effect, the consequences of your actions—they may be a lot more harmful than you realize, than you intended them to be." Her understanding of skillful means provides the foundation for Edie's making sense of her frustration and rejection of "insulting" offers of help while both valuing her abilities and another's desire to be helpful.

Edie's explanation of the Buddhist concept of skillful means has similarities with some ministries of care. Both suggest that the effect of a certain practice on the receiver of that care is a factor in assessing the appropriateness of the care offered. Well-intentioned people who initiate assistance when none is needed do Edie a disservice rather than aid her. Practices of care are most effective when they are attuned to the particularities of the persons receiving care. Edie's advice is good—"Don't assume." In other words, check it out; ask what a person needs and proceed accordingly.

REBECCA: "IN A LOT OF WAYS I'M BLESSED"

Rebecca has people staring at her for almost everything she does, as her comment that begins this chapter notes. She ignores them. She says she would not get much done if she was attentive to stares rather than to what she has to do. In fact, she generally interprets stares and those who stare

generously by reading most stares as curiosity—people simply are trying to figure out what she does and how she does it. Viewing the stare this way makes her life easier. There are times when she cannot sustain this view. Though not consciously attentive to stares, Rebecca does notice them "on a subconscious level." When enough of these have accumulated (and the amount that it takes to tip the scales has increased over the years) or when she experiences a "significant" encounter (one in which unkind words accompanied the gesture), she has to deal with them and the painful thoughts that accompany the words and stares. She may cry and even for a moment take in and accept the other's view that she is "horrible to look at," as one man told her. But she does not stay in that place. Eventually, after a few days pass, as she involves herself more fully in her life once again, she affirms, "I really do lead a relatively normal life." She has family, friends, and a partner who love and enjoy her—"in a lot of ways I'm blessed." She is engaged with studies and work. She participates fully in even the mundane things of life—shopping, cooking, washing dishes, and doing laundry. Her life takes the form of most other people's. Thus, she resists gestures and words that might devalue her, takes a "reality check," and notes that she enjoys life, has mutually satisfying relationships, and is successful in the endeavors of her life.

Rebecca does not articulate religious meaning to her life experiences, though others do. Much as Liz had people coming up to her as a child and offering religious messages or meanings to her, so people share with Rebecca the religious meaning they make of her. She tells of one person who, in the midst of a pedestrian mall, publicly and loudly declared that she and her family were sinners for generations and, he continued, "That is why you are in that chair." Though this was a potentially harmful encounter, Rebecca laughed it off, saying that the other people on the street were *staring at him* because he was making a scene. The sinner-saint dichotomy is a long-standing way people have had of making religious meaning of dis/ability. Either the dis/ability is an outward sign of sin and God's punishment, or a sign that one is a saint, presuming that God would visit dis/ability only on a person who would bear it graciously. Rebecca points out that she is more frequently seen as a saint than being identified as cursed. People want to touch her. Some say they see God in her or feel God when they look at her. Some say she is proof that prayers work. Other people respond in a similar way but without religious words, offering a more secular version of the "saintly" nature of those with dis/abilities. They say she is "amazing." She feels ambivalent about the saintly, and even "amazing," remarks. On the one hand, people who say these things do seem to be in touch with a "Higher Power," and she wants to respect that and not interfere with their faith experience. On the other hand, she is uncomfortable with such comments. "How do you live your life," she asks rhetorically, if "God is doing

all these things through me?" But she is also irritated, not wanting to be used to affirm religious beliefs she does not share.

I want to respect Rebecca's position and thus will not offer specifically theological analysis to her stories. But I do want to make some comments. She clearly feels fortunate ("blessed") to have people in her life who bring her joy. Rebecca, like the four other women, has deeply held beliefs about the value of her life and the lives of other people with dis/abilities. She has created a new life for herself after a traumatic event changed her body, and she had the task of incorporating a "literally new physical image" and discovering a new path for her life.[18] Having been out of college only a short time, she returned to school and has become very involved in researching and writing about the history of people with dis/abilities. She is very open to talking with people about her experience of living with dis/ability, especially to children whom she finds wondrously open in the questions they ask her. She answers simply and honestly and, as she said, "They don't care; they really don't care." That is, they accept her without judgment. They seem to act as if dis/ability just *is*. This acceptance contains no hint of the negative stereotypes that often become attached to dis/ability. Rebecca creates new ways to think about dis/ability and offers that to the young children who speak to her. She calls this "subverting the dominant paradigm" of dis/ability because she displays an alternative viewpoint before the children have absorbed society's largely negative assumptions about dis/ability.

Rebecca's story raises at least two implications for pastoral caregivers. One is the invitation to join her and others in subverting the dominant paradigm about dis/ability. To think outside the stereotype, to be open to more than the media reports or movies about dis/ability, and to examine how one's own preconceived notions opens one to possibilities not typically imagined by the nondisabled population. Her story also reminds pastoral caregivers not to impose a religious interpretation on a person or her life. Pastoral caregivers may be asked to provide care for a person not of one's own faith tradition or of no particular (organized) faith tradition. For a caregiver to force his or her religious view on another can be harmful. Instead one is more likely to provide helpful care by following the other's interpretation of her situation and by letting her tell you the meaning she makes of life and the type of care most desired.

REWRITING DIS/ABILITY

With an ironic nod to the past, the Society for Disability Studies sells pencils with the phrase "Rewriting Disability" printed on them. Indeed, cultural scripts about dis/ability which are inaccurate, toxic, and stigmatizing need rewriting both in individual lives and in the practices of communities of

faith. The narratives of these five women testify to the importance of writing new stories about dis/ability, ones that transform practices—practices of ordinary human interactions and practices originating in faith traditions. The transformation of narratives and practices emerges from resistance to that which dehumanizes or marginalizes, such as stares and stereotypes. Rather than being an aberration of human life, physical limits are part of the human condition. All humans have limitations and abilities. To the extent that dis/ability is seen as embodying limits, it is a common human feature.

Rewriting dis/ability from within faith communities means choosing to act in ways that move people from the edges, from being stereotyped, ignored, or sidelined, to full participation and fullness of life. C. S. Song writes, "God chooses, promises, blesses, and commissions for the sake of life."[19] Rewriting dis/ability is both an individual task and a corporate responsibility. In a life-giving environment, people with dis/abilities are an integral part of the community and, thus, (1) are tapped for leadership roles of all kinds; (2) inform the process for inclusion; (3) assist in the re-creation of accessible rituals and architecture; (4) offer as well as receive care; and (5) provide feedback on such matters as language and scriptural interpretation about dis/ability in order to dismantle stereotypes in such areas as educational events, theological concepts, liturgy, and preaching.

Caring for the urge to resist in persons with dis/abilities who face stares, stereotypes, and discrimination is another arena in which pastoral caregivers may find themselves at work. Again, caregivers can follow the lead of the person marginalized or stigmatized. Pastoral caregivers, disabled and nondisabled, can find ways to draw upon and highlight what individuals already know about themselves and their ways of making meaning in life. Pastoral caregivers can (1) encourage individuals to identify and claim gifts and abilities in a world that primarily sees limitation; (2) support persons in the process of separating their identities from disingenuous cultural images; (3) participate in crafting new images and alternative stories about dis/ability; and (4) affirm disabled persons' own sense of value in life.

As is clear from the stories of these five women, people with dis/abilities are already moving in ways that resist stares and stigmatization and participate in the world in life-affirming ways. Pastoral caregivers are invited to join this journey.

CONCLUSION

I began this project because I wanted others to hear a message of possibility and transformation regarding persons with visible (and other) dis/abilities—possibility and transformation of images of dis/ability and of interpersonal interactions, possibility and transformation of congregations from

excluding places to communities where everyone belongs. Somewhere along the way I also revised my views about dis/ability and possibility through the narratives told by these five women with visible physical dis/abilities. It is not unusual for people with dis/abilities to be surrounded by nondisabled folks. It is not unusual for people with dis/abilities to know no one else or have no one else in their immediate family or among their closest friends who is also disabled. That was certainly my experience. From the beginning I became intrigued with the women who agreed to speak with me and with the stories they told, both the shocking stories of disregard by others and the encouraging stories of finding ways to live fully in the midst of obstacles bred by inaccurate representations of dis/ability. Though each of us experienced confrontation with stares and stereotypes, stigma and marginalization, neither the situations where we experienced these nor our responses to those situations were necessarily uniform. This reinforced for me, in an unexpected way, the erroneous and deceptive categorization of people as disabled and, thus, the importance of resisting stereotypes that constrict participation in faith communities and the wider society.

The women whose narratives inform this chapter cannot be defined by physical features. Each is unique, representing a range of socioeconomic classes, having different educational and vocational backgrounds, and holding a variety of religious or spiritual beliefs. Each has different ideas about what religion or spirituality means in her life and the ways those beliefs enhance life. Though what they have to say cannot be generalized, their narratives do provide some ideas of the obstacles facing women with dis/abilities. Their stories and lives also offer wisdom in the movement toward greater flourishing for all people, with or without dis/abilities, and the communities of faith to which they belong.

NOTES

1. C. S. Song, *Tracing the Footsteps of God: Discovering What You Really Believe* (Minneapolis, Minn.: Fortress Press, 2007), 72.

2. Rosemarie Garland Thomson, *Extraordinary Bodies* (New York: Columbia University Press, 1997), 6.

3. Books with titles such as *No More Stares* and *Staring Back* reveal the negative experience of many people with dis/abilities when confronted with staring others. See Ann Cupulo, Katherine Corbett, and Victoria Lewis, *No More Stares* (Berkeley: Disability Rights Education and Defense Fund, 1982); and Kenny Fries, ed., *Staring Back: The Disability Experience from the Inside Out* (New York: Plume, 1997).

4. Thomson, *Extraordinary Bodies*, 26.

5. Thomson, *Extraordinary Bodies*, 26.

6. Stewart D. Govig, *Strong at the Broken Places: Persons with Disabilities and the Church* (Louisville, Ky.: Westminster/John Knox Press, 1989), 11–12.

7. See Janet E. Schaller, "Failed Mirroring as a Cultural Phenomenon," *Pastoral Psychology* 56, no. 5 (May 2008): 507–20, for an expanded discussion of this experience recounted by Rebecca in conversation with the psychoanalytic concept of mirroring.

8. Paul K. Longmore, "Screening Stereotypes: Images of Disabled People in Television and Motion Pictures," in *Images of the Disabled, Disabling Images*, ed. Alan Gartner and Tom Joe (New York: Praeger, 1987), 70.

9. Susan Wendell, *The Rejected Body: Feminist Philosophical Reflections on Disability* (New York: Routledge, 1996), 156 [emphasis added].

10. According to a survey conducted in 2000, 63 percent of people with dis/abilities were satisfied with their lives. A greater percentage of nondisabled people expressed satisfaction with life (91 percent). The difference may be due to nondisabled people having greater access to factors that improve life satisfaction, such as a greater likelihood of being employed and optimism for the future. See "Life Satisfaction of People with Disabilities," nod.citysoft.org/index.cfm?fuseaction=feature.showFeature&FeatureID=112&C:\CFusion8\verity\Data\dummy.txt (accessed January 13, 2009).

11. Erving Goffman, *Stigma: Notes on the Management of Spoiled Identity* (Englewood Cliffs, N.J.: Prentice-Hall, 1963), 5.

12. Eli Clare, *Exile and Pride: Disability, Queerness, and Liberation* (Cambridge, Mass.: South End Press, 1999), 68.

13. Clare, *Exile and Pride*, 9.

14. As noted in Wendell, *The Rejected Body*, 187, fn6.

15. See the stories of Diane DeVries in Geyla Frank's "On Embodiment," in *Women with Disabilities*, eds. Michelle Fine and Adrienne Asch (Philadelphia: Temple University Press, 1988), 52–53; and Sucheng Chan in "You're Short, Besides!" in *Making Face, Making Soul/Haciendo Caras: Creative and Critical Perspectives by Feminists of Color*, ed. Gloria Anzaldua (San Francisco: Aunt Lute Foundation Books, 1990), 166.

16. "Cultural humiliation" is a term used by Cheryl Townsend Gilkes in "The 'Loves' and 'Troubles' of African-American Women's Bodies," in *A Troubling in My Soul: Womanist Perspectives on Evil and Suffering*, ed. Emilie Townes (Maryknoll, N.Y.: Orbis Books, 1993), 232–49, to describe feelings of African American women when confronted by thin white women as the ideal.

17. "Nonconventional bodies" is a term used by Nancy L. Eiesland in *The Disabled God: Toward a Liberatory Theology of Disability* (Nashville: Abingdon Press, 1994).

18. For further discussion of persons' accommodating multiple self-images or identities, see Janet E. Schaller, "Reconfiguring Dis/ability: Multiple and Narrative Constructions of Self," *Pastoral Psychology* 57, nos. 1 and 2 (September 2008): 89–99.

19. Song, *Tracing the Footsteps of God*, 84.

7

Baptist Clergywomen's Narratives: Reinterpreting the Southern Baptist Convention Schism

Eileen R. Campbell-Reed

INTRODUCTION

> I tried for a year or more before and after finishing Southeastern [Seminary] to find a place in the less conservative states in the South before turning elsewhere to fulfill my dream. I had hoped to be a Southern Baptist pastor. This was my background; this was my home; this was my dream; but when doors are shut God is good to open others.
>
> —Addie Davis[1]

More than four decades ago, in 1964, Watts Street Baptist Church in Durham, North Carolina, ordained Addie Davis, making her the first Southern Baptist woman ordained to pastoral ministry.[2] In the years that followed, Southern Baptists saw a small but growing number of women ordained to ministry. However, the political landscape of the Convention began shifting in 1979 into what moderate Baptists call "the takeover" and what conservative Baptists refer to as a "resurgence" or "course correction." Presently the Southern Baptist Convention (SBC) is comprised of more than 40,000 churches, more than 16 million members, and a multi-billion dollar enterprise of missionary work, theological schools, boards, and agencies, making it the largest Protestant denomination in America.[3]

Out of the conflict that ensued in the 1980s, two splinter groups, the Alliance of Baptists (AB) and the Cooperative Baptist Fellowship (CBF), emerged.[4] The contrasts between the SBC and the new groups are varied and numerous, yet each group continues to declare themselves authentically Baptist. One major difference can be found in the institutional posi-

tions on women's ordination. Since 1979 SBC annual resolutions, confessional statements, Bible study literature, and most official convention publications persistently refocused women's roles toward the private, familial, and supportive, and away from the public, ecclesial, and authoritative. By contrast, churches affiliated with the Alliance and CBF have increasingly declared support for women's leadership and continued to call, ordain, and hire women for ministry.[5]

The schism in the SBC has been documented over the past decade in several academic studies and partisan writings which capture sentiments from both sides.[6] In these studies, if women's ordination and ministry are addressed at all, they are most often portrayed as flashpoints of controversy and typically reduced to one chapter in the larger discussion of the splintering denomination. Clergywomen are almost never taken seriously for their contribution toward understanding the recent schism in the SBC or the ways gender is conceived in the Baptist ethos. This essay contests the portrayal of women's ordination as a mere fault line for division, and considers how the stories and experiences as told by clergywomen in their own narratives deepen and complexify understanding of the Southern Baptist schism.

By making clergywomen's narratives the starting point, two significant findings emerge. First, the clergywomen reinterpret the Baptist ideal of *soul competency*. Previously this interrelated set of beliefs and practices, understood as soul competency, has declared freedom for all people to read scripture, interpret it within a faith community, and act on the convictions that are concluded. However, it has maintained a status quo by hiding within the rhetoric of freedom different and unequal roles for men and women in Baptist communities of faith. Clergywomen challenge the inequality and use the principle itself to practice full membership and ecclesial leadership among Baptists.

Second, the study finds that the clergywomen's reinterpretation of soul competency points the way toward a reinterpretation of the schism itself as inevitable among Baptists, and yet not the final word about who is and is not authentically Baptist. By analyzing how Baptist clergywomen negotiate the tensions between the competing authorities of the Bible and their own religious experience, we see how they find ways to remain Baptist and pursue their callings. Their narratives point to a meaningful cultural space which is created by these tensions, allowing for the development of creativity, maturity, and trust. These same contrasting dynamics can be observed in the SBC schism which seethed in the 1980s and fostered a cultural climate of polarization, conflict, and hostility in the institutional life of Southern Baptists. The analysis reveals that cultural climates of both support and hostility were each present and simultaneously formative.

David Hall, editor of *Lived Religion in America*, suggests that ethnographic studies of laymen and -women are at the heart of understanding religious

beliefs and practices of Americans.[7] The present study argues that *clergywomen* also hold potential for enlivening the historical understanding of the cultural dynamics of lived religion. Like many clergypersons, Baptist clergywomen can be conceived as standing at the boundaries between popular religion and ecclesial religion.

Baptist clergywomen do not necessarily participate in the academic production of religious knowledge, yet they are influenced by it through the teaching and writing of *academic* elites in college and seminary. Neither are the women in the present study among the *ecclesial* elites, publishing church doctrine or policy or acting as denominational power brokers. On the other hand, they are highly invested in the future of their denominational affiliations because their vocations and livelihoods are linked to the shape and direction of those institutions. By virtue of their work in ministry, which includes both reflection and proclamation, they are also skilled and articulate about their religious experiences and able to relate them to Baptist beliefs and practices.

To date, efforts to interpret the motivations, politics, and dynamics of the SBC schism appear mainly in partisan ecclesial publications or through academic studies of the social conflict. The question under consideration is whether an examination of the ways that Baptist clergywomen negotiate Baptist tensions of belief and practice can legitimately construct an interpretive model for understanding the institutional religion of Southern Baptists. Three divergent premises or warrants are necessary to make the argument.

First, this study assumes that culture is understood as a human universal and as "a way of life" which both shapes its participants and is shaped by individuals and institutions in that culture.[8] Second, this study assumes that within the culture of Southern Baptists something actually happened over the past three decades which can be observed at various layers of Baptist life. Factual evidence appears in elite writings of trained observers,[9] through official ecclesiastical actions and documents of the SBC, such as the annual meeting minutes, official changes to the denominational leadership and structure, and in media reports of these changes. Anecdotal evidence of those who participated actively and knowingly as stakeholders, but not as officially sanctioned leaders in Baptist life, also concur with other evidence.[10]

Finally, this study assumes that something can be argued *from* the careful observations of people's lives and narratives who live in the culture *toward* an understanding of the larger whole based on the intensity of the phenomena as experienced by the persons in the study.[11] Personal subjective experiences of conflict and accompanying intensive emotions are analogous to the intensity of the public and visceral conflict that played itself out over the years of disruption and resettling of the Southern Baptist landscape.[12] Following these assumptions, the goal of the study is to assemble an interpretive model and elucidate an anatomy of the schism in the SBC using the

narratives of Baptist clergywomen to show both the durability of Baptist belief and practice and the dynamics of the unfolding conflict which fractured the institution.[13]

People in the pew often declared the Baptist controversy of the 1980s and 1990s a "preacher fight," leading to the question: Was the entire thing really an ecclesiastical and elite dispute that mattered little to the masses in the pews and those loosely associated with the denomination? Or was there a popular or populist aspect of the conflict that made it more explicitly part of a movement? The formation of the new organizations (CBF and the Alliance) with large budgets, thousands of adherents and hundreds of churches supports the notion that a popular movement was also afoot. The Alliance and CBF siphoned off many of the academic and ecclesiastical leaders from the SBC of the 1970s and 1980s such that an entirely new class of managers and thinkers took the helm of the new SBC, making the schism finally more expedient.

Although millions of laypeople in Southern Baptist churches may have been little affected by the changes between 1979 and 2000, it does seem clear the schism was not only institutional in terms of elite and ecclesiastical religion, but also popular in its expression. Thus, exploring Baptist clergywomen's narratives opens up aspects of the lived religious experience of the ecclesiastical group in a new way, and reinterprets the SBC schism as a popular Baptist movement.

SETTING THE HISTORICAL CONTEXT OF SOUTHERN BAPTISTS

In his introduction to the *Dictionary of Baptists in America,* Bill Leonard outlines the notion that Baptists can be defined in terms of a set of tensions which are negotiated over time and circumstance. While some American religious denominations can be understood through a range of particular doctrinal commitments or in the light of charismatic founding figures, Baptists, he suggests, are best comprehended in terms of the following tensions: (1) individual liberty of conscience versus the authority of scripture; (2) the autonomy of the local church versus associational cooperation; (3) clergy versus laity; (4) religious liberty versus loyalty to the state; and (5) dramatic conversion versus nurturing process.[14] Each pair works as a constraint on Baptist life and polity. Together they work like (permeable) walls defining the group's life over time (see figure 7.1).

These tensions can be observed as functioning at various sites in Baptist culture, such as sermons, personal narratives, news publications, denominational histories, congregational polity documents, and confessional statements. At the center of all the tensions of conviction and practice is the mediating presence of the particular faith community. In Baptist life this is most

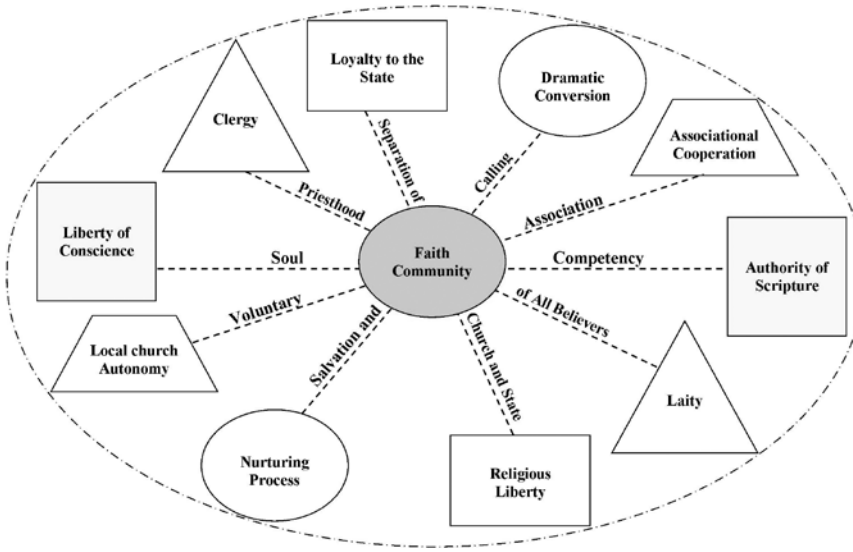


Figure 7.1. Tensions of Conviction in Baptist Life and Polity

often understood to be the local church, but other groupings and institutionalized associations of Baptists also serve as mediators of the inherent tensions of Baptist belief and practice. The SBC itself is one such mediator, responding to pressures of churches, charismatic leaders, cultural claims and trends, other Baptist agencies, and religious groups outside Baptist life.[15]

Each tension can be conceived as a paradoxical set of beliefs and/or practices, and the two extreme poles should be understood as both interpenetrating and dialectical in relationship to each other, as well as present in the central Baptist concept that is negotiated along the continuum of each tension: (1) soul competency, (2) voluntary association, (3) priesthood of all believers, (4) separation of church and state, (5) salvation and calling. One way to summarize the various tensions found in each pair of constraints would be to observe that Baptists have an *overarching conflict concerning the character and location of authority*. They struggle in varying times and places with issues of authority related to paid and volunteer ministry, congregational polity, powers of the state, individual conscience and religious experience, loyalties to differing Baptist institutions, appropriate roles for men and women, and matters concerning the proper interpretation of traditions and texts. Each tension described by Leonard can be viewed as an effort to negotiate the tensions of authority in the major beliefs and practices of Southern Baptist people.

The framework identified by Leonard provides a guide for a brief review of Southern Baptist history leading up to the schism which began in earnest

in 1979. Following World War I Southern Baptists took significant steps to enhance organizational and institutional efficiency during the 1920s including centralizing their decision making and funding mechanisms. Efforts to increase efficiency were renegotiations of *voluntary association,* or the tension between associational cooperation and local church autonomy. Pleas for cooperation, unity, and progress de-emphasized local church autonomy. In the same decade women began voting at annual SBC meetings and the first woman addressed the convention in 1929. White women, as well as black men and women, despite their official and legal enfranchisement to American politics and civil society, continued to live and work among Baptists in the South through secondary and tertiary positions of authority—mainly through separate organizations.

Greater freedom for Southern Baptist women to vote and to work strained the tension between liberty of conscience and authority of scripture, but during this era *soul competency* continued in hidden ways to support both patriarchy and white supremacy and appealed to particular scriptures to maintain the ideologies.[16] The fundamentalist-modernist controversies of the 1920s, which rocked the religious landscape across the United States resulting in denominational splits, impacted the SBC as well. Although Southern Baptists grew numerically and financially, and did not split during the volatile decade, they chose to respond to the demands of fundamentalism and modernism with a spirit of compromise. They maintained their commitment to *soul competency* by adopting the *Baptist Faith and Message* in 1925, insisting it was a confessional statement rather than a binding creed.

The middle decades of the twentieth century started at a low point with the stock market crash of 1929, the Dust Bowl, and the subsequent Great Depression. Southern Baptists, like most denominations, lost ground numerically and financially until the population and economy turned around following World War II. Renewed religious revivals of the 1950s put Baptists in debates over the proper way to *salvation* either by the "Damascus Road" of dramatic conversion or the slower nurturing process of education and persuasion. Communism and the Cold War strained the Baptist commitment to *separation of church and state* with demands for patriotism and state loyalty at the expense of religious liberties. Nevertheless, Baptists were so delighted at the tremendous growth of adherents, budgets, and buildings that such tensions were minimized while growth itself was celebrated.

The 1960s brought renewed threats to authority, not unlike threats of the 1920s, only wielding greater force and straining the careful compromises and alliances that held the SBC together.[17] Controversies over scriptural interpretation, seminary teaching, the ordination of women to ministry, the civil rights movement led by black Baptist Martin Luther King, Jr., and protests of the Vietnam War all contributed to a climate of fear, distrust, and anxiety, which strained every tension identified by Leonard, and laid the

ground for schism in the 1980s and 1990s. Again Southern Baptists turned to their confessional statement in the *Baptist Faith and Message,* revising it in 1963 with hopes of maintaining unity. However, such unity was tenuous in the face of these new encroachments of modernism into the Southern Baptist way of life.[18]

From its start, the ordination of Baptist women was hotly debated; it became a flashpoint of controversy in the 1970s. Underlying the debate was a long-held set of assumptions related to gender and based on proper roles for men and women. Although portrayed universally, in practice *individual liberty of conscience* did not offer women and non-whites the same freedom that the rhetoric implied. White women might have had freedom to decide their fate in matters of faith and conscience, but rarely or never when it came to exercising that freedom to lead with authority, particularly in the church. Women's pursuit of ordination challenged these historical understandings of appropriate roles for men and women. Appeals to scripture were increasingly offered as evidence against the leadership, ordination, and clerical ministry of Baptist women. In 1984 a resolution blaming Eve for the fall of humankind and insisting on the exclusion of women from pastoral ministry was passed by a narrow margin at the annual SBC meeting.[19]

Following closely on the heels of division over the inerrancy of scripture and women's ordination were the issues of prayer in schools, abortion, and the authority of the pastor. From this brief list alone, it is apparent that every tension of Baptist life was strained. Concerns about authority ran like a current through every issue. A public and vociferous conflict raged for a dozen years (1979–1991), during which leadership of every major Southern Baptist institution, board and agency was transferred from Baptist moderates to considerably more conservative leaders. First the progressives, and later the moderates, who lost power in the struggle, set out to start new Baptist groups.[20] Evaporation of support for ordained women and concurrent elevation of male pastoral authority was officially complete by 2000 when additional revisions to the *Baptist Faith and Message* declared "gracious submission" as the ideal role for wives and that the "office of pastor is limited to men."[21]

CLERGYWOMEN NEGOTIATING BAPTIST TENSIONS

In order to explore the claims of the study, narratives of eight clergywomen gathered in personal interviews have been examined for the ways that each woman negotiates the tensions of Baptist life and polity. This particular discreet purpose was not explicitly part of the open-ended interview process. Rather the thesis has emerged out of a back-and-forth movement between the stories told by the women and a study of Baptists in their theological, historical and psychological context.[22] The design of this project

utilized data collection and verification methods common to anthropology and qualitative research. A primary purpose of collecting the clergywomen's stories guided the interviews, supported by the idea that detailed stories of Baptist clergywomen's lives would reveal something significant about the larger Baptist culture.[23]

Evidence for the ways women negotiate the tensions of Baptist life emerges at crucial points when each woman's role and status as a minister is challenged, including, but not limited to: (1) announcing a vocational call to ministry, (2) during her theological education, (3) around her ordination to ministry, and/or (4) in her acceptance or dismissal from a ministry position.[24] Often community opposition and conflict focus on the clergy's (in)adequacy *as women*.

To explore *soul competency* theologically, stories told by thirty-year-old Chloe, a Baptist pastor of a small church in Virginia, provide compelling examples of how the tension is negotiated theologically by individual clergywomen. [25] To understand the psychological dynamics of hostility and alienation, the stories of forty-seven-year-old music minister Beth provide a lens for better understanding. And forty-two-year-old chaplain Anna tells stories that demonstrate how many Baptist clergywomen find a useful cultural space created between poles of tensions in *liberty of conscience* and *authority of scripture,* which allows them to pursue vocation, redefine roles for women, and still remain Baptist. The negotiations of the clergywomen, taken together, help to construct an interpretive model which elucidates the schism of Southern Baptists.

SOUL COMPETENCY: A THEOLOGICAL HALLMARK FOR BAPTISTS

All of the tensions identified by Bill Leonard could be explored for their significance related to the narratives of Baptist clergywomen or Southern Baptist schism; however, *soul competency,* as a recognized hallmark of Baptists, offers a depth of meaning on which to build a model of understanding. Like each pole of each tension identified by Leonard, soul competency can be understood as capturing a set of particular Baptist beliefs, several related practices, and various mundane goods which are important for human well-being. To picture the depth of meaning in the poles of *liberty of conscience* and *authority of scripture*, imagine the diagram of tensions being turned onto a flat plane such that what is under each pole of tension can be seen (see figure 7.2). The anatomy of concepts which comes into view is historically particular for Baptists, theologically descriptive of the human condition, psychologically expressive of dynamics of both creativity and alienation, and evocative for showing how gender is multiply inscribed.

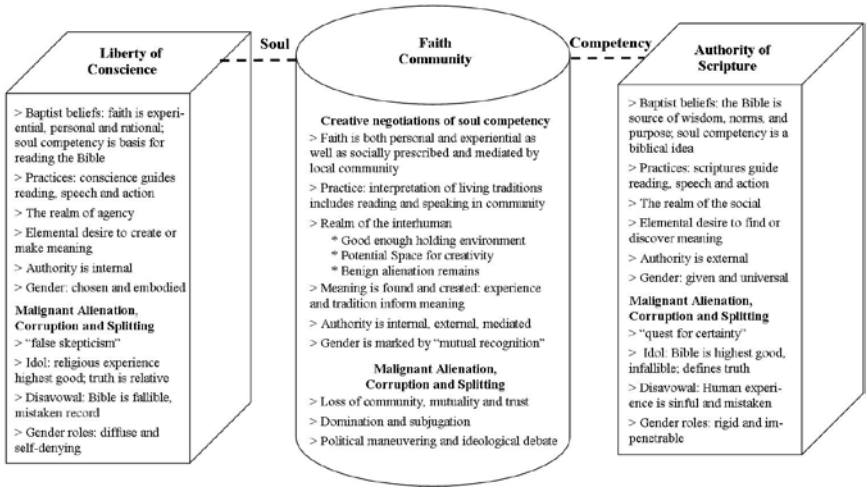


Figure 7.2. Elements of Soul Competency

Chloe made a decision to become a Christian and join her parents' Baptist church at twelve. Soon after her baptism a new pastor was called to the congregation. She remembers her mother, a school teacher, attending a question-and-answer session prior to the church vote. "My mom came home and said that she had asked [the pastor] about women's role in leadership in the church and what he said was very negative and that we were going to look for a new church. And we were out of there so fast that our heads were spinning."

Chloe's much quieter father, an engineer, shared her mother's feelings. When the family ran into some former fellow church members, she recalls, "They asked why we had left. And I remember my dad saying, 'Because we don't want our girls growing up not believing that God can call them to be whatever God calls them to be.' But the funny thing . . . the ironic thing about that story, that I still say, is that my dad was never thinking of my being called to pastor. And neither was I. He was thinking that he didn't want us not being able to be a lawyer or doctor."

Despite the fact that her father's imagination did not include "pastor" among the possibilities for his daughters' vocations, Chloe's parents imagined calling as a matter of individual conscience; while it might be informed by scripture, it should not be limited by only one particular interpretation of scripture. Or put differently, authority of personal religious experience was constrained but not overridden by the authority of scripture. Chloe's story also displays the way that gender was implicated in thinking about vocation, and who exactly is considered competent to lead others in ministry.[26]

Soul competency is one of the most commonly shared doctrinal ideas held by Baptists of all kinds.[27] It grows out of Protestant Reformer Martin Luther's declaration that salvation comes through justification by faith alone.[28] It is called by a variety of names and phrases including "the competency of the soul before God . . . soul liberty . . . experiential religion . . . sanctified individualism."[29] The idea has connections to both Hebrew Bible and New Testament passages, which declare that people are created in the image of God (Genesis 1:26); that they are unique individuals of singular worth (Psalms 8); that they are capable of personal appropriation of divine grace (Ephesians 2:8–9); and responsible to interpret and teach from the scriptures (Matthew 28:19–20; 2 Timothy 2:15). In 1908 Southern Baptist theologian E. Y. Mullins described the "soul's competency in religion" as the "distinctive Baptist contribution to the world's thought" and "a distinguishing mark of the Baptists."[30]

"Soul competency" is common language of Baptist laity and ministers. The idea is both *drawn from* scripture and a *means by which* believers are urged to interpret scripture. Other corollaries that follow from soul competency for Baptists include the primacy of direct access to God; the significance of personal religious experience in the individual's choice to become a baptized believer and church member; and the individual's inalienable freedom from creeds, clerical interference, and government intervention when it comes to matters of conscience and faith.[31]

In addition to these theological beliefs held by Baptists, each pole of tension also expresses several key practices of the Baptist faithful. Although belief and practice are not neatly separable, it is helpful to give example of ways both are present in each pole of tension.[32] Practices that can be related to *soul competency* include reading scripture (personally or devotionally; for guidance in moral decisions; in matters of faith and conscience); speaking of faith (confessionally, prophetically, and from personal conviction); and acting on conviction (in the form of prophetic action, enacting vocation, or attempting to follow biblical mandates).

Chloe's descriptions of her parents, and the space they created for her, give evidence of some of these practices. Their decision to *act* based on their own interpretation of the Bible, and to leave a church because they did not agree with the viewpoint of the new pastoral leader, offer evidence of practices which are part of the tradition of soul competency. Chloe says of her Sunday-school-teaching parents:

> My mother has always been very Baptist, very educated and informed about what that means. . . . And at the time that I was very little she would say things like, "They're trying to take away what it means to be Baptist." And she was very personally affected by the struggle.
>
> Both my parents are very enlightened people. Like very rational. Their faith is very cerebral, very thinking people. . . . In my own journey, I've become

> much more mystical, although I would say . . . they think that I'm sometimes going off the deep end. But (laughs) that's the kind of environment I was brought up in. Like you could think anything out, what you believe is important. "Experience" I'm not sure was as firm as knowledge and knowing and reading and all that. So my mom read a lot and always read the state Baptist paper and *Baptists Today*.[33]

Soul competency took shape in Chloe's family in beliefs and practices such as thinking rationally, reading for understanding, valuing knowledge, solving problems through reasoning, and trusting these practices to be more reliable than "experience." Chloe judges such "experience" by looking back and seeing something more akin to her preferred "mystical" practices, implying more emotion, and less rational mastery of belief.[34] However, both "rational" and "experiential" practices place greater value on "individual liberty of conscience" which is informed by the Bible, but not defined by the Bible alone.

Chloe's choice of words "going off the deep end" to describe her parents' potential alarm at her putting too much emphasis on religious "experience," provides an excellent metaphor of the judgments that are made among Baptists about who is (not) "Baptist enough." Two common stereotypes of Baptists have a way of capturing the shape of this perennial tension. Historically, Baptists have been accused of being too "individualistic" despite their frequent emphasis on (1) soul competency as a matter of the "individual *in community*" and (2) the notion that soul competency is biblical.[35] The stereotype of hyper-individualism hints at how the problem of taking the individual's liberty of conscience too far, failing to accept the constraints of knowledge and wisdom from scripture, can be considered "going off the deep end" and moving beyond the parameters of what it means to be Baptist by engaging in an overly individualistic and privatized religion.[36]

More recently, Baptists have been accused of being too fundamentalist, literalist, or unthinking in their beliefs and practices, despite their emphasis on the role of individual conscience in matters of faith. This stereotype captures the aspect of taking the authority of scripture too far, or of insisting that authority extends only to one particular interpretation of a given passage. This stereotype highlights how someone may be "going off the other deep end" by ignoring or dramatically diminishing the priority of direct religious experience in the name of biblical authority.

"Literal readings," in the name of the *authority of the text*, reduce or eliminate the faith community, the individual, and the presence of God from participation in the process of interpretation. "Pure religious experience" in the name of *individual liberty of conscience* belies the influence of religious communities, traditions and biblical texts on the thinking and behavior of the individual. In each case, emphasizing one pole of the tension to the exclusion of the other, that which "goes off the deep end" in either direc-

tion, takes the form of idolatry that reduces the individual's humility and place within the faith community as well as one's ultimate dependence on God. A similar type of polarization happens in larger cultural and institutional settings as well. Southern Baptist moderates and fundamentalists displayed such reasoning in the "holy war" of the 1980s and 1990s.

Giving him the benefit of the doubt, it seems reasonable to assume that Chloe's new pastor probably held his interpretation of what the Bible had to say about women's leadership in good faith. However, Chloe's parents thought he was extending the authority of scripture too far in the direction of a narrow interpretation of a few passages of scripture. They wanted to maintain the decision-making responsibility of the individual, and they held a high view of the individual's role in the process when it came to decisions about vocation. Both the pastor and Chloe's parents may be understood in this story to be reading, believing, speaking and acting in ways that honor the scriptures (through their respective interpretations) and express freedom of conscience within community. However, they each saw themselves as right and the other as wrong. Such is the nature of conviction and of splitting the world into good and bad. This idea is taken up again below.

Soul Competency as Meaning-Making

Beyond these particular Baptist beliefs and practices, each pole of tension may also be understood to correspond to basic human desires and the mundane goods that support human well-being. Many mundane human goods exist at each pole of the continuum between liberty of conscience and authority of scripture. The primary human good explored here is described by systematic theologian Edward Farley as the "elemental desire for reality," or the human passion for meaning-making.[37]

Chloe describes her own search for meaning as intense and precocious. It was also clearly shaped by a Baptist context which esteems the biblical text. She says,

> I was always somebody who has always been very, very interested in a relationship with God, always been straining to hear God and trying to hear God. What is God saying? What is God thinking? I mean, during the time I was very little, the Bible was huge. I had Bible verses taped all around my bed and [I wondered] what is God saying to me?

Chloe's search for meaning resounds with the human striving for purpose described by Farley. His theological anthropology attempts to develop a phenomenological description of human experience. He identifies three realms of human being: the subjective, the interhuman and the social. Each realm interpenetrates and is also benignly alienated from the others. In other words, they cannot be neatly separated, but neither can they ever be

finally harmonious with each other. The irreconcilability of the realms points out the tragic character and ever-present possibility of chaos in the human situation. Nevertheless, enduring possibilities for beauty, meaning, and creativity are also present in the human condition.[38]

Farley also describes three basic drives or elemental passions: (1) the desire for survival, or elemental passion for subjectivity in each person; (2) the desire for recognition and acceptance by the other, which implies a deep need for the social; and (3) the desire for reality, or the elemental passion to know the meaning of things. None of these desires is ever fully realized or fulfilled, yet each is enduringly present in the human experience. They are interrelated and interdependent. Each passion is personal, and it is connected less to feelings about possessing any one object and more a reflection of feelings about the *striving* after some particular state of being.[39] That sense of striving can be seen in Chloe's self-description about her early search for God's meaning, and in her later drive to find a life purpose.

After college Chloe took a job in broadcast journalism as a television reporter at a small-market TV station in Oklahoma. She recalls the disconnection between her new profession and her sense of purpose. "Vocationally, it was not where I was supposed to be." She recalls covering "house fires and car wrecks" where she was expected to report "objectively" on each disaster. She recalls that it was later when she was she able to name her dilemma:

> I think, for me, a huge issue is that I am relational, when I minister. So I went into journalism with this kind of crusader point of view that I'm going to change the world. And that's great if somebody's house burns down because they didn't have smoke detectors: I can help other people install smoke detectors. But my job was to not get involved with the person that was in front of me . . . I felt like it was very soul stifling to be interacting with people but not truly being in a relationship.
>
> And I just really began to ask, "God, is this really where you want me to be? Is this the best way? . . ." And I had the sense that I did have a gift of being in a relationship with God and knowing that God loved me and that that was something that the world could use. And I wasn't so sure that I was using it in the best way. That was kind of my initial questioning.

The passions that Farley describes create a sense of vulnerability on the part of every person who is always striving toward that which cannot be permanently satisfied. Underlying these elemental passions is an ultimate striving, or fundamental desire for fulfillment. No matter which desires are fulfilled, they continue to point to a desire for the eternal horizon. "The eternal horizon of the passions is not simply a nothingness but is whatever would fulfill the passions. . . . [It is] whatever would ground the self and constitute the mystery of things . . . [it is] that feature of the hu-

man agent apart from which there could be no question of God." Farley makes clear that he is not equating God with the eternal horizon, but connects the ideas this way: "It is only because we are able to passionately desire through our penultimate satisfactions that the very notion of God is meaningful."[40]

Chloe's dissatisfaction with her situation in a career of journalism underscores both the benign alienation created when one's desire for community is unfulfilled, and also the benign alienation within oneself when the passion for meaning is unfilled. Chloe responded to these forms of benign alienation by attending at length to her practices of prayer and reading. She read an article sent to her by her mother which reported a doctor in her hometown serving a deeply impoverished and vulnerable population in the city. He quoted the scripture passage: "To whom much is given much is required" (Luke 12:48). A sense of compassionate obligation (which is implied in this saying) activated and further personalized Chloe's search for meaning, which eventuated in her return to work in her home city and enrollment in seminary to become a minister.

Farley describes two related problems or corruptions of the passion for reality or meaning-making: a "quest for certainty" on one hand and a sense of "false skepticism" on the other. These aspects of the passion for reality correspond to the tensions in *soul competency* in our growing interpretive model. (See figure 7.2.) First about the "quest for certainty" Farley says: "This desire to know engenders the need for and finally commitments and loyalties to institutions, social systems, methods, and categorical and conceptual schemes."[41] This desire to know with certainty can be pictured on the interpretive model as "going off the deep end" at the pole of *authority of the scripture.* Conversely, the elemental passion for knowing is also concerned with survival of the self and includes a kind of vulnerability of the individual ego. This desire to protect one's self corresponds to "going off the deep end" at the pole of *individual liberty of conscience.*

A response to one's anxiety about the uncertainty of knowledge or meaning can cause one's commitment to an institution to slip toward the corrupted (and impossible) quest for certainty. Anxiety about the survival of the self, and the need to be appropriately skeptical about what one can know, tends to slide toward false skepticism. The two forms of corruption are intertwined: a quest for certainty is a sure path to failure, and the despair tied up in such failures leads inescapably to a false skepticism.[42]

Soul competency as an enduring Baptist concept also has features of freedom and creativity which are possible within the space between ego/liberty of conscience and certainty/authority of scripture. The characteristics identified by Farley in this space are "openness and participation," which hold the tensions together in freedom to accept the relativity of meaning and to accept the shared well-being of the self and the other.[43] Traditions (including bibli-

cal texts) inform meaning without rigid predetermination. Individual experience and agency shapes the way one interprets traditions and texts. Chloe expresses something akin to these ideas in response to the question, "What does it mean to you to be a Baptist woman in ministry?" She replies, "I think as a Baptist woman . . . part of my identity, is the freedom of being Baptist." She talks about her Methodist friends who have been "accused, in ordination processes, of having problems with authority." She grants,

> I'm sure I do have problems with authority. So there's a sense of freedom, as a Baptist woman, that's important. I think that, for me, the issue of soul competency and priesthood of the believer . . . have always been important. And, as I continue on my own journey, I'm realizing . . . how very crucial that is. For me . . . a huge part of pastoring is making sure that I'm nurturing my own personal relationship with God and helping [the congregation] to do the same. And, through that relationship, encountering scripture, worshipping and praying together . . . seeking God's presence together. I've tried in my ministry . . . to practice the presence of Christ in community. . . . About half of our church has a Baptist identity and the other half just comes because it's a mixed community and they feel loved when they're there. And I try, periodically, to talk about why *I'm* Baptist—why that's important to me. Why that's important to my identity.

Many academic portrayals of Baptists suggest a rigid and confining cultural space, particularly for women. Yet Chloe and other clergywomen emphasize the freedom of being Baptist where meaning is neither a matter of pure certainty nor an ego trip. Baptist culture for them has been a place where meaning is both found and created, and where soul competency is not without its benign alienations, yet it also holds the promise (or horizon) of meaning and creativity, hallmarks of human freedom and fulfillment.

Soul Competency as a Gendered Construction

The meaning of gender in Southern Baptist culture is among those most stridently contested in recent decades. Historically *soul competency* appeared to express freedom for all Christians, yet for Baptists continues to hide, beneath rhetoric of freedom, interlinked notions of white racial superiority and male normativity. Thus specific and differing gender roles for women and men have been maintained under a banner of soul freedom for all.

Feminist theological understandings and conflicts about gender have been a major source of both debate and production of new insight for the last four decades, roughly paralleling the second wave of the women's movement in the United States and Southern Baptist ordination of women, all of which began in the mid-1960s. Arguments and constructive proposals at academic, ecclesial, and popular levels of culture have taken many directions, from the ideal of androgyny to utopian visions of separate worlds for

male and female, to the complete undermining of the meta-narrative of gender as a dualistic concept.

Chloe and other participants in the study told stories and answered questions about being a woman in ministry. Chloe said it was part of her identity. Beth, whose story is told more fully below, said gender didn't really matter when it came to her ordination. "It wasn't like they were ordaining a woman. It was that they were ordaining *me*. It was not a woman. It was me. So, I could have been a Martian or something." When it came to seminary education, finding a job, ordination, and endorsement, Anna experienced a sense of rejection and belittlement related to her status as a woman in each situation. Her story is offered in the final section of this essay. These three women display a variety of meanings related to being a woman in the context of Baptist ministry from, "it is part of my identity" to "it doesn't matter at all" to "it makes all the difference."

Responding to philosophical challenges of postmodernism, Rebecca Chopp and other feminist theologians have articulated important questions and conflicts related to the meaning of gender. In early academic feminist theology a set of modern liberal assumptions upheld the human subject as structurally coherent and knowable, the powers of reason capable of understanding the subject and the world, and the capacity of language to explain clearly subjects, cultures, history, and language itself.[44]

With these assumptions in hand, feminist theologians worked to elucidate the universal human subject called "woman." Both liberal modernism and feminism were undercut by burgeoning deconstructive philosophies, such as post-structuralism, and by critiques of womanist and mujarista theologians and other women outside the powerful structures of "white feminism." They challenged the idea of a universal "woman." Ironically at a time when women and others outside traditional structures of power began to find voice, the question arose as to the legitimacy of *any* universal human subject.

Southern Baptists, particularly in the years of the controversy, consistent with many popular religious traditions, would not question the category of "woman" as something to be defined as distinct and other than "man." Precisely because of this definition of woman in terms of man, the meaning of women's roles (and by implication men's roles) has been hotly contested. Much of the Baptist contest takes place in the form of rhetoric and events related to women's ordination.

Existing literature about the SBC schism limits the role of women in ministry to one "cause" of the fracture. An articulate expression of the argument is offered by David Stricklin in his 1999 study of progressive, left-wing Southern Baptists, *Genealogy of Dissent*. He asserts that Baptist women who asked for ordination detonated a charge, which became a burning desire by fundamentalists to return the denomination to more conservative roots.

These women, he argues, were extremely devoted to the denomination, while simultaneously most disruptive to its stability:

> Women, the most loyal of progressives among Southern Baptists, became the most vilified, and their efforts actually contributed to the downfall of the moderate consensus more decidedly than those of any other progressive element because they threatened the last major area in which Southern Baptist ultraconservatives thought they still had some control: gender relations. Racism had become such a thing to be avoided that nobody dared express racist sentiments openly. But as fully as public racism came to be shunned in the South, even among the most fundamentalist Christians, restrictive views of women's roles in society became one of the cornerstones of the traditionalist structure that fundamentalists planned to "restore" to Southern Baptist life.[45]

Stricklin's work is mainly concerned with demonstrating the role played by progressives in the fight between moderates and fundamentalists, but his claim about clergywomen's role in igniting the passions of fundamentalists to launch a "takeover" is not as well-supported by evidence from those on the right (who are admittedly not the main objects of his analysis). Nevertheless, his point about the contest over gender has merit. And yet he, like others who write about the controversy, still fails to explore what the women themselves contribute to an understanding of the anatomy of the schism.[46]

One way to frame this theological problem of gender within soul competency is to ask, how is gender, as one category of human experience, both a barrier and an opening for the well-being of women?[47] More conservative and fundamentalist Baptists tend to employ arguments for difference, and sometimes for complementarity: women and men are different (according to biology and scripture) and thus should fill different roles and responsibilities. Their differences complement one another in marriage, but in terms of power women are always in a helping or supportive role. In other words women should occupy separate (and unequal) domains of home, church and society. This view is exemplified in the 2000 *Baptist Faith and Message.*[48]

More moderate and progressive Baptists argue at times for similarity between genders and other times for their difference and complementarity; they tend to use each set of arguments in the service of ending oppression and of fostering liberation and equality for women. They may argue that "there is no male or female in Christ" (Gal. 3:28), thus all people are equal before God and other human beings, and bear the same burdens for leadership.[49] Less often they make a case for the differences between men and women in which women are espoused to possess special gifts and graces needed for the work of ministry that complement and enhance the work of men. In every argument, the problem of gender is persistent and theologically the alienation remains unresolved. At times the alienation turns ma-

lignant, as demonstrated in the last thirty years, growing into irreconcilable differences and seemingly permanent rifts.

The different ways Anna, Beth and Chloe see the significance of being "women" in light of their ordination and ministry point out both the possibility of different interpretations of that meaning, as well as the contested nature of gender and potential for alienation. The alienation between possible ways of making meaning is present. At the pole of liberty of conscience emphasis remains on meanings of gender which are made or created (by persons and communities). At the pole of scriptural authority the emphasis rests on meanings of gender which are found or discovered (in the text). This difference will become important at the point of exploring the psychological dynamic of polarization at work in the situation. Insights from D. W. Winnicott and Jessica Benjamin will bring into focus the way benign alienation can turn into corruption and malignant alienation.

SPLITTING: A PSYCHOLOGICAL FEATURE OF BAPTIST SCHISM

Clergywomen's narratives display not only how they negotiate the theological tensions of Baptist life, but also how the milieu or culture of Baptist life offers a space for clergywomen to experience creative living and meaningful work. Additionally, the stories suggest how that creative space can split the tension into "good and bad" polarities and descend into relations of domination and subjugation.

Beth is forty-seven years old, an ordained Baptist minister, public school music teacher, and divorced mother of two adult daughters. She begins her story this way: "Let me tell you how I got started in the ministry. My dad was a minister of music." Calling, for Beth, grew slowly from her experience as one of the "born-into-the-church kids" present each time the doors were open. Her father was her minister of music much of her life, and he tapped her in seventh grade to fulfill her first ministry role by leading a children's choir. Beth's calling narrative describes a gradual process with each step sounding like part of a normal progression.

Psychologically the tensions which are found at each pole of *soul competency* can be understood as contributing to a "potential space" in which individual members of local Baptist communities of faith can, in the words of pediatrician and psychoanalyst D. W. Winnicott, "play creatively" and negotiate imaginatively the possibilities of life within that space.[50] Put another way, these Baptist tensions collectively make up a "good enough holding environment," which allows for creative negotiation of the tensions into social arrangements which contribute to trust, maturity, creativity, and meaningful work.[51]

In Beth's case the potential space made room for her to play with the ideas she received about calling as a child. Even before her dad recruited her to lead a children's choir, she attended a Woman's Missionary Union camp for girls where she felt called to be a missionary to Uganda.[52] More than half the women in the study tell nearly identical stories about hearing missionaries speak (either at a Baptist camp or in a local church) and experiencing a sense of compelling desire to become a missionary.

Beth attended college, majored in music and married someone also pursuing a career in ministry. Following seminary, Beth returned to Texas where she served as a minister of music at Harvey Memorial Baptist church for thirteen years. After Beth had been on staff at Harvey Memorial for about three years, the pastor led the church in an eight-week study to consider ordination.

The weekly Wednesday night study took place while Beth was busy directing children's choirs, so she could not participate in the discussion. However, members of the congregation asked if Beth was ordained. When the pastor said, "No," the church members wanted to know, "Why not?" More discussion followed and the congregation finally asked, "Well, why don't we ordain her?"

Beth recalls it being just that straightforward. Although ordination for women has been an idea and practice that divided congregations and the denomination as a whole, in Beth's case it was not divisive. Instead it was affirming to her creative capacity to embody the role of minister and for her congregation to acknowledge her calling through a service of ordination.

When asked if she'd thought about it previously or brought it up for discussion with her pastor, her parents, spouse or friends, Beth said,

> Yes, I'd thought about it. . . . But no, I hadn't brought it up, because, well, I didn't know any woman who was ordained. And I wasn't even sure how. Do you bring it up or who brings that up? Do you ask "Will you please ordain me?" You know. So, I didn't—I just said, "Oh, I'm fine." But, they brought it up and continued with discussion on it and that was it. It wasn't like they were ordaining a woman. It was that they were ordaining *me*. It was not a woman. It was me. So, I could have been a Martian or something.

Like many of the congregations who ordained clergywomen in this study, Harvey Memorial provided a potential space in which Beth could creatively exercise her gifts, mature in her self-understanding as a minister, and receive public affirmation through ordination, despite the previous absence of any ordained women in the congregation. Her family, steeped in Baptist tradition, also provided a potential space into which Beth could create something new by improvising on a common theme of ministry in her family. Not only her father, but also her brother and grandfather and great-grandfather were all Baptist ministers. She was simply the first *female* minister in the family.

So how does the potential space in a family, a church, or other caring environment stop providing room for creativity, maturity and trust? One potential path is that of psychological defense which splits the holding environment into oppositional tensions which are idealized as "all good" or devalued as "all bad" and which demand a choice. Initially splitting is a natural defense and protection for an infant, but it can become pathogenic. Psychological defenses grow out of an infant's way of perceiving the world, which at first does not differentiate clearly between self and outer world. The infant thus thinks s/he is omnipotently in control of all that happens. Eventually when the world and self begin to differentiate in the experience and cognition of the infant/child a natural splitting takes place, in which self and other are no longer merged. Such differentiation is necessarily an "either/or" and "this/not that" type of processing which easily gives rise to the psychic defense of splitting.[53]

Initially infants are incapable of object constancy, thus unable to see that the same parent who appeared while s/he was feeling frustrated and hungry was the one who also appeared when s/he was feeling content and full. Instead a good parent and a bad parent exist as separate unrelated objects in the preverbal mind of the infant. In good enough settings of care the "good parent" and "bad parent" will be merged into one more complex and "real parent" as an object of multiple feelings and source of multiple experiences to the child.[54]

As a defensive process, splitting is an effort to ward off danger, discomfort, unpleasant affects and physical or psychic pain. All human beings experience forms of splitting as a part of their development. In a less benign situation the child may split the caregiver into good and bad objects and as the self/ego develops may also perceive all internal self-states and external objects as either "all good" or "all bad."[55] This initial stage of defensive process may continue to predominate as a way of coping, or in milder situations it may become a preferred defense during times of crisis or trauma.

The defense may continue to be used as a measure to ward off danger, discomfort and pain, particularly if the child's world is traumatic, unpredictable, and chaotic. The defensive process of splitting can take additional steps of projecting internal affective and cognitive states, which are unpleasant or dangerous, out onto the external world. In this kind of projection the internal "goodness" or "badness" is seen only in the other, and is not recognizable in the self.

Primary defensive processes may be observed not only in infants, but also in transference which emerges in therapy situations, in everyday human interactions, and in larger social-cultural phenomena. Social situations of splitting may be analyzed in a way analogous to the individual's experience. Psychoanalytic therapist Nancy McWilliams observes:

> Political scientists can attest to how attractive it is for any unhappy group to develop a sense of a clearly evil enemy, against which the good insiders must struggle. Manichean visions of good versus evil, God versus the devil, democracy versus communism, cowboys versus Indians, the lone whistle-blower against the hateful bureaucracy and so on have pervaded the mythology of our culture. Comparably split images can be found in the folklore and organizing beliefs of any society.[56]

The dynamic of splitting can also be observed in the cultural conflicts of Southern Baptists, especially in relation to the tensions of belief and practice already introduced. For example the Bible might be seen as infallible and inerrant ("all good") while personal religious experience is considered fallible and suspect ("all bad"), or the splitting could take an opposite form which sees the Bible as oppressive, totally lacking authority, and full of errors ("all bad") and personal spiritual or religious experience as the only reliable source for truth or meaning ("all good"). Yet neither of these options fosters creativity or trust. Rather each escalates an environment of hostility, scarcity, and danger, setting the stage for conflict.

Before turning to the social splitting among Southern Baptists at the institutional level, it is instructive to see where Beth negatively experienced splitting. A clear and internalized sense of calling and affirmation from her ordination provided Beth with an important source of strength with which to endure her congregation's splitting later in her career. After a dozen years at Harvey Memorial a new pastor came. Beth was still in the role of minister of music, and she along with other church staff and secretaries were dismissed quietly over several months. They were let go with instructions to discuss none of the particulars at the risk of losing their severance pay. The congregation was not informed, and Beth was in shock when a lay leader came to her with the news, "We had a meeting and we decided we don't need you anymore. We're going to go in a different direction, and you're not invited to come."[57]

This sort of dismissal after changes in leadership in Baptist churches is common. In Beth's case it was accepted, not without frustration, but without protest. The idealization of a new guard (new pastor), and devaluation of the old guard (staff who served with the previous pastor) happens frequently and often covertly in congregations. Other splits over leadership are common as well.[58]

After serving five years as a minister of music in the smaller Locust Baptist Church, Beth found herself in a divorce initiated by her husband. She felt that she had to resign. Reflecting on her reasons, she said, "It's not because they don't love me. But they had lots of talks and discussions and group meetings. But, they had a hard time with a divorced person being in leadership. So, that was hard for all of us. It was like my second divorce."

By implication the "hard time" with divorced persons came from an idealization of a certain interpretation of scripture and a devaluation of the five

years of experiencing Beth as their leader. This split was obviously painful for Beth, although she defends the church's actions to a degree. It is not clear what direct or conscious role Beth's gender played in losing either ministry position, if any. However, assumptions about gender run just beneath the surface and influence decisions like hers in ways worth exploring.

Psychologists have theorized about gender in a variety of ways over the past century. In a Victorian age Sigmund Freud saw male sexuality and anatomy as normative and summed up female sexuality as a wish to be male (penis envy) which was eventually replaced by a wish for a baby.[59] In the mid-twentieth century Winnicott theorized about pure "male" and "female" elements, features of human personality that he assigned to male or female. Males, he argued, gravitate toward doing (active and impulsive). Females gravitate toward being (passivity and sameness). This dualistic thinking reproduces modern notions of difference and complementarity between males and females. He further reifies the dualism by separating the "female" and "male" in time, perpetuating a hierarchical view of gender. Infants initially pass through a passive female stage then progress through the more mature male stage.[60]

Feminist psychologists in the late twentieth century arrived at questions similar to those raised by feminist theologians with regard to gender. The tension between individual subjectivity and social construction of persons remains unresolved and pushes to the forefront questions about how gender is constructed and reified by forces biological, interpersonal, and social. Psychoanalytic theorist Jessica Benjamin, in *The Bonds of Love,* adds to the interpretive model we are building. She argues that "assertion" and "recognition" are two tensions which exist in human relationships, and which at their best are resolved in the paradox of shared mutuality.[61] In the Baptist ideal of *soul competency,* assertion maps onto the individual's liberty of conscience and recognition onto the authority of the text. Benjamin argues that the polarity of these ideas is difficult to sustain, and "sets the stage for domination" and subjugation.[62] She says,

> A condition of our own independent existence is recognizing the other. True independence means sustaining the essential tension of these contradictory impulses; that is for both asserting the self and recognizing the other. Domination is the consequence of refusing this condition.[63]

She goes on to argue that in the Western model of parenting, in which many middle-class mothers in the twentieth century raised their children as the primary caregivers, boys have the task of breaking their first bond of mutual recognition with their mothers. Girls have the different task of separating from their mothers in order to discover their own identity. Often boys are not able to complete the breaking task, because the bond is so strong, and they are left to objectify their mothers and by turn all women. Girls conversely are

left with a denial of self. Together these dynamics lay an internal psychological foundation for domination and subjugation. Significantly these dynamics can also be observed at work in the wider cultural ethos.[64]

Beth maintained that her gender did not play a role in the church's decision to hire or ordain her. She was less sure about how being a woman might have played into the endings of her two church ministry jobs. But her submission to the decisions of the church with little or no protest, and the invocation of biblical authority to back up the decisions, display a lack of "mutual recognition" on the part of Beth and her church community. They also suggest an internalized acceptance of the domination of the Bible, the church, and its decisions about her leadership.

Nevertheless, in the face of these conflicts Beth held on to her vocational purpose and self-understanding even when two different churches were no longer able to see her as valuable or needed, preventing her from practicing ministry in their communities. Their views no doubt were influenced by particular interpretations of the New Testament which allowed authority to the text and diminished the authority of their experience of her as their minister. Yet, Beth still sees herself as a minister and her work with music students in a public school as ministry. At the time of the interview she was not willing to risk seeking a traditional church ministry position; however, neither her sense of calling nor her self-understanding as a minister had been diminished by the congregation's schism over her role.

In a similar fashion, Baptists who no longer felt welcome by the SBC or its agencies were not diminished in their sense of being Baptist or of having a mission to fulfill. They simply started over where they found themselves and created new expressions of Baptist culture, starting as movements and growing into social institutions.

REMAINING BAPTIST THROUGH ALIENATION AND SCHISM

When Anna arrived at one of the SBC seminaries in the early 1980s, officials insisted she undergo a special interview before beginning the program. Single women and married women, if their husbands would also be students, were exempt. However, married women whose husbands would *not* be attending seminary had to endure one additional interview. (Neither male seminarians nor their wives were subjected to any similar interviews.) The main question was not to Anna, but to her husband Mark: "Do you understand that your wife is preparing for ministry, and do you support her?"[65]

Anna's pre-entrance interview for seminary sounded a wake-up call for her. She recalls, "Only when I got down there [did I] really begin to realize that there was a problem . . . a huge divide . . . and I really didn't care; *I just*

wanted to minister. So I thought, 'I'll do the best I can. There [will be] someplace I can minister.'"

That initial interview and a job interview two years later functioned like sexist bookends to Anna's formal theological education. Nearing graduation and searching for a ministry position, Anna remembers that her male peers were getting three and four times more interviews than she was. She described a time when she felt mocked and degraded by one interviewer:

> A guy from Georgia was interviewing me. And he said, "You're married?! You want to do ministry and you're married?!"
>
> I said "Yeah."
>
> And he said "What do you think you can do married?"
>
> "Anything I can do single." I didn't understand what [he was talking] about . . . I think he got the name, and started interviewing and assumed that I was single. And then when he saw I was married he became very degrading.
>
> "Well, God can't use you."
>
> And I said, "Well chances are you aren't going to hire me, so maybe we should just end this interview." And I walked out.

At first Anna was bewildered by this man's remarks, before realizing that he was looking for a single woman and assuming that a married woman had obligations to her home and family, which prevented her from doing ministry. These were the same gendered assumptions of the pre-entrance interview. If the entrance interview had been a wake-up call, two years later Anna was wide awake and ready to act. She chose not to endure the man's insults but rather to walk away.

Anna could have kept walking—away from Baptists altogether.[66] However, she chose to remain and believe herself *competent* to hear and respond to a call to ministry. Although seminary officials perceived her as inept for ministry, because as a woman she was to be under the authority of her husband, Anna resisted their challenges and doubts about her competency and chose to pursue her education and search for ministry placement. With persistence she found a youth ministry position, and in effect redefined the tacit gender inequities assumed in *soul competency* by acting as a full and equal participant, creating a way to remain Baptist and to sustain her vocation.

Other places where the politics of gender and negotiation of Baptist tensions are evident in Anna's story come at the points of her ordination and endorsement as a chaplain. Despite continuous full-time ministry in several churches following seminary, it was more than twelve years after publicly declaring a call to ministry that Anna received ordination.[67] Although she hoped not to create conflict, Anna felt that God was "putting on her heart" a desire to be ordained. She remembers earlier in her ministry when she had preached at Grove Baptist Church, a member of the congregation said, "Oh! You did a great job! But it's just a shame they will never ordain you."

She knew the man well, and so replied to him, "You know what? You don't have to. God already has!" She laughingly teased him about not putting his hands on her anyway. Later he came back and said, "You know what? You got the best ordination." Anna concluded, "I guess that's always the way that I looked at it—about ordination itself. I really felt like God had called and ordained me."

Several years later Grove became the church that ordained Anna at the request of Calvary, the church she was serving at that time.[68] She contacted all the young women who had been in her youth groups and served as interns and invited them to the service. At her ordination Anna said she felt confirmed that "there is always hope. The denomination was certainly digressing, and the affirmation is limited, yet there is hope to do ministry."

After more than a decade of student ministry, Anna decided to change directions and pursue her calling in the hospital setting. When she sought endorsement for her work as a chaplain Anna recalls:

> It saddened me that now I had to turn—not that CBF is bad at all—but that I can't ask for the denomination [SBC] that grew me up and told me "Wherever He Leads I'll Go" was a great hymn, except if you're a woman, and now they won't endorse me. . . . But as a woman in ministry, I just hoped, and have hope, and I will continue to hope, that I would just get to do ministry, because that's where my heart is. And I have to be a woman, and I have to bring that to the table. Just as other people feel they have certain . . . gifts and perspectives . . . that has always been my thing.[69]

Anna's story vividly reveals several negotiations of the tensions of *soul competency*. These brief excerpts and the longer narrative told by Anna reveal her faith to be both experiential, often recounting personal conversations with God and modes of discernment and reflection that express her dependence on the divine. Simultaneously she holds a deep reverence for the Bible, interweaving its stories, norms, symbols and imagery into her own life's story. Despite the larger context of conflict in the SBC, local communities of Baptists were available and present to Anna throughout her life and especially during the time from college when she first named her sense of vocation until the time of the interview. These communities supported her call, employed her, and eventually ordained her to ministry, and the CBF endorsed her for chaplaincy.

Although feelings of betrayal, anger, and disappointment toward the SBC run like a current through Anna's years of ministry, so does a refrain of hoping that she would "just get to do ministry." Various Baptist communities provided potential space for creativity, trust, and maturity to develop in Anna's identity as a minister. In retelling the story of her ordination, Anna displays how meaning was both created and found in relation to her vocation and purpose. She believed God had already ordained and blessed her

in the best possible way, which in effect created the meaning of her pastoral identity and helped her to claim her own internal authority to speak and act as a minister. When she found courage to ask for ordination she found a renewed sense of hope despite the anticipation of conflict that might result and the continued alienation she felt from her denomination. The authority conferred by the two congregations emboldened her later to take up the role of hospital chaplain. In terms of gender, Anna's narrative exposes again hidden inequities in traditional Baptist understandings of soul competency. In effect her persistence in the face of humiliations and rejections demonstrated her courage to remain Baptist, pursue her calling, and assert her ministry role as one appropriate for women.[70]

SOUTHERN BAPTISTS: SCHISM AND RENEWAL

In roughly the same years in which Anna and Beth were engaged in professional ministry, and Chloe was discovering her call to the pastorate, the SBC was in a major transition which included sustained conflict and political maneuvering for control of the largest Protestant denomination in the United States. Beginning in 1979 the SBC and its affiliated boards, schools and agencies changed from the hands of moderate and progressive leaders to conservative and fundamentalist ones.[71] A significant aspect of the dramatic change was the loss of women's leadership and status at the institutional level. Key actions included an SBC resolution against women's ordination (1984); a refusal by the Home Mission Board to provide financial support to new church starts in congregations pastored by women (1986); a failure to appoint Greg and Katrina Pennington as foreign missionaries because Katrina was ordained (1989); loss of faculty positions at Southern Baptist Theological Seminary, where theology professor Molly Marshall was forced to resign under pressure of unspecified heresy charges (1994) and Dean of the Carver School of Church Social Work Diana Garland was fired (1995); revisions to the *Baptist Faith and Message* calling for gracious submission of wives to their husbands and the limitation of the role of pastor to men (2000); and closure on the practice of endorsing women as chaplains by the North American Mission Board if they are ordained (2002).[72] This is not an exhaustive list, but it highlights the polarization present in relation to women's roles and leadership during the conflict.

Before offering analysis of the idolatry and corruption at work in the SBC, a brief survey of Farley's depiction of social evil is needed. The social realm, which interpenetrates with the realm of agency and the interhuman, is tragically structured by elemental passions which inherently conflict. This tragic structure does not indicate evil in itself, but often is the opening for corruption and evil in the form of idolatry to enter into a social system.

Corruption becomes possible in a situation when, in response to the contingencies of life, some particular good is absolutized. This absolutization is a form of idolatry in which the eternal horizon is not open, but rather the object of need—an idea or anything temporal—is embraced in an effort to escape vulnerability and finitude.[73] Farley observes:

> Thus, the perennial candidates for things that remove our vulnerability and provide a securing foundation are religions, sciences, nations, social movements, comprehensive interpretive schemes, methods that enable criticism of or interpret the world, value-preserving institutions, and even revolutions to procure freedom and justice. This insisting on and finding a substitute for vulnerability is not just a repetition of the passionate striving through mundane goods toward their horizon. It transforms that striving into attempts to make these goods at hand fulfill these passions and end the tone [of] discontent.[74]

In the social realm corruption takes the form of self-absolutizing or idolizing of the institution itself or of its aims. If the self-perpetuation of the institution or the pursuit of secondary rather than primary aims becomes central, then tragic and inevitable competition between social groups turns into domination and subjugation, and the sacred horizon is diminished. A social institution will take on a life of its own, by virtue of the primacy of its purposes. It also draws in the loyalties of individuals and smaller groups who need the mundane goods it offers. Such competition with other institutions, together with member loyalty, generates fear of scarcity and victimizes potential enemies. The depth of oppression becomes apparent by observing the effects of subjugation on individuals and relations in the social setting. Such corruption spreads like an infection, says Farley, and then the work of collusion keeps the corrupted system in place.[75]

Southern Baptists have been negotiating the tensions identified by Bill Leonard from their start in ways both creative and corrupted. The poles of tension in *soul competency* represent not only theological tensions in Baptist belief and practice, but also mundane goods of human life including freedom and agency for the individual and meaningful traditions in the social realm. Conservative leaders in the SBC embraced the religious and comprehensive interpretive scheme of belief found in the ideal of biblical inerrancy. They allowed it to corrupt their rhetoric, purpose, and organizing social structures in ways that devalued or disavowed anything outside their own understanding. Moderates on the other side were hoping for the security of a revolution which would ensure freedom and justice for "true Baptists." Both groups embraced goods at hand in an effort to secure themselves against the tragic nature and chaotic structure of the human condition. The mundane goods of life and the eternal horizon are confused in each case because the former are expected to act permanently as the latter. Each side "split" the two poles of *soul competency* into "all good" and "all

bad" and blamed the other side for not "believing" rightly. The accumulation of dualistic thinking eventuated in a schism of the denomination, and the emergence of several additional Baptist groups.[76]

The poles of tension have also functioned to hide and perpetuate dualistic thinking about gender which limits various leadership roles to men and not women. Domination and subjugation curtail any possibility of "mutual recognition." Ironically, even paradoxically, these same tensions, along with others observed by Leonard, work together to create a potential space where adherents can experience creativity, maturity, and trust; find and create meaning; negotiate authority; and locate a sense of belonging in the community by fulfilling various roles within it. When, however, the larger institutions of this system, such as the SBC itself, emphasize their own survival and self-perpetuation, the slide to corruption and schism becomes inevitable.

In the past three decades this struggle for control of the SBC took on the features of social evil, not only in the form of competition, subjugation, and collusion, but also in the splitting and projective identification, when each faction took extreme positions and blamed the other for the conflict. Women called to ministry who desired ordination became symbols of this exchange as they were made into villains or martyred in the battle. The splitting by each faction in the struggle (moderate/progressive and conservative/fundamentalist) served to bring an actual parting of ways by Baptists. One of the many ironies of the schism is that all groups that emerged when the dust settled continue to claim themselves authentically Baptist. And by Leonard's account of the tensions that Baptists have historically negotiated, they are all likely correct.

Possibly the greatest genius at the heart of Baptist culture is the enduring emphasis on local congregations of believers as the central and most important social unit. Local congregations are more likely to remain communities which honor the relational realm, offer one another mutual recognition, hold the tensions together in ways that make creativity, meaning, maturity, and trust possible despite the corruption and alienation of the larger institutions with whom they affiliate. It is within these smaller communities that clergywomen have survived and thrived for more than forty years.[77]

Confrontations experienced by clergywomen are analogous to the divisions that Baptists have faced over the last thirty years, and theological and psychological strategies observable in the clergywomen's stories provide a window into the conflicts that eventuated in the fracturing of the SBC. Rather than being merely one of several causes of schism in the SBC, as argued in existing literature, the stories of clergywomen illustrate instead an anatomy of the divide which can be conceived as an inevitable expression of social corruption and evil. However, their stories also illustrate the resilience and reliability of the perennial tensions of Baptist belief and practice to express the ongoing tensions of the human experience and to make po-

tential space for individual creativity and vocational sustainability. Their stories also illustrate the possibility that Baptist communities can continue to reinvent themselves even when they appear to be torn asunder.

NOTES

1. Addie Davis, "A Dream to Cherish," *Folio* 3, no. 2 (Autumn 1985): 1. The seminary where Davis graduated was Southeastern Baptist Theological Seminary in Wake Forest, North Carolina.

2. Leon McBeth, *Women in Baptist Life* (Nashville, Tenn.: Broadman Press, 1974), 153. Davis was not able to find a Southern Baptist congregation to serve, thus she pastored American Baptist churches until 1982 when she returned to her hometown in Virginia and served as a pastor of an ecumenical church. Pamela R. Durso and Keith E. Durso, "Cherish the Dream God Has Given You," in *Courage and Hope: The Stories of Ten Baptist Women Ministers*, eds. Pamela R. Durso and Keith E. Durso (Macon, Ga.: Mercer University Press, 2005), 18–30.

3. See Frank Mead, Samuel Hill, and Craig Atwood, *Handbook of Denominations in the United States*, 12th ed. (Nashville, Tenn.: Abingdon Press, 2005), 213–15; Eileen W. Linder, ed., *Yearbook of American & Canadian Churches 2005* (New York: National Council of Churches of Christ in the United States of America, 2005), 11.

4. Founded in 1987, the Alliance estimated in 2003 a membership of 62,000 in 122 churches, and a combined missions and operating budget of $336,000.00, according to the Alliance newsletter *Connections* 6, no. 11 (November 2003). The Cooperative Baptist Fellowship was founded in 1991 and estimated in 2004 a membership of 210,000 in 1,200 churches and an annual budget exceeding $17 million. See Mead, Hill, and Atwood, *Handbook of Denominations*, 186–87, 195–96, for overviews of both groups.

5. By 1997, sociologist, Sarah Frances Anders had documented more than 1,225 ordinations. Estimates say more than 1,600 women in America have been ordained by Southern Baptists and churches related to the Alliance and CBF since 1964. Anders, "Historical Record-Keeping Essential for WIM," *Folio: A Newsletter for Baptist Women in Ministry* 15, no. 2 (1997): 6; Jim Morris, "Southern Baptists Vote against Women Pastors," CNN.com, June 14, 2000, www.cnn.com/2000/US/06/14/southern.baptists.02 (accessed May 30, 2006).

6. The most comprehensive academic studies of the schism appeared in the following order: Ellen M. Rosenberg, *The Southern Baptists: A Subculture in Transition* (Knoxville: University of Tennessee Press, 1989); Bill Leonard, *God's Last and Only Hope: The Fragmentation of the Southern Baptist Convention* (Grand Rapids, Mich.: Eerdmans, 1990); Nancy Tatom Ammerman, *Baptist Battles: Social Change and Religious Conflict in the Southern Baptist Convention* (New Brunswick, N.J.: Rutgers University Press, 1990); Nancy Tatom Ammerman, ed., *Southern Baptists Observed: Multiple Perspectives on a Changing Denomination* (Knoxville: University of Tennessee Press, 1993); Arthur Emery Farnsley II, *Southern Baptist Politics: Authority and Power in the Restructuring of an American Denomination* (University Park: Pennsylvania State University Press, 1994); David Stricklin, *A Genealogy of Dissent: Southern Baptist Pro-*

test in the Twentieth Century (Lexington: University of Kentucky Press, 1999); Barry Hankins, *Uneasy in Babylon: Southern Baptist Conservatives and American Culture* (Tuscaloosa: University of Alabama Press, 2002).

Partisan accounts of the schism from conservative and fundamentalist perspective include: James C. Hefley, *The Truth in Crisis: The Controversy in the Southern Baptist Convention* (Dallas: Criterion Publications, 1986); James C. Hefley, *The Conservative Resurgence in the Southern Baptist Convention* (Hannibal, Mo.: Hannibal Books, 1991). Hefley also published four other volumes between these first and last books in his series. From the more moderate perspective come the following: Walter B. Shurden, ed., *The Struggle for the Soul of the SBC: Moderate Responses to the Fundamentalist Movement* (Macon, Ga.: Mercer University Press, 1993); Rob James and Gary Leazer, eds., *The Takeover in the Southern Baptist Convention: A Brief History* (Decatur, Ga.: Baptists Today, 1994). Walter B. Shurden and Randy Shepley, *Going for the Jugular: A Documentary History of the SBC Holy War* (Macon, Ga.: Mercer University Press, 1996).

Several attempts to chronicle the events with less editorializing and/or little analysis include: Joe Edward Barnhart, *The Southern Baptist Holy War* (Austin: Texas Monthly Press, 1986); David T. Morgan, *The New Crusades, the New Holy Land: Conflict in the Southern Baptist Convention, 1969–1991* (Tuscaloosa: University of Alabama Press, 1996); and Jesse C. Fletcher, *The Southern Baptist Convention: A Sesquicentennial History* (Nashville, Tenn.: Broadman and Holman Publishers, 1994).

7. David Hall, ed., *Lived Religion in America: Toward a History of Practice* (Princeton, N.J.: Princeton University Press, 1997). Hall describes a constructive project of reorienting the common (academic) understanding of what constitutes "religion." Although I find this an admirable project, I am more concerned to elucidate with added depth and complexity those phenomena which are already widely accepted as "religious" in American culture. My work is grounded in both the study of American religious history and the academic tradition of practical theology, which uses resources in theology and the social sciences to interpret beliefs, actions, rhetoric, and practices of individuals and groups.

8. These understandings of culture are expanded in Kathryn Tanner, *Theories of Culture: A New Agenda for Theology* (Minneapolis, Minn.: Fortress Press, 1997), 25–29.

9. See note 4 above for examples of academic studies of the conflict.

10. Unless otherwise noted, references to "Baptist(s)" in this essay will refer to participants in the Southern Baptist Convention (SBC) and its affiliated agencies.

11. In a quantitative or scientific paradigm, claims of objectivity, validity, reproducibility, and generalizability are the marks of good research. However, in a qualitative project, credibility, dependability, and transferability are more adequate goals for gauging trustworthiness of the research. These goals are measured in the way qualitative research methods are conducted, including peer review, triangulation, member checks, and various data audits. See Y. S. Lincoln and E. G. Guba, *Naturalistic Inquiry* (Beverly Hills, Calif.: Sage, 1985); David A. Erlandson, Edward L. Harris, Barbara L. Skipper, and Steve D. Allen, *Doing Naturalistic Inquiry: A Guide to Methods* (Newberry Park, Calif.: Sage, 1993). Such restraint in qualitative studies is necessary because neither human experience nor cultures are reducible to formulas, nor do they give way to predictive maps or models. See Volney Gay, "Mapping Religion Psychologically: Information Theory as a Corrective to Modernism," in *Religion and*

Psychology: Mapping the Terrain, eds. Diane Jonte-Pace and William B. Parsons (London: Routledge, 2001), 94–109.

12. I am not primarily arguing about the ways that women reacted to the schism in the denomination (some are too young even to remember it), but rather I'm exploring the ways they negotiate the same tensions that are present in the larger institution. Charles Darwin identified six basic affects common to all humans, and his findings have been supported by psychologists and cultural anthropologists. Volney Gay argues that while a discreet set of affects can be identified and that they share a "curve of intensity that builds up slowly then rises faster and faster, is satiated, and subsides," they cannot be reduced to formulas but are better understood metaphorically "through analogue devices like those available in poetic metaphor or dramatic action." See Gay, *Joy & the Objects of Psychoanalysis: Literature, Belief, and Neurosis* (New York: SUNY, 2001), 131, 142.

13. Unless otherwise noted, references to "Baptist(s)" in this essay refer to participants in the Southern Baptist Convention (SBC) and its affiliated agencies. I am not hoping to construct a (strong) model that is predictive, because each cultural situation is unique and thus findings are not generalizable or predictive at this level of human organization. The more modest goal is to assemble a (weak) explanatory model, which offers a clearer understanding of the conflict. For example, the descriptor "schism" is a metaphor which offers a vivid description of events of the past thirty years in Southern Baptist Convention institutions; however, it does not offer a model to explain what happened. The model offered in this study does not attempt to predict what might happen next or suggest what should happen. See Volney P. Gay, "GDR 3054: Syllabus on Methods," (n.d., 5–12).

14. Bill J. Leonard, *Dictionary of Baptists in America* (Downer's Grove, Ill.: Intervarsity Press, 1994), 4–6. In a more recent text Leonard identifies three additional tensions: doctrinal statements: invariably confessional, selectively creedal; ordinances: sacraments and symbols; diversity: theological and ecclesial. Bill J. Leonard, *Baptist Ways: A History* (Valley Forge, Pa.: Judson Press, 2003), 6–10.

15. Kathryn Tanner points out that consensus concerning beliefs and practices in any cultural setting is rare if not impossible. One beauty of Leonard's observations is that concerns for power, authority, and conflict are assumed. Of course other ideas, meanings, and social movements are also at work outside the range of this analysis, including economic and political factors. See Tanner, *Theories of Culture: A New Agenda for Theology* (Minneapolis, Minn.: Fortress Press, 1997), 45–47.

16. Extended examples of the rhetoric against women's leadership can be found in J. W. Porter, ed., *Feminism: Woman and Her Work* (Louisville, Ky.: Baptist Book Concern, 1923).

17. Bill J. Leonard argues that four major forces kept unity among Southern Baptists while simultaneously maintaining a "Grand Compromise": Southern cultural identity, which arose following the Civil War; a broadly based doctrinal unity, which was upheld by centrist political leaders of the agencies and institutions; uniform programming, which week to week and around the year kept Baptists focused on the same concerns of missions, evangelism, and Bible study; and finally a commonly held piety, based in experience, scripture, and a Baptist understanding of faith. See Leonard, *God's Last and Only Hope: The Fragmentation of the Southern Baptist Convention* (Grand Rapids, Mich.: Eerdmans, 1990), 58.

18. Nancy T. Ammerman, *Bible Believers: Fundamentalists in the Modern World* (New Brunswick, N.J.: Rutgers University Press, 1987), 8. Ammerman notes, "Only where traditional orthodoxy must defend itself against modernity does Fundamentalism truly emerge." Although fundamentalism had a lesser impact on the SBC in the 1920s, during the 1960s the threats of modernism were much more powerful and immediate, and fundamentalism became a potent response (21–22).

19. James and Leazer, *The Takeover in the Southern Baptist Convention*, 31–34.

20. Some Baptist leaders characterized as "moderates" were denominational employees, who refused to participate in the arguments and political maneuvering. This left the moderates who were church leaders feeling betrayed. Some of those moderate denominational employees stayed on in their position even after fundamentalists took over the policy-making boards. Other moderates left the SBC to become leaders in new Baptist organizations. See Cecil Sherman, "An Overview of the Moderate Movement," ed. Walter B. Shurden, *The Struggle for the Soul of the SBC: Moderate Responses to the Fundamentalist Movement* (Macon, Ga.: Mercer University Press, 1993), 39–40.

21. "Baptist Faith and Message" (Nashville, Tenn.: Southern Baptist Convention, 2000), www.sbc.net/bfm/bfm2000.asp (accessed May 30, 2006). Although SBC resolutions are non-binding for local Baptist churches, the public perception and views of paid and elected leaders are encapsulated in those resolutions and contribute to further changes to shared cultural beliefs and practices.

22. For discussion of emergent research process, see Erlandson et al., *Doing Naturalistic Inquiry*, 50, 68–69, 73–78.

23. This study does not depend solely on historical texts, previously collected data, or the observations of others. Instead the primary sources are the narratives and experiences of clergywomen conceived as "living human documents" and the social networks and shared experiences of Baptists in "living human webs." See Charles V. Gerkin, *The Living Human Document: Revisioning Pastoral Counseling in a Hermeneutical Mode* (Nashville, Tenn.: Abingdon Press, 1984); Bonnie J. Miller-McLemore, "Living Human Web," in *Through the Eyes of Women: Insights for Pastoral Care*, ed. Jeanne Stevenson Moessner (Minneapolis, Minn.: Fortress Press, 1996).

24. The notion of practical theology as an "interpretation of situations" has been articulated by Edward Farley, *Practicing Gospel: Unconventional Thoughts on the Church's Ministry* (Louisville, Ky.: Westminster John Knox Press, 2003).

25. All names and identifying features of the clergywoman's story have been changed to protect her identity and privacy.

26. Chloe's story about leaving her childhood church could be explored in terms of the tension between clergy and laity (priesthood of all believers) or the tension between dramatic conversion and nurturing process (salvation and calling), but in this essay the discussion will be limited to the tension between individual liberty of conscience and authority of scripture (soul competency).

27. In *Handbook of Denominations in the United States*, Mead, Hill, and Atwood note "soul competency" as first in their description of Baptist doctrine and polity: "Baptists are bound together by an amazingly strong 'rope of sand' in allegiance to certain principles and doctrines based generally on the competency of each individual in matters of faith," 181. The idea was articulated at length by Baptist theologian E. Y. Mullins a century ago in *The Axioms of Religion: A New Interpretation of*

the Baptist Faith (Philadelphia: Judson Press, 1908). See especially chapter 4, "The Soul's Competency in Religion."

28. The idea of soul competency has roots in Martin Luther's reformation ideals: sola fide (faith alone), sola scriptura (scripture alone), and sola gratia (grace alone). Leonard, *Baptist Ways*, 18.

29. Walter B. Shurden, *The Baptist Identity: Four Fragile Freedoms* (Macon, Ga.: Smyth & Helwys Publishing, 1993), 23. Shurden also includes: "individual competency . . . personal faith . . . spiritual religion . . . believer priesthood . . . conversion by conviction . . . individualism in religion."

30. Mullins, *The Axioms of Religion*, 59.

31. Shurden, *The Baptist Identity*, 23–31.

32. Kathryn Tanner, "Theological Reflection and Christian Practices," in *Practicing Theology: Beliefs and Practices in Christian Life*, eds. Miroslav Volf and Dorothy C. Bass (Grand Rapids, Mich.: Eerdmans, 2002), 228–42. Tanner points out that belief and practice cannot be neatly separated, nor can it be assumed that a group appearing to engage in a coordinated practice necessarily shares a set of beliefs upholding that practice. Investigations into such practices (e.g., communion) reveal a tremendous variety of religious beliefs and other reasons given by practitioners for their participation.

33. *Baptists Today*, a newspaper sponsored by moderate Baptists, was begun during the days of the SBC controversy.

34. This observation is also based on other descriptions by Chloe of her changing devotional practices and growing interest in more "mystical" aspects of faith. For her the shift came in the form of practices such as meditation and contemplative prayer. Although she differentiates affective, embodied practices from more rationalistic ones, both kinds of practices put more emphasis on the role of the individual than the role of scriptural text.

35. Shurden, *The Baptist Identity*, 23–24, 34.

36. Shurden, *The Baptist Identity*, 26.

37. Edward Farley, *Good and Evil: Interpreting a Human Condition* (Minneapolis, Minn.: Fortress Press, 1991), 106. Farley describes "mundane goods" as the "things that already function to satisfy our needs and desires" (133). These goods, however, do not finally fulfill human striving or relieve the "tragic vulnerability" of the human condition (134).

38. Farley, *Good and Evil*, 164–70.

39. Farley, *Good and Evil*, 97–113.

40. Farley, *Good and Evil*, 112–13.

41. Farley, *Good and Evil*, 196, 197–205.

42. Farley, *Good and Evil*, 202–3.

43. Farley, *Good and Evil*, 206. This intersubjective well-being of self and other corresponds nicely to Jessica Benjamin's notion of mutuality which lies between assertion and recognition. See Benjamin, *The Bonds of Love: Psychoanalysis, Feminism and the Problem of Domination* (New York: Pantheon Books, 1988), 15, 22.

44. Rebecca S. Chopp, "Theorizing Feminist Theology" in *Horizons in Feminist Theology: Identity, Tradition and Norms*, eds. Rebecca S. Chopp and Sheila Greeve Davaney (Minneapolis, Minn.: Fortress Press, 1997), 215–31.

45. Stricklin, *A Genealogy of Dissent*, 140–41.

46. The perception that women's ordination as an idea and practice is one of the causes of the schism is a commonly argued point in literature about the SBC controversy. However, none of the writers, including Stricklin, show much interest in exploring what the women's experiences contribute to a greater understanding of what happened and why. Stricklin depends heavily on Libby Bellinger's historiography of the organization, Southern Baptist Women in Ministry, and the personal stories of one other woman in ministry, Martha Gilmore, for his evidence of the role women played in the conflict. See Bellinger, "More Hidden than Revealed: The History of Southern Baptist Women in Ministry," in *The Struggle for the Soul of the SBC: Moderate Responses to the Fundamentalist Movement*, ed. Walter B. Shurden (Macon, Ga.: Mercer University Press, 1993), 129–50.

47. Chopp poses an important questions related to understanding subjectivity and gender: "How does the subject in gender or the gendered subject both deconstruct the universalizing of gender and work for change for women?" Chopp, "Theorizing Feminist Theology," 219.

48. *Baptist Faith and Message*, 2000.

49. This argument erodes the historical assumptions about gender that are held within the idea of soul competency, which have worked to keep gender inequity in place.

50. D. W. Winnicott, *Playing and Reality* (New York: Routledge, 1971). Creation of potential space, or playground, between a mother figure and baby is important to the development of a child's capacity for trust and maturity. Briefly, the developmental steps which take place prior to the "playground" becoming available include a time of merger between caregiver and child. The initial phase is followed by a time in which the mother is "repudiated, re-accepted, and perceived objectively" (47), which in effect is the separation or splitting which is necessary for a baby to see him- or herself as separate from the caregiver or care-giving environment. In this stage the mother figure "is in a 'to and fro' between being that which the baby has a capacity to find and (alternatively) being herself waiting to be found." This is the mother or caregiver acting in such a way as to make a "good enough holding environment" for the child's feelings and self-perceptions, such that the infant may develop trust and begin to play creatively.

51. Winnicott, *Playing and Reality*, 71, 81, 89.

52. GA, Girls in Action, formerly Girl's Auxiliary, is a missions-education program of Woman's Missionary Union, SBC. Summer camps, sponsored by state WMU organizations, for elementary-aged girls, often employed a "missionary in residence" to tell stories and inspire missionary service among the children. Beth's experience of feeling compelled to become a missionary is extraordinarily commonplace among Southern Baptist children, especially girls. Five of eight clergywomen in the study told similar stories.

53. Glen O. Gabbard, *Psychodynamic Psychiatry in Clinical Practice*, 3rd ed. (Washington, D.C.: American Psychiatric Press, 2000); Otto F. Kernberg, Michael A. Selzer, Harold W. Koenigsberg, Arthur C. Carr, Ann H. Appelbaum, *Psychodynamic Psychotherapy of Borderline Patients* (New York: Basic Books, 1989); Nancy McWilliams, *Psychoanalytic Diagnosis: Understanding Personality Structure in the Clinical Process* (New York: Guilford Press, 1994).

54. Jay R. Greenberg and Stephen A. Mitchell, *Object Relations in Psychoanalytic*

Theory (Cambridge, Mass.: Harvard University Press, 1983), 332. See also Winnicott, *Playing and Reality*, 111–12.

55. McWilliams, *Psychoanalytic Diagnosis*, 112–13.

56. McWilliams, *Psychoanalytic Diagnosis*, 113.

57. This was not Beth's attempt at a direct quote of the leader, but her rendering of the message she received.

58. For five of eight clergywomen, conflict among staff at churches or religious agencies was a major feature of their stories. For more about the impact of conflict in pastoral ministry, see Dean R. Hoge and Jacqueline E. Wenger, *Pastors In Transition: Why Clergy Leave Local Church Ministry* (Grand Rapids, Mich.: Eerdmans, 2005).

59. Sigmund Freud, "Some Psychical Consequences of the Anatomical Distinction between the Sexes," in *The Standard Edition of the Complete Psychological Works of Sigmund Freud* (London: Hogarth Press, 1925a), 19: 233–39.

60. Compared with Freud, Winnicott does make a theoretical improvement by adding the idea of male envy. See Winnicott, *Playing and Reality*, 76–85.

61. Benjamin, *The Bonds of Love*, 15, 22

62. Benjamin, *The Bonds of Love*, 50, 51ff.

63. Benjamin, *The Bonds of Love*, 53.

64. Benjamin, *The Bonds of Love*, 76–84.

65. Anna recalls that the seminary official who performed the interview also thought it "stupid" and didn't draw out the line of questioning but changed the subject. Nevertheless, he was required to hold the interview and ask the question.

66. Many women, upon experiencing similar and multiple confrontations, have chosen to walk away from Baptist life and pursue vocational ministry in other denominations or to change vocational directions altogether. Many outsiders hear stories like these and fail to comprehend why anyone would remain within the Baptist milieu. This study focuses on the situations of those who have chosen to remain, but other investigations about those who have departed would enrich an understanding of the dynamics.

67. Anna has served five churches since taking her first job as a youth minister in college.

68. No universal process exists for Baptist ordination. However, for males the process typically follows a somewhat identifiable pattern: (1) licensure so the candidate could begin practicing ministry; (2) ordination by a local church to confer blessing for ministry including (a) convening a council or presbytery including ministers from neighboring churches; (b) examining the candidate for authenticity of call and doctrinal soundness; (c) taking a vote in the council and/or the local church; (d) holding a ceremony (usually on the same day as the examination) to bless the candidate and lay on hands. See G. Thomas Halbrooks, "The Meaning and Significance of Ordination Among Southern Baptists, 1845–1945," *Baptist History and Heritage* 23, no. 3 (July 1988): 24–32. For women the process has tended to follow the latter sequence, but it has often taken years longer or precluded ordination.

69. B. B. McKinney, "Wherever He Leads I'll Go," *Baptist Hymnal* (Nashville, Tenn.: Convention Press, 1975), 361. The endorsing agency stopped endorsing female chaplains following the passage of changes to the *Baptist Faith and Message* (2000). The change to policy was reported in the *Baptist Standard*, "SBC to Cease

Endorsing Ordained Female Chaplains" (February 18, 2002), www.baptiststandard.com/2002/2_18/print/endorsing.html (accessed May 31, 2006).

70. All eight clergywomen in the study have faced similar life-defining challenges and creatively strategized ways to redefine key Baptist concepts within their own experiences.

71. The organizing efforts of those on the social, political, and religious right in the SBC were meticulous and used the appointive powers of the SBC president to insure that every board and agency elected only those (mostly men) in step with the program of steering the convention in a more conservative direction. Moderate resistance to the changing of the guard was impossible because they have won a single presidential election after 1979. This change is well documented in several studies including James and Leazer, *The Takeover in the Southern Baptist Convention*; Ammerman, *Southern Baptists Observed*; and Farnsley, *Southern Baptist Politics*.

72. See James and Leazer, *The Takeover in the Southern Baptist Convention*, 31–37. The decision to stop Penningtons' appointment was a case of the elected board of trustees overriding the employed staff of the Foreign Mission Board. See Ammerman, *Baptist Battles*, 230–33. President Albert Mohler's involvement in the dismissal of Marshall and Garland is recounted in Barry Hankins, *Uneasy in Babylon*, 82–88. See revisions concerning roles for women and men in *Baptist Faith and Message* (2000). For changes to the endorsement policy, see the *Baptist Standard*, "SBC to Cease Endorsing Ordained Female Chaplains."

73. See Farley, *Good and Evil*, chapter 6.

74. See Farley, *Good and Evil*, 133.

75. See Farley, *Good and Evil*, chapter 14.

76. In addition to CBF and AB, the two nationally oriented groups, several state conventions (i.e., Texas, Virginia, and Missouri) also split into moderate and conservative groups in similar struggles in the decade which followed the SBC schism.

77. Small communities are not necessarily valorized here. They also feature corruption and splitting, but the possibilities for positive negotiation of the tensions seem more likely.

8

"Spiritual But Not Religious": How Small Groups in America Redefine Religion

Jean Heriot

The American religious landscape appears to have changed significantly in the past few decades, though historians are quick to note that visions of past multitudes of church-going Americans is just that—a vision, not reality.[1] One facet of this perceived change in American religion is that many contemporary Americans are likely to term themselves "spiritual but not religious." As a cultural anthropologist, I have found this phenomenon intriguing because, from my disciplinary perspective, "spiritual" and "religious" are but different facets of the same cross-cultural phenomenon that anthropologists are most likely to term religion. This paper explores what the phrase "spiritual but not religious" may mean in contemporary American society, discusses the phenomenon in cross-cultural context, provides ethnographic examples of five spiritually oriented small groups, and comments on the implications of these forms of religious practices for pastoral care. I argue that these spiritually based small groups provide contexts in which practitioners can explore *religious* meaning, healing, leadership, and voice their critiques of organized religious traditions. Ironically, many persons who belong to these spiritually based small groups also belong to other, more institutional religious groups. Studying such groups is an exercise in understanding overlapping belief systems and reveals a situation in which pastoral care is most likely to be offered by fellow practitioners.

"SPIRITUAL BUT NOT RELIGIOUS"

Like many terms, "spiritual but not religious" connotes different meanings to different groups. Sandra Schneiders, a Catholic nun and scholar, suggests

that there are three possible meanings of the relationship between spirituality and religion. In one framework, the two are "separate enterprises with no necessary connection."[2] In another framework, the two are "conflicting realities, related in inverse proportion."[3] That is, religion and spirituality are competing for the same populations, and the more religious one is the less spiritual, or the more spiritual the less religious. In the third framework, the two are "dimensions of a single enterprise which, like body and spirit, are often in tension but are essential to each other."[4] Schneiders advocates the third position and stresses the historical link to spirituality as a Christian concept. However, she is also quick to note that the term has lost its Christian connotation in contemporary American society. As a result, scholars have come to define spirituality in quite general terms. Peter Van Ness defines it as "the quest for attaining an optimal relationship between what one truly is and everything that is."[5] Though Schneiders explores the term thoroughly in many of her writings, this statement from her work captures much of what the term spiritual means: "spirituality . . . has become a generic term for the actualization in life of the human capacity for self-transcendence, regardless of whether that experience is religious or not."[6]

Much of the dispute about the difference between religion and spirituality apparently hinges on whether or not the belief systems are formally institutionalized. What scholars steeped in Western traditions readily forget is that the cross-cultural literature provides many examples of belief systems that are informally organized. In fact, some band- and tribal-level societies were so loosely organized that researchers found it difficult to separate religious beliefs (as defined by Westerners) from the whole of society. Today, some contemporary Native American groups reclaim this perspective on religion and may state that they have spiritual beliefs but not religious traditions.[7] Because of this fluidity, some anthropologists have chosen to define religion functionally. In accommodating to ethnographic realities, their definitions of religion were often so diffuse that it could be difficult to distinguish the religious from other features of society.[8] One of the most famous of these definitions is that of Clifford Geertz who defined religion as: "(1) a system of symbols which acts to (2) establish powerful, pervasive, and long-lasting moods and motivations in men by (3) formulating conceptions of a general order of existence and (4) clothing these conceptions with such an aura of factuality that (5) the moods and motivations seem uniquely realistic."[9] This functional definition implies that religion and spirituality serve the same human need—the necessity to formulate ultimate meaning—and that religion and spirituality are not dependent on specific forms of institutionalization.

In sum, this social science perspective claims that religion and spirituality are, to use Schneiders' words, "dimensions of a single enterprise." Clearly, many people in America do not agree. A recent article in Newsweek titled,

"In Search of the Spiritual," cites facts and figures indicating that more Americans, "especially those younger than 60, described themselves as 'spiritual' (79 percent) than 'religious' (64 percent)."[10] Of course, these figures also show substantial overlap in persons who must have described themselves as both.[11] The article further notes that church attendance has not gone up, while at the same time, there has been a significant explosion of alternative religious beliefs.

A cross-cultural comparison of religious traditions in America, Sweden, and Japan by Stark, Hamberg, and Miller found that what Americans term spirituality might be better understood as "unchurched religion."[12] For them, "unchurched religion typically lacks a congregational life, usually existing as relatively free-floating culture based on loose networks of like-minded individuals who, if they do gather regularly, do not acknowledge a specific religious creed, although they may share a common religious outlook." Churched religion, as one might expect, does have a congregation and a creed. Stark, Hamberg, and Miller further subdivide the unchurched into several subcategories including folk religions, client religions, and creedless religious groups. However, *all* of these are religions.[13]

In my view, spiritual and religious describe two related enterprises that are part of the larger realm of religion cross-culturally. However, following Stark, Hamberg, and Miller, practitioners who advocate "spiritual but not religious" beliefs and who do not belong to creedal/formal organizations fall into the realm of "unchurched" religion while groups that have creeds and congregations are considered "churched" religions. Persons in contemporary American society may well participate in churched and unchurched religion at the same time, in churched religion only, or in unchurched religion only. In this framework, religion and spirituality are both part of a broader definition of religion, and both religion and spirituality can be part of churched or unchurched religion. Though the framework is complex, it more accurately represents the cross-cultural reality of religious traditions.[14]

While scholars debate the meaning of these terms, practitioners of both churched and unchurched religion are living their lives and trying to make sense of them as best they can. My ethnographic work indicates that the amount of overlap between these types of religion is enormous. For the individual, it means that the sources of meaning systems are numerous, that the possibility exists to pick and choose among many different offerings, and that fluidity is the norm for a person seeking religious meaning outside a formal structure.

Some scholars have tried to categorize the specifics of this diversity. Before discussing my ethnographic methodology and describing the five spiritually based small groups, let me put this work in context. When I began my study, the term "New Age" had just gone out of vogue. It was being replaced by practitioners seeking diverse religious beliefs and practices with the term

"spirituality." Scholars have not, however, given up on the original term and use "New Age" to describe a grassroots social movement with loose organization and much fluidity. Some scholars have attempted to trace the many groups and their belief systems.[15] Some scholars look for the overarching patterns.[16] Pike, for example, stresses the movement's origins in the 1960s and 1970s, and its use of the themes of feminism, the environmental movement, changes in gender roles, and the pan-Indian movement.[17] She also notes that practitioners want to change the world and themselves and use a host of various practices. They typically look to a future where self and society will be transformed into a more harmonious whole.

Overlapping, but often considered distinct from the New Age movement, is the Neopagan movement, also a child of the 1960s and 1970s. Beliefs of this movement have much in common with the New Age movement. Differences stem from what Neopagan practitioners believe is a revival of ancient ritual customs and from their more orderly and systematic approach to ritual.[18] Early on in the movement, researchers separated women-only ritual groups and labeled them practitioners of feminist spirituality.[19] Groups of men and women practitioners were seen as Neopagans.[20] Newer research tends to put the two groups together under the one umbrella of Neopaganism and to separate within that category women-only groups from groups of both genders.[21]

Following these distinctions, groups one through four described below would be considered part of the "New Age" movement and group five would be considered Neopagan. Though most scholars consider these groups religions, occasionally a scholar will try to find some middle ground and will term the groups "quasi religions," meaning that they have some features of religion and some features of non-religious traditions.[22]

Tying this discussion of the New Age and Neopaganism to the spiritual but religious debate brings us back to the typology developed by Stark, Hamberg, and Miller.[23] That is, New Age and Neopagan groups are part of the much broader cross-cultural category they term "unchurched" religion. Many New Age groups, and some Neopagan groups, are client religions, that is, an adherent goes to a particular place, such as an ashram or retreat center, for instruction or an adherent buys materials/studies about a particular tradition from a group that does not require on-going regular meetings. Similarly, many Neopagan groups are creedless religious groups, meeting together in small groups to create and share rituals. Sometimes both of these groups make claims to be direct descendants of past "folk" religions (especially Neopaganism) but no historian has been able to "prove" that they are.

Basically, then, the "spiritual but not religious" phrase is a common one in contemporary American society that expresses the multiple forms of "religious" practices and systems available in contemporary society. As we examine how people practice their lived religion, how they make meaning

and interact with each other, we will see that the diversity, fluidity, and availability of multiple "spiritual" markets ("unchurched" religion) has come to provide a viable alternative to congregationally based religious life ("churched" religion). Then I briefly examine the ways in which these alternative viewpoints changed my view of pastoral care.

ETHNOGRAPHIC METHODOLOGY AND SETTING

In 1992 and 1993, I spent a year observing five small spiritually based groups in upstate New York. I had received funding for the research from the Society for the Scientific Study of Religion and was also teaching part-time. As a result, I was able to devote most of my time to ethnographic research. My base of operations was a Unitarian Universalist Church in a small city that I will call Rolling Hills.[24] Rolling Hills was far enough north that the snow came early in November and lasted to May. The mountains were nearby, but the countryside consisted of rolling hills and river valleys. At the time, Rolling Hills had a population of nearly 100,000.

The ethnographic study also encompassed another perspective. I had become a Unitarian Universalist several years before. I was not ordained at this time, but church members were beginning to turn to me for leadership and to suggest that I might seek ordination. Since there was some overlap in membership of the UU church and membership in the small groups, this created a situation in which I was seen differently depending on the context. At the time of this study, I was primarily involved in researching the groups. In a later section, I comment reflexively on this participatory role.

Rolling Hills Unitarian Universalist Church (RHUUC) could be characterized as a small New England Unitarian Universalist (UU) church of about a hundred members. The congregation was liberal, the minister was an avid environmentalist, and the theologies were plural. That is, there were Christian UUs, Hindu UUs, Buddhist UUs, as well as atheists and agnostics. While UUs are generally open to other religious traditions, they originally grew out of the Unitarian and Universalist Christian churches of the 1800s that merged in 1961.[25] Hence, ritual in these congregations seems Protestant in nature, but without requiring the worship of a triune God. Some scholars place the UU movement within the alternative religions movements of the Americas.[26] Others see the UU movement as close to churched religions, save that it does not have a creed.[27] In this particular congregation, some folks considered themselves spiritual, others did not. Hotly debated at the time was the question of whether an atheist could also be spiritual. In one respect this congregation was atypical of many UU churches in that many of its members had lower incomes than the high middle class UU norm.

As in many communities, the eclecticism of Unitarian Universalists meant that the church building was used by many non-traditional groups. Of the five small groups I studied, four met at the UU church. The fifth, which met in members' homes, had about 50 percent UU membership. Though groups met at the UU church, this fact did not mean that the people who led the groups, or the people who came, were necessarily UU. Rather, in all but one of these small groups (as in many such groups in American society), membership was extremely fluid. Usually there was a "core" in each group who came either all the time or a significant portion of the time. In addition there were the one or two time attendees who came to check out the group but who did not make a commitment to belong. I was one of the core attendees in all five groups, writing field notes on meetings upon my return home.

Small groups, such as the ones I studied, are now a recognized part of the American religious landscape. Wuthnow initiated a large scale sociological study of small groups in the early 1990s. He argued that small groups have become one of the major forms of community in contemporary American society, especially since World War II.[28] Sometimes these groups, as in the case of the ones I studied, have overt spiritual and religious components, and sometimes they do not. In addition, some of these small groups are a part of the organizational outreach of "churched religion." According to a national survey, Wuthnow reports that 40 percent of the American adult population "claims to be involved in 'a small group that meets regularly and provides caring and support for those who participate in it.'"[29] Thus small groups such as the ones studied here are among the ways people experience community in America.

I also interviewed a significant portion of the core membership of each group, but I selected only women. Women made up most of the leadership and most of the core attendees in each group (the highest percentage of men at any meeting was 35 percent). Two groups had only women participate as noted below. I interviewed twenty-six women, tape recording and transcribing twenty-four interviews (two women declined to be tape recorded). The women ranged in age from twenty-two to eighty-two. Eighty-five percent of those interviewed had attended at least once one of the five small groups, and I had observed them in attendance. The remaining 15 percent were referred to me by members of the small groups.[30] In terms of their religious backgrounds, 42 percent were raised Catholic; 38 percent were raised Protestant; 8 percent were raised Jewish; 8 percent were raised with no religious background; and 4 percent were raised within the legacy of the nineteenth-century utopian Oneida Community. Most were from middle-class families of origin if not currently of that income level. Ninety-six percent were white; 4 percent were Hispanic. The group as whole was highly educated: 38 percent had master's degrees or

higher while the remaining 62 percent had either attended college or graduated from college with bachelor's degrees.

In the following paragraphs, I sketch briefly the five groups: Witness Consciousness Meditation; Yoga; A Course in Miracles; the "Intellectuals" (my name for this informal group); and Women's Spirituality. Of these five, the only group I selected for continued study was Women's Spirituality. I went on to study other groups similar to the Rolling Hills women's group for the next ten years. However, I will limit my analysis here to the ethnographic present of 1992–1993.

FIVE SMALL SPIRITUAL GROUPS

The *Witness Consciousness Group* met at RHUUC and was formally sponsored by the church. The primary teacher, Wendy, had been raised as a UU, but currently went as often as she could to the Kripalu Yoga Fellowship ashram in Lennox, Massachusetts, then under the direction of Yogi Amrit Desai.[31] She took yoga and meditation classes in this particular form of Hindu religion that focused on kundalini yoga and brought back what she had learned to the church group. She typically had members meditate to the sound of a tape that had the voices of monks chanting "ohm." Unlike many meditation teachers, Wendy did not care about one's posture during the gathering, which usually lasted from an hour and a half to two hours once a week. Wendy would intersperse talk during the meditation, asking participants to review their day from morning to evening, and to relax to the point that they could "wipe all expression" off their faces. Wendy also followed about a half hour of meditation with a time of sharing experiences, followed by another shorter meditation. As a leader, Wendy was less dependable after she became pregnant and then a new mother. At other times, another member of the church, Keith, would lead or the minister would lead.

Group size varied widely from as few as five to as many as twelve. We usually had 25 to 33 percent men, the rest women. To the researcher, the sharing time after each meditation was extremely fruitful. Members would talk about such things as physical sensations of tiredness, wanting to go to sleep (indeed, once the meditation leader went to sleep himself during the meditation), and how to get comfortable. But practitioners also talked about how to let go of anger, how to forego judging others, how to control fear, feelings of renewal and relaxation, and occasionally various spiritual/religious experiences that happened during the meditation or that had happened in the past.

A second group was a *Yoga* class taught primarily by two women (with Keith filling in on occasion). The principal leader of this group, Rachel, was also

loosely affiliated with a Hindu ashram, this time that of the Shree Muktananda Ashram located in South Fallsburg, New York,[32] headed by the guru Gurumayi Chidvilasananda.[33] Gurumayi belongs to the Siddha Yoga tradition, which "teaches students to live in the awareness of the inner Self so that they can transform themselves as well as the world in which they live."[34] The kind of yoga that Rachel taught was Hatha Yoga.[35] The other woman leader, Jackie, was not affiliated with any particular ashram, but was eclectic in drawing on many different tradition/s including her experiences of various types of yoga.

Unless a student was already familiar with Hatha Yoga, there would be no way to tell that this class drew from this tradition, in contrast with the *Witness Consciousness Meditation* class. The primary teacher did not reference Gurumayi, nor did she advocate that members go to the ashram in South Fallsburg. I did go, however, with the leader to the ashram and to chanting sessions in members' homes. Since this tradition stressed chanting, it appeared that going to the ashram and forming local chanting groups was more important to these practitioners than was the yoga itself. The class size varied greatly from session to session, ranging from five to fourteen with the average being about ten. Most of the time in the class was spent in learning the various yoga poses and holding those for the requisite time frame. There was little discussion of practice or of the experiences people had while practicing. Because of this, it was much harder to understand people's motivations for coming to the class and the benefits they received from it without conducting interviews.

A Course in Miracles (ACIM), the third small group, was the only group led by a male, Gus, who had immigrated to the United States from Spain with his family. Gus was an advocate of ACIM, and he was also a member of the UU church. The class size varied from six to ten participants for each of eleven sessions offered once a week. Gus used the three-volume curriculum published by ACIM which includes a *Text, Workbook for Students,* and a *Manual for Teachers*.[36] He also used audiotapes produced by the writer and spiritual leader, Marianne Williamson, who is one of the biggest promoters of ACIM.[37] Class participants were often given copies of particular sessions from the workbook, though some students had previously purchased and studied the workbook. However, no one was required to buy the book or systematically work through the course. In this case, the books and tapes were the avenue of learning—there was no nearby ACIM religious community. ACIM's teachings are disseminated through the sale of the books and through the meeting of small study groups, such as this one.[38]

ACIM is a curious blending of Christianity with Eastern religious traditions as well as modern psychology. Helen Schucman claimed to have written the work as she received "inner dictation she identified as coming from Jesus."[39] It was first published in 1975. Its website claims that ACIM is "a self-study spiritual thought system that teaches that the way to universal

love and peace—or remembering God—is by undoing guilt through forgiveness."[40] Though the ties to Christianity are present, its belief system is not traditional Christianity. In this system, the world itself is seen as an illusion as are all the problems one encounters in this life. A person who practices faithfully will come to see that only love is real—everything else is illusion.[41] As we will see, this claim was contested over and over again by most persons who came to the class.

The fourth group, a group I have termed "*The Intellectuals*," is more difficult to classify than any of the others. It was also the most stable of all the groups, having the same five persons (and the researcher) come to meetings throughout the study period. Its organization was also different—it was not affiliated with the UU Rolling Hills Church (though half its members belonged to that congregation). Rather, this group of women had met in the past for a long period of time, stopped meeting, and then resumed meeting in 1992. I gathered that they had begun meeting when their children were young and most members now had children in their twenties. One of their children and I constituted the "new members" of the group. Membership was by invitation only and there was no advertisement.

In their beginnings, the group studied the work of Georgei Ivanovitch Gudzhiev, later known as Gurdjieff.[42] While they did not actively study Gurdjieff's work while I was in the group, they frequently reviewed his major teachings in the form of a list of important points. During the year I was with them, the group focused most of its energies on understanding the book *New World, New Mind* by Robert E. Ornstein and Paul Ehrlich.[43] This book stressed that the human mind had evolved to deal with short-term solutions to problems and that the context in which we now find ourselves requires a change in thinking. We, as a species, need to learn to evaluate the consequences of our actions and plan for long-term solutions to such problems as environmental degradation and population growth. Two of the members worked in secondary schools and wrestled with ways to influence fellow teachers and students to think for the long haul. Toward the end of the year, members turned to the Sufi teaching stories of Idries Shah.[44] Teaching stories were also thought to influence behavior and to help with solutions to individual and societal problems. This group appeared to have two foci: (1) they wanted to influence/change the society around them as they were deeply concerned with the sustainability of human societies and felt that unless there was radical change we, as a species, would not last; and (2) they wanted to achieve some form of spiritual enlightenment for themselves, though they did not always agree on what enlightenment might look like.

According to the group, all three of the sources discussed tied into Sufi thought.[45] Their primary information, like the ACIM group, came from published literature. They read books, and they discussed the ideas in the books. It is this tendency, and their ongoing disputes about the value of meditation,

that has lead me to term them "The Intellectuals." Though aware of the "Abode of the Message" retreat center, a Sufi community and conference center in Upstate New York, group members did not actively attend or promote attendance.[46] In addition, they never spoke of attending Gurdjieff centers (note that one of their main centers is also in New York State).[47]

The one center to which half the group had strong ties was officially no longer in existence—the Oneida Community, founded as an intentional religious community in 1848 by John Humphrey Noise and disbanded in 1881.[48] One member, Maisie, then in her eighties, lived in the "Mansion House" which was built by the Oneida Community and became a museum and apartment home in 1987.[49] Her grandparents (who had belonged to the community) moved to a house in Oneida, New York, when the Oneida Community was disbanded. They, her parents, and later Maisie remained near the Mansion House so Maisie was influenced by the legacy of the Oneida Community all her life. The mother of another group member, Dorothy, also lived in the Mansion House and was a direct descendant of the founder, John Humphrey Noise. Since Dorothy's daughter, Wendy (leader of the Witness Consciousness Group as well), was also in the group, and since Maisie and Dorothy's mother were contemporaries, the group had three generations of Oneida connections. As I will explore further, one aspect of this connection seemed to be a willingness to explore new ideas and to read extensively on religious beliefs and traditions from around the world.

The fifth, and final group to be considered here, was a *Women's Spirituality group*.[50] This was the largest of the groups, having as many as twelve women attending on occasion. Formed by Jane, a woman in the UU Church, the group initially met bimonthly to discuss theology using as their text, *Weaving the Visions,* a collection of feminist thought edited by Judith Plaskow and Carol P. Christ.[51] Some members who came were familiar with feminist rituals or with books that had actual ritual guidelines such as Starhawk's *The Spiral Dance, Casting the Circle* by Stein, or *A Woman's Book of Rituals and Celebrations* by Ardinger.[52] Members began to use women's rituals patterned after those in these books for opening and closing the weekly gatherings. Some members (perhaps half of the group) were very drawn to the rituals and sought out other places to experience rituals such as a "Croning" workshop (for older women) held at the local community college and summer solstice rituals held by local women's groups. Other members were more interested in theology and spent a great deal of time discussing the differences between men and women with respect to ritual and to religious belief systems. Finally, some women drifted away from the group because they were not interested in either the theology (some said the articles were too academic) or the rituals.[53]

After finishing *Weaving the Visions,* the group read another feminist text together, *The Chalice and the Blade,* by Eisler and used the workbook, *The*

Partnership Way by Eisler and Loye, for discussions.[54] These books proposed that the history of humanity had once had a significant component of goddess worship and that it was only in the past 5,000 years or so that religion had come to be dominated by men. The argument was that if women and men could recover the worship practices of the past when society was thought to be egalitarian in its treatment of men and women, then a new social order could come into being where patriarchy was vanquished. This controversial alternative history sparked lively discussion and helped group members uncover patriarchal patterns influencing their own lives.[55]

MAKING SENSE OF DIVERSITY

Anyone reading the above group descriptions can clearly see that these groups represent a wide variety of religious practices and religious traditions. What I have presented is, however, only the tip of the iceberg. In interviews with twenty-six women, most of whom had attended at least one of the observed sessions in these five groups,[56] I found even more diversity. One aspect of the contemporary American religious scene is that there has been an explosion of religious information. Even though America has been a meeting ground of peoples from around the world from the 1500s onward, it has become even more so since 1965 when a new immigration and naturalization act was passed. This act allowed for more immigration from Asia in particular and resulted in a new wave of immigrants coming from Asian countries. These immigrants brought with them Asian religious traditions and caused a concomitant increase in interest and practice of Asian religions by Asian and non-Asian Americans.[57]

In the brief sketches of the groups I presented we see evidence of the ongoing experimentation that has been a hallmark of American religion. For example, the Oneida Community was only one of hundreds of religious utopian communities that were a part of the landscape of the nineteenth century. Kanter studied the history of these groups, and Albanese has traced much of what we characterize as contemporary New Age thought to early American history.[58] In addition, the area of New York that I studied is also a part of what was termed the "Burned Over District." In the early 1800s, many new religious traditions and revivals swept through the area, giving birth to the Church of Jesus Christ of Latter Day Saints (or the Mormons) to name just one. Since the area is not far from the millions of people who inhabit New York City, the nearby mountain ranges of the Catskills, Berkshires, and Adirondacks all offered numerous retreat centers catering to the spiritual needs and desires of this large population. Many of these centers reflected the influence of Eastern traditions as noted above with gathering places for Muslim, Buddhist, and Hindu practitioners, as well as various new religious movements.

In attempting to capture this diversity, I will offer the following analyses based on the data collected: the fluidity of practitioners' belief systems, the religious knowledge explosion, seekers growing exponentially, and a reflection on pastoral care.

Fluidity

Forman attempts to make sense of this new and vast interest in what he terms "grassroots spirituality" through the use of Venn diagrams. He shows a core grassroots spirituality community that intersects in places with more traditional and formal religious traditions. He also notes that much of grassroots spirituality does not intersect with traditional religious groups. His analysis is similar to that of Stark and his colleagues who argue that we have churched and unchurched religion—though Forman wants to argue that grassroots spirituality is a new form of religious/spiritual tradition with certain common threads.[59] While I disagree with Forman's attempt to place so many traditions under one umbrella, I do resonate strongly with the imagery of diversity captured by the Venn diagrams.

When we look at someone like Maisie in the "Intellectuals" group, we can see so many different traditions intersecting in the life of one woman. First, we may note ongoing connections to the Oneida community. However, we also may observe her daily practice of yoga and meditation, and her reading of religious books from Aldous Huxley's *Perennial Philosophy* to Harvey Cox's *Turning East* to Stephen Levine's work on death.[60] She has explored Sufism, Christianity, Hinduism, Buddhism, Gurdjieff's work, and many New Age writers. She is fluid in her practices and her beliefs, is always questioning, and is still curious about new religious beliefs even as she is into her eighties. When I interviewed her, I experienced her as a quintessential seeker and a lover of knowledge. If one were to draw Venn diagrams of the traditions that have influenced her, we would see multiple and overlapping traditions influencing her spiritual life. She was not unique. Every woman I interviewed showed similar patterns of diversity, fluidity, and multiplicity in their belief systems, though the specific sources varied.

Unlike the other 88 percent of the women I interviewed, Maisie was unique in that she had never belonged to a traditional religion (Catholic, Jewish, or Protestant) when young and had never been a part of churched religion as defined above. At the time of the study, 27 percent of those interviewed still professed allegiance to churched religious traditions: 12 percent Catholic, 15 percent Protestant, and another 27 percent belonged to the non-creedal but institutionally organized Unitarian Universalists.[61] While religious leaders of churched groups might like to draw clear lines around their traditions through the use of creeds, obviously, American society has shifted to the point that affirming a creed does not necessarily

mean that one's sole allegiance is to the creed. In fact, the women I interviewed who had remained affiliated with a churched religion were quite happy to redefine what the tradition meant for them. For example, a Catholic nun that I interviewed was able to stay within her order and at the same time believe in reincarnation, practice Hindu meditation, and experience visions of the goddess.

The Knowledge Explosion and Its Impact on Religious Experience

I found it impossible to keep track of all the religious/spiritual influences affecting the lives of the people I observed in the groups or the women I interviewed. There was just too much knowledge available, even from 1992 to 1993, before the World Wide Web took hold. All the various sacred texts of the major world religions were readily available, as were commentaries, videos, audiotapes, and word of mouth transmissions. For instance, in the Witness Consciousness group, people expressed interest in Edgar Cayce, kinship with and even talking with animals, the work of Peace Pilgrim, Angel cards, the Findhorn Community, the Rainbow community, yoga, near death experiences, chanting, astrology, Oneida teachings, Quaker teachings, experiences with mind-altering drugs, and other intentional communities in addition to the link the leader had with the Hindu Yogi Desai at Kripalu.

In interviews with a few women, I tried to identify the books that influenced their lives. While the diversity was so great that I had trouble finding clear patterns, I did find one strong pattern: all of the women interviewed did find books a major source of information on religious traditions. Furthermore, several of the women reported having religious experiences while reading religious texts. In contrast, no one reported having religious experiences through watching television or videos. It appears that the reading of texts is one of the major sources of religious or spiritual knowledge for these women, followed by the experiences that they had at various retreat centers and in small groups.

Another important pattern that I did note with the women's spirituality group, in particular, was that many women read about women's spirituality first and were then interested in forming groups similar to those about which they had read. Since women's spirituality groups were so new at the time, this use of books to spread these traditions made sense.

Seekers Growing Exponentially

While the majority of persons involved in the groups and interviews were baby boomers, they were definitely not the only generations who participated.[62] I interviewed four women in their twenties and one woman each in her sixties and eighties. That left the majority, 77 percent, as baby boom-

ers. Pike notes that many who participate in contemporary New Age and Neopagan events are baby boomers, but goes on to note that "categorizing participants in these movements is a near impossible project."[63] While teaching at Santa Clara University from 1995 to 2002, I often had students do short ethnographic projects on alternative traditions in the San Jose area of California. I was astounded by the number of alternative religious traditions that students found of both churched and unchurched varieties. They even found spiritually based Generation X churches.[64] Research indicates that the generation currently in college, the Millennials, is deeply interested in spiritual practices.[65] Thus, the phenomenon of seeking authentic religious/spiritual experiences continues to be a hallmark of our society.

What were the women I interviewed and the people I observed in the five small groups seeking? Perhaps my response might echo Pike's above—they were seeking so many things that to categorize them is a "near impossible project." However, I did notice several strong themes. These themes are: (1) seeking to heal and transform the self; (2) seeking to heal and transform the world; (3) seeking to transform gender roles; and (4) seeking religious/spiritual experiences. Such seeking is maintained by a process of inclusive "borrowing"[66]: one can study any tradition and purchase any book, crystal, religious service, healing session with a therapist, and so forth without worrying about where the tradition comes from or who has the authority to practice the tradition. Anyone can "market" their spiritual wares; anyone can purchase them. Of course, the buyer-practitioner has the right to evaluate whether the product "works" and to seek another product if the first one does not deliver. In this sense we are in a spiritual/religious marketplace of unprecedented availability. By the same token, though, the responsibility for the search and the responsibility for finding what will bring truth, healing, and enlightenment is left up to the individual. None of the themes I am noting here is unique to my analysis.[67] My analysis does contribute, however, a strong ethnographic component to illustrate the themes and to show how individuals within the study lived their religion. The examples also show how this seeking is dynamic, how individuals will pick and choose which parts apply to them, and how they wrestle with the wide range of information and practices available to them.

Seeking to Heal and Transform the Self

Undoubtedly many people came to the small groups for healing of one sort or another. Sometimes people would share in the groups what was going on in their lives that needed healing. One good example of this sharing occurred in ACIM class. We were in the middle of the eleven-week class and the core participants had begun to know each other. Gus, the group leader, summarized for the class the information presented in the previous week's tape by

Marianne Williamson. He noted that, "We are all coded for success. We are all stars. The problem is not what is coming in, it is what is not going out. We get back what we give. . . . The course shows you what you should do in this moment." As Gus prepared to continue playing another tape by Marianne Williamson, I heard dissent. One group member muttered under her breath, "Marianne Williamson is not a spiritual person. She is breezy and full of herself." Another person remarked, "Good, these tapes are wonderful."

Gus played the tape, which stressed that we need to see ourselves as temples of light and to see that the thought systems of this culture are based on fear. By contrast, Marianne Williamson said we are really coded for success. We just need to get up and keep going after we fall. We need to honor ourselves and then we will see that all relationships, no matter how they turn out, will be a success.

Anne, a member who had been coming every time, blurted out loudly, "Now, wait a minute!" She vehemently disagreed with this statement. Gus turned off the tape and the group spent about a half-hour talking about Anne's problems. It turned out that Anne had a bad relationship with her boss at work. She was furious with him and said that she was going to go into her job tomorrow and quit. She said, "All relationships can't be a success. Sometimes you have to take action." Gus and another class member, Will, both told her that ACIM teaches that every relationship in life is an assignment and a lesson to be learned. Will told a story about his relationship with his grandmother. He said he used to get very mad with her, but that he had turned everything over to the Holy Spirit and now he was able to deal with her without getting angry. Anne was not convinced; she kept saying, "This does not work." Others in the group said, "Perhaps if you didn't work things out in this life, you came back to work it out in another life." Nothing helped Anne. She remained intractable. Gus finally said that life was an endurance test and that you just had to keep working the principals of ACIM. Then he returned to playing more of the tape. This was not the last time that Anne brought problems to the group. She wanted help with ways to handle her landlord, the horse that threw her, and other ongoing problems. The muttering about whether it was worth listening to the tapes also continued. Some persons were much more committed to the tapes than others.

Compounding the search for healing through ACIM was that some members of the group also practiced other forms of healing. Thus, Will not only knew a lot about ACIM, but he also knew a great deal about traditional Christianity and about a healing technique called Reiki (a technique that draws on energy surrounding the body to help in healing). Sometimes he would stay after class to practice Reiki healing on other group members.

Anne obviously wanted help with her anger and her everyday problems. She struggled with the guidelines of ACIM and found them inadequate.

Nevertheless, she kept coming every week until the class ended. Her problems may be seen as psychological, but ACIM interpreted those problems as a failure to embrace this spiritual system.

A more positive story about healing came from two women who independently told me this story in their interviews with me. Cheryl, in her sixties, had been having trouble with her eyes and had lost about 60 percent of her vision in one eye. She went to a local Reiki practitioner, Ella (whom I also interviewed), for treatment. Cheryl reported that during the healing she felt a tingling all over her face and that she had seen an angel standing by Ella. The angel had wings, was about six feet tall, and seemed male in appearance. Cheryl credits this healing with saving her eyesight. When I talked with Ella she told me the same story, noting that this was the first time she had ever done a "full Reiki" session. Ella said, "It was really odd because, for the first time, I had this image of this angel behind me, guiding me through all this. Of course, I didn't say anything to her. When it was over, after the session, we were talking about it. Cheryl said, 'Ella, there was this angel!' She described the exact same angel. It just totally blew me away."

Ella not only practiced Reiki, she went to shamanic workshops to learn more about healing, believed in the power of crystals, chanted using chants from Gurumayi, and participated in women's rituals—to name just a few of her unchurched religious practices. Ella had grown up Jewish, but no longer practiced that faith. Similarly, Cheryl had been a part of many healing groups, including the above referenced ACIM, after leaving the Catholic faith in her early twenties. While reference to seeing angels was a bit unusual in the interviews I conducted, the stories of seeking physical and emotional healing presented here are typical of members of the small groups I studied.

Seeking to Heal and Transform the World

Of the five small groups studied, only two routinely discussed seeking to heal and transform the world—the Intellectuals and the women's spirituality group.[68] However, healing and transforming the world were themes in all the interviews, though to varying degrees. The group most dedicated to systematically exploring the theme of making a difference in the global world was the one I termed the Intellectuals. Their study of Ornstein and Ehrlich's *New World, New Mind* captured much of their thought on this issue. First, all were agreed that the world was in trouble. Specifically mentioned were over-population, violence and its portrayal in the media, warfare, environmental damage, and worldwide hunger. In another sense, too, these group members were often the most socially active. Four of the five (excluding myself from this analysis) were involved in various social causes, engaging in a range of activities from teaching others to working on the front lines to change local and national policies. Another theme that sur-

faced was that changing social policies was not going to suffice. Rather humans had to change their ways of thinking and being in the world. Members thought these changes in humanity would have to come through a spiritual revolution. We can see this latter theme in Dorothy's story.

Dorothy had been dedicated to social justice activities for more than thirty years (she was currently in her fifties). She had worked on fair trade issues, had written grants for storytelling as a way of helping children, and was a peace activist. She said of her activism, "I became a coordinator for [a] congressional district. . . . I became involved in an inner city group to help children. I learned a very great deal about how to organize people at the grassroots level to help their own neighborhoods know what their rights are in terms of federal law, how to get money coming into their neighborhoods. I edited a newspaper for the inner city for six years, and I got involved in fair housing. I was totally immersed in the peace movement of the 1980s. I was president of the local food bank and of the League of Women Voters. I have just received a grant for helping people to think about global issues."

Though she was always a part of a church or small group of a religious/spiritual nature, she says that now she also feels it is even more important to transform herself through spiritual development. She has a deep sadness for the world—saying that she had put her fingers in the dyke trying to stop the flood of world problems, but the world has flooded anyway. So now, she said, "I think the real answer has to be more on a conscious level. Anyway, I am hoping that is the answer. Maybe there is no answer, but I've read enough that I think it is possible that humanity is going through this terrible suffering to force us to expand our consciousness. So, I must do this [work of transforming myself spiritually] on the individual level. Then, maybe for each individual that does raise their consciousness, it will make it that much easier for others to raise theirs." Dorothy and others in this group cited the story of "the hundredth monkey." According to this account, originally written by Lyall Watson in his book *Lifetide* and made popular by Keyes, once a hypothetical number of monkeys in a troop, in this case the hundredth monkey, learns a new task it will spread rapidly through the whole group and also to other groups.[69] By analogy then, once a certain percentage of humanity has reached a new spiritual plane, the whole human population will rapidly follow. The spiritual work of transforming a few people will eventually multiply to the critical number and humanity will be transformed. Note that this transformation is dependent on human dedication to the cause and not to divine intervention.[70]

Seeking to Transform Gender Roles

Similarly, the women's spirituality group also thought that rapid social change was possible, but their emphasis was on changing gender roles. As

noted previously, they based much of their thinking and discussion of this possibility on the work of Riane Eisler, *The Chalice and the Blade*, and the accompanying workbook, *The Partnership Way*, by Eisler and her husband, David Loye. The gist of this perspective was that women and men were once equal and lived together without hierarchies. Since this egalitarian society had once existed, it could exist again. Further, because social changes had brought women more power in society recently, human society was on the brink of being able to live again in gender harmony as envisioned in *The Partnership Way*. One example of the discussion of this book will give a flavor of both the humor and the anger that underlay this struggle for more equitable gender relations.

In a women's spirituality group gathering, the leader for the evening, Jane, began with lighting a candle and asking each member of the group to envision how the world would be different if there were equality between men and women. Her instructions included the phrase, "to be specific." Sharing afterward brought visions of men and women dancing together with joy, a world in which there was no war, different forms of parenting, safety for both men and women, and acrobats holding up tiers of persons, both male and female. Following this was a discussion of what the chalice and the blade symbolized to each person in the room.

Another exercise was quite interesting as it involved contrasting partnership, or egalitarian models, with "dominator" or hierarchical visions. We were asked to envision what a matriarchy, as the opposite of patriarchy, might look like. With lots of laughter, women talked about how men would feel unsafe if they had to go out alone, how men would be attacked because they had worn short shorts, and how men would look and feel in high heel shoes with pointy toes and wearing make-up. One woman had the idea of saying to a spouse, "Why don't you lose weight? Look at what you look like with that beer gut hanging out. Why don't you wear make up in the morning?" Following up on this verbal play, other women had men cooking dinner for their spouses, being a secretary at the beck and call of a superior, and being paid less for the same work. After all the laughter, the talk turned serious again as we discussed what it would feel like to live in such a world. We discussed what it means to have and to exercise the power that resides in dominant positions, who currently has power, and how some women use power to become like men.

In other sessions discussing this book, the women in the group questioned the authenticity of Eisler's recounting of history, whether there had ever been a true sharing of power, and whether there could ever be a partnership way. While there was hope for transformation, members also often expressed anger at the different standards, at the differences in pay, at the differences in religious leadership, and so forth. While these women saw themselves as feminists, they also revealed in interviews how difficult it was

to live their beliefs and to foster change. Some women worked to raise their daughters with more awareness, some worked in teaching about gender issues, and some were activists for social change. The actual practice of rituals where women organized, planned, and led the rituals worked to empower some of these women for their work in the world.

Seeking Religious/Spiritual Experiences

Twenty-one of the twenty-six women interviewed, or 81 percent, reported having some sort of religious/spiritual experience in their lives. Discussions of various forms of religious experience also occurred in four of the five groups studied. The yoga group was the exception as people just practiced and did not discuss during class. However, women in this group who were interviewed also reported religious/spiritual experiences. In my interviews I used the definition of religious experience as expressed in the following Gallup Poll question, "Have you had a religious experience—that is—a particularly powerful religious insight or awakening?"[71] In some of the interviews, depending on the openness of the interviewee, I followed up with questions about religious experiences frequently reported in the cross-cultural anthropological literature such as experiences of evil, out of body experiences, experiences of the dead, experiences of healing, experiences of union with a higher power, a vision or assurance that a higher power was present, and predictions of the future.[72]

It is beyond the scope of this paper to analyze all the experiences reported. Frankly, I was amazed at the range and types of experiences reported in both the group conversations and in the one-on-one interviews. All of my questions about the various types of experiences were answered in the affirmative by at least one of the persons interviewed. To give a flavor of the experiences, which include the story of the angels discussed above, I offer two other examples. One is an experience that Jackie, a member of the yoga class, had during an accident. The other is an experience reported while reading. As noted earlier, one of the findings of this study was that women often found that reading was an important spiritual practice and that it could, on occasion, trigger a spiritual experience.

Several years earlier, Jackie, a teacher in her forties and one of the leaders of the yoga group discussed here, was visiting her cousins at their lake house and went swimming. There was a slide that went down into the water that she very much wanted to try out. In retrospect, she said that anyone would have known it was dangerous to do what she did, but she wanted to go down this slide head first. So she did. She hit her head on a concrete block in the water. Blood poured from the wound. As she was underwater, she looked up and saw the sun shining down into the water and came up. Everyone wanted to treat her including a nurse who witnessed the accident.

Jackie reported not being worried about her head, but she was worried she might have injured her spine. As she waited for further treatment, she would get scared. But "every time I would get this feeling of warmth that would slide down my whole body and a voice would say to me, 'Jackie, you are going to be fine.' And this happened like three times when I was waiting for the ambulance to come. It was just such a powerful invitation to trust, which," she laughs, "is a very hard thing to do." She then went on to describe other experiences such as experiences in nature when "the world suddenly gets thin," when time seems different, and when the depth of connection to the world around you is "mystical."

In my interview with Elizabeth, a UU in her fifties and a librarian who had attended both the ACIM and the women's spirituality groups, I asked her whether she had had an experience of union with a higher power. She replied, "I think so," and went on to describe experiences in nature. She then added that she had also had experiences when reading Ralph Waldo Emerson in college. She had experiences of transcendence then—which another student later told her was "just indigestion!" Elizabeth described these experiences as a feeling, "those times when you know on some level that is not intellectual that there is some something beyond yourself." In keeping with this theme of belonging to something larger than the self, Elizabeth's imagery of the divine was as "the blob." While we both laughed a lot about that image, Elizabeth said that God was a part of all things such as trees and human beings. She thought God liked to have experiences of life through being a part of everything. Elizabeth was exceptionally thoughtful when considering the nature of the universe and her relationship to that universe. She had also had experiences in which she saw and spoke to her father after his death.

PASTORAL REFLECTIONS—THEN AND NOW

At the time I conducted this research, I was not yet a pastor in the Unitarian Universalist Association of Congregations. I had become a UU in the fall of 1990, embracing this eclectic and open tradition with enthusiasm. I had not, however, participated in the small group segment of the church until I moved to Upstate New York. There I learned so much from the participants in this study and from congregational members that I began to think of ordained ministry, in part, because they encouraged me as a leader. When I moved to Princeton University the following year for a postdoctoral fellowship, UU members, faculty, and fellow students also saw me as someone who could become a minister. Finally, I said yes to this call, after much wrestling as it meant another three years of school and a year of internship in a church. I went to Pacific School of Religion, Berkeley, California, from 1995 to 1999, and was ordained in 2001.

As I reflect on my experiences with these small groups, I see much of what I too was asking: What does it mean to live a meaningful life? How can we heal our brokenness? How can we heal the brokenness of the earth? And from the women, especially, what does it mean to imagine God differently—either without gender, with a "gentler" male gender, or as a female? What do rituals and prayer and hope look like when we go beyond stereotypical answers? The positive side to the questioning from members of all five groups is that they were not content with superficial answers or platitudes. They wanted more, much more. However, in terms of pastoral care to help with this seeking, there was no person in attendance to turn to in most of the groups who had been ordained (very rarely the ordained pastor of RHUU church came to a session). Instead, they turned to each other. That was a blessing and a problem.

Pastoral care when done by the laity (and the laity do a great deal of pastoral care in many congregations and settings) can be community based, warm, and hopeful. It can also be distant, uncaring, and cold (and, of course, in between). A lot depends on the caregiver and on their training. In the case of this UU congregation, there was no "caring team" and no training provided to congregational members in pastoral care. In terms of the groups I studied, all but one group was ephemeral. They came together for a ten-week course or a semester, without a structure and with little accountability or responsibility. The community was so fluid and the experiences so diverse that most care came from friends or a person willing to take on the role. Sometimes the needs were so great that, in my opinion as an observer, an exceptionally skilled counselor was needed—but there was no one (and as far as I know, no referrals were made).

As I look back on some of the interviews I conducted, I may have played a larger counseling role than I knew, especially with a core group who were in the Women's Spirituality Group. These women wanted to talk when I visited with them—so many of the interviews stretched over two or three sessions as they told me the story of their lives, their questioning and their seeking. I did not think of it then as counseling in any way, but I was a good listener.[73] Sometimes I felt that my "social science credentials" were in jeopardy because I listened and followed the lead of the interviewee rather than interjecting my own questions. I was also a sympathetic companion in that I went to many of the same sessions they attended, asked many of the same questions, and wanted to change the world in similar ways.

If we examine this seeking through the lens of postmodern culture, the groups were all postmodern in character—questioning modernity, with permeable boundaries, having less core (or creed) than most "official" religious groups, and skeptical of scientific knowledge.[74] Pastoral care for such groups needs to meet them where they are—which I did when I listened well. However, in the world of pastoral care, would listening be enough? Where do we

go for more concrete answers? What would those answers look like? What is truth and who has that truth?[75] If a more "psychological" model from the social sciences was applied, then we would also need to deal with the unhappiness and neurotic behavior of some of the attendees (from my perspective, Anne in the account above clearly needed psychological help). For example, even if the participants in this study were in counseling (or had sought counseling), and a number of them had done so, they tended not to see their counselor as providing help with their religious and spiritual questions. They went to other sources—namely these groups—for ways to explore the issues they faced. Since they moved in a culture with access to multiple sources of truth (rather than in a small tribal culture where there may have only been one world view available), all these participants had multiple ways to construct meaning and multiple ways to define care.

After many years as an ordained minister, working in institutions of higher education, I now tend to see my role in pastoral care in the light of companionship. That is, I listen, offer suggestions, and refer the deeply troubled to counselors with more skills and training. I have remained profoundly influenced by my time in Upstate New York: I do not see myself as having "answers" or the "answer" even though I currently work primarily with Christian students (usually from mainline traditions and Roman Catholicism). This theological stance is much in tune with UU theologies which assert that UUs use wisdom from all the world's religious traditions and in tune with postmodern eclecticism. It also leaves me open to the primary critique of postmodernism—namely, if there is no fixed truth, how do we determine how to live and act faithfully in the world. I resolve this tension though my commitment to social justice. I teach liberation theology, live periodically with the poor (and most of the time with the affluent), and see the gospel and the teachings of other religious leaders such as Gandhi as claiming a moral ground that works for justice as defined by those "at the bottom" of society.[76]

CONCLUSION

In this example from the late twentieth century, five small groups illustrate the unchurched model of religious practices loosely affiliated with the Unitarian Universalist Association. These "unchurched" opportunities to explore religious meaning are now so prevalent that most Americans are familiar with them, and many are likely to refer to such religious activities as "spiritual." Sometimes they will even contrast religion and spirituality, generally falling into the pattern of claiming that spirituality is different from organized religion. And they are right if by the term spiritual they are intuitively referring to the difference between churched and unchurched religion.

While the lived religion described in this paper is fluid, draws on numerous sources, and is especially appealing to seekers of healing and personal and/or social transformation, what does all this diversity mean? As we have seen, the religion portrayed here is postmodern as defined by the lack of strong boundaries around groups; the freedom of participants to pick and choose bits and pieces to form their meaning systems; and a strong tendency to value individualism over community.[77] At the same time, paradoxically, the search for religious meaning, transformation, and belonging is also the postmodern equivalents of the search for community. A person joins these small groups, in part, to belong to something more than the self. These practitioners want to experience something of community.

But the community represented by these small groups was itself limited and subject to mobility and individualism. Members did not necessarily find the same people in these groups over time; there was little commitment of money, time, or effort required to belong to these groups; and as a consequence, a member could not usually depend on other group members for help over the long haul. As Albanese points out, there was a longing for home, for being a part of a larger whole in these groups, but the home was illusory and fragmented.[78]

Meaning-making when the choices are this enormous leaves the individual both in control and often alone in decision making. Diversity, fluidity, and exploration often come with a postmodern price—that is, the community found may lack depth, endurance, and stability. Pastoral care in such settings is challenging and also postmodern. The caregiver must decide how much to share, to critique, to prod, and whether or not to attempt to influence the direction of change at the individual and communal level.

POSTSCRIPT

While I remain a practicing UU minister, there remains a tension in my pastoral care that I suspect I share with many in this postmodern world: that is, how to be open to the spirit and at the same time live in a community that has some stability. I also wrestle with the tension between care of the individual and care of the social world, opting for commitment to social justice as my framework for addressing these problems.

NOTES

1. Roger Finke and Rodney Stark, *The Churching of America, 1776–1990: Winners and Losers in Our Religious Economy* (New Brunswick, N.J.: Rutgers University Press, 1993).

2. Sandra Schneiders, "Religion and Spirituality: Strangers, Rivals, or Partners," Santa Clara Lecture, Ignatian Center, Bannan Institute (February 6, 2000), 2.

3. Schneiders, "Religion and Spirituality," 2.

4. Sandra Schneiders, "Religion vs. Spirituality: A Contemporary Conundrum," *Spiritus: A Journal of Christian Spirituality* 3, no. 2 (2003), 3.

5. Cited in Schneiders, "Religion vs. Spirituality," 3.

6. Schneiders, "Religion vs. Spirituality," 3.

7. See Peggy V. Beck, Anna L. Waters, and Nia Francisco, *The Sacred* (Tsaile [Navajo Nation], Arizona: Navajo Community College Press, 1977); and Keith Basso, *Wisdom Sits in Place* (Albuquerque: University of New Mexico Press, 1996).

8. Other anthropologists use substantive definitions to alleviate this problem. Substantive definitions usually reference spirit beings or powers. However, substantive definitions are limited in their cross-cultural applicability to traditions such as some forms of Buddhism that do not posit higher powers. Scholars must carefully consider which type of definition best fits their research project. For a good brief discussion of the differences see James C. Livingston, *Anatomy of the Sacred*, 4th ed. (Upper Saddle Creek, N.J.: Prentice Hall, 2000).

9. Clifford Geertz, *The Interpretation of Culture* (New York: Basic Books, 1973), 90.

10. Jerry Adler, "In Search of the Spiritual," *Newsweek*, September 5, 2005, 50.

11. See Brian J. Zinnbauer, Kenneth I. Pargament, Brenda Cole, Mark S. Rye, Erie M. Butter, Timothy G. Belavich, Kathleen M. Hipp, Allie B. Scott, and Jill L. Kadar, "Religion and Spirituality: Unfuzzing the Fuzzy," *Journal for the Scientific Study of Religion* 36, no. 4 (December 1977), 549–64; and Robert Owens Scott, "Are You Religious or Are You Spiritual: A Look in the Mirror," *Spirituality and Health* (Spring 2001), 26–28. Scott reports that a national survey done by Blum and Weprin Associates showed that 59 percent of Americans said they were both religious and spiritual, while 20 percent selected "spiritual" only, and 8 percent said they were "only religious."

12. Rodney Stark, Evan Hamberg, and Alan S. Miller, "Exploring Spirituality and Unchurched Religions in America, Sweden, and Japan," *Journal of Contemporary Religion* 20 (2005): 3–23. They also discuss the role of magic cross-culturally, but I have not included a summary of their discussion in my article.

13. Similarly Meredith McGuire has argued for distinguishing between official and unofficial religion, noting that both may exist side by side in *Religion: The Social Context*, 5th ed. (Belmont, Calif.: Wadsworth, 2001). Susan Sered, basing her work on women's religious traditions cross-culturally, has argued for distinguishing between domestic religious traditions that exist alongside non-domestic religion. See "The Domestication of Religion: The Spiritual Guardianship of Elderly Jewish Women," in *Across the Boundaries of Belief*, eds. Morton Klass and Maxine K. Weisgrau (Boulder, Colo.: Westview Press, 1988), 96–112. However, Stark, Hamberg, and Miller's analysis in "Exploring Spirituality and Unchurched Religions" is more inclusive of the cross-cultural diversity found.

14. Note that this complex framework is intended to cover all the world religions, including the major traditions such as Judaism, Hinduism, Buddhism, Islam, and Christianity, as well as the smaller, more local religious traditions. In America, many of the world religious traditions adapt to the congregational pattern

as part of the acculturation process of immigrants. See Diana Eck, *A New Religious America: How a "Christian Country" Has Become the World's Nation* (New York: Harper One, 2002).

15. See J. Gordon Melton, *New Age Encyclopedia* (Detroit: Gale Research, 1990); James R. Lewis and J. Gordon Melton, eds., *Perspectives on the New Age* (Albany: State University of New York Press, 1992); and James R. Lewis, *The Encyclopedia of New Age Religions* (Amherst, N.Y.: Prometheus Books, 2004).

16. See Mary Farrell Bednarowski, "The New Age Movement and Feminist Spirituality," in *Perspectives on the New Age* (Albany: State University of New York Press, 1992), 167–78; and Sarah Pike, *New Age and Neopagan Religions in America* (New York: Columbia University Press, 2004).

17. Pike, *New Age*, 15.

18. Pike, *New Age*, 15.

19. Cynthia Eller, *Living in the Lap of the Goddess* (New York: Crossroad, 1993).

20. Eller, *Living;* and Mary Jo Neitz, "In Goddess We Trust," in *In Gods We Trust*, eds. Thomas Robbins and Dick Anthony, 2nd ed. (New Brunswick, N.J.: Transaction Publishers, 1990), 353–71.

21. See Helen Berger, *A Community of Witches: Contemporary Neo-Paganism and Witchcraft in the United States* (Columbia: University of South Carolina Press, 1998). However, even this distinction is problematic. For example, Jane Salomonsen argues that researchers need to distinguish between feminist and non-feminist versions of Neopagan witchcraft in America. See *Enchanted Feminism: The Reclaiming Witches of San Francisco* (New York: Routledge, 2002), 10.

22. Arthur L. Greil and David R. Rudy, "On the Margins of the Sacred," in *In Gods We Trust*, eds. Thomas Robbins and Dick Anthony, 2nd ed. (New Brunswick, N.J.: Transaction Publishers, 1990), 219–32.

23. Stark, Hamberg, and Miller, "Exploring Spirituality."

24. The church, the participants, and interviewees have been given pseudonyms.

25. David Robinson, *The Unitarians and the Universalists* (Westport, Conn.: Greenwood Press, 1985).

26. Mason Olds, "Unitarian Universalism Through its History," in *America's Alternative Religions*, ed. Timothy Miller (Albany: State University of New York Press, 1995), 87–98; and William W. Zellner, *Extraordinary Group*, 7th ed. (New York: Worth Publishers, 2001).

27. The position that the Unitarian Universalist Association of Congregations is an accepted religious tradition tends to be the position of the organization itself. As an ordained minister in this tradition and as a social scientist, I am able to see both points of view. To determine where UUs "fit" depends on the categorization used. The UUA has adopted a set of principles and purposes but does not have a formal creed. The denomination is well organized, has congregational polity, and ordains ministers. But, unlike other American denominations, one can be an atheist and fully accepted in the tradition, including ordination as a minister. For basic introductions to Unitarian Universalists, see John Buehrens and F. Forrester Church, *Our Chosen Faith* (Boston: Beacon Press, 1989); and William F. Schultz, ed., *The Unitarian Universalist Pocket Guide*, 2nd ed. (Boston: Skinner House, 1993).

28. Robert Wuthnow, *Sharing the Journey* (New York: Free Press, 1994).

29. Wuthnow, *Sharing the Journey*, 45.

30. I interviewed several people who attended one or more of the groups I studied but that I had not personally seen attending the groups. These interviewees were referred to me by others in the groups.

31. History of Kripalu, in Kripalu Center for Yoga and Health website, www.kripalu.org/about/491/ (accessed July 1, 2008).

32. Shree Muktanada Ashram, in SYDA Foundation website, www.siddhayoga.org/shree-muktananda-ashram.html (accessed July 1, 2008).

33. The guru, in SYDA Foundation website, www.siddhayoga.org/guru-siddhayoga.html (accessed July 1, 2008).

34. Welcome to the Siddha Yoga Path, in SYDA Foundation website, www.siddhayoga.org/ (accessed July 1, 2008).

35. Hatha Yoga, in SYDA Foundation website, www.siddhayoga.org/practices/hatha_yoga/hatha_yoga.html (accessed July 1, 2008).

36. "Introduction to *A Course in Miracles*," A Course in Miracles website, www.acim.org/ACIM/SectionIntro.htm (accessed July 1, 2008); a combined volume of the *Text*, *Workbook for Students*, and a *Manual for Teachers* was published as *A Course in Miracles*, 3rd ed. (Mill Valley, Calif.: Foundation for Inner Peace, 2007).

37. Holly Wittaker, "A Course in Miracles," in *New Religious Movements Homepage Projects*, ed. Jeffery K. Hadden (University of Virginia, 2000), web.archive.org/web/20060829151944/religiousmovements.lib.virginia.edu/nrms/course.html (accessed July 1, 2008).

38. Whittaker, "A Course in Miracles."

39. Whittaker, "A Course in Miracles" (introduction).

40. Whittaker, "A Course in Miracles" (introduction).

41. Whittaker, "A Course in Miracles."

42. Cate Mansfield, "Gurdjieff," in New *Religious Movements Homepage Projects*, ed. Jeffery K. Hadden (University of Virginia, 1999), web.archive.org/web/20060829152032/religiousmovements.lib.virginia.edu/nrms/gurdjieff.html (accessed July 1, 2008)

43. Robert Ornstein and Paul Ehrlich, *New World, New Mind* (New York: Touchstone, 1989).

44. Idries Shah, *Wisdom of the Idiots* (London: Octagon Press, 1988), and *Tales of the Dervishes*, repr. ed. (London: Penguin, 1993).

45. My research also indicates a great deal of overlap as Ornstein promoted Shah's work, referenced in "Robert Ornstein to Speak," News from the Library of Congress (October 16, 2002), website of the Library of Congress, www.loc.gov/today/pr/2002/02-147.html (accessed July 1, 2008). Ornstein was profoundly influenced by Shah as indicated by "Idries Shah-Short Biography," in Katin Kahesselink website, www.katinkahesselink.net/sufi/idries-shah-biography.html (accessed July 1, 2008).

46. Information about the Abode of the Message can be found on their website www.theabode.net/ (accessed July 1, 2008).

47. The Gurdjieff International Review web site lists the following organization founded in New York in 1953: Gurdjieff Foundation of New York, www.gurdjieff.org/foundation/htm (accessed June 26, 2006).

48. Keith Bernstein, "The Oneida Community," in *New Religious Movements Homepage Projects*, ed. Jeffery K. Hadden (University of Virginia, 1998), web.archive.org/web/20060828131057/religiousmovements.lib.virginia.edu/nrms/Oneida.html (accessed July 1, 2008).

49. "History," the Oneida Community Mansion House website, www.oneida-community.org/page2.html (accessed June 27, 2006).

50. I distinguish here between a women's spirituality group that stresses women's religious experiences and the Neopagan movement which includes both women and men. See Neitz, "In Goddess We Trust," and Eller, *Living in the Lap*. Berger, *A Community of Witches*, places both groups in the Neopagan movement but separates the groups that embrace both sexes and the ones that are women only.

51. Judith Plaskow and Carol P. Christ, eds., *Weaving the Visions* (San Francisco: Harper, 1989).

52. Starhawk, *The Spiral Dance: A Rebirth of the Ancient Religion of the Great Goddess*, 20th anniversary ed. (San Francisco: Harper San Francisco, 1999); Diane Stein, *Casting the Circle* (Freedom, Calif.: Crossing Press, 1990); and Barbara Ardinger, *A Woman's Book of Rituals and Celebrations* (San Rafael, Calif.: New World Library, 1992).

53. Another reason that some women left was that there had been conflict in the church over forming an all-women's group. Some men protested loudly against the formation of the group. The pastor's wife came to the group meetings and was seen as "reporting" to her husband about the group discussions.

54. Riane Eisler, *The Chalice and the Blade* (San Francisco: Harper San Francisco, 1987); and Riane Eisler and David Loye, *The Partnership Way* (San Francisco: Harper San Francisco, 1998).

55. The controversy about this history was evident in 1992–1993, but it had not reached the level of critique that would come at the end of the century. Cynthia Eller, *The Myth of Matriarchal Prehistory* (Boston: Beacon Press, 2000), has written an authoritative study showing the inaccuracies in the history Eisler (*The Chalice and the Blade*) and Eisler and Loye (*The Partnership Way*), as well as others, had proposed.

56. The numbers are as follows: 85 percent went to one of the groups; 15 percent were referred to me by persons in one of the groups but had not attended while I was present.

57. Diana Eck, *A New Religious America* (San Francisco: Harper San Francisco, 2001).

58. Rosabeth Moss Kanter, *Commitment and Community* (Cambridge, Mass.: Harvard University Press, 1972); Catherine Albanese, *Nature Religion in America* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1990).

59. Robert Forman in *Grassroots Spirituality* (Charlottesville, Va.: Imprint Academic, 2004), argues that there is a new "grassroots spirituality" movement that crosscuts many different religious traditions and new religious movements. He attributes to this movement a certain commonality and search for transcendence that is similar to the perennial philosophy articulated by Aldous Huxley (Forman, *Grassroots Spirituality*, 101). However, this new grassroots spirituality is different in terms of its vast scale, its inclusion of so many middle-class persons, its use of psychology and medical models, and in the size of its markets. Forman also runs workshops that teach that spirituality is not the same as religion. See Robert Forman, Doug Kruschke, and Diana Denton, *Spiritual Development in a Diverse World: Theory and Practice—Facilitator's Manual* (Hastings on Hudson, N.Y.: Forge Institute, 2005). Part of the rationale for doing so is that if spirituality and religion are not the same, then

one can teach spirituality practices in non-church based institutions of higher learning. Note that this article's perspective critiques such a stand.

60. Aldous Huxley, *The Perennial Philosophy* (New York: Harper, 1945); Harvey Cox, *Turning East* (New York: Simon and Schuster, 1977); and Stephen Levine, *Healing into Life and Death* (New York: Anchor Books, 1989).

61. Stark, Hamberg, and Miller, "Exploring Spirituality," might have the same difficulty in classifying the Unitarian Universalists that I describe in note 26 above. By some measures UUs would be "churched" religions but they do not have a formal creed, placing them in the "creedless religious groups" category of "unchurched" religion.

62. Wade Clark Roof titled his study of the spiritual lives of baby boomers in America, *A Generation of Seekers*, and he portrayed the revolution in religious practices this generation instituted (New Brunswick, N.J.: Rutgers University Press, 1993).

63. Pike, *New Age*, 14.

64. For information on Generation X churches see Tom Beaudoin, *Virtual Faith* (San Francisco: Jossey-Bass, 1997); Richard W. Flory, "Conclusion: Toward a Theory of Generation X Religion," in *GenX Religion*, eds. Richard W. Flory and Donald E. Miller (New York: Routledge, 2000); and the other articles in Richard W. Flory and Donald E. Miller, eds., *GenX Religion*.

65. For information on the research being conducted with contemporary college students by the Higher Education Research Institute at the University of California, Los Angeles, see "Spirituality in Higher Education: A National Study of College Student's Search for Meaning and Purpose," www.spirituality.ucla.edu (accessed July 1, 2008).

66. The politics of borrowing religious rituals, practices, beliefs, and sacred texts from groups other than one's own is hotly debated by scholars, and ethically deplored, especially if the group being borrowed from is more marginal than the group doing the borrowing. Many examples of critiques by Native Americans of whites who borrow from their traditions are available. See Christopher R. Jocks, "Spirituality for Sale," *American Indian Quarterly* 20, no. 3 (1996), 415–31; and Wendy Rose, "The Great Pretenders," in *The State of Native America*, ed. Annette Jaimes (Cambridge, Mass.: South End Press, 1992). The Unitarian Universalist Church is also in the process of debating and forming ethical guidelines about "borrowing" from other religious traditions given its pluralistic and inclusive tradition. For example, the Unitarian Universalist Association offers educational information such as the following, "Reckless Borrowing or Appropriate Cultural Sharing?" by Jacqui James, on the UUA website, archive.uua.org/re/reach/winter01/social_justice/reckless.html (accessed July 1, 2008). However, since cultures in contact have historically borrowed religious traditions, often called "syncretism" (though that word is out of favor as well), it is hard to see how anyone—scholar or practitioner—will be able to stem the tide of this borrowing. Certainly, practitioners typically ignore the politics and ethics of using religious traditions and practices from other religious-cultural traditions.

67. See especially Bednarowski, "The New Age Movement," and *The Religious Imagination of Women* (Bloomington: Indiana University Press, 1999); and Pike, *New Age and Neopagan Religions*.

68. It is interesting to note that it was the women-only groups that were the most interested in social change. The Intellectuals were the most "New Age" in their perspective on social change while the women's spirituality group was more focused on gender equity.

69. See Ken Keyes, Jr., *The Hundredth Monkey* (Camarillo, Calif.: Devorss and Company, 1984) for the popular version. However, the story of "The Hundredth Monkey" is quite controversial. Elaine Myers notes that the account has wide appeal but looking to the actual events described by the primatologists indicates that the story referenced by Lyall Watson in *Lifetide* and Keyes in *The Hundredth Monkey* is inaccurate. Apparently there is no "critical threshold that would impart the idea of the new behavior" to the entire troop or to other troops of monkeys. See Elaine Myers, "The Hundredth Monkey Revisited," *In Context: A Quarterly of Humane Sustainable Culture*, skepdic.com/monkey.html (accessed June 6, 2006).

70. Mary Farrell Bednarowski has a good discussion of the theology of social change as envisioned by alternative American religious traditions in *New Religions and the Theological Imagination* (Bloomington: University of Indiana Press, 1989). She also discusses this theme in a comparison of the New Age and women's spirituality movement in "The New Age." Pike, *New Age and Neopagan Religions* discusses the importance of this perspective of social change as well.

71. I shortened the question. The full question as asked by Gallup in a study done in 1978 was, "Have you ever had a religious experience—that is, a particularly powerful religious insight or awakening—that changed the direction of your life, or not?" See "Questionnaire Profile: Evangelical Christianity in the United States," Gallup Brain website, brain.gallup.com/documents/questionnaire.aspx?STUDY=AIPOSP78139 (accessed July 3, 2008).

72. One of the most influential sources for my decision to expand the questions I had about religious experiences was the summary of the Alister Hardy Research Project by Meg Maxwell and Verena Tschudin, eds. *Seeing the Invisible* (London: Arkana-Penguin, 1990). They used data collected in Great Britain to analyze various categories of religious experience. I augmented their work with other examples from the cross-cultural anthropological literature.

73. See Carrie Doehring, *The Practice of Pastoral Care: A Postmodern Approach* (Louisville, Ky.: Westminster John Knox Press, 2006) for a thorough overview of contemporary pastoral care that stresses reflexivity in the role of the caregiver.

74. See Pamela D. Couture, "The Effect of the Postmodern on Pastoral/Practical Theology and Care and Counseling," *Journal of Pastoral Theology*, 13, no. 1 (June 2003): 85–104. She notes that postmodernism has entered pastoral care and counseling especially in the arena of theology where some practitioners have rejected theology "in favor of psychology or spirituality, as the basis for the ministries of care" (90). She also notes that practitioners reflect the point of view of other scholars of religion in their views on spirituality—some spirituality as a part of religion, others seeing religion and spirituality as adversaries (91). See also Elaine L. Graham, *Transforming Practice: Pastoral Theology in an Age of Uncertainty* (Eugene, Ore.: Wipf and Stock, 1996) for a thorough discussion of the effect of postmodernism on pastoral care.

75. These are the quintessential questions that skeptical postmodern thought asks. Because of the overlapping spiritual-religious thought and practices of

members of these small groups, they asked these same questions. Graham says that the postmodern self is "finite, continguent and embodied, and not a 'disembodied cognito' or a collection of qualities existing independent of context" (*Practicing Theology*, 28).

76. Couture captures this dichotomy well when she speaks of the tensions between modernity and postmodernity in the field of pastoral care and counseling in "The Effect." Graham argues that we should abandon any fixed knowledge based on theology and move to a pastoral care situated in context and practice in *Practicing Theology*. I disagree.

77. Since postmodernism is, like modernism, a product of the Western world, the focus on individualism rather than community is part of the postmodern worldview. Anthony Giddens in *The Consequences of Modernity* (Stanford: Stanford University Press, 1991) argues that postmodernity is really an outgrowth of the changes in space and time that have come about through technological inventions in late modernity. As such, the concept of the "individual" is fragmented even further.

78. Catherine L. Albanese, *America: Religions and Religion*, 3rd ed. (Belmont, Calif.: Wadsworth, 1999), 277–79.

III

INTERCULTURAL NUANCE

9

Lively Choruses: Relational Dance with God

Lonnie Yoder

On a bright sunny September morning in 2001 our family was worshipping with the Calvary Mennonite Church in Retreat, St. Mary, Jamaica.[1] As a relative newcomer on the island, I was especially attentive to much that was happening around me. In this particular case, the worship experience contained many new elements and experiences. A twenty-something female song leader was leading the Jamaican congregation in the singing of a number of hymns and choruses. The singing was spirited and there was considerable energy in the worship service. Then, at a point about fifteen minutes into the period of singing, the song leader intoned, "Let's now sing some lively choruses." The mood change was palpable, the energy level rose as worshippers became more animated as they sang these "lively choruses." The lively choruses were sung without interruption as the song leader led the group seamlessly from one animated chorus to the next. After about fifteen to twenty minutes, she suddenly stopped the string of lively choruses, pausing long enough to bring the worshippers back to the singing of other, more sedate choruses and hymns. I sensed in these moments that I had experienced something significant in the life of Jamaican Mennonites. That sense was confirmed time and again as, in almost all Jamaican Mennonite worship services during that year, there was time devoted in the worship service to the singing of these lively choruses. Early on in the year I decided, with the help of my sixteen-year-old daughter, to commit to writing the lyrics of as many of these lively choruses as we could identify.[2] It was my sense that the singing of these lively choruses was central to what it meant to be a Jamaican Mennonite.

The singing of lively choruses is a common practice in Jamaica Mennonite worship services. It is helpful to understand this practice in the larger

context of a typical Jamaican Mennonite worship service. A Jamaican Mennonite worship service begins with the worshippers gathering informally with many participants arriving after the announced starting time. The worship service itself may or may not start at the designated starting time and sometimes is delayed up to thirty to forty-five minutes. Although the worshippers gather informally, they are often dressed in their finest clothing. Women and young girls often wear brightly colored dresses while men and boys wear suits or classy casual slacks and shirts.

The formal worship service typically begins with a welcome indicative of the British influence on the island. A "pleasant good morning to you" from the moderator or worship leader is met with a communal response from the congregation "good morning to you." The moderator often gives a devotional thought or two and then invites the song leader to lead in singing. There then follows a period of thirty to forty-five minutes of singing including a variety of songs and hymns. The singing may be interrupted at some point with a short Bible reading and devotional reflections on the Biblical passage. At some point an offering is taken with a prayer following the collection of the offering. The period of singing leads up to the focal event of the worship service, the delivery of the sermon by the pastor or some other person designated to provide the preaching. Much of the leadership of the service leading up to the sermon is often provided by females whereas the sermon is most often delivered by a male. Following the sermon, which typically lasts from forty to sixty minutes, there is usually a closing hymn and benedictory prayer. The service in its entirety typically lasts about two hours.

Worship is central to the life of a Jamaican Mennonite Christian and music is a predominant and central component of that worship. The music which is sung can be broadly typed in three categories: (1) *general choruses,* which are sung from memory and vary in their focus, (2) *lively choruses,* which are also sung from memory, and (3) *hymns,* which are sung from a variety of hymnbooks from the United States. The choruses, both general and lively, are sung with passion and are clearly more indigenous. The hymns, on the other hand, have a feeling of being borrowed and are sung with more restraint and challenge.

The singing of the lively choruses is palpably different from the singing of the general choruses. In the very naming of this subset of choruses I find a key difference. The lively choruses are sung in a more energetic fashion than the general choruses and are set off from the more restrained singing of hymns. The body of the worshipper is more engaged. The tempo of the songs is faster. Instrumentation, primarily in the form of tambourine in the rural areas and amplified instruments and drums in the urban setting, is almost a given for the lively choruses while it is often optional for the general choruses and hymns.

In the singing of the lively choruses each singer appears to move into an intense, relational experience with the divine. This experience takes on var-

ied visible forms, ranging from intense bodily engagement to complete bodily reserve. One worshipper may be dancing in place while the person next to her or him is standing quietly and not moving at all. Despite the variation in form and expression, each worshipper appears to be having an authentic, genuine worship experience. Furthermore, the variety of expressions does not seem to be problematic to those present. Individuals who move around or express themselves dramatically seem to do so without distracting those who are more reserved in their worship. In other words, there appears to be little social consciousness about how one is alike or different from others in style of worship. Hence, there does not appear to be any preferred or normative way of singing the lively choruses.

RATIONALE FOR THIS STUDY

This study of Jamaican Mennonite lively choruses may be perceived as simply an academic's curiosity regarding an unusual phenomenon. However, this study gains depth when situated in the context of larger religious and cultural dynamics in the Caribbean region. Diane Austin-Broos, in her insightful study of Jamaican Pentecostalism, views this Pentecostalism as a negotiated reality between European Christianity and the religions of West Africa. In her words, it is characterized by "a marked tension between moral discourse and ritual eudemonic as they are practiced in the church, between a strong emphasis on guilt and sin and the joyous celebration of healing rite."[3] It will become clear that the Jamaican Mennonite lively choruses share more in common with the ritual eudaemonistic/healing rite of West African religions than with an emphasis on guilt and sin found in some quarters of European Christianity.

Austin-Broos, in her analysis of the Pentecostal in-filling of the Holy Spirit as an embodied rite, observes that "through an instant and mysterious change, the Pentecostal rite confers the power to be a saint. In realizing this experience, the popular belief and practice of Jamaican Pentecostalism partakes of a cosmology in which normative order is challenged and changed through a 'trick,' through immediate normative breach rather than 'man-made' discipline."[4] While the Jamaican Mennonite lively choruses are not heavily Pentecostal in style or origin, they nevertheless can be easily understood as yet another form of embodied rite that are contextually relevant in the Jamaican Mennonite world. In the immediacy of the lively chorus, the Jamaican Mennonite's experience is transformed. For example, the grinding daily socioeconomic challenges faced by many Jamaicans is reframed during the singing of the lively choruses into an uplifting encounter with the divine.

Emmanuel Lartey, in his essay on global perspectives in pastoral care and counseling, argues for a refined focus in the postmodern context. He argues

that "a return from the exclusive focus on the written word to the oral, narrative, and story—art, music, poetry, dance and other expressive forms of creativity are now as central for theory making as are rationality, logical propositions and abstract concepts."[5] The Jamaican lively chorus as a musical form which has passed through the generations in oral form fits this focus well.

Finally, this study clearly fits within the lived religion paradigm which emphasizes "ordinary" practice in particular settings. Jamaican Mennonites understand the singing of the lively choruses as a common practice in their worship. To my knowledge, the term "lively chorus" is not used in any other Mennonite worship setting around the globe. As such, this awareness points to the particularity of this religious practice in the Jamaican Mennonite context. This study also involves both social-political and theological analyses of the lively choruses, another feature of the lived religion paradigm. Lively choruses represent an intriguing example of local theology practiced in a particular time and particular place addressing both social-political and theological concerns of the worshipper.

IN VIVO CODES

A final introductory perspective on the lively choruses has to do with their nomenclature. Strauss and Corbin refer to the "in vivo code" or the very choice of words as instructive in developing grounded theory.[6] This is especially true in the Jamaican Mennonite choice of the name "lively chorus" for the spirited songs they sing. In the United States lively church tunes are often referred to as "praise songs." The use of the adjective "lively" rather than "praise" highlights the life and death reality of both the slave days and the current times for many Jamaican Mennonites. The term also describes the mode of singing—that is, the choruses are sung with a lively spirit which generates an enlivening experience for the singer.

The noun "chorus" rather than the more generic word "song" is also appropriate. The original meaning of the word "chorus" is "a dance in a ring." In more detail, it described "originally a band of dancers accompanied by their own singing or that of others."[7] Although it is not likely that Jamaican Mennonites are self-conscious about the choice of the word "chorus," the term's relevance to the Jamaican context is striking. The theme of movement or dance in the etymology of the word "chorus" is central to the singing of the lively choruses. In viewing the videos of two Jamaican Mennonite worship services,[8] I am struck by the change in the use of the body depending on the type of music being sung. When worship participants sing from North American hymnbooks, their bodies are still and their eyes are literally buried in the hymnbook as they read and sing the words of the hymn. However, in the singing of the lively choruses from memory, the body is a

central part of the experience with swaying, hand clapping, and intent focusing with the body which is expressed in both animated and reflective postures. Children are also quite active in the singing of the lively choruses and often know them by heart. In contrast, during the singing of the hymns, they often do not actively participate.

BRIEF JAMAICAN HISTORY

The island of Jamaica was settled by a native group known as the Arawaks around 700 A.D. Christopher Columbus arrived on the island in 1494 and dubbed the island "Land of Wood and Water." From 1494 until 1654 the island was under Spanish rule. Initially, the island was Columbus's personal property. In 1510, one of his lieutenants began to colonize the island. In 1517, the Spanish began to import slaves to Jamaica, beginning a long history of slavery on the island.

In 1654, the British defeated the Spanish and began a long reign on the island which lasted until Jamaica gained independence as a nation in 1962. During British rule, slavery continued unabated and grew dramatically in its influence. In 1700 there were 7,000 persons of English descent on the island and about 40,000 slaves of African descent. A century later the number of English had tripled while the number of slaves was almost eight times as many as a century earlier.[9]

In the early nineteenth century, a number of slave rebellions, riots, and revolutions led eventually to emancipation in 1838. Post-emancipation Jamaica was characterized by a continuing strong British colonial presence. Even though independence came to Jamaica on August 6, 1962, the nation is still a part of the British commonwealth and British influence continues. Post-independence Jamaica has struggled with issues of poverty, violence, and garrison politics while at the same time functioning as a desirable tourist destination for many North Americans and Europeans. Jamaica has been and continues to be an island of many contrasts. Her people are both laid back and hardworking. At the same time, they are both loud and passionate and characterized by a peaceful reserve, mirroring their setting in which the threat of violence and a serene tropical peace coexist in daily life. The economy is not quite Third World and yet there is little hope for economic gain in the lives of most Jamaicans.

RELEVANCE OF HISTORICAL AND CONTEMPORARY CONTEXT

This historical context is important to a richer understanding of the lively choruses. The long history of slavery in the Jamaican experience still exerts

influence in Jamaican culture and experience to this day. Bob Marley, the popular reggae singer, implored his Jamaican listeners to "emancipate yourselves from mental slavery." Although emancipation from slavery in Jamaica came in 1838, the vestiges of that life find their way into contemporary experience. It is important to note that while the slave experience was oppressive in many ways, it also served to build character traits, including patience, endurance, perspective, and the ability to live one day at a time.

Furthermore, a number of scholars have noted the central place of music in the slave experience. Michael Burnett, in his discussion of Jamaican work songs, observes that "the slaves were forbidden to talk to each other as they worked. But the slave overseers, or bushas as they were called, did not mind if the slaves sang."[10] Olive Lewin nuances this reality as follows: "Our African ancestors seem to have known instinctively how to use sound to outmanoeuvre the boss and his carefully engineered system. Music became an important means of expression and communication. Ideas, news and comments that could not be spoken, could be sung."[11]

A key theme in the slave experience is that of resistance to oppression. Theresa Lowe-Ching, a Caribbean theologian, speaks to this same reality as she discusses the dynamic of imperialism in the region. "Imperialism of the spirit is the most final and fatal subjection any people could experience. This imperialism has done and is still doing its work among us. Yet it has not completely conquered. The human spirit in the quest for wholeness bounces back in myriad ways. In the Caribbean, the search of the human spirit for freedom, wholeness and authenticity has expressed itself in various ways."[12] The Jamaican Mennonite lively choruses function as a powerful example of this type of resistive expression.

Diane Stewart, in her identification and discussion of six ritual practices in African and African-derived religions in Jamaica, notes that "at a fundamental and practical level, individuals engage in these sacraments to address problems and crises that impede wellness and abundant life."[13] Finally, Hilary Beckles, in her essay on slavery in the Caribbean, emphasizes the central role of music and dance as a response within the slave experience. She highlights the multiple functions of this music and dance when she notes that "the linkages of these cultural encounters, . . . represented much more than the passionate pursuit of pleasure; they were encoded with noises of spiritual ideological liberation and invoked the voices of cosmological redemption."[14]

After emancipation in 1838, British colonial realities and dynamics continued in force. Lartey's observation regarding colonial influence and the ensuing response is germane.

> Colonial "subjects" have well and truly become post-colonial agents, writing, creating and healing their own realities and challenging the expertise of the

> foreign experts. Pastoral caregivers need to increasingly recognize the ability of local contextual therapists . . . NOT AS EXOTIC "OTHERS" but as authentic "others" whose practices can offer help where western techniques might not.[15]

The Jamaican Mennonite lively choruses serve as one form of local contextual therapy as these Jamaican Christians respond to a long history of slavery and colonialism.

The current Jamaican reality of challenging economic and social structures is also relevant to the singing of lively choruses. Although there is no longer an official slavery, one could argue that unofficial forms of slavery still exist in the Jamaican experience. Jamaicans do not live in the hopeless poverty of some other nations, but rather are teased by the first fruits of a functional capitalism. However, such factors as a lack of uniting vision and lack of effective leadership make progress extremely difficult. Although the slavery is no longer physical, it has its contemporary economic, social, and psychological legacies.

THE JAMAICA MENNONITE CHURCH

The Jamaica Mennonite Church (currently twelve congregations with about 700 members total) had its beginnings in 1955 with the establishment of the Good Tidings Mennonite Church in the capital city of Kingston.[16] In 1954 a middle-aged Canadian Mennonite couple moved to Kingston with an interest in establishing a Mennonite presence on the island. With the eventual support of the Virginia Mennonite Board of Missions, this couple, along with several others, started the Good Tidings congregation on Whitehall Avenue in Kingston. In the early years, the leadership of Jamaican Mennonite congregations was shared by missionary personnel from the United States and native Jamaicans. Over time, leadership for the congregations has turned totally to the indigenous population and the missionary presence has decreased considerably.

Three congregations are in the St. Elizabeth parish on the south coast. One congregation is in Mandeville in the Manchester parish. Another congregation is at Salters Hill, high in the mountains above Montego Bay in the St. James parish. Two congregations are located in and around the tourist destination of Ocho Rios. The final five churches may be found in and around the capital city of Kingston. These twelve congregations provide a rich and lively expression of Christianity characterized by a warm and vibrant faith. While resource poor by many standards, these congregations extend warm hospitality and are filled with committed and visionary young people. In the life of the churches there is a clear willingness to use the gifts of children, youth, and women in addition to those of the typically male

pastoral leadership. However, it is also important to note that in recent years two women have assumed pastoral roles in two of the churches.

RESEARCH METHODOLOGY

Over the course of my year in Jamaica my daughter and I committed forty lively choruses to writing. We then gave the forty choruses to Datene Cornwall, worship leader at Retrieve Mennonite Church in the St. Elizabeth parish and an accomplished musician, for her correction of any mistakes in the lyrics. In addition to making a few corrections, she also added three additional lively choruses to our list of forty for a total of forty-three lively choruses, which became the data for the research study. Each lively chorus has been given a title (often the first words of the chorus). The entire collection was alphabetized by title and numbered.

Robert Henry, pastor in the Jamaica Mennonite context for more than thirty years, provided some historical context to the singing of these choruses. From his perspective, the singing of the choruses has been a part of the Jamaica Mennonite worship scene for as long as he has been associated with the Jamaica Mennonite churches (thirty plus years). It is his sense that most of the choruses are native to the Jamaican context with many of them having roots in the pre-1838 slavery period.

In analyzing the lively choruses, I have applied the grounded theory methodology of Anselm Strauss and Juliet Corbin. I developed two forms, a concept development work sheet and a category development work sheet, to record the open, axial, and selective coding required by the grounded theory methodology.[17] I then pilot tested these two grounded theory work sheets with my Psychology of Religious Experience class (spring 2003) at Eastern Mennonite Seminary. In that class we also viewed and analyzed the two worship videos. Further, I tested the students' familiarity with the lyrics of the lively choruses. Fourteen of the forty-three choruses were familiar to at least one person in the class. Nevertheless, twenty-nine of the choruses were not familiar to anyone in the class, indicating a significant corpus of probable Jamaican music available for further analysis. A Mennonite musician quite familiar with praise songs in the United States identified one additional chorus with which he is familiar in the North American context. Hence, it appears that twenty-eight of the forty-three lively choruses do not originate in the United States. However, this does not eliminate the possibility that several choruses may have origins elsewhere, such as in the British context, especially given the long historical connections between Jamaica and Britain.

I then applied the grounded theory methodology to eight of the choruses which were chosen randomly from the list of forty-three lively choruses. It was fortunate that seven of the eight choruses randomly chosen appear to

be original to the Jamaican context.[18] Following the grounded theory analysis, I developed the following thesis with respect to Jamaican Mennonite lively choruses:

Jamaican Mennonite Christian experience involves an:

- immediate
- total, and
- embodied

relational dance with God ("gestalt" faith) which

- recognizes God's saving actions in the past (minor note),
- transforms one in the present moment (major emphasis), and
- sustains one's longings for a personal faith experience and Christian community into the future (major emphasis).

This relational dance responds to the legacy of slavery and colonialism as well as to the challenges posed by contemporary social and economic realities in Jamaica.

To support this thesis, I will offer a thorough reflection on six of these choruses. If one simply counts the number of references to the various components of the thesis explicated above, one lively chorus emerges above the rest. It is with this lively chorus that we begin.

We Need to Hear from You
We need to hear from you
We want a word from you
If we don't hear from you,
what will we do?
One thing you move each day
to show us your perfect way
There is no other way
that we can live.

This chorus is characteristic of the *relational dance* which exists between God and the worshipping community in Jamaican lively choruses. The gathered community ("we") addresses God with the plaintive request "We need to hear from you." This communal theme connects well with Marilyn Rouse's observation in her discussion of Jamaican folk music that "in West and Central Africa, participation in musical performances by the entire community is the norm."[19] Not only is there a need, but the community desires ("wants") a word from God. "A word" is open to interpretation. It could literally mean one word. The word could be spoken or written. Given the predominant oral culture, it is likely the word expected here is oral. The first line, "we need to hear from you," also supports this interpretation. "A word" limits the message. The community is not asking for a detailed theological discourse or

communication. It simply desires "a word," which likely means a clear, succinct message. This message implies contact, connection, and relationship. One word is sufficient. This clear, succinct message guarantees that the relationship with God is intact. Barry Chevannes, in his reflection on African-Caribbean religion, observes that "African-Caribbean peoples place a greater emphasis on the experience of God as a normal part of human life than they place on dogma."[20] In this regard, I sense that the content of the message is less important than the actual communication experience itself. The communication of "a word" is a sign that the relationship with God is intact and alive. The word is desired "here and now." The "here and now" theme in these choruses leads me to name the relational dance as a "gestalt faith"—a faith that emphasizes the immediacy of the relationship and reality of faith. However, if the "word" is absent and there is silence, then the relationship with God is called into question. Such silence implies a potential crisis for the community which is expressing its need.

The third and fourth lines of the chorus ("If we don't hear from you, what will we do?") are in the form of a question. It is rare in the discourse of the lively choruses to have a question voiced. Hence, we must pay special attention to the appearance of this question. The singers are implying that, if they do not hear from God, they will not know what to do. Silence from God will lead to lack of direction, confusion, and perhaps even chaos. Silence represents a crisis. In Jamaican culture communication is desired, even if it is negative. Thus, any communication is preferable to silence. In some strange way, it may be that the master-slave relationship is reframed and redeemed in this question. The community desires to hear from the master (God), so that it (the Christian "slave" community) might respond in obedience.

The singers quickly move from the questioning mode to a mode of affirmation. To God, they say "one thing you move each day." "One thing" implies a unitary phenomenon and a clear focus. That one special thing is that God "moves" each day. There are various meanings that can apply to this movement: (1) movement as action—God is a physical, active God, (2) movement as a change in location—this meaning is consistent with Orlando Patterson's focus on "quashee" in his treatment of the sociology of slavery, namely, the idea that the slaves had power by keeping the master off guard with deception, intrigue, and sleight of hand.[21] Is there a way in which God keeps the Christian off-balance by moving and, in so doing, stays in relationship with humanity?, (3) movement as dance—this possibility picks up the theme of movement and dance in Jamaican culture. Taken literally in this song, God moves and, therefore, the community knows how to move in response. The equation is: God moves + the community moves = the Christian dance. God leads, the community follows. This is the ultimate call and response style which is characteristic in slave communities. It is also important to note that God moves each day (consistent and lasting movement by God). Why does

God move? Perhaps God's movement shows the community God's perfect way. God's dance step is revelatory. And it is no small revelation, but rather "the perfect way." God shows the community the exact right step to take in response. Using this imagery, the fear is that God will not dance (move) and, therefore, the community will not know how to respond.

The chorus ends with a sobering statement—"there is no other way we can live." There is no alternative to God's moving in a revelatory way. By God's movement, the community lives. "To live" has the potential for dual meaning. One, it can mean simply to go about life making right choices and engaging in right behavior. Two, it can refer to survival. Both meanings make sense in the Jamaican context. The community needs to hear from God in order to know what to do. But at an even deeper level, the community needs to hear from God in order to survive. This survival theme is pervasive in Jamaican culture. It was a reality in the slave days and it is a reality for many in the contemporary setting. Bob Marley's classic line "Emancipate yourselves from mental slavery" likely refers to the survival mentality which holds back Jamaicans from moving on to a better life. That backdrop gives credence to the first meaning as the more healthy for the singers in the community. However, the second meaning is not without import. Jamaicans experience a sense of accomplishment by simply surviving.

The three dimensions of the relational dance (immediate, total, and embodied) are present in this lively chorus. The theme of *immediacy* is implicit in this chorus. The worshipping community desires to hear a clear word from God. This word, though it is unitary and focused, is also *total* or *comprehensive*. The question "If we don't hear from you, what will we do" implies that either there is this clear word from God or else there is a sense of confusion and being lost. Finally, the *embodiment* in this chorus picks up on a persistent theme in most of the choruses, namely that the embodiment of the relational dance has a strong sensory component. In this chorus the auditory ("We need to hear from you") and the visual ("to show us your perfect way") are present. While I could interpret each of these lines in a figurative sense, the Jamaican context would beg for a more concrete and earthy interpretation. The "hearing" needs to be a literal hearing and the "showing" needs to be clear and directive. The lines of this chorus heard in the context of many other choruses point to this concrete and embodied interpretation. In this regard, Chevannes observes that "African-Caribbean peoples place a great value on the integrity of body, mind, and spirit. The experience of God, they maintain, cannot be limited to the mind, but must also move body and spirit. Many observers, past and present, note the emotional character of African-Caribbean religious worship, but fail to grasp its philosophical foundation."[22]

Although most Jamaican lively choruses have a strong present tense reality about them, there is also often a theme of *longing* which points to the

future. In that regard, this chorus is no exception. In fact, the chorus begins with longing ("We need to hear from you, we want a word from you"). Lines three and four (offering the poignant question "If we don't hear from you, what will we do?") reiterate this powerful sense of longing. Both Marilyn Rouse[23] and Howard Gregory[24] note a melancholic longing in historical and contemporary Jamaican music.

This chorus, like many others, uses the first person plural "we" rather than the first person singular "I." The singing of the lively choruses is clearly a communal experience and the relational dance, though it may have personal and intimate components, is ultimately also a communal dance. It is the community in relationship with God, not just solitary individuals. This theme fits well with classical Mennonite Anabaptist theology which stresses the importance of the Christian community for living out the Christian faith. The Mennonite Anabaptist emphasis on "discipleship" or following Jesus daily in life is best practiced in a communal, rather than solitary, context.

Another theme found in many of the lively choruses, *movement*, is present in this chorus. In fact, the central affirmation in this chorus is found in the lines ("One thing you move each day to show us your perfect way"). The relational dance begins with God's movement, which prompts and guides the communal response from the worshipping community. This relational dance is literally embodied by many worshippers with movement or dance as the words of these and other choruses are sung.

A final theme highlighting the *tension* inherent in the faith of Jamaican Mennonite Christians is present in this chorus. A clear affirmation of faith ("One thing you move each day") and a clear question ("If we don't hear from you, what will we do?") are juxtaposed in this short chorus of eight lines. There is a sense in which the relational dance with God has a strong tensive character. I can, at the same time, clearly affirm faith while holding out a basic and fundamental question about God's possible silence.

Enter My Chamber
Enter my chamber, be free Holy Spirit
Speak to me gently as I close the door
Heaven beloved, let Thy presence cover
Shekinah unending is all I long for

This short chorus is highly personal and invitational in nature. The *relational dance* in this chorus begins with the solitary individual extending an invitation to the Holy Spirit to enter the individual's chamber. The word "chamber" may allude to at least three things: (1) the heart (chambers of the heart), (2) a sense of void (need), that is, a hollow or cavity, or (3) there may also be a sense of the whole body as a chamber. In fact, the heart sometimes represents the whole body. Once the Holy Spirit enters the chamber,

the Spirit is to speak (*sensory*) gently "as I close the door." The dance begins with an invitation from the individual to the Holy Spirit. The Holy Spirit responds by entering the individual's chamber, connoting the intense intimacy and *immediacy* of this relationship.

The second line of the chorus ("Speak to me gently as I close the door") contains clear intimate, if not sexual, allusions. The words "Speak to me gently," which again are at the invitation of the worshipper, connote the language of love. Note that this longed-for gentle speech is in sharp contrast to the harsh speech of a slave owner or the harsh realities of contemporary Jamaican life. The words "As I close the door" create the private space for intimate encounter. Once again, the initiative to close the door is that of the worshipper, not the Holy Spirit. This chorus has a clear emphasis on the importance of the worshipper creating space for the relationship with the Spirit. So, this relational dance is indeed a collaborative affair.

This chorus also contains a strong sense of the protective element of the relationship with the divine. Although the worshipper closes the door, it is the "Heaven beloved" who provides the cover of protective presence. In the slave experience, such a chamber of protection would have been highly valued. In contemporary Jamaican society, privacy is a relatively rare commodity. Given the tropical climate, many homes are characterized by an open and interactive relationship with public reality. Especially in the rural areas of Jamaica, doors and windows of houses are simply open spaces often fronting on to public space in the form of a road or path. In this context then, a religious experience and encounter with the Holy Spirit serves as a welcomed intimate, private experience.

Presence is what is desired in this song—presence of the Holy Spirit. This presence is characterized by immediate intimacy portrayed by the chamber language and the language of loving intimacy. The final line uses the term "shekinah," which is "the word used in the Targums and rabbinic writings as a circumlocution to express the reverent nearness of God to his people."[25] This unusual technical reference in a lively chorus should not be passed over lightly. First, the concept of "shekinah" captures well all three dimensions of the relational dance with God (immediacy, totality, and embodiment). In fact, for months I had heard the final line of this chorus as it was being sung as "Shaking unending is all I long for." The intimacy and powerful immediacy of the chorus led me to believe that it literally climaxed in a sexually charged ecstatic relationship with the Spirit. It was only the corrective of Datene Cornwall which alerted me to my error in hearing. However, I continue to assert that this chorus is indeed about an intense and intimate relationship with the Spirit. All of the language and imagery leading up to the final line support this contention.

It is also of great interest that "shekinah" is a term of circumlocution. Circumlocution refers to a communication which is round-about or

evasive in some manner. This pattern of speech and music is characteristic of the folk music of Jamaica, much of which has its origins in the periods of slavery and colonialism in Jamaica. Lewin refers to this nuanced form of communication in her discussion of Jamaican work songs when she notes that "a song about birds sung vigorously in chorus had nothing to do with birds. It actually "threw words" at various people with whom the workers had to cope."[26] In general, Lewin notes that "under the surface, this music also helped workers to communicate and protest against the system that enmeshed them, without arousing the master's suspicion or antagonism."[27] With this historical precedent, it should come as no surprise that a technical reference to circumlocution appears in a Jamaican lively chorus.

The final words of the chorus ("all I long for") pick up both the theme of *totality* and the emphasis on *longing*. The intimate experience of "shekinah" is all the worshipper longs for in this relationship. In essence, this is the sole desire of the worshipper's heart. And, indeed, it is a longing which the worshipper hopes will be realized in the relationship with the Holy Spirit. The recurring tension between realized experience and longed-for experience is once again present in the lively chorus.

There is in this chorus a clear sense of *embodiment*. The concrete imagery of a private chamber, closing doors, covering presence, and the experience of shekinah all point to an embodied relationship. As has been noted, this chorus can easily be interpreted using sexual imagery. That sexual imagery is immediate, total, and truly embodied in the relationship which takes place behind closed doors.

Returning to the first line of the chorus, it is important to observe that the theme of freedom is present in the phrase "be free Holy Spirit." Although, in fact, the longing for freedom is likely that of the worshipper, once again the dynamic of circumlocution may be at work. The invitation for the Holy Spirit to be free is indirectly an expression of the longing of the worshipper to be free. These words in the ears of the slave master would likely not have raised concern. For it is the Holy Spirit who is free, not the worshipper. But, in reality, the relational dance with the Spirit leads to a certain kind of freedom for the worshipper.

He is Here
He is here, alleluia
He is here, amen
He is here, holy, holy
I will bless His name again
He is here, listen closely
Hear him calling out your name
He is here, you can touch him
You will never be the same.

This chorus is yet another rendition of the *relational dance* between God and the worshipper. God's immediate presence leads to a response of human praise. God in turn calls out the name of the worshipper. Although this chorus alternates between propositional statements and experience, the propositional statements are about the religious experience itself. It begins with the affirmation that God is here. This *immediacy* (presence) then evokes praise in a number of forms ("alleluia," "amen," "holy, holy"). The opposite experience, distance or absence, is troubling given the Jamaican history of slavery where distancing from and absence of family members might be the day-to-day experience of the slave. It was also the case that slave owners in Jamaica were often absentee and thus the plantations were under the leadership of managers hired by the absentee owners who often did not have the best interests of the slaves or owners in mind.

Because of the immediate presence of God ("He is here"), the singer commits to blessing the name of God again. The word "again" implies that this praise has occurred in the past. Then the singer admonishes his/her fellow worshipper to listen closely for God's voice ("He is here, listen closely"). It is intriguing to think about the choice of words in this chorus. A more literal phrase might be to "listen carefully" for God. But, no, the worshipper is admonishing others to listen closely. If I do listen closely, I will hear God calling out my name (another form of *immediacy*, a personal relationship in which I am called by name). The use of the word "closely" implies immediacy in two ways: (1) it means to listen carefully for what God has to say, and (2) the word itself (root "close") implies immediacy. "Calling out one's name" evokes images of a family where the parental figure calls for the child. This imagery is especially powerful given the absence of the father or a father figure in many Jamaican families.[28] Implied in this chorus is the importance of listening. It is offensive not to listen to someone in Jamaican culture. As part of our orientation for our year of service in Jamaica, the female members of our family were instructed not to ignore male sexual harassment, but rather to respond directly to the harasser by addressing him and setting clear boundaries. In the Jamaican context, to ignore a speaker is an insult and has the potential to provoke an angry response. If this dynamic is present in human relationships, what divine wrath might one incur for failing to listen to God?

There is also an interesting *relational dance* regarding the concept of naming in this chorus. The singer promises to bless God's name and, in turn, the singer can hear God calling out his very own name. There is a form of "naming mutuality" in this chorus which parallels the relational dance of the worshipper with God.

The fifth and final affirmation in the chorus, that God is present, is immediately followed with the promise that one can touch him. This tactile imagery is a form of *embodiment* of the relationship with the divine. This is

a real, literal experience of touching God. When we speak of God touching our lives, we often interpret that figuratively, namely, God changes us in some way. It is difficult to think about the invitation to touch God in a figurative sense. Literally, the chorus implies that God is within arm's length and can be touched. This here-and-now experience leads to a lasting transformation ("you will never be the same"). The change is *total* and *comprehensive*. Hence, the chorus affirms the powerful, transforming quality of this immediate relationship with God. It is interesting to note that this strong affirmation follows the use of tactile imagery not auditory imagery. Hearing God can be and often is interpreted figuratively. However, when the worshipper him/herself reaches out and touches God, there is much more a literal sense of connection. In fact, the notion of reaching out and touching God figuratively is a bit of a conundrum.

Finally, the last line of the chorus has a clearly plaintive sense of finality to it. If, and the "if" is substantial, the worshipper literally reaches out and touches the immediately present God, that person will never be the same. This is an example of at least a partially realized eschatology. But what if that immediate presence has not and is not being touched? Then the worshipper is truly in a state of *longing* for this intimate and fulfilling relationship with God.

Send Down the Rain
Send down the rain
Send down the rain
Send down the gospel rain (x2)
It's coming down, down, down
It's coming down
When the glory of the Lord is coming down
Then the saints begin to pray
And the Lord shall have His way
When the glory of the Lord is coming down.

This chorus is delivered in the classical call and response style. It begins with the singer asking (commanding) God to send down the rain (the gospel rain). This request implies a period of spiritual drought (perhaps both personal and collective). The imagery of drought and rain mirrors the Jamaican climate where there are alternating periods of drought followed by copious amounts of rain. A classical cosmology is at work here with God located in the heavens above. Although the rain in this chorus is understood figuratively, one cannot escape the sense of truly being drenched just as one would in a rain storm (*embodiment*). The experience of being drenched is primarily a tactile experience. One's skin is soaked during a downpour. It is this sense of immersion in the water which enlivens this particular chorus. In addition, it is a whole body experience (*total; compre-*

hensive) that is being described here. The gospel rain washes over the entire body of the singer. The repetition of the request highlights its urgency. *Immediacy* is a strong theme in this chorus as the expected rain is desired here and now.

The second part of the chorus is the response that comes in the form of the realized gospel rain ("It's coming down, down, down, It's coming down"). The powerful repetition in this section of the word "down" implies that the gospel rain storm is characterized by impact, duration, and finality. The rain is present (*immediacy*) and it is efficacious. It is not just a gospel shower but a driving and consuming rain (*total; comprehensive*) which relieves the spiritual drought of the singer. However, I could also interpret the "coming down" in a future sense, namely, this is a statement of faith about the hope in a coming rain. This interesting tension between promise and fulfillment in some ways characterizes the Jamaican experience. There is a powerful lived experience of faith, but it is does not always issue forth in substantial day-to-day changes in the lived reality. For example, the typical Jamaican is not removed from the daily experience of poverty but rather persists and survives in that context.

The "gospel rain" is further defined with the term "the glory of the Lord." This further explication of the "gospel rain" confirms the earlier sense that this rain is all-consuming. "Glory" implies power, impact, and immersion. The glory of the Lord is an immediate and future difference-maker. The immediate difference seems to be more perceptual with the hope of concrete change in the future.

Two realities issue forth from the "coming down" of the gospel rain: (1) the saints begin to pray, and (2) the Lord will have His way. Note that it is the saints (plural) rather than a saint (singular) who respond to the gospel rain. This highlights again the *communal* dimension of the Jamaican Mennonite's faith. The saints' lived faith response is illustrated by the practice of prayer. It is interesting to note that the saints will *begin* to pray, which implies some lack in the past practice of the faith community. The ideal of the Lord having His way reminds us of the phrase in the Lord's Prayer "Thy kingdom come." The emphasis on "coming" in this chorus and the lodging of the way/kingdom with the Lord are two common elements which make this comparison viable.

Embedded in the call and response style of this chorus is the *relational dance* which has characterized each of the choruses we have examined. When God acts ("when the glory of the Lord is coming down"), the Christian community responds with prayer ("when the saints begin to pray"). God has the final move in the relational dance by having God's way.

Returning to the opening lines of the chorus, I would be remiss in failing to note the sense of *longing* in this chorus. The plea to "send down the rain" is repeated again and again. The singers are longing for an immediate, total,

and embodied experience with the divine. One way that the community can work toward this end is simply to implore God for that experience.

> I Feel Like Running
> I feel like running, skipping, praise the Lord
> For what He hath done for me
> He hath set my spirit free
> I feel like running, skipping, praise the Lord
> For what He hath done for me.

"I Feel Like Running" literally plays out the Jamaican emphasis on use of the whole body (*totality* and *embodiment*). It is a lively chorus in which the singer literally runs in place, skips in place, and waves his/her arms with each singing of the line "I feel like running, skipping, praise the Lord." The phrase "feel like" emphasizes the affective root and experience of this chorus. It is the Lord who is being praised in this song for "what he hath done for me." The chorus is quite personal and individual. God has acted in the past on the singer's behalf which evokes a here-and-now response (*immediacy*), which involves not only one's voice, but one's entire body. The physical motions of this chorus represent a dance. It is a dance which incorporates in one line three distinct movements (running, skipping, and waving one's hands). It is instructive to note that the bodily actions of running and skipping are intimately connected to praise of the Lord. In mainstream North American Mennonitism the tendency is to associate praise only with the use of one's voice. As someone has said, it is worship "from the neck up." In contrast, in the singing of this chorus the worshipper uses her or his entire body. Because of the rapid pace of this chorus, its singing in fact is a form of aerobic exercise.

Finally, with regard to the *movement* associated with this song, it is helpful to observe that while the singer is active, her or his running and skipping is done in place, that is, the singer does not move from a given location. This active, but immobile, movement symbolizes a typical Jamaican life experience, namely, an active life but one which does not issue in much change, particularly for the better. Hence, this chorus functions in a way as a metaphor for the life of the Jamaican Mennonite. It addresses the dynamic of *freedom of movement* by embodying the reality that, even though one's life situation may not change dramatically for the better, one can be enlivened in her or his place (the running and skipping and waving of the arms in place). It is also interesting to note that this movement in place is indicative of at least two forms of Jamaican music: mento[29] and reggae.[30]

The *movement* of praise in this chorus results from God's action of setting the individual's spirit free (a form of *freedom*). It is important to note that it is the spirit, not the body or the daily life situation, which is set free. This dynamic reflects accurately the experience of slavery as well as that of the

contemporary Jamaican experience. This chorus, which both symbolizes and embodies the Jamaican experience, is powerful because it reflects the reality of the singer. In this regard, an academic colleague and I, both of whom had just returned from international Christian settings, were remarking about how we were moved by the clear language of piety in our respective international Christian settings, but put off by similar language in the North American context. We were struggling to understand this difference. I have identified at least two factors which may be at play: (1) congruency—The language of piety is congruent with the challenging daily experience of Jamaican Christians. This contrasts with the disconnect for middle- and upper-middle-class North Americans who sing praise songs in a context that associates that singing more with a form of self-centeredness. In the North American context our basic needs are met and our desires are indulged. To sing to God with thanksgiving for this experience rings a bit hollow. (2) the dynamic of power and control—North Americans sing praise songs in a way that implies their own power and control over their religious experience and life in general. Jamaican Mennonites, on the other hand, sing of an experience about which there is little to protect and control. It is a heartfelt expression of lived experience, not the desire to show piety and thus practice a form of one-upmanship. I am reminded of Jesus's words about practicing piety before others.

Move Satan
Move Satan move, mek mi pass
Move Satan move, mek mi pass
I am born again, saved and sanctified
Move Satan move, mek mi pass

This final selection is an intriguing chorus in which the singer (individual) commands Satan to get out of the way ("Move Satan move, mek mi pass"). It is the only song in the collection which uses explicit *patois*, the Jamaican dialect. The command is authoritative because the singer has been saved and sanctified ("I am born again, saved and sanctified"). The singer is clearly the authoritative subject in this song (an empowering place to be). The theme of *immediacy* is picked up in the very command to move, namely, if Satan weren't close or in the way, there would be no need for the command. The direct dialogue with Satan is of no small import. The singer could just as well implore God to move Satan out of the way. But the Jamaican propensity for bold and direct speech is evident here. Why use God as an intermediary when you can do the job yourself! This direct address of Satan is highly unusual in the discourse of Christian music. There are songs where the devil (Satan) is named in a song, but the direct address of Satan is not in the typical repertoire of the singer. I do find a similar dynamic in Jesus's comment to Peter in Mark 8:33, "Get behind me, Satan."

It is interesting to reflect on who Satan might be in this song. At least two possibilities emerge: (1) Satan is the devil. This would be a literal interpretation of the text. (2) Satan may represent any evil in the singer's experience. Furthermore, that evil seems to be characterized by the potential to restrict the singer's movement forward or through (*freedom of movement*). This imagery fits well with the slave experience where the slave is not only restricted in movement but is denied fundamental freedoms in a number of ways. In the contemporary Jamaican context, social and economic challenge may serve as the restricting reality. Therefore, the freedom of movement desired in this song is quite practical and embodied in the Jamaican context.

The singer is empowered in this chorus because she or he has experienced and continues to experience both salvation and sanctification (*relational dance*). The singer is not just saved, but also sanctified, that is, life has changed for the better in some significant way(s). The authority to command Satan puts one in a peer stance with none other than Jesus. This empowerment is a lasting one. It does not come and go. It is present at all times. The experience of being "born again" is both needed in the Jamaican experience and flies in the face of the persistent reality of death, a common reality in both the slave period and in contemporary experience. Death can be interpreted both literally and figuratively in this context. The bold empowerment in this song is also symbolized by the upbeat and bold manner in which this song is sung in the worship service.

The *movement* dynamic in this chorus can function as a form of dance. Consider what happens when a person runs into someone else in a hallway or other space which both intend to occupy. A dance occasionally ensues in which first one, then the other, tries to occupy the space. This dance sometimes goes on for several seconds in which both parties engage in "the dance step" of intending and not intending to occupy the desired space. While such an existential reality is at work in this chorus, the singer's dance step is that of an authoritative challenge of the evil one in whatever form that evil one assumes.

PASTORAL SIGNIFICANCE OF THE JAMAICAN MENNONITE LIVELY CHORUSES

My initial intuitive hunch that the singing of lively choruses was central to the Jamaican Mennonite experience has been borne out in the closer study of the lyrics of these choruses. Early on I sensed that these choruses functioned both as an articulation of the basic theology of Jamaican Mennonites as well as a form of pastoral care and support for Christians attempting to be faithful in daily challenging circumstances. As the study progressed, it became clear these choruses also serve as a form of resistance and protest

in the long history of slave music. Subtle and sometimes veiled expressions of protest against one's circumstances in life emerged time and again.

The singing of the lively choruses is first and foremost *a lived experience*. The choruses reflect lived reality both in the past and the present. There are clear strains of response to the lived reality of slavery in many of the choruses. Although slavery ended in 1838, the ensuing colonial realities as well as contemporary economic and social challenges form a rather seamless history of persistent challenge in daily life. It is in this context that the singing of the lively choruses functions as a response to the daily and persisting challenges many Jamaicans face.

Second, the singing of the lively choruses is a *communal lived experience*. These choruses are sung primarily as the church gathers. A frequently sung lively chorus ("Get Together in the Lord") embodies this communal dynamic at work. In fact, this chorus became the title for the first history of the Jamaica Mennonite Church.[31] As the lyrics of this chorus are sung in a typical Jamaican Mennonite worship service, worshippers move about the room exchanging infectious smiles, warm greetings, and all-consuming hugs and embraces.[32] Another Jamaican Mennonite Church practice which embodies this communal dimension is the annual conference gathering on the first weekend in March in a Kingston location. Friday and Saturday are typically dedicated to the business of the church. These sessions are attended primarily by pastors and congregational delegates. On Sunday morning, however, a large worship area is rented in the city and many of the 700 members of the various Jamaica Mennonite congregations throughout the island gather, at what for them is considerable expense, in order to spend the bulk of the day in worship together. It is a lively and celebratory event that encourages those who gather in the face of another year of challenging life experience.

Third, as has been noted throughout this essay, the singing of the Jamaican lively choruses is an *embodied sensory experience*. One cannot sing lively choruses with integrity without using one's body and one's senses. Movement and the response to restriction of movement in the slave experience and contemporary life are central themes in the choruses. Thus, when Jamaican Mennonites move their bodies, they are challenging their existential reality enlivened by their strong Christian faith. Swaying, clapping of hands, running in place, skipping in place, waving hands, and dancing are all forms of body movement utilized in the singing of the lively choruses. Of all the senses, tactile and auditory imagery is predominant. One's faith experience is heavily involved with both touch and hearing.

Fourth, the singing of lively choruses is an *identity-clarifying experience*. I have argued that the primary form for the clarification of identity can be understood as a relational dance between God and God's people. God acts, God's people respond, and God acts again. And the dance goes on. Of Wil-

liam Clebsch and Charles Jaekle's classical four modes of pastoral care, it is clear that healing and sustaining are predominant in the Jamaican Mennonite experience of the singing of the lively choruses.[33] The identity of the worshipper is that of a slave who is being set free. This liberating movement involves both the acts of God and the clear involvement of the worshippers.

Fifth, and finally, singing the lively choruses is fundamentally a *musical experience*. Of course, this is obvious, but it must be highlighted nevertheless. The central role of music in the Jamaican context is illustrated by a conversation I had with a Jamaican Mennonite woman near the end of our year in Jamaica. The middle-aged woman, a person of deep and lively faith, was sharing with me the challenges of the reality of abuse within many Jamaican families. She asked me with longing, "How do we deal with this issue in our churches? How do we get healing?" She went on to say that there was great silence in the churches about abuse. My response to her questions was something to the effect that healing would begin to come when individuals and churches began to talk about the reality. My response was based heavily on my Eurocentric therapeutic orientation in which healing comes by articulating the pain and working through it in some fashion. The woman responded, "That will never work in Jamaica." Not to be deterred my unvoiced question for her was "Then what will bring the healing?" The question which I articulated to her was more like this "How do you get healing in Jamaica?" Her quick and natural response was "We get healing in our music." It is in the spirit of this basic, but profound, insight that Jamaican Mennonites sing their lively choruses. Whether this insight is conscious and clearly articulated by most Jamaican Mennonites is beside the point. The point is that, in the singing of the lively choruses, Jamaican Mennonites dance with God in an immediate, comprehensive, and embodied fashion which leads to individual and communal healing and provides sustenance for the ongoing journey.[34] In that spirit, I close with the words of yet one more Jamaican lively chorus.

Press Along Saints
Press along saints, press along in God's own way
Press along saints, press along in God's own way
Persecution we must bear, trials and crosses in our way
Oh, the harder the battle, the sweeter the victory.

NOTES

The author made every effort to locate the copyright holders of the songs not in the public domain that are quoted in his chapter. If copyright information becomes available, the author has every intention of making appropriate acknowledgement of the lyrics' sources and paying remuneration.

1. The author spent ten months from August 2001 until July 2002 in Jamaica on a sabbatical assignment providing leadership development to Jamaica Mennonite churches. During this time, the author was able to visit and worship with all twelve Jamaica Mennonite churches at least two or three times per congregation.

2. At no time during the year in Jamaica did I see evidence that any of these lively choruses had been previously committed to writing. They are part of the oral tradition of this worshipping community.

3. Diane J. Austin-Broos, *Jamaica Genesis: Religion and the Politics of Moral Orders* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1997), 7.

4. Austin-Broos, *Jamaica Genesis*, 256.

5. Emmanuel Y. Lartey, "Global Views for Pastoral Care and Counseling: Postmodern, Post-colonial, Post-Christian, Post-human, Post-pastoral," 2001, www.icpcc.net (accessed May 31, 2006).

6. Anselm L. Strauss and Juliet M. Corbin, *Basics of Qualitative Research: Techniques and Procedures for Developing Grounded Theory* (Newbury Park, Calif.: Sage Publications, 1998), 105.

7. Dana F. Kellerman, *New Webster's Dictionary of the English Language* (New York: Delair Publishing Company, 1981), 178.

8. The author filmed major portions of two Jamaican Mennonite worship services in June 2002, capturing the essence of the singing of lively choruses in the context of the larger worship service.

9. Christopher P. Baker, *Jamaica* (Hawthorn, Vic., Australia: Lonely Planet Publications, 2000), 15–31.

10. Michael Burnett, *Jamaican Music* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 1982), 31.

11. Olive Lewin, *Rock It Come Over* (Kingston: University of the West Indies Press, 2000), 56.

12. Theresa Lowe-Ching, "Method in Caribbean Theology," in *Caribbean Theology: Preparing for the Challenges Ahead*, ed. Howard Gregory (Kingston: Canoe Press, University of West Indies, 1995), 24.

13. Dianne M. Stewart, *Three Eyes for the Journey: African Dimensions of the Jamaican Religious Experience* (New York: Oxford University Press, 2005), xv.

14. Hilary M. Beckles, "'War Dances': Slave Leisure and Anti-slavery in the British-colonised Caribbean," in *Working Slavery, Pricing Freedom: Perspectives from the Caribbean, Africa, and the African Diaspora*, ed. Verene A. Shepherd (New York: Palgrave, 2001), 223–24.

15. Lartey, "Global Views," 2001.

16. Twila Y. Brunk, *Together in the Lord: The Jamaica Mennonite Church, 1955–1980* (Harrisonburg: Virginia Mennonite Board of Missions, 1980), 7–15.

17. It is important to note that this particular research study is focused on only one dimension of the lively choruses, namely the written lyrics. Other dimensions of the music including rhythm, beat, harmony, and musical score are not being studied at this time.

18. However, it is important to note that lively choruses which have been borrowed from other contexts have likely survived in the Jamaican setting because they have significant meaning and/or utility for the worshipper.

19. Marilyn A. Rouse, *Jamaican Folk Music: A Synthesis of Many Cultures* (Lewiston, N.Y.: Edwin Mellen Press, 2000), 289–90.

20. Barry Chevannes, "Our Caribbean Reality (2)," in *Caribbean Theology: Preparing for the Challenges Ahead*, ed. Howard Gregory (Kingston: Canoe Press, University of West Indies, 1995), 67.

21. Orlando Patterson, *The Sociology of Slavery: An Analysis of the Origins, Development and Structure of Negro Slave Society in Jamaica* (Rutherford, N.J.: Fairleigh Dickinson University Press, 1967), 174–81.

22. Chevannes, "Our Caribbean Reality (2)," 67.

23. Rouse, *Jamaican Folk Music*, 17.

24. Howard Gregory, "Ministry Formation for the Caribbean," in *Caribbean Theology: Preparing for the Challenges Ahead*, ed. Howard Gregory (Kingston: Canoe Press, University of West Indies, 1995), 92.

25. Dale Moody, "Shekinah," in *The Interpreter's Dictionary of the Bible*, 4 vols., ed. George A. Buttrick (Nashville: Abingdon, 1962), 317.

26. Lewin, *Rock It*, 56.

27. Lewin, *Rock It*, 94.

28. Delores E. Smith and Robert A. Muenchen, "Gender and Age Variations in the Self-image of Jamaican Adolescents," *Adolescence*, vol. 30, no. 3 (1995): 645.

29. Lewin, *Rock It*, 106.

30. Burnett, *Jamaican Music*, 43.

31. Twila Y. Brunk, *Together in the Lord: The Mennonite Church, 1955–1980* (Harrisonburg: Virginia Mennonite Board of Missions, 1980).

32. One Jamaican Mennonite commented that warm hugs and embraces were unique to the worship service itself. In the daily lives of many worshippers there would typically not be such warm embraces with family members and friends. It is in the context of the gathered Christian community that the "getting together" is embodied.

33. William A. Clebsch and Charles R. Jaekle, *Pastoral Care in Historical Perspective* (Englewood Cliffs, N.J.: Prentice-Hall, 1964), 32–66.

34. This study has focused primarily on the lyrics of Jamaican Mennonite lively choruses and not the music itself. A focus on the music itself could merit yet another full-length study with additional perspectives and insights.

10

Pastoral Care and Counseling in Independent Evangelical Charismatic Churches in Ghana: A Barthian Theological Perspective

Esther E. Acolatse

INTRODUCTION

In most African[1] churches today, many people who suffer from a variety of human ills, whether of physical, psychological, relational, or spiritual origin, wander from one pastor to another seeking a spiritual cure. Because of the way cultural beliefs about the spiritual world have interwoven with their Christian belief, many African Christians live in bondage to their fears of evil spiritual powers. That is to say, traditional beliefs about witchcraft, evil spells, and demonic activity are interwoven with Christian practice in such a way that persons seek Christian pastors to deliver them from spiritual oppression. They see Jesus as a superior power to use against these malevolent spiritual forces. Pastoral problems are not diagnosed in a differentiated way to indicate a need for medical attention in one situation, psychological insight in another, relational skill in a third, and prayer in yet a fourth (or perhaps all or several of the above in any single situation). Rather, they consider all problems to be of a fundamentally spiritual nature and thus understand them precisely to need a strictly spiritual solution. Consequently, Christians are no different from the rest of African society, caught in never-ending battles with spiritual powers.

Spiritual warfare has become both the means and end of the Christian life. In their preoccupation with evil spiritual forces, many African Christians have inadvertently and subtly shifted the focus of the Christian life from gratitude for the salvation God has wrought in Jesus Christ to anxiety about all the necessary steps they need to take each day to ward off evil spiritual powers. The life of exuberant praise and victory over evil

spiritual forces demonstrated in communal worship seems to have little effect in private life. This chapter first offers a thick description of participant observation in several churches in Ghana, West Africa, churches of various ethnic varieties with influences from surrounding West African countries, particularly Nigeria. It focuses primarily on how the parishioners and pastors interact around pastoral diagnoses and care. It then interprets these findings from the perspectives of the parishioners and pastoral staff. Finally I discuss the findings and interpretations from a theological and psychological perspective, arguing that the lack of differentiation among causes of presenting problems as well as among the components of what constitutes the human being is by far the greater drawback to effective diagnoses and care in the African Independent Evangelical/Charismatic Churches (AIECC). I also offer suggestions for utilizing a psycho-theological paradigm for pastoral diagnoses and care that takes seriously cultural and theological contexts where the spiritual world characterizes common life.

THE CHURCH IN SUB-SAHARAN AFRICA: MAIN CHRISTIAN DENOMINATIONAL GROUPS

Today, African churches can be grouped under three broad umbrellas in order of their appearance on the Christian scene. First are the historic churches, sometimes called the missionary churches, because they were churches planted in the Lower Niger by the early missionary enterprises (mainly from Europe). There were Catholic missionaries in Central Africa from Portugal as early as 1458, but the first Protestant mission was not established until the arrival of the Moravian Brethren in the Cape in 1792.

However, the slavery emancipation act of 1833 was the springboard for the rich missionary work in Africa after centuries of failure due to bad weather and tropical diseases. This act allowed Africans to work beside white missionaries and to extend the work of the gospel because their knowledge of what motivated the African people was invaluable. Moreover, their physical constitution made it easier for them to withstand the tropics. Through the aid of Africans, the successful establishment of Christianity in Sierra Leone became the impetus for and created the possibility of spreading Christianity to all of Africa. A number of missionary societies targeted various places in Africa for the spread of Christianity. For instance, in May 1842 Andreas Riis led a recruiting mission to Jamaica "and from there the first batch of Christian colonists, twenty-four in all from Jamaica and Antigua, sailed for the Gold Coast"—present-day Ghana.[2] Thus began the first extensive missionary movement to Ghana. After Riis's efforts church planting began in earnest, spreading all over Ghana. The Bremen

missionaries followed and worked among the Ewes on the coast and the hinterlands of the Volta Region with the Presbyterian mission, extending into Togoland. The Methodists and Baptists were to follow shortly after, and the churches planted by these denominations, as well as the Roman Catholic and Anglican churches, are what have traditionally become known as the historic churches.

These historic churches founded by Western missionaries proclaimed a gospel clothed in Western garb with a worship experience that was foreign to the African. Like the Western churches, they laid emphasis on the verbal and cerebral aspects of worship rather than the more celebrative and symbolic approach with which the African was familiar.[3] In the historic or mission churches people tended to be Christians in name only; in times of crisis they fell back on the resources of the traditional religions. This is because the African found it difficult to connect on a deep level with the Western form of worship found in the historic or mission churches. Subsequently, groups began forming that eventually broke away from the historic churches. These break-aways, some as early as the early twentieth century, prepared the way for the emergence of the African Independent Churches (AIC). The acronym AIC also stands for different groups such as African Instituted Churches and African Initiated Churches, but all indicate that these churches were formed from African initiative.[4]

While some of these African Independent Churches came into being by separating from existing historic churches (like the Musama Disco Christo Church, which broke away from the Methodist Church of Ghana), others were founded in the emergence of Pentecostalism by men and women who felt the call of God. Through whatever avenue they came into existence, the African Independent Churches, as J. Pobee observes, are "a place to feel at home," and thus "represent an indigenizing movement in Christianity."[5] Right from their inception they incorporated a worship and liturgical style familiar to the African because they borrowed largely from African traditional religious rituals. But while adapting Christian liturgy and teaching to the African cosmology made it more relevant to the African on the one hand, it also reinforced "the strong preoccupations of Africans with fears of witchcraft," on the other.[6] The African Independent Churches often combined the resources of the Christian tradition and those of the African Traditional Religions, thus producing a form of syncretism.[7] Syncretism is the prevalent phenomenon all over the continent of Africa that takes the form of partial allegiance to both Christianity and African traditional religions, either blatantly or subtly.

The third set of churches in Ghana are the Independent Evangelical/Charismatic churches, which began to appear on the religious scene during the late 1960s when some more fundamentalist groups, discouraged by the lack of biblically based teaching in the historic churches, began to form

house-fellowships. Some of these fellowships turned into churches over time, and from the late 1980s to the present have experienced a surge in growth. These are mostly charismatic in doctrine and practice, and church services are often filled with displays of some gifts of the Holy Spirit, especially glossolalia. In addition to these new churches, there are prayer camps or retreat grounds, also following a similar format, where people go for prayers, and where the sick, the demonized, and the barren flock for deliverance. In spite of this plethora of religious and spiritual places, the hunger of the population for a meaningful life continues.[8]

The focus of my chapter is on this third group, the Independent Evangelical/Charismatic churches, which are mushrooming all over the continent. I studied the Independent Evangelical churches for two reasons. In the first place, though they are new on the Christian scene, they are growing more rapidly than the historic churches. In fact the historic churches lose members, especially the youth, to these churches at a significant rate. Their Western-style televangelist message coupled with contemporary Christian music and vigorous dancing all appeal to the youth. Many of the pastors of these churches, however, have little or no theological training. They believe that it is unnecessary to have formal theological training; in fact, for them formal theological training merely blocks the presence of the Holy Spirit in worship. While we may not dispute the possibility of the presence of the Holy Spirit in these churches, it seems that they equate exuberance and excitement with the presence of the Holy Spirit. Parishioners assume that since the Holy Spirit is present with them, then the words of the pastor or leader are from the Holy Spirit, and thus God. Because of this belief, how the pastor understands the problems of the people and the solutions he proffers are accepted as the absolute truth because they are assumed to come directly from the Holy Spirit.

In light of the fact that their largest audience is the youth of the country, we might say that the future of the church in Africa, as well as its theology, lies with these Independent Evangelical churches. Kwame Bediako astutely points out that while African Independent Churches had become a force to be reckoned with on the continent and were the pacesetters for African Christianity, "Academic orthodoxy was still far from recognizing that it was the independent churches which were in fact indicating the trend and direction of African Christianity."[9] That being the case, it is important to assess whether the theology and the pastoral ministry practiced in these churches are consonant with the witness of Scripture. These churches claim to adhere closely to the word of God and believe that their approach to pastoral counseling stems from the word of God. However, it remains to be seen whether perhaps the cosmology of African traditional religion has a greater influence on the practices of these churches than belief in the saving grace of Jesus Christ.

METHOD AND FIELD

Since I am focusing this chapter on a particular culture and intend to speak directly to that culture, it is relevant, therefore, to describe the people, their socio-economic background, as well as the religious ethos that guides day-to-day life. It is also useful to understand that there is no such thing as a homogeneous African group, but rather that within Africa, and in fact the various nations, reside different tribes grouped by language with variations in the language groups within each tribe, variations large enough to make one dialect group unintelligible to the others. Nevertheless, a commonality in religious ethos, deriving largely from African traditional religions and their peculiar *Weltanschauung,* allows for inferences to be made from one group to the other. While the participant observation described in this essay took place in churches and para-church organizations that utilize the four languages with which I am familiar, namely English, Ewe, Ga and Twi, what is said of their religious beliefs and influence on pastoral theology and ministry is not limited to them. Rather, what I say of their religious beliefs is representative of the beliefs of other groups in Ghana, at least in essence. We can make applications, therefore, from this model to pastoral care situations among the other groups in Africa.

THE FIELD

I conducted the field research in this project largely through the use of a questionnaire that I developed and filled out through face-to-face interviews with pastors, and also through participant observation at church services and special "deliverance" services. I also recorded several of the interviews for later transcription to allow me the opportunity to reflect on conversations with the pastors. I particularly concentrated on the mode and criteria that pastors used for selection of individuals for various types of counseling or for deliverance sessions. I interviewed about fifty pastors from various Protestant denominations. Of these, about 15 percent belonged to the mainline or historic churches, 75 percent belonged to the Independent Evangelical churches, including the Apostolic churches and the Assemblies of God, while the remaining 10 percent were from para-church organizations that provide a form of counseling as well as prayer and deliverance. The overtly syncretistic African Independent Churches were not part of the groups researched.[10] Interviewing a number of pastors from the historic churches, as well as participant observation at a predominantly African Independent Evangelical Charismatic Church in the United States, provided a basis for comparison and enabled me to ascertain whether the phenomenon under observation was limited to the focus group.

WORSHIP SERVICE IN THE AIEC CHURCHES

Worship at the churches visited often lasts about four hours. There is usually praise and worship. The former is based in loud and more rhythmic music, where worshippers clap and dance, and the latter has slower and more solemn music where worshipers are more somber and utilize minimal bodily movements beyond a raised hand. This aspect of the service could go on for about an hour. After that there is a time for congregational prayer, which entails each congregant praying loudly and intensely about their needs. The leader may be the minister for prayer who often walks the congregants through the prayer time by calling out what issues should be under consideration for prayer at particular times, giving appropriate intervals between topics for prayer. Movements during prayer include walking up and down; punching the air; and finger wagging as if warning something or someone. Some cry openly as they kneel in supplication. One comes away from such a scene with the feeling that members have an intimate relationship with God and with one another. Following the corporate prayers comes the sermon in the form of expository teaching on several verses in the Bible which are relevant to the particular theme under consideration. Usually these themes are a variation on the promises and blessings of Abraham which accrue to the believer through Jesus Christ:

> God is moving powerfully in our services. For the next few weeks there is going to be a great emphasis on Inheriting the Blessing of Abraham as distributed to the Sons of Jacob (Gen 49 and Deut 33). As Sons of God and Joint Heirs with our Lord Jesus Christ we have Full Access to all the Blessings of Abraham.[11]

The sermon or word or the usual terminology employed, "message," is followed by the pastoral prayer. It often includes a word of knowledge that gives the details of particular situations of persons in attendance at the services declared to the assembly. These revelations through the gift of prophetic utterance may be of blessings or forebodings that the person for whom it is intended should avoid through prayer and laying on of hands by the pastor and/or a special prophet brought in for prophetic ministrations. During such ministration where the pastor/prophet may ask people to come forward for anointing with oil and prayer with laying on of hands, people who are touched fall and may lie on the floor for a considerable amount of time before they return to their seats, sometimes with the aid of attendants who facilitate the event. In anticipation of such bodily responses as falling, attendants from the congregation are stationed behind those who have come forward for prayer and help ease their fall to the floor and cover the women up to avoid indecent exposure.

A peculiar feature of these prayer times is that persons may be told what ails them and prevents them from flourishing before prayer is said on their

behalf. Many times they are told that they have been bewitched through a meal they have shared with another person whom they know. Usually the type of food they consumed is mentioned. The effects of such witchcraft activity on their lives may range from poor finances which may affect all their family, to an inability to bear children. Those who in the course of ministration show more bodily agitation such as writhing on the floor are separated for further ministration which often includes exorcism of demonic powers and influence in their lives. In order that they may be offered further help, these people are invited to come later during the week for special prayers during which more extensive diagnosis is made.

PASTORAL DIAGNOSES AND INTERVENTIONS

My own interest lay in this later dimension of what constitutes the heart of pastoral care in the AIEC—how presenting problems are diagnosed and attended to by the pastor. Problems parishioners bring for counseling are of various types stemming from different sources. Consider the following scenarios that took place within hours of each other at one of the churches I visited.

A woman brought her eighteen-month-old son to be prayed for so the spirit of fear might leave him. The infant's aunt, who was a member of the church, had observed that the boy got startled rather easily and interpreted the cause as a spirit of fear. Another woman and her female relatives brought a young police officer who was paralyzed from "unknown causes." He seemed to be in a stupor most of the time. The family wanted prayer for healing for him because they believed he was bewitched. At the close of the service, one of the pastors called my attention to a young woman with an enlarged (probably cancerous) breast who had come for healing for what seemed to be an incurable disease. Two elderly ladies accompanied her. It is striking that all of these persons, with prolonged somatic symptoms, had come to a pastor for help. The previous day, several people, the majority of whom were women, had gathered together to pray and be prayed for. They gathered to stand together against the forces of evil that threatened to destroy their lives, work, and marriages and to declare their victory over their adversaries. The day's prayer time ended with a call from the pastor to "hoot at fear" and drive the spirit of fear out of their midst.[12]

In several other Independent Evangelical churches people waited to be counseled. Normally the pastor prayed with the people to find out the root causes of their problems through spiritual discernment. Pastors understood most physical manifestations, some similar to epileptic fits, others as innocuous as fidgeting, to be indications of possible demonic presence and/or activity. They saw the individual as either demon-possessed or demon-

oppressed. Such manifestations called for warfare praying[13] and deliverance; often there were trained groups of people for this form of prayer. They used prayer, especially deliverance prayer, to heal physically, psychically, and spiritually.

Most of the Independent Evangelical churches used very similar questions to determine whether parishioners' presenting issues were of demonic origins or not. These very detailed questions cover all areas of life from possible physical ailments through family history to present spiritual problems. I will explore the significance of some of these questions and the implications for therapy in the churches under focus to clarify the bases and sources of these questions. Such an analysis will also aid in explaining the theological concerns at stake in this examination.

INTERPRETING PASTORAL DIAGNOSTIC PRACTICES IN AIEC CHURCHES

To help me learn more about this process and the rationale behind it, I designed a questionnaire to gather information on how pastors diagnosed presenting problems in counseling situations. Paramount issues the questionnaire was designed to probe included what conceptual tools were available to the pastors engaged in pastoral counseling; what theological and theoretical stance, if any, informed their pastoral ministry to the people who sought counsel from them; and how their pastoral interventions were conceived and carried out.

A CULTURAL INTERPRETATION OF DIAGNOSTIC TOOL

The questions pastors addressed to the individual who comes for counseling fall into seven categories. Each of these categories is pertinent to understanding the reasons behind the ailments that are brought to the pastor for help. First are questions dealing with personal particulars. Questions in this category include the person's name and the meaning of the name; gender; age; marital status; hometown; religion or church affiliation; and whether or not the person has been "born again," and if so when. While some of the questions in this category may be for general information, in conversations with several pastors it became clear that some are geared toward eliciting information about possible spiritual forces at work in the life of the individual.

The meaning of one's name is important to determining the significance of the circumstances surrounding the counselee's birth. Most indigenous names carry meaning, and are normally derived from circumstances surrounding one's conception and birth, or even from events going on in the family; thus

the meaning of one's name holds clues to vital information about the individual as well as the family of origin. There are several names from all the tribes, for instance, that indicate the birth order of children within particular clans and what those names mean. But there are also peculiar names reserved for infants born after a series of miscarriages, stillbirths, or short-lived babies. The rationale behind these unusual names arises from the belief that those who keep returning to the womb to be reborn will be deterred from coming back to torment their poor mothers if they are given unpleasant names. Some of these names, however, contain subtle messages to the infant to stay and not depart. Often when a family loses several children in infancy, the parents might seek a diviner to intervene in the situation. Pastors believe that the intervention sought from a fetish shrine or diviner makes people vulnerable to attack from evil spiritual beings. The individuals seeking help may thus be suffering because of their past connection with shrines and fetish groves they or their forebears frequented, places where rituals were performed following revelations through divination. Since Christians presuppose that God opposes such practices, and that they are forbidden in Scripture, then visiting shrines and participating in such rituals are sinful, even idolatrous, acts for which God exacts punishment. Since such shrines and their rituals are of satanic origin (because they could not come from God who forbids it), Satan has a hold on whoever seeks help from these shrines. When such persons or their descendants become Christians, Satan's hold on them is not immediately or completely relinquished. African Christians see the struggles they go through, such as the loss of many children, lack of success in business, and other trials, as signs of the struggle for control of their lives between good and evil powers.

The questions about the counselee's hometown and religious affiliation deal with the presupposition that these could also be avenues for demonic influences. People believe certain towns and villages, for instance, to be strongholds of particular gods, and others to be populated with witches. Hailing from any of these places makes an individual an easy target for witches unless he or she guards constantly against such intrusions. In addition, several pastors reported that individuals who come to them from syncretistic churches, especially the ones in which worshipers are required to remove their footwear, often presented with symptoms of spiritual attacks.[14]

Church affiliation and whether or not the individual is "born again" are considered indicators of the counselee's spiritual state. The knowledge of the individual's spiritual state is vital for effective deliverance as well as preventing spiritual attacks from evil forces. If the individual is "born again," that is, has invited Christ into his heart, then there is less chance of attacks from evil forces. Existing idols/gods or ancestral stools[15] in his family provide avenues for harassment from evil spirits, as do his parents' affiliation with secret societies such the Society of Odd Fellows or Freemasons.

After a thorough interview following the very extensive questionnaire, the pastors determine whether the individual needs to have further sessions with the pastor or whether there is sufficient information to enter into deliverance prayer to first break the hold or influences of any demonic powers that may be holding the individual in bondage. After such prayer, which could go on for thirty minutes or more, the individual is then proclaimed free of the powers that hold him or her and enjoined to go home believing that the problem has been solved. If the prayer was for a breakthrough in their lives to allow blessings to come in, they are encouraged to be in prayer for at least three days following the intervention, in order to seal the victory that has been gained by the deliverance session.

The focus questions generally used for diagnosing issues brought for counseling had both depth and clarity. The emphasis of the questions was weighted toward the spiritual causes of the individuals' problems and paid little or no attention to possible psychological or somatic causes of the problems. There was no clear differentiation among the spiritual, psychological, and somatic causes of the presenting problems, and pastors directed intervention mainly toward the spiritual dimension of the problem and did not allow for the possibility of other sources or causes. This approach is based on the belief by the pastors that what affects the human being in any form first transpires in the spirit realm and affects the human being first at the level of the spirit and only later manifests in somatic symptoms. This understanding is not unlike the African traditional religious view of all reality. All reality is believed to exist first on a spiritual level, the earthly manifestation being a copy of what exists actually on the spiritual level. In fact, a person's life in this physical realm is what has already been lived on the spiritual level. Life on this level comes under constant attack by evil spiritual forces from the spirit realm. If a person has what is known as a strong spirit, *sunsum duro*, then attacks have minimal if any effect on the person. There are, however, means of strengthening one's spirit and making it "heavy" *duro* so that it is not carried away by the forces that seek one harm. One such means of strengthening one's spirit in the traditional religious belief is by wearing charms and amulets that are obtained from priests and priestesses of divinities or from witchdoctors noted for their ability to ward off attacks from particular types of evil spiritual forces and spells of witches.

That pastors work within these two frames of reference is demonstrated both in their approach to care as in adducing spiritual causes to the presenting problems, as well as exertion of physical power and language employed sometimes in exorcism. In several Ewe churches I visited, for example, the most common phrase to overpower a demon was "*me sagbedewo le Yesu nko me*": literally, "I bind up herbs and throw them at you in the name of Jesus." This phraseology replicates what occurs within traditional healing practice

where herbs, which are gathered by priests and priestesses or medicine men and women under the power of their divinities, are purified and sprinkled on the bodies or domiciles of the seekers for curative or protective purposes.[16] No doubt hearing such words recalls for both pastors and parishioners the powerful beliefs that they hold together about the ability of the "Name of Jesus" to overturn the evil spiritual forces that threaten lives, because they have both auditory and visual memories associated with such incantations. By means of the connection between their traditional religious worldview and their reading of Scriptures, they made meaning of what was occurring in their midst even if they did not use the biblical or theological terminology that academic practical theology would require.

In conversations with Pastor Paul on July 9, 2008, a few weeks following the prophetic service, he reported that the ministration had a positive effect on all those present and explained the need for the church to embrace this form of ministry. He emphasized the need to minister in this "prophetic" way to suffering people following the example of Jesus and the Apostles who not only healed publicly but named the precise sin and brokenness.[17] The purpose in naming these problems publicly is twofold. First it wakes faith in the believers; second it allows those to whom the word is directly spoken to be encouraged to believe and also to understand that their personal prayers may be "targeted to the proper problems" so that their prayers are not "a shot in the dark." In his words, "The prophetic word is seen as both a diagnostic tool as well as the solution to the problem."

Obviously the assumed Christian basis of the praxis in these churches cannot be denied without rejecting the deep mythological powers of large portions of the New Testament. At the same time, the stories of healing encountered therein are not questioned by the people who benefited from them and are often corroborated by others, even those who did not believe in Jesus. What is different in the "But" questions still remain to be explored, at least from an academic practical theological perspective—a discipline which by its nature allows contexts to speak to it as it also addresses and seeks to shape contexts of theological reflection and character. What, for example, happens to persons whose ailments are discerned in this public arena of worship as stemming from spiritual sources through association with families and friends and for whom the prophetic word discerned through prayer brings both relief and confusion? How, for instance, does the lady in an African church I attended in Durham, North Carolina, live among the fellowship of other African brothers and sisters when she had been diagnosed as possessing a python spirit? Further, what happens to the lady who is told in the same service that her womb has been sealed by her drinking peanut butter soup prepared by a close friend of hers? Or a couple whose younger son comes forward for prayer and is informed by the prophet that a spirit in their eldest son would destroy their younger son

unless they take precautions? Who cares for the fragmentation that might ensue in relationships among friends and family and, more important, how these people continue to live as full participants in the household of faith when they have been demonized? As a participant in the weekend prophetic ministration that day, I did not witness any further words or actions from the prophet or the pastor of the church to the effect that healing had been effected to some degree in the lives of these people whose ailments and the sources for them had been publicly shared. I wondered if more "wounding" than "healing" had occurred, not only for the persons singled out, so to speak, but for the whole church as well. Further, what happens when the "prophetic utterance" is not fulfilled according to the word of prophecy?[18] Finally, if the prophetic ministrations and attendant prayers which might entail exorcism are that effective in the lives of those who receive such ministry, how does one account for the incessant movement of people from one prayer house, church, or prophet to another?

PRACTICAL THEOLOGICAL READINGS AND INTERPRETATIONS

As described above, in most of these AIEC churches today, counseling seems to be based on a set of beliefs and practices that is inherited from the African Traditional Religion and blended with certain cosmological ideas from the Old and New Testaments that seem to give weight and authority to this way of looking at the world. If spiritual reality is ultimate and the universe is filled with spirits intending us harm, then the purpose of religion would be to fight off these dangerous spirits. Jesus would be a powerful god to help ward off these dangers. If human beings consist of body, soul, and spirit and are vulnerable to evil spiritual beings through their spirit, especially if they are not "born again" (implying that they do not belong to God), then the need for vigilance in doing the right thing is essential to well-being and for preventing attacks from the spirit world.

Many of these churches are led by pastors with little or no formal theological training or access to ministerial formation.[19] They believe that their giftedness and calling are sufficient for pastoral ministry and often proclaim in their messages the blunting effect of theological education on the power of the Holy Spirit in the lives of pastors of mainline denominations. Without adequate theological training, which would include biblical studies as well as some practical theology, pastors fall back on their own understanding of the biblical passages upon which they base their theology and pastoral intervention. They often take these passages literally and without the knowledge of the original background, or *Sitz im Leben*, of the passages, nor the intended meaning of the words in the original language. In these circumstances, theology based on such exegesis portrays less than the passages intended. The

theological and anthropological images derived from such readings of Scripture might not be the complete picture of God nor of human beings that the Scriptures intended. To give pastoral counsel and care to people based on such an understanding might not be helpful and at times may be dangerous. For instance, in the present Ghanaian context almost all problems brought to the pastor are addressed from a spiritual perspective based on the reading and understanding of certain Scriptures. If we can develop an argument on grounds that would be convincing to these churches—that the theology in sermon and pastoral practice currently being taught (i.e., evil cosmological forces have powers that extend beyond the lordship of Jesus Christ unless certain rituals are performed, and here rituals are the deliverance ministrations by qualified persons) in effect causes greater bondage to these very evil forces—then there might be a way to set the pastoral ministry on a more secure footing. But current pastoral practices seem to stem more from assumptions about the powers of these cosmological forces than from faith in Jesus Christ in the lives of baptized Christians.

CONSIDERATIONS OF THESE LIVED RELIGIOUS PRACTICES FROM A BARTHIAN PERSPECTIVE

Observations from these interviews with the pastors, as well as participant observation in several churches both in Ghana and the United States, led me to conclude that at the least, Ghanaian Christian anthropology needs a clearer differentiation among the components of the human being (e.g., physical, psychical, spiritual), as well as a more differentiated diagnostic tool for pastoral diagnoses and intervention. How may we bring African Christian theology in general and its anthropology more consistently into line with the gospel message of hope it seeks to expound without weighing it down by a cosmology that reinforces fear? How may a pastoral ministry derived from such theological anthropology serve to liberate people not only from bondages to fear, but also provide conceptual and diagnostic tools for pastoral intervention in crisis situations? Further, how may it help pastors move from acting in a crisis mode to developing enduring practices of care which allows congregants to care for themselves and each other?

The theology of Karl Barth has been helpful as I have pondered the magnitude of the theological and practical challenges facing the African church today. As I searched for substantive theological guidance on these complex issues, I turned to Barth for several reasons. First, African Christians (myself included) seek to understand themselves in the light of Scripture. They have a high view of the authority of Scripture and are convinced by preaching and teaching that is scripturally based. Karl Barth undertook his entire theological enterprise for the sake of preaching and teaching the scriptural witness.

Second, Barth has developed a way of relating and ordering theological issues with cultural issues that would be helpful to the African Christian in sorting through various strands of belief and practice. Which beliefs and practices are in accord with the New Testament witness and which are divergent? Is it possible to distinguish between a theological affirmation and how it is conveyed through cultural symbolic forms? Barth is helpful in making crucial distinctions between the gospel and the cosmologies that developed over time through the biblical era.

Third, Barth is a practical theologian par excellence. His theology is not speculative or esoteric, but is closely allied with the practice of the church. His discussion of the true nature of human beings, of human beings in the cosmos, and of the relation of the soul to the body, all have important implications for the practice of pastoral counseling in the African Church.

I now turn to an exploration of relevant facets of Barth's theological anthropology and the promise it holds for diagnoses and intervention in the Ghanaian and larger African pastoral context. In the next few pages, we will see how Barth's rejection of speculative philosophy can have a striking impact on the African apprehension of Christian theology, which in turn has profound implications for pastoral practice. We will also see how his understanding of the relationship between body and soul affects how we can differentiate, unify, and order pastoral theology in African practice. But first, we will explore the most troubling aspect of pastoral diagnosis and intervention—what seems to be an undue fascination with the demonic, and how to determine what is truly demonic and deal appropriately with it.

BARTH'S THEOLOGICAL ANTHROPOLOGY: ITS RELEVANCE FOR THE AFRICAN PASTORAL SCENE

According to Barth, a theological perspective is the proper starting point of anthropology. While the various anthropological approaches, such as cultural anthropology or social anthropology, have their value and contribute in important and diverse ways to our understanding of the human being, they are limited in one crucial respect. They do not offer us a picture of what Barth calls *wirkliche Mensch*, "real man." By "real man," Barth means Jesus Christ based on God's self-revelation, and by inference human beings as God sees them on account of this "real man." Barth's theological anthropology affirms the place of other bodies of knowledge in the understanding of human beings so far as they own that knowledge as limited and only partial. He is opposed to them when he sees them setting themselves up as having the capacity to show us the "real man." Barth writes,

> At this point we find ourselves in basic opposition to philosophy, but we are all the closer methodologically to the inductive sciences based on observation and inference. The latter are differentiated from theological science by the fact that their object and source of knowledge are neither identical with each other nor with the Word of God. The source of their knowledge lies in the process of observation and inference and therefore not in faith in the Word of God.[20]

For Barth, the hypothetical exact sciences and the speculative philosophies are based on facts and assumptions from a human perspective, rather than on faith in the word of God. When we acknowledge the subordinate place of these forms of knowledge about human beings and see them as additional information on aspects of human beings, they can contribute to theological knowledge. If, however, we set these bodies of knowledge above theological knowledge of human beings, they stand in opposition to the Christian confession. Barth distinguishes two types of anthropological knowledge which, though they usually merge, are yet distinct and therefore need to be approached differently. These are the speculative philosophies and the hypothetical sciences.

The speculative philosophies, which belong to the realm of worldview or cosmological theories, are often a combination of myth and philosophy. They sometimes take their point of departure from the exact sciences or from "pure self-intuition purporting to be axiomatic."[21] The sources of the exact sciences' knowledge are mainly observation and inference; thus they are preoccupied with the appearance of things, namely, the external person and not the "real man." The danger with the speculative philosophies is that they leave the moorings of hypothetical sciences and begin to propose their observations and inferences as worldviews. Rather than see what they offer as hypothetical, they go beyond their proper boundaries and offer intuition as fact. Like worldviews, these speculative philosophies thrive where the word of God has not taken root. Barth says that a speculative philosophy

> arises in the arid place—unspiritual in the biblical sense of "spirit"—where man has not yet heard the Word of God or hears it no longer. In this place man supposes that he can begin absolutely with himself, i.e., his own judgment, and then legitimately and necessarily push forward until he finally reaches an absolute synthesis, a system of truth exhaustive of reality as a whole. On this assumption he also and primarily thinks that he can know and analyse himself. . . . Anthropology on this basis is the doctrine of man in which man is confident that he can be both the teacher and the pupil of truth.[22]

Though humanity is always humanity in the cosmos, Barth does not give the cosmos or cosmology undue attention. He argues that the Bible itself does not regard cosmology as a distinct and independent concern worthy of separate attention. Scripture itself has no single cosmology, for while it employs several, it adopts none.[23] There is thus

> no world outlook which can be described as biblical, or even as Old Testament, or New Testament, or as prophetic or Pauline. There can be a welter of cosmological elements in the Bible deriving from the most diverse sources, and none of them is given in its totality, none is expounded as a doctrine, and none is made obligatory for faith.[24]

No particular cosmology is central to the Scriptures. Barth makes several pertinent points to uphold his argument. In the first place, the theme of Scripture is always humanity in the cosmos, and never the cosmos itself. Scripture, therefore, is free to employ any cosmology it sees fit for a particular illustration, but it is also free to set aside any or all cosmology. It is not wedded to any particular cosmology to make its point. The creation saga that depicts the unfolding of humanity's relationship with God, as well as with the rest of creation, is filled with various implicit worldviews. This may be true, but according to Barth, it does not mean that Scripture has one particular worldview. We simply receive the narratives from the perspective of various and sometimes differing worldviews. Nor does it mean that the Bible endorses a particular worldview. In fact, it warns us against being embroiled in worldviews because they can become our focus rather than Christ.[25] This being the case, the Bible can even be disloyal to any cosmology without detracting from its own central message. It can and does oscillate between and within worldviews while keeping its central theme in focus.

In arguing for recognition of the variety of cosmologies found in the Bible, Barth is not, however, making light of the import of the cosmos. He goes so far as to own that humanity as part of the cosmos "must remain loyal to the earth."[26] However, of greater importance is the understanding that humanity stands between heaven and earth and thus is equally bound and committed to both. Now, if heaven is the dwelling of God, then what heaven says of human beings holds greater sway than what Earth speaks regarding them. Barth writes, "We shall never truly understand him; and even less so if we forget that heaven is above him."[27] Again it is true that

> the New Testament has a "cosmic" character to the extent that its message of salvation relates to the man who is rooted in the cosmos, who is lost and ruined with the cosmos, and who is found and renewed by his Creator at the heart of the cosmos. In the present exposition we must not and will not be guilty of any failure to appreciate the significance of the cosmos, of any insulating of man from the realm of the non-human creation.[28]

We can thus affirm and applaud the place of the cosmos in the life of human beings, as long as the cosmos is placed in the right perspective with regard to human beings and their place in it, as those who live in a covenant relationship with God. Barth's concern is to understand the cosmos in a proper perspective, that is, not making it into something other than what it

was intended to be or according it undue attention. He argues against making a commitment to a particular view of the cosmos per se and interpreting all reality through that lens.

Since most pastors of these Independent Evangelical/Charismatic churches have little to no formal theological education, biblical exegesis is usually literal. They tend to view presenting problems as having only demonic causes which can be dealt with by God alone if one believes in faith healing. Furthermore, all demonic phenomena are explicated in a single dimensional way as if the demonic expresses itself in a uniform rather than a pluriform manner. This does not mean that demons are not real or personal. Personalization of evil in Paul's day and in the African worldview today might be problematic to modern minds. Modern understandings of evil tend to depersonalize and split evil into psychological complexes or sociological determinations.[29] However, it is not out of place to believe in the personalization of evil in our own time. It is not uncommon to come up against a situation or a person whose actions and being constitute something that we can only term evil. Documented evidence on exorcisms in the modern church indicates that we cannot discount reports of personal evil.[30] Barth himself views the demonic as both real and metaphorical. We should also bear in mind that if God is able to empower the church by the Spirit to do acts of healing and reconciliation, it is certainly possible for the Evil One to empower people for destructive acts as well. What we need to stress is neither the personalization nor the depersonalization of evil. Rather we should stress a position that takes account of both forms of evil; that is, both personal and impersonal evil, and that enables human beings to acknowledge and confess their part in the evil that pervades their life.

In reading the New Testament, it is clear that there is no one understanding of "principalities and powers," and we cannot assume from the terminology of "spiritual hosts and wickedness in heavenly places" that only heavenly spiritual beings or demons are implied, as African pastors teach. A balance between the two positions, between personalization and depersonalization of evil, is preferable if we would address all aspects of presenting problems in the pastoral encounter. Such a balanced approach would prevent the pastor from assuming the presence of evil spiritual beings as the obvious cause of any problem a parishioner might bring. The pastor would be aware that there could be other possible impersonal powers, like strict familial codes, for example, that may be at the root of the problems presented by parishioners. But above all, pastors should stress that deliverance comes because One who is like us has conquered and destroyed evil once and for all.

Barth's explication of demonic possession and how to deal with it is helpful for understanding and perhaps curtailing the African Christian tendency to demonize and spiritualize all ailments. Barth's attitude toward the demonic is based on New Testament examples as well as his study in *Church*

Dogmatics, IV/3, of the exorcism of a young woman in the parish of Pastor Johann Blumhardt. In Blumhardt's account of the exorcism during which the woman was finally freed, the demons cried out "Jesus is Victor!" as they left her body. We note that the demons cast out by Jesus also make similar assertions about Jesus's power and authority over them.[31] Barth devotes an entire section of the *Church Dogmatics*, IV/3, to demonic possession and Jesus's victory over demons, but he doesn't limit the meaning of the phenomenon to the spiritual realm alone. As Daniel J. Price points out, Barth delineates three aspects of demonic phenomenon in his approach.[32] According to Barth:

> The occurrence during which Blumhardt heard this cry: "Jesus is Victor," has three aspects. On the first, it is realistically explained in the sense of ancient and modern mythology. On the second, it is explained in terms of modern psychopathology, or depth psychology. On the third, it is not explained at all but can only be estimated spiritually on the assumption that the two former explanations are also possible and even justifiable in their own way.[33]

Barth's own interest is in the third perspective, the spiritual approach, but he does not ignore or belittle the other two. In the African Christian community, the first and the third perspectives are operative; African Christians realistically understand and treat the demonic from a spiritual perspective. The danger is that with only a realistic explanation of the demonic, they ignore more nuanced and varied aspects. The Barthian approach does not ignore or label unscientific (as others might see it) the realist explanation, but there is room to offer other plausible explanations that take in all facets of demonic possession. Barth's understanding and treatment of the demonic allows us to use it in tandem with depth psychology to explicate and treat cases that have demonic undertones. As Deborah Hunsinger points out, there is a sense of "psychopathological and spiritual complexity" evident in Barth's treatment of the demonic.[34] Such a balanced approach ensures that the individual suffering from demonic possession receives complete care from both a theological and a psychological perspective. From a biblical perspective, and as explicated by Barth, we get an understanding of the demonic that subjects demons and their influence to the finished work of Christ. In Christ all demonic powers are subject to the one who believes, and the simple prayer of faith can bring freedom. When the simple prayer of faith does not bring the desired relief, then we need to turn to other plausible explanations. We must look to the praxis of Jesus's own ministry as a means of assessing and evaluating our approach to care for the ailing.

The second important contribution of Barth's theological anthropology which holds promise for the Ghanaian pastoral context has to do with the understanding of what constitutes the human being. Is the human being a tripartite composite of body, soul, and spirit as is assumed and by many

Christians including Ghanaian Christians? Or biblically speaking and as Barth asserts, is the human being a "besouled body" and an "embodied soul"? Following the language of the Hebrew Scriptures, Barth points out the obvious fact that the Bible does not speak of human beings as having a third entity, namely spirit, but rather that the human being is an animated body—body and soul. Further, body and soul are interconnected such that the fate of one affects the fate of the other. At the same time we can talk of the entities in their particularity as individual entities without collapsing one into the other. Finally there is a proper ordering of these two aspects of the human being such that the soul leads the body. As a "besouled body" and as the soul of his body, he precedes the body in controlling and using it and having dominion over it. When he is able to do this, he is a "spiritual soul."[35] He is undergirded by God and lives as such before God. In death, in which such activity ceases, freedom is lost, as the dominion or precedence that the soul exercised over the body is broken.

Given the context of our discussion, the understanding of the interconnection between soul and body, to impute immortality to the soul and mortality to the body would negate the unity between them at a very basic level. If soul and body part from each other at death, if one is spiritual and otherworldly, and the other is mortal, corporeal, and this-worldly, can we still say one is the life of the other? Can we still argue for such a basic interconnection? Could there still be an indestructible unity between them? If what is said of one can also be said of the other, and if what is done to one is automatically done to the other, how then can we impute immortality to one and mortality and decay to the other? This kind of understanding can only persist when we lack an appreciation for the unity of body and soul as portrayed by the Scriptures.

The Scriptures are the source of neither the current Christian belief about the immortality of the soul nor of the negation of the body. In Greek and Latin antiquity, people understood humanity to be a genuine duality, a separation of body and soul. In this duality was a hierarchical ordering in which the soul was superior to the body.[36] I believe, however, that this conception has no place in Christian theology because the Bible gives a clear indication not only of the unity of the body and soul, but also of the inestimable value of the body as the temple of the Holy Spirit (1 Corinthians 6:19).

What we have been saying so far about the human being is that he is fully body and fully soul. The relation between the two is not such that one exists alongside the other, nor that different activities are assigned to them. Instead, there is a differentiation within the unity pertaining to the two moments of the one being that is undergirded by spirit.

Altogether I have made several assertions based on Barth's theological anthropology and the promise it holds for African pastoral theology and the pastoral counseling that can derive from it. First, we can use non-theo-

logical anthropologies (both the exact sciences, such as psychology, and the speculative philosophies, such as various worldviews) eclectically and noncommittally as sources of knowledge. They can give us valuable information about human phenomena, but when they set themselves up as axiomatic or dogmatic, they are to be opposed. They function within a context set by theological anthropology. Thus, the construction of a worldview is a kind of speculative philosophy in Barth's sense. If adherence to a particular cosmology becomes central (rather than peripheral) to our theological anthropology, we are to oppose it because it usurps the place that needs to be accorded to the witness of Scripture, namely, the lordship of Jesus Christ.

Second, human beings are constituted as soul and body undergirded by God's spirit. Our souls and bodies are patterned after Jesus Christ as "embodied souls" and "besouled bodies," existing in a differentiated and ordered unity. While there is no dualistic separation between body and soul, neither is there a confused enmeshment between them. We must give each its due in the ordered relationship.

Barth's rejection of speculative philosophy, taken seriously, can have a striking impact on the African apprehension of Christian theology, which in turn has profound implications for pastoral practice. His understanding of the relationship between body and soul affects how we can differentiate, unify, and order pastoral theology in African Christian practice.

While I support the place of prayer and discernment in the quest for healing, I also want to suggest that psychological tools, when used with discretion, can help in distinguishing what is purely spiritual from what is a combination of spiritual, psychic, and somatic causes.

REFRAMING PASTORAL DIAGNOSIS, CARE, AND COUNSELING

In the previous pages I made allusions to challenging aspects of the current African Christian scene, a scene in which pastoral diagnosis is based on the assumption of the spiritual worlds' influence on the earthly dimension, and assumed constant battle between evil and good spiritual forces—between God and Satan—which God wins on account of being omnipotent. I have argued from a Barthian perspective that such a dualistic understanding is contrary to Scripture. The fact that the dualistic nature of the battle between the forces of good and evil is decried does not mean that the darkness has been so overcome by the light that it no longer affects the children of light. That would be slipping in to what Barth terms "monism," which is as erroneous as the dualistic assumptions that underlie the understanding of the spiritual world in the African Churches. Scripture does own that there is a battle going on between the forces of evil and the forces of good, but it portrays it neither in starkly dualistic terms nor in monistic terms, but in

what Barth describes as a "dynamic teleology" akin to the relationship between Jesus, the light of the world and the darkness that, though penetrable by the light, yet remains although it does not have the capacity to overcome the darkness.[37] It is not a once and for all time historical enactment, but rather an unfolding of history in the relation of light to darkness, culminating in the eventual defeat of darkness. It means that the end is not yet here, God's promised good future, in which the darkness is completely subjected to the light once and for all, is in the process of realization. But for now, what does it mean to take the presence of the darkness seriously, especially in the African context where the presence of the darkness takes the shape of demonic forces, real or perceived, and further an apperception that, in fact, feeds the darkness rather than ushers in the liberative light? What would be the implications for a pastoral theology of ministry?

Following Barth's theological anthropology, African Christians and pastors might be encouraged to rethink their understanding of the role of their cosmology on their reading and interpretation of Scripture. It is hoped that doing this would allow, among other things a consideration of a more nuanced way of apprehending the demonic in both individual and corporate life, of according a place to psychic and somatic factors in what is always assumed to be spiritual causes of presenting problems. In consideration of such factors as psychic causes of assumed demonic assaults usually in the form of a dream, a Jungian approach to dreams and dream interpretation would yield fruitful insights into individual lives and facilitate diagnosis and care. Other issues, such as conflictual marital and familial relationships, might also benefit from a family systems approach to care, instead of being viewed as a demonic attack on the family, and thus labeled a generational curse to be addressed through prayers of deliverance alone.

SUMMARY

In this chapter I have presented an outline of pastoral diagnoses and care of people in African Independent Evangelical Charismatic Churches (AIEC) who are caught up in fear of the demonic spiritual world. Through the use of field research consisting of surveys and participant observation, I have described both public acts in church services and private advice offered in pastoral counseling, and have argued that the theological anthropology I encountered, which is tied to African cosmology, adversely affects attempts at providing care for those who come to believe they are possessed or bewitched.

I have also indicated that there is a need for more differentiation among what constitutes human being, as well as the presenting problems in pastoral situations, suggesting that theological insights be used to address theo-

logical situations and psychological insights used for addressing psychological issues, while both should be used in tandem to address cases in which theological and psychological factors coincide.

While these psychological insights would be helpful in diagnosis and care, the lack of opportunity for theological training also remains an issue to be addressed. What is readily available to most African pastors is the theological understanding gleaned from reading Scripture, often without study aids. Thus a misunderstanding of biblical and theological approaches to the demonic plays a crucial role in the issues plaguing diagnosis and care. Therefore, a practical theological framework forged from a Christological anthropology such as Barth's, which takes seriously the cultural undertones of care (even without the psychological support that I have described), is beneficial in African contexts with their deep adherence to scriptural principles, and where belief in the spiritual world characterizes common life.

NOTES

1. The designation "African" is used here as a designation for sub-Saharan Africa. The nations in this region share a similar colonial and Christian history, and are different from North African states in many respects. A commonality among sub-Saharan African nations, seen especially in worldview and religio-cultural practices, allows for inferences to be made from one culture to another.

2. Lamin Sanneh, *West African Christianity: The Religious Impact* (Maryknoll, N.Y.: Orbis Books, 1983), 107.

3. The worship atmosphere in these churches has undergone drastic changes since the end of the nineteenth century. Current worship incorporates both Western and African styles, drumming and dancing, and sometimes similar songs, termed "local choruses" because they are born out of the worship experience of the Christian community.

4. J. S. Pobee, "African Instituted (Independent) Churches," in *Dictionary of the Ecumenical Movement*, ed. Nicolas Lossky (Grand Rapids, Mich.: Eerdmans, 1991), 10.

5. Pobee, "African Instituted (Independent) Churches," 11.

6. Pobee, "African Instituted (Independent) Churches."

7. While all religious traditions have syncretistic elements, consciously or unconsciously, Christianity is no different, because the Gospel from its inception takes on the garb of the culture it addresses and often incorporates elements of the religious culture of its new situation. Here syncretism is used to describe the practices of deliberately blending distinct religious beliefs and traditions (in this case Christianity and African Traditional Religion) in a new form of unique Christian expression where neither tradition challenges and refines the other, but both operate side by side. Linda Thomas argues that this descriptor is redundant since it can be applied to both established and emergent churches alike. See her *Under the Canopy: Ritual Process and Spiritual Resilience in South Africa* (Columbia: University of South

Carolina Press, 1999). As a Christian African familiar with the beliefs and practices of adherents of African traditional religions (ATR), however, I need to stress the distinction between religio-cultural and socio-cultural aspects of ATR and the way in which they are incorporated into African expressions of Christian belief and practice. Thus, what to the outsider might be seen and understood through socio-cultural lenses alone may hold deeper religio-cultural meaning for the actual people than an ethnographer or sociologist assumes. Perhaps a note of caution is also in order: a postmodern approach to the study of religious phenomena must nevertheless guard against what may come off as assuaging "missionary guilt" or over-romanticizing in the assessment of other cultures. In this case what seems like a favorable "reading" of a culture may benefit the "reader" more than the "read."

8. Churches and Christian groups are springing up all over Ghana. As of summer 2002, there were 400 Christian groups on just one university campus.

9. Kwame Bediako, *Christianity in Africa: The Renewal of a Non-Western Religion* (Maryknoll, N.Y.: Orbis Books, 1995), 113.

10. See note 7 above. The incorporation of adherence to other gods and deities, depicted in sacrifice and worship of them, and not what is commonly known as Africanization of Christianity in form and structure of worship, is what sets these churches apart from mainstream Christian theological orthodoxy. In Ghana, the Apostles Revelation Society would serve as an example of such a syncretistic church. In bracketing these churches, it helps to make the singular point of how easily even what may seem as penultimate Christian orthodoxy, even in African vein (which is how the AEIC churches self-describe), still operates closer to the African traditional religious worldview, than they otherwise suppose.

11. This quote is taken from the website of a church in Durham, N.C., led by an African pastor and his wife, who is the co-pastor.

12. Though this project is not specifically about the effect of the prevailing spiritual climate on women, it is striking that most of the people in need of prayer and counseling or who saw the need to bring other people to be prayed for were women. Mercy Oduyoye is right when, in speaking of the situation of African women, she calls them "religion's chief clients." See Oduyoye, *Daughters of Anowa: African Women and Patriarchy* (Maryknoll, N.Y.: Orbis Books, 1995).

13. Warfare praying refers to specialized prayer in which believers aggressively claim their authority over demonic activities in their lives as well as in the lives of others by appropriating the power and help of the Holy Spirit, while putting on the whole armor of God and under the protection of the blood of the lamb. Refer to Ephesians 6:10–17.

14. Like the examples in the Old Testament where people were ordered to remove the sandals from their feet because they were in the presence of the Holy, these churches require that worshipers remove their footwear before entering the sanctuary. In addition to this reason for removal of footwear, however, are reports and belief that the ground may have been previously sprinkled with magical or other such potions intended to make the worshippers dependent on the "man of God" in these churches. One is also reminded of the belief in magic as contagious direct contact through the skin that is likely to have detrimental effects on the person.

15. Ancestral, or blackened, stools are stools that have attained their black color because sacrificial blood, usually of animals, has been smeared on them for years.

Among the Anlo, for example, the yearly festivals of clans and tribes provide opportunity for communal worship and on such occasions the stools are "washed" with blood.

16. I note here for the reader that passages of exorcisms in the Ewe bible did not use this phrase, which is commonly used in the churches. The Ewe translation uses the phrase translated into English as "command."

17. The examples of Jesus' healings in the Gospels, as well as the prophetic utterances of Peter to Ananias and Sapphira (Acts 5:1–12) and Paul's confrontation with Elymas whose sorcery was preventing the Proconsul from believing the message were cited as biblical examples of this practice (Acts 13:8–12).

18. In his introductions that evening, Pastor Paul testified to the veracity of the prophetic words of Prophet Anto, who had prophesied into the life of Pastor Paul three years prior to the event in Durham, N.C. The prophetic word included revelations about aspects of his life that could not have been known by the Prophet without revelation knowledge inspired by the Holy Spirit. The flyer advertising the event from May 30 to June 1, 2008, had the following scripture passage on it: "Believe in the Lord your God and you shall be established, believe in his PROPHET and you shall prosper (2 Chronicles 20:20, KJV). Without making any allusions to the context of this text, we can say that obviously the capitalization of the word "prophet" was intended for effect; at the same time one wonders why the Lord God is in toggle case and the Lord God's servant is in upper case letters, when in the text the LORD is capitalized.

19. While many of these pastors have congregants with whom they share a common language and are thus able to minister in those languages, many lack the basic School Leaving Certificates that allow them to be accepted in seminaries and Bible colleges. In June 2008 I met a prophet from one of these churches in Durham, N.C., with a sixth grade education trying his best to minster in English from the KJV Bible.

20. Karl Barth, *Church Dogmatics*, III/2, trans. and ed. G. W. Bromiley (Edinburgh: T. & T. Clark, 1961), 12.

21. Barth, *Church Dogmatics*, III/2, 22.

22. Barth, *Church Dogmatics*, III/2.

23. Barth, *Church Dogmatics*, III/2, 6.

24. Barth, *Church Dogmatics*, III/2, 9.

25. Colossians 2:8, 20 (RSV) tells believers, "See to it that no one makes a prey of you by philosophy and empty deceit, according to human tradition, according to the elemental spirits of the universe, and not according to Christ. . . . If with Christ you died to the elemental spirits of the universe, why do you live as if you still belonged to the world? Why do you submit to regulations?"

26. Barth, *Church Dogmatics*, III/2, 4.

27. Barth, *Church Dogmatics*, III/2.

28. Barth, *Church Dogmatics*, III/2.

29. Theodore O. Wedel, "Ephesians," in *The Interpreter's Bible*, ed. George Buttrick (New York/Nashville: Abingdon, 1956), 604.

30. Michael Perry, ed., *Deliverance: Psychic Disturbances and Occult Involvement*, 2nd ed. (London: SPCK, 1987, 1996).

31. Examples abound in the gospel accounts; see especially the healing of the boy gripped by seizures (Matthew 17:14–20).

32. D. J. Price, *Karl Barth's Anthropology in Light of Modern Thought* (Grand Rapids, Mich.: Eerdmans, 2002), 303.
33. Barth, *Church Dogmatics*, IV/3, 170.
34. Deborah van Deusen Hunsinger, *Theology and Pastoral Counseling: A New Interdisciplinary Approach* (Grand Rapids: Eerdmans, 1995), 203.
35. Hunsinger, *Theology and Pastoral Counseling*, 424.
36. Hunsinger, *Theology and Pastoral Counseling*, 390–94.
37. Barth, *Church Dogmatics*, IV/3.1, 167.

11

Religion in Thailand: Pastoral Theological Reflection from the Perspective of Thai Buddhist Monks

Siroj Sorajjakool

INTRODUCTION

Since Seward Hiltner's *Preface to Pastoral Theology*, the field of pastoral theology has gone through various periods of modification and expansion as it continues to seek answers to questions of human experience, the socio-political contexts of religious phenomena, and current philosophical and theological developments.[1] Pastoral theology as a discipline has formulated its own discourse and methodology within the context of Western cultural and religious practices. However, in the past decade the field of pastoral theology has witnessed a movement toward an intercultural paradigm. Speaking of this approach, Emmanuel Lartey writes, "Many voices need to be spoken, listened to and respected in our quest for meaningful and effective living." And in order to listen to the "other" carefully, Lartey challenges us to the "recognition of the complexity, plurality, fragmentation and pluriformity of our postmodern and post-colonial times."[2] In view of this development within the field of pastoral theology, this chapter is concerned with the following questions: what will a discourse on pastoral theology from the perspective of diverse religious traditions be like? And how will the methodologies differ from what is being done in the West? This chapter intends to explore pastoral theological reflection within the context of Thai religious practices in an attempt to understand Buddhist monks' approaches to the lived religious experiences of the Thai people. It will start with observation of religious phenomena in Thailand, follow with a description of pastoral theological reflection upon these religious phenomena from the perspective of Thai

Buddhist monks, and conclude with an evaluation of a Buddhist approach to pastoral theology and its applications.

METHODOLOGY

Speaking of methodology, Robert Orsi reminds us of the need to cultivate "a disciplined attentiveness to the many different ways men, women, and children have lived with the gods and to the things, terrible and good, violent and peaceful, they have done with the gods to themselves and to others."[3] This need for attentiveness is also reflected in Lartey's *Pastoral Theology in an Intercultural World*:

> In theological terms, the ultimate context to be analysed by all pastoral theologians is the global context, not simply and exclusively their own little corner. However, the best way to do this is to listen deeply, and with empathy and interpathy, to the experiences of "others" from distinctly different contexts, without seeking to subsume them into our own . . . Pastoral theology is contextual theology precisely because it engages in the analysis of local and global contexts as an intrinsic part of its practice.[4]

It is from the above perspective that the following methodology is developed, consisting of the gathering of information based on observation, participation, and interviews. Observation includes paying attention to religious practices in the day-to-day lives of Thai people, such as the use of religious relics, objects, and icons and the way respect is shown to sacred places and visiting sacred sites such as Wat Prakaewmorakot and the Emeral Buddha, Erawan Shrine (Four Face Bhrama), Chao Po Luk Muang (City Pillar), and Doi Suthep in Chiang Mai. Along with these forms of observation, I also participated in the celebration of religious festivals, attended Buddhist funeral services, and listened to Buddhist sermons. The final source of information is semi-structured interviews that seek to understand religious beliefs among Thai people and Buddhist monks' pastoral theological understanding and approach to these phenomena. In this process I interviewed eight Thai Buddhist monks from the following Buddhist temples: Wat Thai of Los Angeles, Wat Padhammachart (La Puente, California), Wat Chaobuddha (San Bernardino, California), Wat Samakkidhammaram (Long Beach, California), Wat Buddhajakramongkolratanaram (Escondido, California), Suddhavasa Buddhist Meditation Center (Ontario, California), Wat Buddha of Chino Hills (Chino Hills, California), and two Buddhist monks from Thailand. All these monks received their religious training from Thailand and spent many years serving in Buddhist monasteries in Thailand.[5]

I approached this data as a Christian Thai who was born and raised in Thailand. My parents raised me within the Seventh-day Adventist tradition.

My academic training has been primarily Western in orientation. Most of the seminary training that I received came from either Westerners or teachers who received their theological training in the United States. My master's degree in religion is from Andrews University in Michigan (even though I earned my degree in India). And I completed my doctor of philosophy degree from Claremont School of Theology in California. Hence, my perspective during the interview process was colored by these experiences and background.

All of the interviews were done in the Thai language. Before the interviews every participant was casually introduced to the research topic. Interviews were semi-structured, guided by a list of open-ended questions. The monks were asked the following open-ended questions:

1. Can you describe the religious beliefs and practices of the Thai people in Thailand?
2. Can you explain the existence of shrines of Hindu Gods in Thailand?
3. Can you describe Buddhist practices among Thai people?
4. How do you help promote Buddhism among Thai people?
5. How do you help Thai people embrace the teachings of the Buddha?

The open-ended questions permitted participants to articulate experiences from their own perspectives. During the interview, each answer was probed carefully in order to deepen and clarify the meanings of the participants' responses.

The analysis of the transcription is based on grounded theory. Using the grounded theory approach, it was coded at three levels: open, axial, and selective. The first level involved identifying phenomena based on the properties and dimensions of the data.[6] The next level involved refining and differentiating categories resulting from open coding by relating subcategories to a category. In this process, there was continual comparison to see whether or not a new response corresponded with a previous category.[7] The final level of analysis sought a conceptualization based on patterns emerging from participants' reports of their experiences. This explanation sought to account for variation in responses. Emerging themes were constantly compared to the interviews to see if the analysis explained each case. In instances where analysis did not offer sufficient explanation, the analysis was revised. Revisions involved renaming categories, developing new categories, and identifying alternative paths or processes.

THEMES AND DISCUSSION

In this section I explore emerging themes based on two categories: Thai religious beliefs and practices, and pastoral theological reflection based on

the perspective of Thai Buddhist monks. Unless otherwise stated, all translations from the Thai language in the following sections are mine.

Thai Religious Beliefs and Practices

The analysis of the interviews together with data collected through observation show the following themes that capture the phenomena of religious beliefs and practices in Thailand: Thai belief system consists of a combination of animism, Hinduism, and Buddhism; the existence of the unseen world of ghosts, spirits, gods, and karma is as real as the seen world; the belief in magic is a common feature among Thai people; and the actual practice of Buddhism as taught by Buddhist monks exists among a minority of the Thai people.

Thai Religious Beliefs

Growing up in Thailand where 94 percent of the population is Buddhist, I had the privilege of witnessing, attending, and participating in numerous Buddhist rituals. Pictures of Buddhist monks in saffron robes receiving food from believers and offering blessings are a part of everyday Thai experience. I have heard monks preaching the Four Noble Truths with applications to daily living. I have seen Buddhists offering saffron robes to monks while praying for merits. I have observed Buddhists during *kau pansa* and the way they kept the eight precepts. My grandfather was a staunch Buddhist. Next to his bedroom was a small room full of Buddha statues. Every morning and evening he would enter this room reciting the triple gems in Pali and praying for protection. And every morning he would go to the spirit house[8] in the shape of a Thai Buddhist temple on a white cement stilt standing at the right-hand corner of the very front of his home, burning incense and offering food. It never occurred to me while growing up that these two sacred places emerged from two very different belief systems. And it did not seem to make any difference to my grandfather. Actually, it does not make any difference to millions of Thai people who, on a regular basis, pray to Buddha and Bhrama or Ganesha or Shiva at the very same time.

While the geographical landscape of Thailand is filled with sights of Buddhist temples and statues of Buddha, sacred sites in Thailand are not limited only to the practice of Buddhism. Some of the most revered places in Bangkok are the City Pillar,[9] located adjacent to the Grand Palace where Emeral Buddha is housed, the Erawan Shrine, where devotees offer prayer to the Four Face Bhrama, the Ganesha Shrine, located in the central part of Bangkok, and the sacred Bo Tree, where Thammasart University students request assistance during their exam week.

There are many other local beliefs and practices that were passed on before Hinduism and Buddhism came to Thailand. These are the local belief in spirits of ancestors or spirits that reside in various locations.

According to Thai metaphysics, spirits reside in every location. These spirits have the power to enhance prosperity or inflict pain. These spirits are divided into two main categories: domesticated and non-domesticated. Domesticated refers to spirits that do not respond until being evoked through prayer and offering. Non-domesticated spirits are spirits that act before evocation and often bring harm. Speaking of domesticated spirits, Thais believe that there are spirits in every location and hence one finds a spirit house in almost every home. Respect for the spirit is dependent on one's location. A person is expected to show respect for the spirit of the location in which he or she lives. But when one finds oneself in a different location, it is unwise to be loyal to one's primary location. It is important to note, too, that the spirits are 'amoral'. In granting wishes there is no morality involved. The determining factor is the rituals. As long as the rituals are performed correctly, the spirit is obliged to grant wishes.[10] According to Phrakru Srivithedhammakhun of Wat Suddhavasa Buddhist Meditation Center, Thai metaphysics is a combination of Buddhism, Hinduism, and animism. It is hard to make any clear distinction in religious practices among Thai people.[11]

This approach to religion is not uncommon among Asians in general, because Asian religious perspective tends to be pragmatic in nature. Unlike the Western world where logic and rationality are tools in the quest for truth, among Asians, truth is what works. Perhaps this is because the logic embedded in religious practice is pragmatic in nature. Therefore religious observance is often not a quest for truth within a single religion. Rather, Asians tend to be more eclectic in their approach. For example, it is not uncommon for the Chinese to practice Buddhism, Taoism, and Confucianism at the same time. Tan Teik Beng observes:

> It would be more correct to describe them [Chinese people] as multi-religious since they also worshipped nature, spirits, multiple gods, Heaven and their departed ancestors, apart from the three officially recognized religions. In other words, Chinese religion is syncretic because it contains pluralistic religious beliefs.[12]

Another pragmatic aspect of Chinese religious beliefs, according to Tan Teik Beng, is reflected in the common practice of praying to multiple deities simultaneously. "They prayed to many deities, those which belonged to their own religion as well as to those which did not, because they believed that each one of these deities could grant a different favour and that the more deities they worshipped, the more favours they received."[13]

Thai religious belief is pluralistic in nature. It does not limit itself to one religion. It integrates various belief systems present in the Thai historical

root, such as local spirits and spirits of ancestors to the multiple gods of Hinduism. It does not strive for logical consistency but for pragmatic aid in everyday living. It is about interacting with the spirits and the gods, and the metaphysical laws of the unseen world as they relate to the peoples' lives.

The Unseen World

Among Thais, the worlds of humans and the spirits, gods, or deities are very closely related. Interactions between people and the gods are a part of the social reality. These take place in every dimension of life, such as health, education, career, finances, and politics. Interactions are often ritualistic in nature. Walking into different shops in Thailand, one will find shrines dedicated to a particular deity or deities. Some shops have two shrines, one for the Chinese gods and the other for Thai spirits. Some shrines consist of Buddha statues, pictures of venerated Buddhist monks, and Nang Kwak (a female goddess believed by Thai people to bring prosperity, a belief rooted in animism). Taxi drivers place religious relics or statues on their dashboards. Rituals are performed on a daily basis, as worshippers offer food and flowers, or burn incense to the gods, and request protection, prosperity, and good health in return. The unseen world is as real as the phenomenal world in which they find themselves. Within the religious psyche of Thai people, the world of gods, spirits, and karma is operative and real. On a day-to-day basis, Thai people deal with spirits and gods in the same way they interact with people. They talk to people and pray to the spirits. They placate the gods and please people. And within this religious psyche, the impacts of the gods and spirits are viewed as just as real as responses from their friends and family members. People try not to offend the spirits in the same way as they avoid hurting their friends. They are intentional about showing respect to the gods in the same way that they show respect to the elderly. The reality of the unseen world is an important part of their daily living.

For example, I remember a group of university students who rented my house. Once when I went to collect my rent they asked if I had asked permission from the local spirit to stay there. They described how an elderly man, who did not appear to be friendly, would appear late at night every night in this house. I told them that I did not know the right rituals. The following month when I came to collect my rent again I saw a bowl of rice, a bottle of soda, fruits, and incense in my backyard. Not long after, the students left my house never to return again. To these university students, the world of the spirits was very real and one needed to learn how to deal appropriately with these spirits or else one might not be able to cope with life effectively.

Speaking of this reality within the Buddhist context, Phra Mahadarbchai of Wat Buddhajakramongkolratanaram told a story about a Laotian man who escaped political conflicts in his country through the Mae Khong River that

borders Thailand and Laos. The man's relatives believed that he was shot dead and that his body was floating in the river. They organized a religious ceremony and performed *pae meta chit* (an offering of merits to the deceased) for this Laotian man. But the man was saved and at the time living in a refugee camp in Thailand and he reported that his stomach felt bloated for three days and he did not eat anything for three days. Pramahadarbchai went on explaining that the offering of merits was like giving food to the dead person. "This thing happens and it is real," affirms Pramahadarbchai.[14]

The son of a family friend in Thailand was diagnosed with cancer. I called his mother to find out more information about his condition. At the time I called, she was at a Buddhist temple. I later learned that she brought him to the Buddhist temple in order for him to perform a religious ritual that she believed could extend her son's life. She had a deep conviction that the accumulation of merits could change his fate.

A famous Thai nun, Maechee Thanaporn is often quoted as saying, "The karma accumulated by spirits of a dead person attached to us can impact our health."[15] She went on to explain that the spirit of a dead person had caused harm to others, and the accumulated bad karma showed itself in physical symptoms in a person to whom that spirit is attached. She offers an example: if the dead person had intentionally caused head injury to people or animals, headaches may be the symptoms expressed through the person to whom this spirit is attached.[16]

In the collective religious psyche of the Thai people, metaphysical reality is taken very seriously and the interaction between these two realities (the physical and the metaphysical) remains significant in the lives and practices of the people. For most Thais, the significance of this unseen metaphysical reality resides in its power to transcend the natural phenomenal world. This attachment captures the power offered to the devotees.

Magic

There are many sacred sites (Ganesha Shrine, Erawan Shrine, Doi Suthep, Lak Muang, Wat Phra That Doi Kham, Pra Phathom Chedi) and objects (*yantra*, amulets, Nang Kwak, *lingum*, sacred turtle) that Thai people believe are embedded with sacred magical power. As stated earlier, the reason Thai people take this unseen metaphysical reality seriously has much to do with the spiritual power or magical power that is believed to impact lives both positively and negatively. A Thai student who attended one of the top private high schools in Bangkok related to me a story of a shrine located at the entrance of her school. A common belief among students that had been passed on for generations was that the spirit of this shrine is able to affect students' grades positively if the right ritual is performed. The ritual, according to this Thai student, consists of first petitioning and making a vow. The

petition is mostly for good grades. A vow is based on the students' understanding of this particular spirit as one who likes to watch students run around the basketball court and consume red soda. Often after petitioning for good grades, students will promise to run five or ten rounds around the basketball court (depending on how desperate they are) and consume a bottle or two of red soda. If the grades turned out the way they had petitioned, the next step is for the student to follow exactly what they had vowed, for otherwise bad luck might occur.

At the center of Erawan shrine sits the statues of the Four Face Bhrama.[17] This is one of the most sacred sites in heart of Bangkok city. Surrounding this shrine are devotees praying for health, protection, good luck, a life-partner, and prosperity. There are thousands of wooden elephant statues in all shapes and sizes around this shrine. To the east of the shrine is a group of musicians playing traditional Thai music and eight dancers performing classical Thai dance. The Thais believe in the power of this sacred site to offer prosperity and grant wishes. The ceremony starts with burning incense and petitioning. Once wishes have been fulfilled, devotees buy a wooden elephant and pay approximately US$20 for dancers to perform, because they believe that Bhrama loves watching classical Thai dance. According to Hindu mythology, the wooden elephant symbolizes the three-head elephant that functions as transport for Bhrama.

I would now like to describe two sacred objects (Nang Kwak and sacred turtle) that are commonly found among Thai shops and restaurants in Thailand and overseas. Near the cashier counter of many Thai restaurants in the United States is a shrine with a statue of Nang Kwak (*nang* refers to a lady and *kwak* is the gesture of invitation). Nang Kwak's statue is often in a sitting position adorned with a classical Thai costume while her right arm is stretching out in the gesture of calling something toward her. Myth has it that during the Epic Period (500 B.C.E to 200 C.E.), Pu Chaokaokeow noticed an orphan whose personality radiated kindness, compassion, and peacefulness. Wherever she went, she brought prosperity, unity, and peace with her. After he adopted her, Pu Chaokaokeow taught her *vippassana* meditation and methods of acquiring magical power. Since then Nang Kwak has been known for the gift of endowing worshippers with prosperity and success. Secret rituals consist of wrapping the base of the statue with three colored clothes (green, red, and yellow) and offering her banana, young coconut, pineapple, water, and five incense sticks. While petitioning, worshippers should also remember Pu Chaokaokeow and his merits. Water offerings to Nang Kwak should be changed every day. After a day, this water should be preserved for other uses, such as washing one's face or sprinkling in one's shop to increase prosperity.[18]

Another common sacred object for prosperity among Thai and Chinese people is the sacred turtle. In Buddhist mythology it is believed that in the

many cycles of incarnation the Buddha went through, he once reincarnated as a giant turtle on a remote island practicing dharma. One day there was a shipwreck near this island and many survivors came to this place looking for shelter. Many days passed without food, desperate survivors became agitated, angry, and hungry, and they started fighting and killing one another. When the old turtle saw this, he begged the people to cease their evil deeds, promising them that they could use his flesh for food. He then proceeded to walk to the top of the hill and jump. The survivors were able to use his flesh for food and his shell as boats to return to their homes.[19] Worshippers normally place this sacred turtle in a tray of water. Within this tray, one should place lotus petals and morning glory leaves. This water should be changed on a regular basis, as murky water is bad for one's fate. Prayer should be offered with three to five incense sticks before leaving the house or in the evening, remembering the Buddha, Dharma, and Sangha.[20]

As we have seen, the belief in magical and supernatural power is common among Thai people, leading to petitions for prosperity and good fortune. However, according to Phramaha Charoen Chanchring of Wat Thai, Los Angeles, Buddhism as a religion does not believe in petitions to a higher power.[21] And according to Phrakru Srivithedhammakhun of Wat Suddhavasa Buddhist Meditation Center, magic is not considered an effective way of dealing and coping with the reality of life.[22]

The Practice of Thai Buddhism

Phrakru Srivithedhammakhun believes that while the majority of the Thai people integrate animistic and Hindu beliefs into their understanding of Buddhism, there are those whose religious beliefs and practices come closer to the basic teachings of Buddhism.

There are certain core practices common among those who claim to be practicing Buddhism. These core practices include the following:

- Keeping the five precepts. These precepts are: (1) abstain from taking lives, (2) abstain from stealing, (3) abstain from sexual misconducts such as committing adultery or watching pornography, (4) abstain from telling lies, and (5) abstain from intoxication (alcohol and drugs).
- Chanting morning or evening chants (short version). The chant involves salutation to the Triple Gem. First to the Buddha (Homage to Him, the Buddha, the Blessed One, the Holy One, the All Enlightened One). Second, the Dharma (Homage to the Dharma the Noble Doctrine well-preached by the Blessed One). And finally to the Sangha (Homage to the Sangha, the Noble Bhikkhus of the Blessed One). This is followed by salutation to the Buddha (Honor to the Exalted One, freed from all bondage, and fully enlightened One) and closed with

salutation to The Three Refuges, which is normally repeated twice (I take Buddha as my guide. I take Doctrine as my guide. I take the Order as my guide.).

- Visiting the Buddhist temple four times a month during Buddhist holy days. These regular visits to the temple are based on the lunar calendar. The Thai lunar calendar is divided into two parts: *khang kuen* (waxing moon, referring to the period from the new moon to full moon that lasts for fifteen days) and *khang Raem* (waning moon, referring to the period from the full moon to new moon that lasts between fourteen to fifteen days). Buddhist holy days fall on *kuen* 8 and *kuen* 15 (the eighth and the fifteenth days of the waxing moon) and *raem* 8 and *raem* 14 or 15 depending on whether the month is an odd or even number (the eighth and the fourteenth or fifteenth days of the waning moon). On the eve of the holy day and for twenty-four hours following, believers will start keeping the eight precepts.[23] These regular visits during Buddhist holy days include listening to sermons and receiving blessings from Buddhist monks. Adherents also go to Buddhist temples to listen to sermons and receive blessing.
- Making merits. Every Thai knows the importance of making merits. It is a part of their reality. This is how Buddhist temples are built. The structure of the Sangha (Buddhist monastery) is based on charity itself. Without charity, Buddhist monks would not be able to survive. It is estimated that most Buddhists in rural areas spend between 5 percent to 10 percent of their annual income on charity. The concept of merit making among Thai Buddhists are best described by Karuna Kusalasaya:

> "To do good" (*Kusala Kamma*) is a cardinal point in the teachings of Buddhism. Consequently the idea of performing meritorious deeds is very deeply ingrained in the minds of the Buddhist. Ways of doing good or making merit (*Punna*) among the Thai Buddhists are numerous. A man gains merit each time he gives alms to monks or contributes to any religious rituals. To get ordination into monkhood even for a short period, of course, brings much merit. Besides, there are other ways of merit-earning, such as releasing caged birds or freeing caught fishes, plastering gold leaf on Buddha statues or religious monuments, contributing to the construction of a new temple or the repair of an old one, etc.[24]

To understand the importance of merits within Thai society, one has to understand the beliefs behind this motive. "The Law of Karma which teaches that each action has its corresponding result, and the belief in rebirth are two important factors in molding attitude towards life among Buddhists."[25] When Buddhism first came to Thailand, Thailand was a land of plenty. The weather was warm. The earth yielded fruits. It was a fertile land. It was perfect for cultivation. Describing this land, King

Rakamheng wrote: "This land of Thai is good. In the waters are fish; in the fields is rice . . . coconut groves abound in this land. Jackfruit abounds in this land . . . Whoever wants to play, plays. Who wants to laugh, laughs. Whoever wants to sing, sings."[26] People had only to harmonize with the physical environment, conform to the rhythm of the seasons, and enjoy the bounty which nature provided them. This condition has had an effect on how Buddhism was integrated into Thai culture and mentality. While Buddhism viewed life as suffering, the early Thais were experiencing life as pleasant and hopeful. Life was good. The earth was yielding fruits. Hence Thai Buddhists do not strive for Nirvana but a better life in the next incarnation. While Thai Buddhists believe in Nirvana as the final path of liberation, they also believe that it is indeed a very difficult path to achieve. Therefore, their aim is primarily to contribute enough in this life so that these charitable and meritorious acts will assure them a better life in the next cycle of reincarnation.

There is another very important function to the concept of karma. During my interviews with ten Thai women from rural areas in northern Thailand infected with HIV/AIDS, I identified an important role the concept of karma plays in bringing comfort to those who face terminal illness. Of the ten women interviewed, six were initially suicidal. An interesting pattern I noticed among the four Thai women who did not have any suicidal ideation was a common phrase "*tam boon ma kae nee*." Literally translated, it means, "I've only earned so much merit [in my past life]." Among these four women there was a firm belief in the law of karma that helped to promote acceptance. A participant states, "I am more willing to accept [the reality of my illness] when I recognize that this is my karma."[27] This place of acceptance is made explicit in the Buddhist understanding of anicca or impermanence. A number of Thai friends have said to me that the oft repeated phrase "*chewit kur garn gurd kae jeb tai*" [life is the cycle of birth, old age, and death] helps them face the reality of life and learn to "*ploy wang*" [let go], which offers them a sense of peace.

Tidhinart Na Pathaloong, a very successful business woman, told a story of the day she received a phone call informing her that her husband had just died in a car accident. During the funeral service, bankers from various banks came to claim over a hundred million baths of debt from a loan her husband took before the tragic accident. It was this experience that changed her entire perspective on life. The teachings of the Buddha became her primary focus, enabling her to cope with this sad reality of life and to succeed. In her book *Kem-thid Chewit: Panti Do Jit Boriharn Chewit Su Itsara Tang Karn Ngan Lae Chit Jai* (Life's Compass: A Guide Toward Spiritual and Financial Freedom), she writes, "Whenever we experience suffering, pain, or struggle we need to look deep in our hearts. Hidden beneath this pain we will find a sense of attachment, the need to control, and the desire to manipulate nature."[28]

Thai Buddhist Monks and Pastoral Theological Reflections

Emerging themes regarding pastoral theological reflection among Buddhist monks consist of embracing people where they are; using their belief system to advance them to a higher understanding of Dharma; and helping them to accept the reality of life (birth, suffering, and death) in order to free them from pain.

Accepting People Where They Are

All the Buddhist monks interviewed believe that both animism and Hinduism are an integral part of the Thai religious and cultural beliefs. It is difficult for most Thai to make a clear distinction between the three religious worldviews and practices. Before Buddhism and Hinduism became a part of Thai religious practices, local Thais believed in spirits of ancestors and local spirits residing in sacred places such as mountains, trees, forests, rivers, and others. This belief, according to Buddhist monks, remains a part of Thai people to the present day. Then came Buddhism that formed itself as the national religion during the Sukhothai era (thirteenth century) under the leadership of King Ramkham-haeng, who invited Sri Lankan Buddhist monks to spread the teachings of Buddhism.[29] Following the Sukhothai era came the Ayuthaya period, which was one of the richest periods in the history of Thailand. According to Phra Charoen Chanchring and Phra Mahadarbchai, during this period, Thai kings expanded the territory and in the process brought back to Thailand Hindu beliefs and practices common among the Khmers from Angkar Wat. One of the beliefs that was brought to Thailand was Rajadeva or the God-king. Here the king is viewed as an incarnation of Vishnu (the main deity at Angkar Wat).[30] Till today, the king of Thailand is considered the incarnation of Lord Vishnu, and the yellow royal flag contains the image of Garuda (a half bird, half human mythological being whose function is to serve as the transport for Lord Vishnu). The existence of this type of religious syncretism (animism, Hinduism, and Buddhism) within the Thai society is affirmed by one of the most respected Buddhist monks, the Venerable Buddhadasa Bhikkhu: "We have to admit that this mixed blood, born of Hindu-cum-occultical and Buddhist elements, continues to vitalize Thai blood to the present days."[31]

The attitude of Buddhist monks interviewed regarding this diverse mix of religious beliefs and practices is that of acceptance. Their attitude of acceptance is reflected in various forms. Phrakru Srivithedhammakhun believes that it is inappropriate to harbor a judgmental attitude toward people who embrace animistic beliefs. As religious leaders "we can't say you are not welcomed here at the temple because your belief system is impure." No matter what their belief systems, no matter how far they are from the original teachings of the Buddha, everyone, according to Phrakru Srivithedham-

makhun, should feel welcome at Buddhist temples.[32] Besides not being judgmental, Phra Charoen Chanchring believes that it is important to show respect to other religious beliefs and practices that have for generation after generation been a part of Thai religious and cultural practices.[33] The importance of respect for other gods, deities, and spirits, to a Thai Buddhist monk in Wat Padhammachart,[34] is that it helps to sustain a person in difficult times. There is an inner need for people to have something they can hold on to, a power that transcends the ordinary to which they can attach themselves. "This belief provides comfort. If there is nothing to hold on to, they feel helpless. So people reach out to sacred power of various forms and this dependency offers courage. It is a good thing."

Attaching the term *occultism* to various ritualistic practices of Hinduism and animism, Buddhadasa Bhikkhu writes:

> I entertain no reproof for occultism because, as said, it is useful for the weak-minded. Governments and kings of old days must have known the psychological condition of their people well. Hence they allowed both the Brahmin and Buddhist shrines to exist side by side. Later on Brahmin shrines were gradually done away with but their historical traces remain still. Many images of Hindu gods and goddesses were given sanctuary in Buddhist temples. For instance at the pagoda of Wat Chedi Kaew, two Shiva-*lingas* and an elephant head of the Hindu God Ganesha were found. This only shows that Brahmin images were given respect, and ordinary people, according to their level of intelligence, were allowed free choice.[35]

Using Their Belief System to Promote Growth

It is not uncommon for Thais to come to Buddhist temples requesting from the monks sacred religious objects, *yant*, or amulets for protection and prosperity, believing that these objects or tattoos have magical power. *Yant* or *yantra* is a form of sacred mantra normally written in Sanskrit language using Khmer alphabets. It contains special geometrical designs and is believed to possess magical power for protection against bodily harm and sickness and also to support prosperity and wealth. This *yantra* may be given in two forms. *Phayant* refers to the sacred mantra written on a piece of cloth. The *yantra* may also be in the form of a tattoo or *Sakyant*. Both *phayant* and *sakyant* may be performed only by well-known and respected Buddhist monks. Amulets, on the other hand, are either made of metals such as bronze or gold or ceramics. Ceramic amulets are often cased in metal frames with covers made of glass. Most amulets contain images of Buddha but there are amulets containing images of famous monks and kings as well. Among kings, those most favored on amulets are King Mongkut (Rama IV) and King Chulalongkorn (Rama V). The back of each amulet contains an inscription of sacred *yantra*. Many Thais search for amulets

from famous monks whom they trust to offer special magical protection and bring good luck. Not every amulet has the same potency, nor does every monk share the same level of sacred magical power. When my grandfather was alive, he had more than half a dozen amulets that he hung around his neck all the time. There are many stories affirming the magical power of amulets, such as the story of a politician who received the Phra Pidtanalurcha amulet from Luang Po Sing (a famous Buddhist monk from Wat Pai Luong) and survived when he was shot many times by his political opponents.[36] Further, there is the story of Thawatchai Somnaskum who survived a bad car accident without a scratch because he wore a Phra Song Somdet amulet around his neck.[37]

When asked about the functions of *sakyant*, *yantra*, or amulets, every Buddhist monk interviewed replied with the same answer. There are no magical powers inherent within these objects. However, because people believe in them, Buddhist monks use them as a stepping stone to enable them to achieve a higher understanding of Buddhism. Phra Charoen Chanchring told me the story of a man who was being mugged by robbers. As he fell to the ground he grabbed his amulet and placed it in his mouth. Feeling something moving in his mouth he thought the magical power of the amulet had been activated and so he got up, fought with all his might, and defeated the robbers. When all was done, he pulled out the amulet, but it turned out to be a frog.[38] "The use of amulets is all *Kusonlayobai*," explained a young monk from Wat Chaobuddha, San Bernardino.[39] *Kuson* is translated as charity or good deeds, while *yobai* here is from the Thai word, *konlayobai*, which means to play tricks. *Kusonlayobai* therefore refers to tricks that indirectly direct a person toward charity and goodness. All the monks interviewed agree that they use people's belief in magic inherent in *yantra*, amulets, and other sacred objects as a means to advance them to a higher level of morality and spirituality. Revered monks tell believers requesting *sakyant* or amulets that for these to be potent and able to provide protection and prosperity they need to practice the five precepts, do good deeds, keep pure, and remember the teachings of the Buddha. Further, those who wear amulets should always show respect through their behavior to individuals whose images are represented in the amulets. *Yantra* and amulets are not able to provide any form of protection if individuals having possession of them do not practice the basic teachings of Buddhism.[40]

Like the story of the man who thought a moving frog in his mouth was an amulet coming to life, all these beliefs in magical power are simply *kusonlayobai*. "Nowadays," suggests Luang Pu Charoenporn, "people are not interested in keeping their souls pure, [practicing] temperance, and self-restraint. They focus on amulets and magical objects until they have forgotten the need for peace."[41] Luang Pu Charoenporn only offers the trick of *vippassana* (meditation) to help to uproot lustful desires. He is willing to use tricks because

"all good things emerge from bad things in life."[42] The beautiful lotus flowers were once submerged in dirty mud. Likewise, Luang Pu Charoenporn believes, it is beneficial to use the commonly held magical beliefs and turn them into something beautiful like the lotus.[43] If Buddhist religion is not about magic or the supernatural, if all these monks engage in through *yantra*, amulets, and other sacred objects are *kusonlayobai*, to what end does it lead?

The Reality of Life: Buddhist Perspective

While Buddhist monks accommodate beliefs in magic and the use of *kusonlayobai* as a stepping stone, their ultimate aim is to help release people from pain and suffering. They help them by enabling them to come to terms with the reality of life. In real life, there is no magic. People seek magical power through sacred objects or deities for protection and prosperity but the Buddha teaches hard work. Magic only comes from hard work. Phra Phromkhunaporn writes, "Success is not something that can be easily achieved. People need to have determination, strength, patience, and they need to constantly struggle to develop who they are."[44] Life decisions dictate our destiny. Things we do, choices we make, will determine our future and success. "Buddhism," affirms Phra Charoen Chanchring "is not a religion of petition. We are the authors of our own destiny." At the very same time, success in life is not about mere prosperity. Success is not purely material, it must be spiritual as well. To be spiritually successful, one must attain a good grasp of the term *enough*. "Enough" is not about being lazy. "Enough" is an enlightened understanding of life. While explaining the Buddhist understanding of "enough," Phra Charoen Chanchring makes reference to King Bhumipol's economic proposal, *sedthakit porpiang* or sustainable economy.[45] *Sedthakit porpiang* is the total opposite of global economy through big corporations.[46] In the early 90s when I was working for a local NGO in Bangkok, I was introduced to an officer who had been trying to implement the King's project in rural areas. The concept was to offer the type of agriculture whereby each family may be able to sustain themselves and depend as little as possible on cash flow and other businesses for survival. Speaking of sustainability, Sulak Sivaraksa, a famous Thai Buddhist scholar, writes:

> To sustain lifestyle in community, we must have good friends who care for the right scale, who understand that small is beautiful, stressing decentralization, local self-reliance and real participation of all, rather than the centralization of national government and multinational corporations with hierarchical systems which lead to monoculture.[47]

This concept exemplifies the Buddhist understanding of "enough." It is the type of economy that promotes spirituality at the same time. "The troubles that we currently face in this world," according to Phra Phoawana-

virijakun, "have [their] root in our attachment to material goods, competition for maximum productions, and usage of numerical figures to determine political success, economic success."[48]

Another very important aspect of reality being taught by Buddhist monks is *anicca* (impermanence). The reality of life is birth, old age, and death. Life is transient, and attachment causes pain. While traveling to Chiang Mai city by train, I had the opportunity to sit across from a Buddhist monk. While discussing the concept of impermanence he related to me a story from *Dhammapada Khuddaka Nikaya*, chapter 8.

> Kisagotami was the daughter of a rich man from Savatthi; she was known as Kisagotami because of her slim body. Kisagotami was married to a rich young man and a son was born to them. The boy died when he was just a toddler and Kisagotami was stricken with grief. Carrying the dead body of her son, she went about asking for medicine that would restore her son to life from everyone she happened to meet. People began to think that she had gone mad. But a wise man seeing her condition thought that he should be of some help to her. So, he said to her, "The Buddha is the person you should approach, he has the medicine you want; go to him." Thus, she went to the Buddha and asked him to give her the medicine that would restore her dead son to life.
>
> The Buddha told her to get some mustard seeds from a house where there had been no death. Carrying her dead child in her bosom, Kisagotami went from house to house, with the request for some mustard seeds. Everyone was willing to help her, but she could not find a single house where death had not occurred. Then, she realized that hers was not the only family that had faced death and that there were more people dead than living. As soon as she realized this, her attitude towards her dead son changed; she was no longer attached to the dead body of her son.
>
> She left the corpse in the jungle and returned to the Buddha and reported that she could find no house where death had not occurred. Then the Buddha said, *"Gotami, you thought that you were the only one who had lost a son. As you have now realized, death comes to all beings; before their desires are satiated death takes them away."* On hearing this, Kisagotami fully realized the impermanence, unsatisfactoriness and insubstantiality of the aggregates and attained Sotapatti Fruition.[49]

The story of Kisogotami is a reminder of the fundamental teaching of Buddhism. Life is impermanent and the sooner we can learn to deal with it and accept it, the better we will be prepared to cope with events in life and find contentment.

CONCLUSION

The distinctive feature of pastoral theology as a discipline is its attempt to understand the ministerial role from the lived experience of people. Within

this field, theology is not an abstract understanding of God detached from the texture, sound, sense, social relations, and the paradox of life. It is based on a living and organic theology that shapes and informs everyday living. This approach is well described by Orsi when discussing the need for religious scholars to learn to stand in-between. "This is an in-between orientation, located at the intersection of self and other, at the boundary between one's own moral universe and the moral world of the other. And it entails disciplining one's mind and heart to stay in this in-between place, in a posture of disciplined attentiveness, especially to difference."[50]

A chaplain friend of mine told me that when he started his ministry, all he wanted to do was to convert patients. Years of being exposed to people's struggles, pain, and suffering taught him otherwise. "I was force to rethink my entire theology," he reflected. After listening to ten Buddhist monks reflect theologically on their pastoral functions, I was amazed at the shared commonalities in approaches between the field of pastoral theology in which I was trained and the methods used by these Thai Buddhist monks, particularly how Thai Buddhist pastoral theology has expanded in order to integrate the lived experience of the people.

Perhaps the lotus metaphor best represents pastoral theology of these ten Thai Buddhist monks. Like Luang Pu Charoenporn's description of the lotus flower, "all good things emerge from bad things in life,"[51] beautiful lotus flowers were once submerged in the dirt and the mud. When given an opportunity, they emerge as elegant flowers. First, Thai Buddhist monks have a clear understanding of the lived religious experience of the people. They realize that the religious psyche and metaphysical reality of the people do not represent a pure understanding of Buddhism but, instead, an incongruent mixture of beliefs in ancestral spirits, local spirits, Hindu deities, and the teachings of the Buddha. Although these Buddhist monks may be in disagreement, they do not place judgment or set criteria for inclusion. They understand this pluralistic metaphysical reality in the collective psyche of the Thai people and extend their invitation in spite of it. While Christian churches often expect understanding of doctrinal beliefs and renunciation of certain practices, Buddhist pastoral theology embraces the lotus flower even when it is submerged in the dirt and the mud.

Beside offering this acceptance, these Thai Buddhist monks do not rebuke magical beliefs commonly held within society. They show respect toward those beliefs and make use of them through *kusonlayobai* to uplift people to a greater understanding of the teachings of Buddha. They use *sakyant*, *yantra*, amulets and other sacred objects or images of deities to promote compassion, charity, purity of thought and action. Thai Buddhist pastoral theology does not promote an abstract theology of *dukkha* (suffering), *anicca* (impermanence), and *anatta* (no-self). Rather, it takes seriously the lived religious experience of everyday life in Thailand. It engages the

system through embracing it and at the very same time bringing to the awareness the reality of suffering and the way out. Its theological construction, using the metaphor of the lotus, is the theology that integrates the pluralistic metaphysical reality within the collective psyche with the spiritual teachings of the Buddha.

Lotus flowers, given sufficient nourishment, do not stay submerged. They grow. They emerge and blossom. This is one of the most important pastoral functions of Buddhist monks. To be enlightened is to finally realize, at the existential level, that attachment is the primary cause of suffering and pain. Here lies the significant difference between the discipline of pastoral theology as articulated in the Western world and that of the Thai Buddhist monks based on these interviews. Currently, pastoral theological discourse in the West takes seriously the socio-economic, ethnic, and political situations of the people to whom pastors are ministering. It explores issues of race, ethnicity, gender, and economy within the wider socio-political context and calls for structural change in order to bring about fairness and equality and reduce oppression. In discussing pastoral theology based on discourse theory, Susan Dunlap writes, "When pastoral theology neglects to see individuals as situated in the context of power relations, with unequal access to political and economic resources, our care is not only ineffective, but it subtly blames the victim for her pain rather than names the power structures that are involved."[52] Thai Buddhist monks, on the other hand, while understanding the importance of equality and fairness and the evil of oppression, state clearly that ultimately suffering is the result of attachment. When asked about Buddhist approach to politics, a senior monk at Wat Chaobuddha states, "What we need in our society is not democracy. What we need is Dharma-cracy."[53] By Dharma-cracy he meant, the government that is governed by the teachings of Buddhism emphasizing simplicity, detachment, and the doctrine of no-self (*anatta*). The presence of equality and fairness and the absence of oppression do not solve the fundamental human dilemma. In the final analysis, the Buddhist monks' aim is to help people realize that desire is the root cause of all suffering. This is true for the oppressor and the oppressed, the perpetrator and the victims. Only when one is enlightened can one truly escape from the physical and spiritual suffering that transcend the socio-economic and political realities of the world in which we live.

Reflecting on the lived religious experience of the Thai people and the Buddhist pastoral theological perspective raises a significant issue for me in my own pastoral theological construction. In Thailand the assumption of metaphysical reality plays a significant role in everyday living. Philosophically there is no clear progression from pre-modern to modernity. Thai people seem to be able to hold these two in tension without any need for justification. The presence of transcendence in various shapes and forms remains very much a part of the collective psyche. Hence any theological development that

does not address the importance of transcendence will remain incomplete for Thai people. This applies to any theological attempt to deal with social situations whether they be poverty, oppression, or discrimination. The gods need to be evoked and the spiritual realm has to be brought into the conversation. While I recognize the need to address the sociological aspect of suffering, these interviews have given me an insight into the spiritual dimension of liberation. Being liberated does not make one a free person. True freedom is an inner existential realization that Transcendence remains the source of self-definition. In "Pastoral Theology: Historical Perspectives and Future Agenda," Rodney Hunter urges pastoral theologians to take the concept of Transcendence more seriously in their theological construction, otherwise, the academic pastoral theologians risk "becoming irrelevant to the actual, concrete spirituality and life of religious communities."[54] I find Hunter's comment very relevant to the practice of pastoral theology. It is important to allow Transcendence to be the very source from which we arrive at our understanding of reality and thus of life itself.

On the opposite side, it may be beneficial to ask how does the concept of Dharma-cracy function within the context of socio-political crisis leading to oppression? Perhaps a further study incorporating sociological and political data on the Buddhist monks and the devotees they serve would add nuance to our understanding of lived religion and pastoral theology in this setting.

NOTES

1. Bonnie J. Miller-McLemore, "A Feminist Theory in Pastoral Theology," in *Feminist & Womanist Pastoral Theology*, eds. Bonnie J. Miller McLemore & Brita L. Gill-Austern (Nashville, Tenn.: Abingdon, 1999), 90–92.

2. Emmanuel Y. Lartey, *Pastoral Theology in an Intercultural World* (Cleveland, Ohio: Pilgrim Place, 2006), 124.

3. Robert Orsi, *Between Heaven and Earth: The Religious Worlds People Make and the Scholars Who Study Them* (Princeton, N.J.: Princeton University Press, 2005), 203.

4. Lartey, *Pastoral Theology in an Intercultural World*, 71.

5. Permission has been granted by the interviewees to cite actual names for this study.

6. Anselm L. Strauss and Juliet Corbin, *Basics of Qualitative Research* (London: Sage, 1990).

7. Uwe Flick, *An Introduction to Qualitative Research* (London: Sage, 2002).

8. The Thais believe that there are spirits in every location and when the spirit is disturbed, the spirit will retaliate. Building a spirit house is a way of placating the spirit. The spirit house is often built where the shadow of the house does not fall. Offerings of rice, flowers, fruits, and incense are expected.

9. According to one Buddhist monk I interviewed, this City Pillar was originally a linga, but due to the attempt to dissociate itself from the worship of lingum, the name is changed to City Pillar.

10. Neils Mulder, *Everyday Life in Thailand* (Bangkok: Duang Kamol, 1985), 21–55.

11. Phrakru Srivithedhammakhun, interview by Siroj Sorajjakool, February 10, 2006.

12. Tan Teik Beng, *Beliefs and Practices among Malaysian Chinese Buddhists* (Kuala Lumpur: Buddhist Missionary Society, 1988), 22.

13. Tan, *Beliefs and Practices among Malaysian Chinese Buddhists*, 23.

14. Phra Mahadarbchai, interview by Siroj Sorajjakool, February 7, 2006.

15. Burapa Phadungthai, *Gurd Tae Gum* (Bangkok: Pannee Karn Pim, 2005), 100. According to Thai Buddhism, the spirit of a dead person moves in one of two realms: *sukhati* (happiness) or *tukhati* (suffering). In the realm of *sukhati*, one may be reborn as an angel or as a human being. In the realm of tukhati, one may be reborn in hell, as an animal, or as a ghost or wandering spirit. Phra Mhawuthichai Wchiramethee, *Tai Lew Gurd Mai: Tam Nai Pra Phuthasasana* (Bangkok: Thamada, 2003), 63. Burapa Phadungthai, *Gurd Tae Gum: Maechee Thana Porn* (Bangkok: Media of Media, 2006), 101.

16. Phadungthai, *Gurd Tae Gum*, 100–102.

17. Around the 1950s, the current site of this shrine was designated for a modern hotel to accommodate tourists. During the construction, it was believed that the cutting of certain trees had caused disturbance among spirits in this location. Many incidents started happening that caused a delay in the construction plans. The construction firm believed that something had to be done to placate the spirits and that a regular spirit house would not suffice. This was the origin of the Erawan Shrine that originally sat at the corner now housing the famous Erawan Hotel in central Bangkok.

18. Burapa Phadungthai, *Ruay Duay Kong Klang: Ruam Kled Rub Karn Bucha Yang Took Vithee Te Tham Hai Tuk Kon Me Sith Ruay* (Bangkok: Pannee Karn Pim, 2005), 11–31.

19. Phadungthai, *Ruay Duay Kong Klang*, 143–47.

20. Phadungthai, *Ruay Duay Kong Klang*, 155–57.

21. Phramaha Charoen Chanchring, interview by Siroj Sorajjakool, January 4, 2006.

22. Phrakru Srivithedhammakhun, interview by Siroj Sorajjakool, February 10, 2006.

23. The above five precepts plus the following: abstain from taking food after midday, abstain from music and dance and any use of adornments such as jewelry and perfumes, and abstain from using high or luxury seats or beds. Most Buddhists are encouraged to sleep on the floor with a thin mattress.

24. Karuna Kusalasaya, *Buddhism in Thailand: Its Past and Its Present* (Bangkok: Mental Health Publishing House, 2001), 43–44.

25. Kusalasaya, *Buddhism in Thailand*, 44.

26. John Paul Fieg, *Common Core: Thais and North Americans* (Yarmouth, Me.: Intercultural Press, 1989), 9.

27. Siroj Sorajjakool, "Thai Women's Experience with HIV/AIDS: Perspectives on Coping," *Journal of HIV/AIDS and Social Services* 5, no. 3/4 (2006): 94.

28. Tidhinart Na Pathaloong, *Kem-thid Chewit: Panti Do Jit Boriharn Chewit Su Itsara Tang Karn Ngan Lae Chit Jai* (Bangkok: Arasomsaranard, 2004), 53. Mircea Eliade, recognizing the need to embrace suffering (evil) within one's view of reality, suggests in his book *The Two and The One* that by meditating on myths that promote *coincidentia oppositorum* (unity of opposites) one can "uncover a secrete dimension

of reality." Mircea Eliade, *The Two and The One* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1965), 97.

29. According to Karuna Kusalasaya, a Buddhist scholar, Buddhism came to Thailand during the third century BC through a Buddhist missionary from India who brought Theravada Buddhism to Thailand, the type of Buddhism promoted by King Asoka of India. Kusalasaya, *Buddhism in Thailand*, 5.

30. Phra Mahadarbchai, interview by Siroj Sorajjakool, January 25, 2006.

31. Buddhadasa Bhikkhu, "India's Benevolence to Thailand," in *Buddhism in Thailand: Its Past and Its Present*, ed. Karuna Kusalasaya (Bangkok: Mental Health Publishing House, 2001), 56–90. For an argument on how the term "syncretism" can be applied to seemingly established churches as well as to those emerging outside the establishment and therefore may be a meaningless term, see Linda Thomas, *Under the Canopy: Ritual Process and Spiritual Resilience in South Africa* (Columbia: University of South Carolina Press, 1999).

32. Phrakru Srivithedhammakhun, interview by Siroj Sorajjakool, February 10, 2006.

33. Phra Charoen Chanchring, interview by Siroj Sorajjakool, January 4, 2006.

34. A Buddhist Monk at Wat Padhammachart, interview by Siroj Sorajjakool, January 12, 2006.

35. Buddhadasa Bhikku, "India's Benevolence to Thailand," 79.

36. Rach Ramun, "Luang Po Sing Wat Pai Luong Bang Yai Nunthaburi," *Saksit*, 530 (2006), 35.

37. Thawatchai Somnaskum, "Prasobkarn Saksit Jak Poo Arn," *Saksit* 530 (2006), 29.

38. Phra Charoen Chanchring, interview by Siroj Sorajjakool, January 4, 2006.

39. Phra Mahadarbchai, interview by Siroj Sorajjakool, February 7, 2006.

40. This reminds me of growing up in a Christian home and being told constantly that there was no use praying for God's help and protection if I misbehaved and did not keep God's commandments.

41. Cited by Poonsak Phasunont, "Phra Kur Kunakorn," *Saksit* 530 (2006), 32.

42. Phasunont, "Phra Kur Kunakorn," 32.

43. Phasunont, "Phra Kur Kunakorn," 32.

44. Phra Phromkhunaporn, *Rathasart Pur Chat Vs. Rathasart Pur Lok Lae Phuthawithee Kae Panha Pur Satawat* Te 21 (Bangkok: Sahathammik, 2005), 15.

45. Phra Charoen Chanchring, interview by Siroj Sorajjakool, January 4, 2006.

46. In *Thidsadee Pungpa Lae Tewawithaya Hang Karn Plod Ploi*, Tavivat Putrikwiwat shows the impact of global economy on third world countries and Thailand, arguing that it has created dependency and thus removed dignity from local farmers in this region. Putrikwiwat, *Thidsadee Pungpa Lae Tewawithaya Hang Karn Plod Ploi* (Bangkok: Mulaniti Witheethad, 2002), 1–42.

47. Sulak Sivaraksa, *Global Healing: Essays and Interviews on Structural Violence, Social Development, and Spiritual Transformation* (Bangkok: Sathirakoses-Nagapradipa Foundation, 1999), 58.

48. Phra Phoawanavirijakun, *Rathasart Cherng Phut Lae Bod Wikrao Thksicomic* (Bangkok: Dokya, 2005), 135.

49. Dwa Mya Tin, trans., "The Enlightened Nun: Kisagotami," www.nibbana.com (accessed June 7, 2007).

50. Orsi, *Between Heaven and Earth*, 198.

51. Tin, "The Enlightened Nun."

52. Susan Dunlap, "Discourse Theory and Pastoral Theology," in *Feminist & Womanist Pastoral Theology*, eds. Bonnie J. Miller-McLemore and Brita L. Gill-Austern (Nashville, Tenn.: Abingdon, 1999), 139.

53. For further explanation of this concept of "Thammadhipatai" or "Dhammacracy" see Phra Phawanawiriyakhun, *Rathasart Cherng Phut Lae Bod Wikrao Thaksicomic* (Bangkok: Dokya, 2004), 133–36.

54. Rodney Hunter, "Pastoral Theology: Historical Perspectives and Future Agenda," *Journal of Pastoral Theology*, 16, no 1 (2006): 28.

Select Bibliography

Albrecht, Daniel E. "Pentecostal Spirituality: Looking Through the Lens of Ritual." *Pneuma* 14 (1992): 111.

Anderson, Victor. *Pragmatic Theology: Negotiating the Intersection of an American Philosophy of Religion and Public Theology*. Albany: SUNY Press, 1999.

Ammerman, Nancy T. "Golden Rule Christianity." Pp. 196–216 in *Lived Religion in America: Toward a History of Practice*, ed. David D. Hall. Princeton, N.J.: Princeton University Press, 1997.

_____, ed. *Everyday Religion: Observing Modern Religious Lives*. New York: Oxford University Press, 2007.

Asad, Talal. *Genealogies of Religion: Discipline and Reasons of Power in Christianity and Islam*. Baltimore: Johns Hopkins University Press, 1993.

Ashby, Homer. *Our Home is Over Jordan: A Black Pastoral Theology*. St. Louis: Chalice Press, 2003.

Austin-Broos, Diane J. *Jamaica Genesis: Religion and the Politics of Moral Orders*. Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1997.

Bass, Dorothy C., ed. *Practicing Our Faith: A Way of Life for a Searching People*. San Francisco: Jossey-Bass, 1997.

Bass, Dorothy C. and Craig Dykstra, eds. *For Life Abundant: Practical Theology, Theological Education, and Christian Ministry*. Grand Rapids, Mich.: Eerdmans, 2008.

Bediako, Kwame. *Christianity in Africa: The Renewal of a Non-Western Religion*. Maryknoll, N.Y.: Orbis Books, 1995.

Behar, Ruth. *The Vulnerable Observer: Anthropology that Breaks Your Heart*. Boston: Beacon Press, 1996.

Bonilla-Silva, Eduardo. *Racism Without Racists: Color-Blind Racism and the Persistence of Racial Inequality in the United States*. 2nd ed. Lanham, Md.: Rowman & Littlefield, 2006.

Brown, Teresa L. Fry. *God Don't Like Ugly: African American Women Handing on Spiritual Values*. Nashville, Tenn.: Abingdon Press, 2000.

Browning, Don. *Religious Thought and the Modern Psychologies: A Critical Conversation in the Theology of Culture*. Philadelphia: Fortress Press, 1987.

_____. *A Fundamental Practical Theology: Descriptive and Strategic Proposals*. Minneapolis: Fortress Press, 1996.

Bunge, Marcia J. "Herder and the Origins of a Historical View of Religion." Pp. 171–90 in *Revisioning the Past: Prospects in Historical Theology*, eds. Mary Potter Engel and Walter E. Wyman, Jr. Philadelphia: Fortress Press, 1992.

Capps, Donald. *Biblical Approaches to Pastoral Counseling*. Philadelphia: Westminster Press, 1981.

Congar, Yves, O.P. *Tradition and Traditions: An Historical and a Theological Essay*, trans. Michael Naseby and Thomas Rainborough. New York: Macmillan, 1967.

Connerton, Paul. *How Societies Remember*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1989, 2003.

Crites, Stephen. "The Narrative Quality of Experience." *Journal of the American Academy of Religion* 39, no.3 (September 1971): 291–311.

Doehring, Carrie. *The Practice of Pastoral Care: A Postmodern Approach*. Louisville: Westminster John Knox Press, 2006.

Dunlap, Susan. *Counseling Depressed Women*. Louisville: Westminster John Knox Press, 1997.

_____. *Caring Cultures: How Congregations Care for the Sick*. Waco, Texas: Baylor University Press, 2009.

Dupré, Louis. *Passage to Modernity: An Essay in the Hermeneutics of Nature and Culture*. New Haven, N. J.: Yale University, 1993.

Durso, Pamela R. and Keith E. Durso. "'Cherish the Dream God Has Given You': The Story of Addie Davis." Pp. 18–30 in *Courage and Hope: The Stories of Ten Baptist Women Ministers*, eds. Pamela R. Durso and Keith E. Durso. Macon, Ga: Mercer University Press, 2005.

_____. "Discourse Theory and Pastoral Theology." Pp. 133–48 in *Feminist & Womanist Pastoral Theology*, eds. Bonnie J. Miller-McLemore and Brita L. Gill-Austern. Nashville, Tenn.: Abingdon, 1999.

Eck, Diana. *A New Religious America*. San Francisco: HarperSanFrancisco, 2001.

Eiesland, Nancy L. *The Disabled God: Toward a Liberatory Theology of Disability*. Nashville, Tenn.: Abingdon, 1994.

Eiesland, Nancy L. and Don E. Saliers, eds. *Human Disability and the Service of God: Reassessing Religious Practice.* Nashville, Tenn.: Abingdon Press, 1998.

Emerson, Michael. "Beyond Ethnic Composition: Are Multiracial Congregations Unique?" Paper presented at the annual meeting of the Society for the Scientific Study of Religion, 2000.

Emerson, Michael and Christian Smith. *Divided by Faith: Evangelical Religion and the Problem of Race in America*. New York: Oxford University Press, 2000.

Erlandson, David A., Edward L. Harris, Barbara L. Skipper, and Steve D. Allen. *Doing Naturalistic Inquiry: A Guide to Methods*. Newberry Park, Calif.: Sage Press, 1993.

Farley, Edward. *Good and Evil: Interpreting a Human Condition*. Minneapolis, Minn.: Fortress Press, 1991.

_____. *Practicing Gospel: Unconventional Thoughts on the Church's Ministry*. Louisville, Ky.: Westminster John Knox Press, 2003.

Fett, Sharla. *Working Cures: Healing, Health, and Power on Southern Slave Plantations*. Chapel Hill: University of North Carolina Press, 2002.

Finke, Roger and Rodney Stark. *The Churching of America, 1776–1990: Winners and Losers in Our Religious Economy*. New Brunswick, N.J.: Rutgers University Press, 1993.

Flick, Uwe. *An Introduction to Qualitative Research*. London: Sage, 2002.

Flory, Richard W. "Conclusion: Toward a Theory of Generation X Religion:" Pp. 231–49 in *GenX Religion*, eds. Richard W. Flory and Donald E. Miller. New York: Routledge, 2000.

Forman, Robert. *Grassroots Spirituality*. Charlottesville, Va.: Imprint Academic, 2004.

Freedman, Jill and Gene Combs. *Narrative Therapy: The Social Construction of Preferred Realities*. New York: W. W. Norton, 1996.

Fulkerson, Mary McClintock. *Changing the Subject: Women's Discourses and Feminist Theology*. Minneapolis, Minn.: Fortress Press, 1994.

_____. *Places of Redemption: Theology for a Worldly Church*. Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2007.

Gergen, Kenneth. *The Saturated Self: Dilemmas of Identity in Contemporary Life*. New York: Basic Books, 2000.

Gerkin, Charles. *Prophetic Pastoral Practice: A Christian Vision of Life Together*. Nashville: Abingdon, 1991.

Gilkes, Cheryl Townsend. "The 'Loves' and 'Troubles' of African-American Women's Bodies." Pp. 232–49 in *A Troubling in My Soul: Womanist Perspectives on Evil and Suffering*, ed. Emilie Townes. Maryknoll, N.Y.: Orbis Books, 1993.

Goizueta, Roberto. "The Symbolic Realism of U.S. Latino/a Popular Catholicism." *Theological Studies* 65 (June 2004) 255–74.

Graham, Elaine, Heather Walton, and Frances Ward. *Theological Reflection: Methods*. London: SCM Press, 2005.

Hacker, Andrew. *Two Nations: Black and White, Separate, Hostile, Unequal*. New York: Scribner, 2003.

Hall, David D., ed. *Lived Religion in America: Toward a History of Practice*. Princeton, N. J.: Princeton University Press, 1997.

Hinson, Glenn E. "Tradition." Pp. 489–91 in *A New Handbook of Christian Theology*, eds. Donald W. Musser and Joseph L. Price. Nashville: Abingdon Press, 1992.

Hobsbawm, Eric and Terence Ranger, eds. *The Invention of Tradition*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1983.

Holloway, Karla. *Passed On: African American Mourning Stories*. Durham, N. C.: Duke University Press, 2002.

Hopkins, Dwight N. *Being Human: Race, Culture, and Religion*. Minneapolis: Fortress Press, 2005.

Hummel, Leonard M. *Clothed in Nothingness: Consolation for Suffering*. Minneapolis, Minn.: Fortress Press, 2003.

James, William. *The Varieties of Religious Experience*. New York: Viking/Penguin Press, 1982.

Jones, Serene. "Graced Practices: Excellence and Freedom in the Christian Life." Pp. 51–77 in *Practicing Theology: Beliefs and Practices in Christian Life*, eds. Dorothy Bass and Miroslav Volf. Grand Rapids, Mich.: Eerdmans, 2002.

Kleinman, Arthur. *The Illness Narratives: Suffering, Healing, and the Human Condition*. New York: Basic, 1988.

Lartey, Emmanuel. *Pastoral Theology in an Intercultural World*. Cleveland, Ohio: Pilgrim Press, 2006.

Lincoln, Yvonna S. and Egon G. Guba. *Naturalistic Inquiry*. Beverly Hills, CA: Sage, 1985.

Lowe-Ching, Theresa. "Method in Caribbean Theology." Pp. 23–34 in *Caribbean Theology: Preparing for the Challenges Ahead*, ed. Howard Gregory. Kingston: Canoe Press, University of the West Indies, 1995.

Maffly-Kipp, Laurie F., Leigh E. Schmidt, and Mark Valeri, eds. *Practicing Protestants: Histories of Christian Life in America 1630–1965*. Baltimore, Md.: Johns Hopkins University Press, 2006.

Massey, David E. "Empathy." P. 354 in *Dictionary of Pastoral Care and Counseling*, ed. Rodney Hunter, et al. Nashville: Abingdon Press, 1990.

Mauss, Marcel. "Body Techniques." Pp. 97–105 in *Sociology and Psychology: Essays*, ed. and trans. B. Brewster. London: Routledge & Kegan Paul, 1979.

Maynard, Jane F. *Transfiguring Loss: Julian of Norwich as a Guide for Survivors of Traumatic Grief*. Cleveland, Ohio: Pilgrim Press, 2006.

McAdams, Dan P. *The Stories We Live By: Personal Myth and the Making of the Self*. New York: Guilford Press, 1993.

McDannell, Colleen. *Material Christianity: Religion and Popular Culture in America*. New Heaven, Conn.: Yale University Press, 1995.

McGuire, Meredith B. *Lived Religion: Faith and Practice in Everyday Life*. New York: Oxford University Press, 2008.

Miller-McLemore, Bonnie. "Feminist Theory in Pastoral Theology." Pp. 90–99 in *Feminist & Womanist Pastoral Theology*, eds. Bonnie J. Miller McLemore and Brita L. Gill-Austern. Nashville, Tenn.: Abingdon, 1999.

Morgan, David. "The Materiality of Cultural Construction." *Material Religion* 4, no. 2 (July 2008): 228.

Moschella, Mary Clark. *Ethnography as a Pastoral Practice: An Introduction*. Cleveland, Ohio: Pilgrim Press, 2008.

_____. *Living Devotions: Reflections on Immigration, Identity, and Religious Imagination.* Eugene, Ore.: Pickwick Publications, 2008.

Neuger, Christie. *Counseling Women: A Narrative, Pastoral Approach*. Minneapolis: Fortress, 2001.

Orsi, Robert. "Everyday Miracles: The Study of Lived Religion." Pp. 3–21 in *Lived Religion in America: Toward a History of Practice.* Princetonm N. J.: Princeton University Press, 1997.

_____. "Is the Study of Lived Religion Irrelevant to the World We Live In?" Special presidential plenary address, Society for the Scientific Study of Religion, Salt Lake City, November 2, 2002, *Journal for the Scientific Study of Religion* 29, no. 2 (June 1, 2003): 169–74.

_____. *Between Heaven and Earth: The Religious Worlds People Make and the Scholars Who Study Them*. Princeton, N.J.: Princeton University Press, 2005.

Patton, John. *Pastoral Care in Context: An Introduction to Pastoral Care*. Louisville Ky.: Westminster/John Knox Press, 1993.

Peirce, Charles Sanders. "How to Make our Ideas Clear." Pp. 160–79 in *Peirce on*

Signs: Writings on the Semiotic, ed. James Hoopes. Chapel Hill: University of North Carolina Press, 1991.

Pohl, Christine D. *Making Room: Recovering Hospitality as a Christian Tradition*. Grand Rapids, Mich.: Wm. B. Eerdmans Publishing Company, 1999.

Prown, Jules David. "Mind in Matter: An Introduction to Material Culture Theory and Method." *Winterthur Portfolio* 17, no. 1 (Spring 1982): 1–19.

Raboteau, Albert. "The Afro-American Traditions." Pp. 539–62 in *Caring and Curing: Health and Medicine in the Western Religious Traditions*, ed. by Ronald L. Numbers and Darrel W. Amundsen. Baltimore: Johns Hopkins University Press, 1986.

Ramsay, Nancy. *Pastoral Care and Counseling: Redefining the Paradigms*. Nashville: Abingdon, 2004.

Riebe-Estrella, Gary. "Latino Religiosity or Latino Catholicism?" *Theology Today* 54, no. 4 (January 1998): 512–15.

Rieger, Joerg. *Remember the Poor: The Challenge to Theology in the Twenty-First Century*. Harrisburg, Pa.: Trinity Press International, 1998.

Roof, Wade Clark. *A Generation of Seekers*. New Brunswick, N.J.: Rutgers University Press, 1993.

Rössler, Dietrich. "Fromm sein als Protestant: Gelebte Religion als Frage an die wissenschaftliche Theologie." *Evangelische Kommentare* 11, 1978.

Schaller, Janet E. "Reconfiguring Dis/ability: Multiple and Narrative Constructions of Self." *Pastoral Psychology* 57, nos. 1 and 2 (September 2008): 89–99.

Scheib, Karen D. *Challenging Invisibility: Practices of Care with Older Women*. St. Louis Mo.: Chalice Press, 2004.

Seamone, Donna Lynne. "Body as Ritual Actor and Instrument of Praise: Verna Maynard's Experience as Praise Leader in the Kitchener Church of God." *Journal of Ritual Studies* 12 (1998): 31–59.

Slater, Philip. *The Pursuit of Loneliness*. Boston: Beacon, 1970.

Sommers, Regina. *Lebensgeschichte und gelebte Religion von Frauen*. Stuttgart: Kohlhammer, 1998.

Sorajjakool, Siroj. "Thai Women's Experience with HIV/AIDS: Perspectives on Coping." *Journal of HIV/AIDS and Social Services* 5 nos. 3 and 4 (2006): 87–96.

Spener, Philip Jacob. *Pia Desideria*, ed. and trans. Theodore G. Tappert. Minneapolis, Minn.: Fortress Press, 1964.

Stewart, Dianne M. *Three Eyes for the Journey: African Dimensions of the Jamaican Religious Experience*. New York: Oxford University Press, 2005.

Strauss, Anselm L. and Juliet M. Corbin. *Basics of Qualitative Research: Techniques and Procedures for Developing Grounded Theory*. Newbury Park, Calif.: Sage Publications, 1998.

Tanner, Kathryn. *Theories of Culture: A New Agenda for Theology*. Minneapolis, Minn: Fortress Press, 1997.

_____. "Theological Reflection and Christian Practices." Pp. 228–42 in *Practicing Theology: Beliefs and Practices in Christian Life*, eds. Miroslav Volf and Dorothy C. Bass. Grand Rapids, Mich.: Eerdmans, 2002.

Thomas, Linda. *Under the Canopy: Ritual Process and Spiritual Resilience in South Africa*. Columbia: University of South Carolina Press, 1999.

Thomson, Rosemarie Garland. *Extraordinary Bodies*. New York: Columbia University Press, 1997.

Townes, Emilie. *Breaking the Fine Rain of Death: African American Health Issues and a Womanist Ethic of Care*. New York: Continuum, 1998.
Turner, Victor. "Betwixt and Between: Liminal Period." Pp. 93–111 in *The Forest of Symbols*. Ithaca, N.Y.: Cornell University Press, 1967.
Van der Ven, Johannes. *Practical Theology: An Empirical Approach*. Leuven, Belgium: Peeters, 1993.
Volf, Miroslav and Dorothy C. Bass, eds. *Practicing Theology: Beliefs and Practices in Christian Life.* Grand Rapids, Mich.: Eerdmans, 2002.
Wallace, Maurice O. *Constructing the Black Masculine: Identity and Ideality in African American Men's Literature and Culture, 1775–1995*. Durham, N.C.: Duke University Press, 2002.
Watkins Ali, Carol. *Survival and Liberation: Pastoral Theology in African American Context*. St. Louis, Mo.: Chalice Press, 1999.
Way, Peggy. *Created by God: Pastoral Care for All God's People*. St. Louis, Mo.: Chalice Press, 2005.
Weber, Max. *From Max Weber: Essays in Sociology*. ed. H.H. Gerth and C. Wright Mills. London: Oxford University Press, 1981.
Wendell, Susan. *The Rejected Body: Feminist Philosophical Reflections on Disability*. New York: Routledge, 1996.
Williams, Delores S. "A Womanist Perspective on Sin." Pp. 130–149 in *A Troubling in My Soul: Womanist Perspectives on Evil and Suffering*, ed. Emilie M. Townes. Maryknoll, N.Y.: Orbis, 1993.
Wimberly, Edward. *Using Scripture in Pastoral Counseling*. Nashville: Abingdon, 1994.

Index

abilities, 108, 125, 130, 131, 136, 137, 140
African: Christian theology, 246–48, 251–52, 253–55, 257nn10–12; church, 235–239, 256nn1–7; people in Jamaica, 215–16, 233nn13–14; traditional religion, 12, 239, 244, 246. *See* African Independent and Evangelical Charismatic Churches
African American: congregations and healing, 9, 91–92; members in interracial congregation, 24, 27–29, 35
African Caribbeans, 215–16, 220, 221, 287
African Independent and Evangelical Charismatic Churches (AEIC), 12, 236–247, 255
age, 18n20, 27, 28, 45, 48, 50, 63, 75, 176n52, 184, 234n28, 242, 271, 276
agency, 4, 10, 23, 94, 123, 149, 157, 168, 169
Albanese, Catherine, 189, 201, 205n58, 208n78
Ammerman, Nancy Tatom, 4, 17nn8–9, 18nn11–12, 19n36, 19n42, 19n49, 38n19, 171n6, 174n18, 178nn71–72, 283
anxiety, 31, 72n57, 148, 156, 235
appointment, pastoral, 56, 57, 58, 59, 72n54, 178n2
architecture, 3, 48, 79, 140
artifacts, 9, 16, 75, 77, 78, 86, 87
attitudes, 31, 36, 78, 104, 123, 129, 134
authority: biblical, in Southern Baptist Convention, 11, 146, 148, 150–51, 153–54, 156, 164; location, in Southern Baptist Convention, 147, 148, 149, 170, 171n6; of women, in Southern Baptist Convention, 149, 157, 160, 165–66, 168, 174n26

Baptist Faith and Message, 148, 149, 159, 168, 174n21, 176n48, 177n69, 178n72
Barth, Karl: theology applied to African churches, 247–55, 258nn20–24, 258nn26–28, 259n33, 259n37
Bass, Dorothy C., 2, 18n22, 18n33, 30, 38n20, 39n28, 89n8, 175n32, 283, 285, 288
beliefs: cultural, regarding disability, 125–30; in African traditional

religion, 235, 246, 248, 257n7; linked to practices in congregations, 77–79, 85–87; new, about dis/ability,139–40; Thai religious, 264–65, 269, 270
belonging, 16, 64, 73n74, 87, 130, 170, 198, 201
Benjamin, Jessica, 160, 164, 175n43, 177nn61–64
Berger, Peter L., 3, 17, 17n9, 18n11, 19n49
biomedical explanations for illness, 82, 85, 128
blessing, 84, 111, 177n68, 199, 225, 240, 270
body (ies), 7, 8, 9, 31, 32, 36, 40n36, 41n52, 81, 109, 112, 180, 197, 198, 246, 248, 252–54, 267, 276, 285, 286, 287, 288; and dis/ability, 40n46, 41n62, 82, 125, 127, 129–30, 135; and healing, 9, 79, 80–82, 84, 85, 87, 193, 245, 252; and illness, 9, 77, 83; and knowledge, 31–33, 39n33; and otherness, 24–25, 3, 33, 36, 37, 142n16; disabled, 25, 31, 121, 125–30, 134–35, 139, 142n9, 142n14; in Jamaican Mennonite worship, 212, 214–15, 221–22, 226–28, 231
Brown, Teresa Frye, 35, 40n48, 41n64, 284
Buddhism, 124, 190, 202n8, 202n14, 264–78, 280n15, 281n29

care, pastoral, 14–16, 64, 75, 86, 179, 183, 190, 199–201, 213, 230, 232, 235, 239, 241
caregiver, 139, 162, 176n50, 199, 201, 207n73
caregiving, 9, 64, 86, 127
Catholic, 1, 9, 39n27, 39n31, 80, 179, 184, 190, 191, 194, 236–37
charity, 103, 108, 127, 270, 274, 277
children, 7, 36, 76, 164, 176n52, 187, 195, 215–17, 241–43, 262; and dis/ability, 122, 126, 139; and homelessness, 9–10, 99, 108–113, 115n1, 115n3; at Agape UMC, 52, 61–63; at Our Lady of Guadalupe, 83–84
Chinese religion, 265, 266, 268, 280nn12–13
clergywomen, 28, 144–46, 149–50, 157, 160–61, 170, 174n23, 176n52, 177n58, 178n70
comfort, 16, 25, 87, 131, 271, 273
communication, 31–32, 34, 39n31, 40n47, 41n63, 44, 216, 220, 223, 224; printed, 44–49
congregations, 10; and communal identity formation, 9, 43–70; and healing practices, 9, 12, 75–88, 235–56; and ministry of hospitality to homeless, 9, 91–115; as sites of theological reflection, 2, 8, 23–27; in Jamaican Mennonite Church, 12, 211–32
Connerton, Paul, 8, 33, 34, 38n16, 40nn36–37, 40nn40–43, 40n45, 41nn52–53, 41nn56–59, 41n61, 284
conscience, liberty of, 11, 146–54, 156, 160, 164, 174
consolation, 1, 8, 17n2, 18n32, 285, 290
contradiction, 24, 26, 31, 66, 103
controversy, 10, 56, 144, 146, 149, 158, 159, 172n6, 175n33, 176n46, 205n55
conversion, 6, 47, 69, 112, 114, 146, 148, 174n26, 175n29
coping, 1, 162, 269, 280n27, 287
Corbin, Juliet M., 214, 218, 233n6, 279n6, 287
corruption, 11, 156, 160, 168, 169, 170, 178n77
cosmology, 213, 226, 237, 238, 247, 249, 250, 254, 255
cosmos, 83, 248–251
counseling, pastoral, 75, 88n1, 174n23, 238, 242, 248, 253, 255, 259nn34–36, 284, 288
courage, 32, 111, 168, 171n2, 273, 284

deliverance, 238, 239, 242–44, 247, 251, 255, 258n30

denominations. *See particular denominations* (e.g, Lutheran, United Methodist)
devil, 81, 163, 229–30
diagnosis, pastoral, 12, 248, 254
dis/ability, 10, 119, 122, 124–140
doctrine, 23, 77, 145, 174n27, 238, 249, 250, 269, 270, 278
Dykstra, Craig, 2, 18n22, 30, 38n20, 39n28, 283

embodiment, 27, 142n15, 221–228, 290
empathy, 86, 87, 89n25, 262, 286
ethnography, 16, 19n44, 88n4, 286
Eucharist: in forming lived religion of hospitality, 101–15
evangelical, 38n13, 69, 207n71, 284. *See also* African Independent and Evangelical Churches
evangelism, 60, 69, 115, 173n17
"everyday religion," 3, 4, 17nn8–10, 18nn11–13, 19n42, 19n49, 283
exorcism, 241, 244, 246, 252

Farley, Edward, 154–56, 169, 174n24, 175nn37–43, 178nn73–75, 284
feminism, 158, 173n16, 175n43, 182, 203n21
finitude, 77, 84–85, 169
fluidity, 11, 180–83, 190, 201
food, 1, 29, 94, 99, 103–4, 109, 114, 241, 264–69, 280n23
formation, 31, 35–36; cognitive, 40n39, 41n55; identity, 44, 46; ministerial, 246; redemptive, 48; spiritual, 2, 5; theological, 15
freedom, 34, 107, 155, 201; and Baptist life, 144, 148–49, 152, 154, 156–57, 169; in Caribbean context, 216, 224, 228, 230, 233n14; in Christian life, 89n8, 285; in Ghanaian context, 252–53; of the pulpit, 60; Thailand Buddhist context, 271, 279
friends, 45, 86, 105–7, 199, 234n32, 245–46; Baptist clergywomen, 157, 161; Thail Buddhist Context, 266, 271, 275; women with dis/abilities' narratives, 130, 133, 136, 138, 141

Gadamer, Hans-Georg, 28, 38n21, 39n23
gender, 11, 36, 75, 144, 150–51, 176n47, 242, 278; equity and inequity, 11, 14, 166, 168, 176n49, 196, 207n68; in psychological theory, 164–65; in Southern Baptist Culture, 157–60, 164, 166, 170; of God, 199; -positive care, 10, 119; roles, 149, 157, 182, 192, 195
Ghana, 12, 235–37, 239, 247, 257nn8–10
Gilkes, Cheryl Townsend, 130, 142n16, 285
God, presence of, 2, 65, 81, 153, 225
gospel, 5, 36, 66, 104, 200, 236–37, 248, 256n7, 258n31; rain, 226–27; -singing, 63
grace, 1, 9, 103, 108, 110; and soul competency, 152, 175n28; at Agape United Methodist Church, 65, 67, 70; at Our Lady of Durham Church, 83; at Tent City, 110, 112
grief, 2, 17n3, 276, 286
grounded theory, 12, 14, 214, 218, 219, 233n6, 263, 287
growth, church, 49, 51–53, 56, 58, 59, 67, 148, 238

habit-memory, 33–36, 40nn40–45, 41n56–61
habitus, 32–34, 39n33, 40n45, 41n61
Hall, David, 3, 101, 111, 144, 172n7, 285
heal, 28, 84–85, 190, 192, 194, 199, 242
healing, 1, 11–12, 17, 19n41, 34, 59, 81–5, 95, 130, 179, 197, 201, 216; African Independent Evangelical context, 241, 244–46, 251, 254, 258n31; Jamaican Mennonite context, 213, 232; Reiki, 191–4

health, 14, 85, 93, 266–68, 285, 287, 290
history, American religious, 2, 5, 172
Holy Spirit, 193, 213, 222–224, 238, 246, 253, 257, 258n18
homelessness, 10, 14, 91–102, 111–115, 116n7, 118n73
hospitality, 9, 29, 97–115, 117n36, 117n44, 217, 287; lived religion of, 91, 95, 101–2, 109–110, 112, 115; to strangers, 91, 100, 102–6, 109
human being, 99–100, 109, 154, 236, 244, 247–8, 252–53, 280n15
humanity, 104, 129, 189, 195, 220, 249–50, 253

identity, 17n1, 29, 32, 39n35, 71n13, 88n4, 142n11, 175n44, 285, 286, 288; corporate, 5, 9, 24, 26, 31, 33–34, 36, 44–46, 114; in Jamaican Mennonite context, 231–32; of Agape UMC, 44, 48–49, 52, 58, 60, 65–70; of Baptist clergywomen, 157–58, 164, 167–68, 174n25; of Baptists, 173n11, 175n29, 175n31, 175nn35–36; shaped by hospitality, 105, 109
illness, 9, 14, 75–86, 94, 271, 286

Jamaica, 12, 211–19, 223–25, 231–32, 233nn1–2, 236, 283
Jesus Christ, 27, 49, 51, 61, 65, 87, 189, 235, 238, 240, 247–48, 254
justice, 5, 11, 37, 96, 99, 108, 111–12, 169, 195, 200–201, 206n66

language, 12, 24, 26, 31, 32, 34, 39–41, 61, 78, 107, 140, 158, 229, 239, 244, 246, 253; abusive language, 95; common language, 152, 258; of love, loving-intimacy, 223; Thai language, 263–64
Lartey, Emmanuel, 213, 233n5, 261, 179n2, 286
leadership, pastoral, 47, 52, 56, 58, 66, 68, 218
Leonard, Bill, 11, 146, 150, 169, 171n6
liberation, 26–27, 142n12, 159, 216, 271, 279, 288; theology(ies), 2, 5, 23–24, 28, 37n3, 200
liturgy, 10, 39n34, 140, 237
lived religion, 1, 24, 31, 123, 182, 201, 214, 279; and pastoral theology and practice, 5–8, 13–17, 75–76, 87; definition, 2–4; of hospitality, 91–115
low-income housing, 111–112, 118n71

MacIntyre, Alasdair, 29, 32, 39nn22–23, 39n26, 39n31
Maffly-Kip, Laurie F., 2, 3, 17nn5–7, 18n13, 286
magic, 202n12, 257n14, 264, 267, 269, 274, 275
material culture, 76, 78–80, 89n13, 287
McGuire, Meredith, 16, 17n10, 19n41, 19nn47–48, 202n13, 286
memory, 8, 24, 31, 33, 34, 96, 212, 214; habit-memory, 33–36, 40, 41
Mennonite Church in Jamaica, 12, 211–14, 216–19, 222, 228, 233n1, 233n8, 233n16, 234n31, 234n34; pastoral significance of lively choruses in, 230–32, 234n32. *See also* music
methodology, 13, 181, 183, 218, 261, 262
misconduct, pastoral, 52–55, 56, 59, 65
modernism, 148, 149, 158, 172n11, 174n18, 208n77
Morgan, David, 78, 89n15, 172n6, 286
movement: Neopagan, 182, 192, 203n16, 203n21, 205n50, 206n67, 207n70; "New Age," 181–82, 189, 190, 192, 203nn15–18, 206n63, 206n67, 207n68, 207n70
music: in Mennonite worship, 15, 212, 214, 218, 229, 232

New Testament, 123, 152, 165, 245, 248, 250–51

Old Testament, 250, 257n14
oppression, 14, 26, 32, 130, 159, 169, 216, 235, 278–79

ordination, women's, 10, 144, 148–50, 157–58, 160–61, 163, 166–68, 170, 176n46, 177n68, 183
Orsi, Robert Anthony, 16, 19n48, 31, 38n18, 39n32, 76, 88, 88n6, 89n7, 262, 277, 279n3, 282n50, 286
orthodoxy, 5, 27, 174n18, 238, 257n10

participant observation, 14, 25, 37, 37n7, 44, 236, 239, 247, 255
passions, 46, 155, 159, 168, 169
pastoral counseling, 75, 88n1, 174n23, 238, 242, 248, 253, 255, 259nn34–36, 284, 288
pastoral theology, 8, 10, 11, 12, 13, 87, 239; and lived religion, 4–6, 13–15, 75–76; and living with dis/abilities, 123–40; in African Christian practice, 248–55; of Buddhist monks, 261–79
peace, 99, 187, 191, 195, 215, 268, 271, 274
Peirce, Charles Sanders, 6, 18nn23–24, 286
Pentecostal, 27, 81, 88n5, 89nn18–19, 213, 283
philosophy, 2, 7, 18n26, 18n29, 95, 137, 190, 205n59, 206n60, 248–49, 254, 268n25
phronesis, 23, 28
pluralism, 1, 3, 14, 16
Pohl, Christine 103, 107, 113, 117nn36–37, 117n39, 117n53, 118n80, 287
polity, 68, 146–47, 149, 174n27, 203n27
postmodernism, 2, 5, 158, 200, 207, 208n77
poverty, 9, 12, 92–94, 215, 217, 227, 279; and homelessness, 10, 91–97, 102, 111–15
practical theology, 5, 7, 75, 172, 174n24, 246, 283–84, 288
practice(s): bodily, 32, 40n43, 41n59; definition, 2–4; pastoral, 8, 10, 12, 14, 16, 124, 130–33, 247–48, 254, 291; religious, 1–3, 6,7, 11–17, 91, 111, 115, 179, 182, 189, 200, 214, 247, 261–272; theories of, 28–31, 38–39nn20–22
practitioners, 1, 4, 9, 16–17, 29–30, 87, 175n32, 179, 181–82, 185–86, 189–90, 201, 266n66, 207n74
prayer, 1, 149, 156, 175n34, 199; in African churches, 235, 238, 239, 240–42, 244–46, 252, 254, 257nn12–13; in Agape UMC, 62,63, 64, 73n69; in healing ministry, 77, 80–82, 85; in Jamaican Mennonite worship, 212, 227; in Thai Buddhism, 264, 265, 269
praxis, 5, 9, 28, 38, 245, 252
preaching, 27, 62, 69, 77, 79, 140, 212, 247, 264
prophetic, 88, 152, 240, 245, 246, 250, 258, 285, 292
prosperity, 265, 266, 268, 269, 273, 274, 275
Protestant, 8, 11, 26, 68, 80, 82, 84, 85, 143, 152, 168, 183, 184, 190, 236, 239
Prown, Jules, 78, 79, 89, 287
psychological, 11, 67, 82, 149, 150, 160, 162, 165, 170, 194, 200, 217, 235, 236, 244, 251, 252. 254, 256, 273

qualitative research, 10, 44, 150, 172, 291. *See also various methods* (i.e., participant observation, grounded theory)

racism, 8, 14, 26, 37, 86, 159, 290
redemption, 8, 35, 87, 216
reflection, 5, 15, 23, 34, 97, 110, 145, 155, 167, 190, 212, 219, 220, 245; pastoral, 13, 198, 261, 263, 272; theological, 8, 9, 10, 13, 14, 23, 26, 36, 44, 261, 263, 272
Reformed tradition, 9, 80, 82, 85
religion: churched, 11, 181, 183, 184, 190, 191; unchurched, 10–11, 181–83, 190, 200, 206n61; popular, 14, 24, 80, 145
renewal, 112, 168, 185
resistance, 3, 122, 123, 130, 132, 140, 178, 216, 230
resurrection, 2, 34, 99, 106

ritual(s), 12, 39, 40, 41, 81, 106, 182, 183, 188, 213, 216, 267, 290

sacrament(s), 83, 102, 107, 109
sacramentals, 81, 83, 84, 108
St. Mark's Cathedral (Seattle). *See* hospitality, lived religion of
saint(s), 83, 138, 213, 226, 227, 230
salvation, 27, 77, 104, 147, 148, 152, 174, 230, 235, 250
sanctuary, 43, 47, 48, 51, 65, 109, 257, 273
Satan, 229, 230, 243, 254
schism, 10, 11, 144, 145, 147, 149, 150, 158, 159, 165, 170, 171, 172, 173, 176, 178
seekers, 190, 191, 201, 245
seminary/ies, 80, 143, 145, 148, 156, 158, 161, 165, 166, 169, 171, 177, 218, 258, 263
sexual, 54, 136, 137, 223, 224, 225; abuse, 129; misconduct, 269
sexuality, 46, 75, 136, 164
sin, 26, 138, 213, 245
slave, 214–16, 220, 223–25, 230–32
slavery, 12, 14, 15, 215–17, 219–21, 224, 225, 228, 231, 236
sociology of religion, 2, 3, 5
spirituality, 3, 7, 14, 80, 84, 89nn18–19, 106, 202nn2–6, 202nn11–13, 203n16, 203n23, 205n50, 205n59, 206n61, 206nn65–66, 207n70, 207n74, 279, 283, 285; in small groups, Upstate New York, 11–12, 15, 180–82, 185, 188, 190–91, 194–96, 198–200, 207n68; of dis/abled women, 124, 141; of Thai Buddhist monks, 13, 274–75
split, 11, 15, 28, 31, 45, 46, 148, 160, 162–64, 169, 178, 251
splitting, 11, 154, 162, 163, 170, 176, 178
stereotypes, 30, 122–24, 128–32, 136, 137, 139–41, 153
Strauss, Anselm L., 214, 218, 233n6, 279n6, 287
submission, 34, 76, 149, 165, 168
syncretism, 206, 237, 256, 272, 281
system, 46, 68, 72, 113, 168–70, 180, 194, 216, 224, 249, 278; emotional system of congregation, 46, 71; of beliefs, 187, 264, 272, 273; thought system, 186

Tanner, Kathryn, 172n8, 173n15, 175n32, 287
temple, Buddhist, 264, 267, 270, 272
Thailand, 261–72, 277–78, 281n29, n46
theological anthropology, 26, 154; of Karl Barth applied to African setting, 247–54
theological reflection. *See* reflection
theology. *See types* (e.g., liberation, pastoral, practical)
Thompson, Rosemarie Garland, 40n46, 441n62, 125, 141n2, 287
Tilley, Terrence W., 30–31, 36, 39n27, 39n31
traditional, 12, 15, 24, 131, 158, 159, 165, 168, 184, 187, 190, 193, 235, 237, 239, 244–246, 256, 268
traditioning, 8, 24, 26–28, 31, 35–36, 40n39, 41n55
transcendence, 180, 198, 205n59, 278, 279
transformation, 15, 16, 107, 110, 128, 140, 195–96, 201, 226, 281n47

Unitarian Universalists (UU): characteristics of, 183–84, 200, 203n27, 206n61, 206n66
United Methodist Church, 50, 54, 61, 68, 71n31, 72n54, 73n63

whiteness, 25, 33, 47n40, 41n63
wholeness, 5, 16, 17, 19n41, 129, 216
Winnicott, D.W., 160, 164, 176nn50–51, 176n54, 176n60
Wuthnow, Robert, 184, 203nn28–29

yoga, 185–86, 190, 191, 197, 204n31, 204nn34–35

About the Contributors

Esther E. Acolatse is Assistant Professor of Pastoral Theology and World Christianity at Duke Divinity School. She holds a B.A. (Hons) from the University of Ghana, Legon; an MTS from Harvard Divinity School; and a Ph.D. from Princeton Seminary. In her research she explores the intersection of psychology and Christian thought with interests in gender and the experience of Christianity, methodological issues in the practice of theology of the Christian life, and the relevance of these themes in the global expression of Christianity. Her forthcoming articles include "Unraveling the Relational Myth: Pastoral Care and Counseling to African Women" in *Women Out of Order: Multicultural Issues in the Pastoral Care of Women* (Fortress).

Eileen R. Campbell-Reed is Associate Director of the Learning Pastoral Imagination Project and Research Faculty at Luther Seminary, St. Paul, Minnesota. The project articulates how ministers learn the wisdom of practicing ministry over time. She teaches in the area of Pastoral Care, Counseling, and Theology and earned her doctorate from Vanderbilt University in Religion, Psychology, and Culture. Her book *Anatomy of a Schism: How Clergywomen's Narratives Interpret the Fracturing of the Southern Baptist Convention* (working title) will be published by Baylor University Press (2010). Eileen is an ordained Baptist minister and resides in Nashville, Tennessee.

Susan J. Dunlap, M.Div., Th.M., Ph.D, is an Adjunct Professor at Duke Divinity School and the chaplain at a homeless shelter in Durham, North Carolina. Ordained in the Presbytery of Eastern Oklahoma, she has served Presbyterian churches in the Baltimore Presbytery and the Presbytery of New Hope.

She is the author of *Counseling Depressed Women*, and she received a Louisville Institute grant to write *Caring Cultures: How Churches Respond to the Sick*, an ethnographic study of three churches of different ethnicities.

Mary McClintock Fulkerson is Professor of Theology at Duke Divinity School with a secondary appointment in Duke Women's Studies. An ordained minister in the PC (USA), Fulkerson got her M.Div. at Duke and her Ph.D. at Vanderbilt University. Her first book, *Changing the Subject: Women's Discourses and Feminist Theology*, offered a feminist theological interpretation of the practices of nonfeminist women of faith. Her most recent book, *Places of Redemption: Theology for a Worldly Church*, is based upon an ethnography of an interracial church. In it she interprets ecclesial practices that both reproduce and resist racism and other forms of social brokenness.

Barbara Hedges-Goettl is an ordained Presbyterian minister with more than fifteen years of pastoral experience. She is a doctoral student in Liturgical Studies at Garrett-Evangelical Theological Seminary, Evanston, Illinois. Her dissertation title is "The Body is Missing: Embodiment and the Lord's Supper in the PC-USA." She is also working on several entries for T&T Clark's *Dictionary of the Reformation*.

Jean Heriot is a cultural anthropologist (doctorate from UCLA) and a Unitarian Universalist Community minister. She is the Associate Director of Vocational Discernment and Service Learning for the Vocation and Values Program at Hastings College. She is also an Assistant Professor of Religion and Sociology there. Her first book is an ethnography of a Southern Baptist Church, *Blessed Assurance* (University of Tennessee Press, 1994). Currently, she writes about women's ritual leadership as well as on-service learning pedagogy in the fields of faith and social justice. She works intensively with students in addressing issues of poverty locally and globally.

Leonard M. Hummel is Associate Professor of Pastoral Theology and Pastoral Care at the Lutheran Theological Seminary at Gettysburg in Gettysburg, Pennsylvania. He received his Ph.D. in Pastoral Psychology from Boston University and his Master of Divinity and Master of Sacred Theology degrees from Yale Divinity School. An ordained pastor in the Evangelical Lutheran Church in America, he has served in congregations and as a pastoral counselor and hospital chaplain. His first book is *Clothed in Nothingness: Consolation for Suffering* (Fortress, 2003). He is currently a Templeton Visiting Scholar with HealthCare Chaplaincy in New York City and the editor of its publication, *Practical Bearings: The Critical Bibliography for HealthCare Chaplaincy*. He researches and writes actively on religious perspectives

concerning the evolutionary phenomenon of cancer and on the practical theological significance of the borough and battlefield of Gettysburg.

Jane F. Maynard is currently serving as Priest in Charge at St. Thomas Episcopal Church in Medina, Washington. She holds a Ph.D. in Pastoral Theology from Claremont School of Theology, an M.Div. from the Church Divinity School of the Pacific, and an M.A. in Developmental Psychology from the University of Illinois. She has served as an ordained Episcopal priest for seventeen years and has worked as a hospital chaplain, pastoral counselor, seminary professor, and congregational interim. Her first book is titled *Transfiguring Loss: Julian of Norwich as a Guide for Survivors of Traumatic Bereavement* (Pilgrim, 2006).

Mary Clark Moschella is Professor of Pastoral Theology and Congregational Care at Wesley Theological Seminary in Washington, D.C., where she has been teaching since 2001. She has been an ordained clergywoman in the United Church of Christ for twenty-five years. She served as a pastor in Massachusetts for thirteen years. She holds an M.Div. from Harvard Divinity School and a Ph.D. from Claremont School of Theology. Her recent publications include *Living Devotions: Reflections on Immigration, Identity, and Religious Imagination* (Pickwick, 2008) and *Ethnography as a Pastoral Practice: An Introduction* (Pilgrim, 2008).

Janet E. Schaller, Ph.D. (Claremont School of Theology), is Associate Professor of Pastoral Care at Memphis Theological Seminary. Using qualitative research methods, her current research and writing centers on the intersection of women, dis/ability, and (in)visibility, and the implications of this juncture for pastoral practice. She is presently working on a book with a similar focus. Schaller is also a Pastoral Counselor with the Samaritan Counseling Centers of the Mid-South and an ordained Minister of Word and Sacrament in the Presbyterian Church (U.S.A.).

Karen D. Scheib is Associate Professor of Pastoral Theology and Pastoral Care at Candler School of Theology, Emory University in Atlanta, Georgia. She is a past editor of the *Journal of Pastoral Theology* and a member of the Society for Pastoral Theology and the American Academy of Religion. Professor Scheib is also an ordained minister in the United Methodist Church and has served as a local church pastor. Professor Scheib is the author of *Challenging Invisibility: Practices of Care with Older Women*, as well as the author of articles and book chapters on pastoral theology and pastoral care. Her current research project examines the role of clergy in providing guidance to families facing ethical decisions, particularly regarding genetic testing and reproductive technologies.

Siroj Sorajjakool received his Ph.D. in Theology and Personality from Claremont School of Theology. He currently serves as Professor of Religion, Program Director for M.A. in Clinical Ministry, and Research Associate for the Center for Spiritual Life and Wholeness, Loma Linda University and as adjunct clinical professor at Claremont School of Theology. His recent publications include *When Sickness Heals: The Place of Religious Beliefs in Healthcare* (Templeton, 2006), *Do Nothing: Inner Peace for Everyday Living: Reflections on Chuang Tzu's Philosophy* (Templeton, 2009), and an edited volume, *World Religions for Healthcare Professionals* (Routledge, 2009).

Sharon Thornton is a United Church of Christ minister and Professor of Pastoral Theology at Andover Newton Theological School. She earned her B.A. at the University of Washington, her M.Div. at Pacific School of Religion, and her Ph.D. at the Graduate Theological Union. Her book, *Broken and Yet Beloved* (Chalice Press, 2002), addresses experiences of historical suffering. Her essay "America of the Broken Heart" continues this theme in *Realizing the America of Our Hearts: Theological Voices of Asian Americans*, coedited by Eleazar Fernandez and Fumitaka Matsuoka (Chalice Press, 2003). Her chapter, "Failed Community," is in *Recovering the Prophetic Voice of the Church*, edited by Hugh Sanborn (Chalice Press, 2004).

Lonnie Yoder is Professor of Pastoral Care and Counseling at Eastern Mennonite Seminary in Harrisonburg, Virginia. He holds a Ph.D. in Religion and Personality from the University of Iowa, a M.Div. from Associated Mennonite Biblical Seminary, and a B.A. from Drake University. He has publications in the areas of pastoral counseling, pastoral leadership, and aging studies.